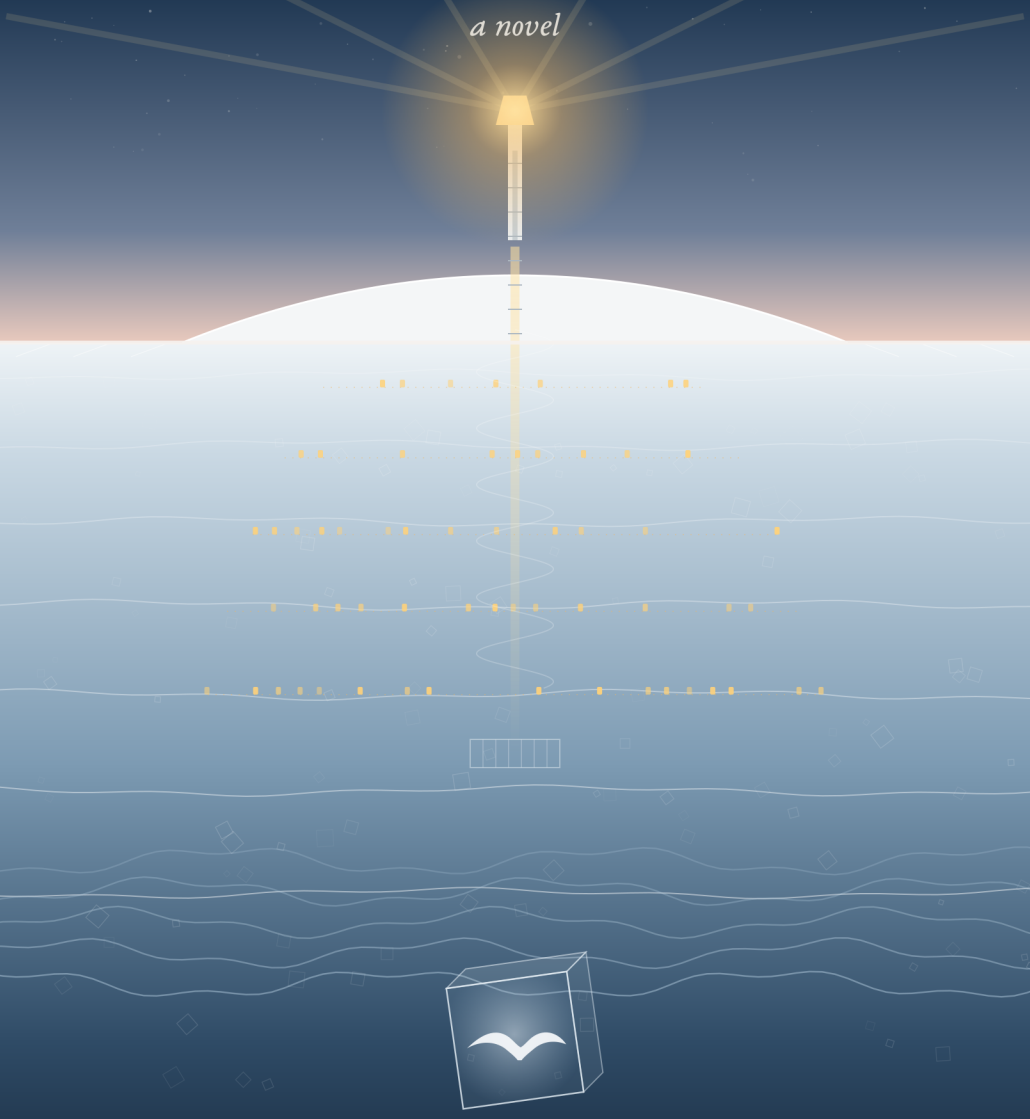
THE HALCYON CYCLE · BOOK ONE

# WHAT THE SALT KEEPS

*a novel*



[AUTHOR NAME]

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*a novel*

[AUTHOR NAME]

What the Salt Keeps

The Halcyon Cycle · Book One

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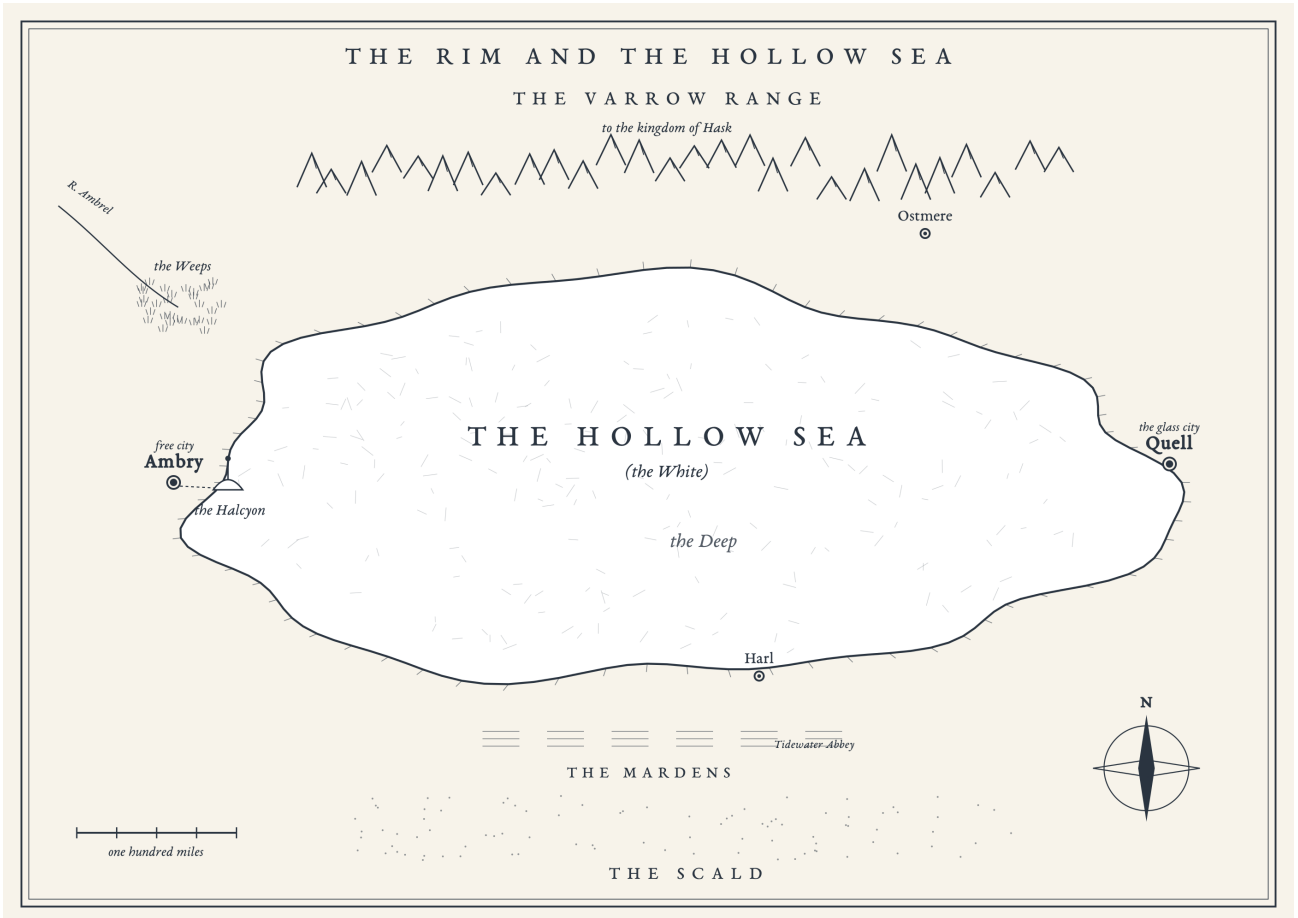
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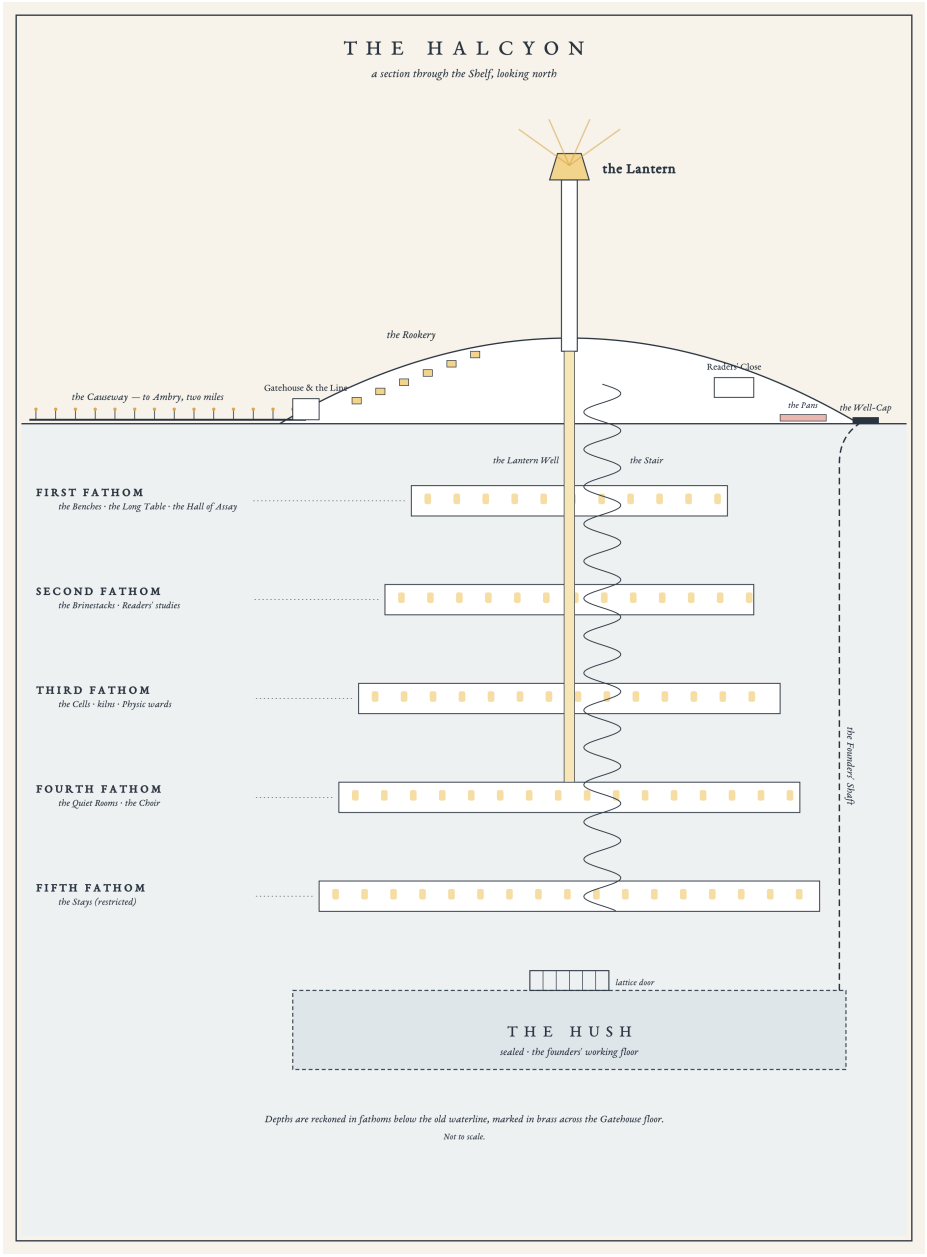
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*The Rim and the Hollow Sea*


THE HALCYON
a section through the Shelf, looking north
the Lantern
the Rookery
Readers' Close
the Causeway — to Ambry, two miles
Gatehouse & the Line
the Pans
the Well-Cap
the Lantern Well
the Stair
FIRST FATHOM
the Benches · the Long Table · the Hall of Assay
SECOND FATHOM
the Brinestacks · Readers' studies
THIRD FATHOM
the Cells · kilns · Physic wards
FOURTH FATHOM
the Quiet Rooms · the Choir
FIFTH FATHOM
the Stays (restricted)
the Founders' Shaft
lattice door
THE HUSH
sealed · the founders' working floor
Depths are reckoned in fathoms below the old waterline, marked in brass across the Gatehouse floor.
Not to scale.

*The Halcyon*

CHAPTER 1

# *The Cold House*



*The living keep clear. Visiting hours, second bell to sixth. Do not touch the casings.*

— Board above the door of the Ambry Charitable Brinery, Coldwater Street

Hester Vail's brother had been fourteen for eleven years. On the first morning of autumn she went, as she went on the first of every month, to pay for the privilege.

The Sere had come in overnight. It always did in Russet: the dry east wind off the White, carrying the plain's salt in it as a dog carries a smell. By the second bell it had got into everything. It gritted in the hinges of Lowside's shutters and furred the slate roofs. It turned the puddles in Tanner's Row into small white crusts that cracked under her boots like sugar. There was no use complaining. It was a thing to say to one another on the first of Russet, as they said *mind the step* or *tide willing*, and Hester said it twice before she reached the bottom of the lane, to the baker's boy and to the old man who sold matches from a tray. "Sere's in." "Sere's in." It cost nothing, and it was nearly always true.

She went down Coldwater Street with her collar turned up and her purse inside her coat, against her ribs, where she could feel its weight with her elbow. Six sols in silver and four flecks in copper. She had weighed it on the kitchen scales the night before, which was a habit and not an anxiety. She knew the weight of a sol as other people knew the weight of their own hand. A sol was a fifth of an ounce, less the wear, and these were old sols. She knew to the grain what it took to keep her brother for a month.

The Ambry Charitable Brinery was the last building on Coldwater Street before the street gave up and became the old sea-wall. It had been a customs warehouse once, when there were ships, and it still had the look of a building meant to hold things for other people. It had a wide front, few windows and a deep door. Someone had painted the board above the door in white letters on blue three generations ago, and someone else had repainted it, carefully, around the original words, so that it read now in a slightly heavier hand:

THE LIVING KEEP CLEAR.

The city called it the Cold House, which was accurate.

* * *

Inside the door there was a desk, and at the desk there was a clerk, and in front of the clerk there was a ledger the size of a paving slab. Hester waited behind a man in a carter's smock who was paying for his wife in flecks, counting them out in stacks of five. It took some time. The clerk did not hurry him. That was a thing Hester liked about the Cold House: nobody hurried anybody at the desk. Everyone in that queue would be standing in it again next month, and the month after.

When it was her turn she put the six sols on the felt.

"Vail," she said. "Two hundred and eleven."

"Morning, Miss Vail." The clerk was a young man called Ennis with a moustache he was not yet good at. He found the line without looking. "Six. That's you square to the first of Fallow."

"Ta."

"Sere's in," Ennis said.

"So it is."

She wrote her name in the column, where it had been written a hundred and twenty-seven times before in her hand and four times, at the beginning, in someone else's. She had counted. She did not look at the first four lines any more.

The charity ward was through the double doors and down six steps. The steps were salt-glazed and worn into dishes in the middle, and the air changed on them. It went cold and still and faintly sweet, like the air in a cellar of apples, except that nothing in the Cold House was rotting. That was the point of it. Nothing in the Cold House was doing anything at all.

There were three hundred and four casings in the charity ward, in eight long rows, on stone plinths about the height of a bed. The windows were high and small. In autumn the light came through them at a long angle and lay across the rows in bars, and in each bar the casings caught it and held it. Casings were made of salt, the same salt that was getting into the shutters outside, but they did not look like it. They looked like glass, or like ice that had been taught some manners. They were clear right through, faintly rounded at every edge, and they fitted their sleepers the way water fits whatever you drop into it: close at every point and nowhere tight.

Inside them, the sleepers lay as they had been laid, on their backs mostly, some on their sides. One or two were sitting up, kept in a hurry. There was an old man with his mouth open on a word. There was a girl of nine or ten with her hair spread out and a ribbon in it, red, which had stayed red for sixteen years. There was a woman with a baby. Hester had stopped looking at the woman with the baby some years ago.

People said of keepings that they were like flies in amber. People who said that had not stood in the Cold House. A fly in amber is dead. The sleepers in the Cold House were alive, in law and in fact, and they looked it. That was what nobody warned you about. The colour was in their faces. Their skin had the faint wet sheen of skin, and their eyes, where they had been kept open, had the wet of eyes. If you stood close enough you could see the hairs on a forearm standing up in a gooseflesh that had been raised by some draught a decade ago and never been allowed to settle. They were not dead and they were not sleeping. They were between one moment and the next, and they had been there a long time, and the Cold House charged six sols a month to keep them there.

Two hundred and eleven was in the fourth row, nearly at the end, under the third window.

"Morning, Tib," she said.

Her brother lay on his back with his head turned a little toward the window, as though someone had said his name from that direction. His eyes were half open. His mouth was closed. He was fourteen and he looked it: long in the shin, short in the patience, with hands too big for his wrists and wrists too big for his sleeves. His hair needed cutting and always would. There was colour high in his cheeks that was not health but fever, the hectic pink of the bloom, which was the last thing his body had been doing when they kept it. His right hand lay on his

chest with the fingers curled, the thumb pressed against the first finger, as though holding a pencil.

He had always been holding a pencil. He had drawn landships on everything: on the backs of their father's tally-sheets, on the plaster by his bed, once on the inside of Hester's best shoe, so that she found out about it at a funeral. Landships with three masts and with five, landships that did not exist and could not, with sails on top of their sails and runners as long as streets. He had wanted to be a pilot. Half the boys in Lowside wanted to be pilots, and the other half wanted to be delvers until they were old enough to see what happened to delvers. Tib had wanted it as some people want air. He knew the rig of every freighter in the dry harbour and he could tell you the wind on the White from the sound of the Lantern's mirrors turning, which nobody could actually do, but he said it with such certainty that you let him.

She stood at the side of his plinth with her hands in her coat pockets.

"Sere's in," she told him. "I know. You'd like it. You'd be down the harbour with your nose in the wind telling everyone it'll blow nine knots by noon. Daisy Fenn's had another one, did I tell you? That's five. Girl. She's called it Marguerite after herself, so there's two of them now and the whole office is going to have to start using surnames. Comptroller Mallory has a new wig. It is the colour of a wet fox." She considered. "That's all the news. The *Constant Wren* is due in today, from the east. Three masts. Ferrers and Lisk. You'd know her rig."

The casing gave back a little of the window. Her own face was in it, faintly, over his: a long, plain, rawboned face with a crooked front tooth and grey coming in at the temples where she had cut her hair short enough that she did not have to think about it. Thirty-three. She had been twenty-two when they kept him. She had been older than him then by eight years, and now she was older by nineteen, and every year the sum got a little more ridiculous.

She looked at his hand. Then she looked at the casing over his hand, because something was wrong with it.

* * *

IT WAS WET.

Not much. A dozen beads of moisture, no larger than the head of a pin, standing on the curve of the casing above his knuckles, as sweat stands on a cold jug. She leaned close. There were more lower down. They were on the side of the cas-

ing facing the far wall of the ward. She walked round the plinth to look, and on that side there were dozens, on the shoulder and the flank and the long slope down to his heel. They were beading in lines. That was what made her stop. Not a scatter of damp, like frost on a window, but lines, short ones, a thumb's length or two, all of them running the same way. The lines ran down and toward the eastern end of the plinth, toward his feet. A few had joined into a single runnel that had crept to the plinth's edge and was hanging there, a drop as fat as a lentil, not falling.

Casings did not get wet. That was rather the point of them.

Hester stood very still and looked at the lines and did not touch anything. Do not touch the casings. It was written on the board over the door and on another board just inside the ward and on a third, in red, beside the plinths of children. She had never touched Tib's casing. Not in eleven years. She was not a sentimental woman and she did not touch things in other people's buildings that she had not paid for.

She had paid for this.

She took off her right glove and put the tip of her smallest finger to the fat drop at the plinth's edge, and lifted it, and put it on her tongue.

What she had, and what she had always had, and what had got her off the floor of the Customs House at twelve years old and onto the stool at the assay bench at nineteen, was a tongue. Not a palate, which was a thing rich men had for wine. A tongue, and behind it, somewhere at the back of her skull, a sense of weight that was not weight. Some people with the sense heard grain. They said stillsalt rang, that a pinch of good Middling hummed like a wet finger round a glass, and that the deeper the grain the lower the note. Some people felt it as cold. Hester tasted it. Grain tasted sweet to her, at the back of the tongue, under the brine. The sweetness pressed downward behind her eyes, as if somebody had laid a coin on each lid. The deeper and stiller the grain, the heavier the coins. She had spent twenty-one years putting things on her tongue that other people would only touch with tongs, and she could tell you, from the weight behind her eyes, which fathom of the Hollow Sea a pinch of salt had come up from and how long it had been out of the ground. She was nearly always right.

A casing that had been kept eleven years should have tasted like nothing she owned a word for. She knew roughly what it would be. It would be deep Halcyon grain, the expensive kind, the kind that kept people. It would have been lying in

this cold room soaking in the stillness of the life inside it for a decade, and it would be like putting a mountain behind her eyes. Old keepings were stiller than new ones. Everybody knew that. They settled.

This drop was not still.

It was sweet, yes. Grain, yes, and deep grain, the coins on her eyelids landed hard. But under the sweetness was something else, a taste she had met before only rarely and never in a keeping. It was metallic and bright and wet. It was like the taste of your own mouth when you have bitten your tongue: blood and salt and a sort of startle. It was the taste of a thing in motion. Assayers, the few who could taste at all, had a word for it. They said a sample was *quick*.

The drop on her tongue tasted quick. It tasted, she thought, of something going somewhere.

She stood with her finger in her mouth like a child, and the light from the window lay across her brother, and the beads on his casing stood in their little lines, all pointing the same way.

* * *

"You touched it," said Mother Agathe.

"I did."

"Well." The old woman looked at Hester's bare finger and at the casing and at Hester's face, in that order, without hurry. "Then we shall neither of us mention it. Was it bad?"

Agathe Linden had been senior keeper at the Cold House since before the Great Bloom. She was seventy, small and upright, and she wore the grey shawl of a lay sister of the Returning Tide pinned with a cheap brass wave at the throat. The Tiders did not hold with keeping. They believed the kept could not meet the sea when it came home. The Order had argued about Agathe for years, as far as Hester could tell, and in the end let her alone. The Cold House was the people's choice, Agathe said, and the people had to be cared for in whatever they chose. She walked the eight rows twice a day with a soft brush and a can of oil for the plinth-lamps. She knew every sleeper's name and the names of most of their families. She talked to them. Hester had heard her, more than once, telling the old man with his mouth open that he was quite right and she'd see to it.

"It's wrong," Hester said.

"Yes."

"You've seen it."

"On fourteen of them, my dear, now there's your lad." Agathe did not lower her voice. She had a theory, she had told Hester once, that the sleepers liked being talked over, as babies do. "A few in the spring. Twelve since midsummer, the Corrie twins among them. Mr. Pell says it's the damp season."

"There's no damp season. It's been dry since Seedmonth."

"So I said to Mr. Pell."

"What did Mr. Pell say?"

"He said it was the damp season." Agathe's mouth moved in a way that would have been a smile on someone less tired. "He's had the brinewright in to recast two of them. Mrs. Ommaney in the sixth row and the Hallam boy. Forty sols each, out of the charity fund. They wept again inside the month."

Hester looked down the long rows. Now that she knew what to look for she saw it: the faint misting on a casing here, three plinths along; on another at the end of the second row, where a big man lay kept with his boots on. The light found the wet and made it shine. It was not much. If you did not know the place, you would not have seen it at all.

"Show me," she said.

They walked the rows. Agathe pointed and Hester looked. Fourteen casings wept. Every one of them wept in lines. Every line ran the same way: down, and toward the eastern end of the plinth. On the plinths that were turned crosswise, at the ends of the rows, the lines ran toward the side of the casing that faced east, which was not toward the feet at all but toward the wall. Hester stood at one of those with her hands in her pockets and looked at the wall. It was plain whitewashed brick. Beyond it, she knew, there was nothing but the last few yards of Coldwater Street and then the sea-wall and then the White, the whole flat glittering width of it, out to where the Halcyon sat on its dome two miles east with its Lantern.

"What is it?" she said. "What does it mean, if they weep?"

"It means they're losing their keep," Agathe said. "Casings weep when they're tired. It's natural in the old ones, a little. Sixty, seventy years, you get a sweat on some of them in summer, and the brinewright comes and gives them a fresh coat. But it is slow, my dear. It is slow and it is all over, like a cold glass. This—" She lifted her chin at the lines. "I've not seen this."

"What happens if it goes on?"

Agathe looked at her for a moment, the look of a woman deciding how much to give a customer who has paid.

"They thin," she said. "Casing gets thin. Then it gets a crack, and the crack goes, and they come back."

Come back. That was how the Cold House said it. Hester had heard it said for eleven years and had heard, under it, every time, the other thing it meant. A sleeper who came back came back to the moment they had been kept in. A man kept with a knife in his belly came back with a knife in his belly. A girl kept in the last hour of the bloom came back in the last hour of the bloom. Keeping did not mend. Everybody knew that, and the Cold House knew it best, because the Cold House was where the people went who could not afford to be kept anywhere that expected a cure.

"How long?" she said.

"I don't know. I don't. Tide willing, they'll find what it is."

"Who's they?"

"The Halcyon, I suppose." Agathe's mouth did the thing again. "Mr. Pell's written to them."

"When?"

"Midsummer."

Hester nodded. She was conscious of her purse, emptier now, against her ribs, and of the taste still at the back of her tongue, faint, like a coin she had sucked.

They had come round again to the fourth row. Tib lay as he had lain. The beads stood on his casing. Agathe stopped beside him and looked down at him the way she looked at all of them, the way a gardener looks along a bed.

"He's clear," she said. "Yours is clear, my dear. You look." She put out a finger, not to touch, and drew it in the air along the casing's flank. "See it? Clean through. That's what you watch for. The living keep clear and the dead keep grey. If one goes grey you'll know it's done and nothing to be had by keeping it. Yours is as clear as the day they did it. Hold on to that."

Hester looked. She had looked every month for eleven years and it was true, the casing was perfectly clear, so clear that you forgot it, so clear that only the beads standing on it told you where its surface was. On the plinth across the aisle a woman lay in a casing that had a faint pearly bloom in it, like breath on a mirror. Hester had never asked about that one. She did not ask now.

"Mr. Pell," she said. "Is he in?"

* * *

Mr. Pell was not in, which surprised no one. Mr. Pell was at a meeting of the Charitable Board, said Ennis at the desk, or at the Exchequer, or possibly at his sister's. Mr. Pell was a great deal at his sister's. Hester left a note. She wrote it standing at the desk with Ennis's pen. She knew, as she wrote it, that it was the kind of note that is written so that the writer can say afterward that she wrote it.

*Mr. Pell. Casing 211 is weeping, as are thirteen others. The weeping is directional (east) and the brine tastes quick. This is not damp. I would be grateful to know what the Halcyon has said and when a Reader is to be sent. H. Vail (sister). Customs House, Dry Harbour.*

She read it over and added *Assay Bench* after *Customs House*, because the Exchequer seal on her stool was the only thing about her the Charitable Board was likely to respect. Then she read it again. It sounded like a frightened woman who had decided to sound like a customs schedule instead.

"I'll see he gets it," Ennis said.

"Ta."

She stood a moment longer. Through the double doors she could see the end of the fourth row. From here the casings were just light, a long low glitter under the windows, like the White itself on a winter morning. You could not see the beads from here. You could not see who was in which.

She had not meant to think about the night they kept him. She did not, as a rule. She had a way of not thinking about it that was like a way of walking round a soft place in a floor: practised, and so quick she hardly knew she did it. But the Sere was in, and it had been Russet then too, the end of Russet, the night before Lantern Night. She had been standing at this desk, in a coat that had been her mother's. Their father had been outside on the step, drunk, which was not his fault, because he had been sitting up with Tib for four nights. The bloom had been in Tib's lungs for three weeks by then, and the physician from the Exchequer dispensary had said, kindly, *days*. The Cold House had a bed. The keeping fee was six sols a month, though it had been five then. Hester had been earning nine. The clerk, who was not Ennis, had turned the form round on the felt for her to sign. She had taken the pen. And before that, upstairs in the room in Tanner's Row, an hour before, with the fever heat coming off him like a stove—

He had said something to her. He had opened his eyes and found her and said something, clearly, the way the very sick sometimes do. And she had come down Coldwater Street with it in her ears and stood at this desk. She had signed her name, Hester Vail, sister, on a form that did not ask what the sleeper himself might have said, because the sleeper himself was not considered competent.

She stepped round it. Quick and practised. She looked at the board over the inner door—DO NOT TOUCH THE CASINGS—and buttoned her right glove over the finger that had.

"Morning, Ennis."

"Morning, Miss Vail. Mind the step."

* * *

Outside, the Sere had got stronger. It came up Coldwater Street in long dry shoves and the salt in it stung her face. Hester turned her collar higher and walked west, away from the sea-wall, toward the harbour and her work.

At the corner of Coldwater and Chandler's Lane the street rose, as all Lowside's streets rose eventually, because Lowside was built on the old seabed and the rest of Ambry was built on the old shore. From the top of the rise you could see over the roofs. She did not usually stop. She stopped today, as you stop to count a change you were sure of.

Lowside lay below her, a slope of grey slate and salt-glazed chimney pots, smoking. Beyond the roofs was the old sea-wall, tall and black and stupid. It had once kept water out of a town that now had no water to keep out. Beyond the wall, the White.

People who had not grown up on the Rim never believed how white it was. They thought it would be grey, or yellow, like sand. It was not. It was the white of new paper and new teeth and bone in the sun. It ran flat to the edge of the world and past it, so flat that the eye kept looking for a slope to make sense of it and failed. In the morning, in Russet, it was faintly rose with the low sun, and the long shallow pans along the margin, where the brine stood, were coloured in bands: pink, and copper-green, and pink again, where the shrimp and the weed were. Out on it, small, the sails of two landships were standing in toward the harbour, white on white. One had three masts. It was the *Constant Wren*, a day early. Hester knew her by the set of her topsails, which was not a thing she had ever

wanted to know; twenty-one years in the Customs House teach you a few things whether you want them or not.

And two miles out, east, on the only rise in all that flatness, the Halcyon.

You could not see much of it from here. A dome of salt, white on the white, that might have been a cloud's shadow except that shadows are darker. On top of it the Lantern stood up thin and bright and tall: a tower of salt-glass and iron. At its head the great mirrors turned slowly all day to take the sun and send it down into the dome. As she watched, the Lantern's head flashed once, white and hard, as the mirrors came round. It would go on like that till dusk, the long slow blink that the whole city lived under and no longer saw.

Somewhere under that dome, Mr. Pell's letter of midsummer was presumably sitting on somebody's desk.

Hester had never been to the Halcyon. She had never had cause to go. The Halcyon came to the Customs House when it wanted something, in the persons of its Readers, men and women in grey wool gowns who smelled faintly of brine and were always cold. They tasted her grain and countersigned her schedules and occasionally, when they were young, tried to explain to her what she had just told them. It was where the grain went, and where the light came from, and it was where you sent the clever children of the Upper Ward, and Lowside's children if Lowside's children were very clever and very lucky. Then you got them back thirty years later, Settled, with white hair and salt in their tears. It was a fact of the landscape, like the sea-wall.

The taste of the drop was still faintly on her tongue. Quick.

She thought: something in that room is leaving.

She thought: it is leaving east.

The Lantern flashed. Down in the harbour, a bell began to ring for the *Constant Wren*, which meant that the excisemen were going down to the quay and that in about half an hour Comptroller Mallory would want to know where the assayer was. Hester put her bare hand in her pocket, found the edge of her purse and closed her fingers on it. She told herself she was counting. Then she went down Chandler's Lane toward the harbour, fast, with the wind behind her, and did not look east again.

CHAPTER 2

# *The Dry Harbour*



*Grain shall be declared by grade, as Shelf, Middling, or Deep. False declaration is fraud. No declaration of Hush grain shall be received, there being none lawfully for sale.*

— Customs Schedule of the Free City of Ambry, Article IX

The harbour of Ambry had been dry for nine hundred years, and nobody had told the harbour.

It still had the long curve of the quay in black Marrane stone, with iron bollards worn bright by the ropes of ships that had been firewood for centuries. It had taverns called the Anchor and the Mermaid and the Drowned Man, after things no living person in Ambry had ever seen. It had steps going down from the quay to where the water had been, and at the bottom the steps simply stopped, at the White, level and blank, with a fringe of grey crust piled against the stone like snow against a door. On the wall above them you could still see three tide-marks, faint and brown, one above another. Lowside children were told they were the marks of the sea's fingers, where it had held on before it went.

The landships moored where the ships had. They came in off the White under bare poles, iron runners grinding and then hissing as the pilots dropped the brakes, and rode up ramps of raked salt to rest with their bowsprits over the quay and their sterns out on the plain. In a good season there were forty of them at once, hulls painted blue and red and ochre, sails furled grey. From the end of the quay it looked like a picture of a harbour. You could almost hear water.

Hester could not hear water. She could hear Comptroller Mallory.

"Vail. *Vail*. The *Wren*'s been on the ramp twenty minutes and I've excisemen standing about on the quay like hens. Where have you been?"

"The first of the month, sir."

"The first of the—" Mallory remembered, visibly, and visibly decided not to have remembered. He was a heavy, soft, careful man with a reddish wig that sat on him like a cat on a fence. Daisy had been right about the wet fox. "Well, you're here now. Forty crates. Ferrers and Lisk. Shelf grain for curing, so the manifest says, Exchequer-certified at the warehouse in Quell. Sample it and sign it, and let's have the excise off and the *Wren* unloaded before the Sere takes the roof off."

"Exchequer-certified in Quell," Hester said.

"So the manifest says. Sample it, Vail. Sign it."

* * *

The assay room of the Ambry Customs House was on the second floor at the back, above the bond-shed. It had north light, which was the only good thing about it. It had a long bench of slate scarred by two hundred years of grain, a rack of brass scales, and a rack of tasting spoons in horn and silver, horn for Shelf and silver for anything better. It had a cupboard of reference grains in sealed jars, labelled by assayers long dead. It had a stove that did not work. It had Daisy Fenn.

"She lives," said Daisy, as Hester came in. "Mallory's been hopping like a man with a wasp in his breeches. I told him you were at your devotions."

"I was at the Cold House."

"I know where you were, duck. I didn't tell *him*." Daisy was forty-one, round, quick and loud. She had five children and had been back on her stool nine days after the fifth. She had an assayer's eye, though not the tongue, and she kept the most accurate ledger in the Customs House. "How's your lad?"

Hester hung her coat on its nail. She thought about the beads.

"Same," she said. Then, because it was Daisy: "Weeping."

Daisy's face changed. "Oh, Hes."

"Fourteen of them. The charity ward. Pell says it's damp."

"*Damp*." Daisy put an enormous amount of opinion into one syllable. Then she looked at Hester's face again and put her pen down. "What d'you want me to do?"

"Nothing. Sample the *Wren*." Hester took down the horn spoons and a small brass scale and the tray of numbered dishes. "Did you see the manifest? Certified in Quell."

"The Exchequer hasn't a warehouse in Quell."

"Mallory," said Hester, "would say the Exchequer has a warehouse on the moon, if Ferrers and Lisk put it on a manifest in a good hand."

Daisy snorted and went back to her ledger.

The excisemen brought up five crates under seal, one in eight, as the law required. They were good Hask pine, iron-banded, with the Ferrers and Lisk mark burned into the lids, an F and an L leaning on each other like drunk men. Inside, under sacking, the grain was packed in waxed paper bundles of five pounds each. She chose one from the top of the first crate, one from the middle of the third and one from the bottom of the fifth, which meant unpacking it, which made the excisemen sigh. She laid the three bundles on the slate and opened them.

Shelf grain was grey-white and coarse, a little damp, with a cold sulphurous smell like a cellar step. It came out of open pits in the first few fathoms, and it kept a herring for a season.

This grain was white the way the White was white in high summer, so white it had a little blue in it: large clean-edged cubes, some as big as her thumbnail, perfectly dry. And it was warm.

Hester had put her hand flat on the open bundle to feel its weight, as she always did. She took her hand away and looked at it. Then she put it back.

Warm. Not hot: the warmth of a stone wall in the evening after a sunny day. Grain was cold, always, and the deeper it came up from, the colder. Shelf was cold, Middling colder, and Deep so cold that the Readers who handled it wore gloves.

This was warm.

"Daisy."

"Mm."

"Come and put your hand on this."

Daisy came. She put her hand on it, flat, and her eyebrows went up into her cap.

"It's been in the sun," she said. "On deck."

"It's been in a crate, in a hold, under sacking, for three days on the White. And it's the third bell of a Russet morning." She took up a pair of fine brass tweezers, lifted out one of the large crystals and held it to the north light.

It was clear, a cube with slightly bevelled edges, the kind you got only from deep grain. And inside it, near one corner, there was a bead.

At first she thought it was a bubble. Inclusions were common; the old delvers called them *eyes*. But eyes in grain were always still, sealed in the crystal long ago. This bead moved. As she turned the crystal in the tweezers it slid along the inner face toward the lowest point, slow as honey. When she turned it back it slid back, and settled, and trembled.

Liquid. Liquid water, in grain, moving.

Hester set the crystal down gently in a dish and stood with her hands flat on the bench.

"Hes?" said Daisy.

"Get me the reference jars," Hester said. "The Deep. All of them. And the—" She thought. "The old cupboard. The bottom shelf. The ones Mr. Thorne put up."

"Those are Halcyon samples. We're not supposed to open those without a Reader present."

"Then don't watch me open them."

* * *

It took her an hour. The excisemen, bored, went down to the quay to smoke. Mallory came up once, saw her face, and went down again. Daisy did not go anywhere.

Hester did it properly, because if she was right she was going to need to be believed. She weighed. She crumbled. She dissolved a measured pinch of the warm grain in fresh brine, and it went down slowly, sullenly, as though reluctant to let go of being salt. She did the same with the reference jars of Deep at forty fathoms and eighty and a hundred and forty, sealed in wax by the Halcyon in 861. The Ferrers grain dissolved slower than any of them.

Then she tasted.

She tasted the Shelf first, to clear her mouth: a feather on each eyelid. Then the Middling. Then the Deep at forty, at eighty, at a hundred and forty, each sweeter and heavier, until the coins on her eyelids were gold sovereigns and she had to sit down and wait for her eyes to stop watering. It was the deepest grain she had ever had in her mouth, and only a dozen times in her life; the Brineries took nearly all of it, to keep people.

She rinsed her mouth three times. She took a single grain of the warm white salt from the *Constant Wren*, no larger than a sesame seed, on the tip of a silver spoon, and put it on her tongue.

The weight came down behind her eyes like a door closing.

It was nothing like the Deep at a hundred and forty. It was heavier, so heavy that for an instant she could see only white, and in the white something enormous pressing, pressing, on the far side of her face. The sweetness was so deep it was nearly bitter. She knew, as surely as she had known anything on that stool, that this salt had not come from a hundred and forty fathoms, or from three hundred. It came from a depth only one institution on the Rim was licensed to dig to, and the Charter said, in so many words, that grain from that depth could not be sold.

And under the weight, under the sweetness, the other thing. Bright and metallic and wet. A bitten tongue. A startle. The taste of the bead in Tib's casing, the taste of something going somewhere.

Quick.

She sat with her eyes shut and the salt dissolving on her tongue and her hands gripping the edge of the slate. Then, because she did not know when she would have the chance again, she did the thing she was not, strictly, licensed to do.

She went into the hold.

Nobody had taught her. She had found it out at fourteen, on this same stool, with a pinch of Middling on her tongue: that if she went still enough, still as a cat before it jumps, the taste opened. Breath slow. Heart slow. Hands, shoulders, the muscles of her face. The whole of her settling round the grain like silt in a glass, until she was nearly as still as it was. Then the salt, which had been only a taste, became a place.

Readers called it *reading*. In the Customs House it was called nothing, because the Customs House did not officially know that its assayer could do it.

She went still. The office went away.

For a moment there was only the white, and the weight. Then there was a sound.

A roar. Everyone said that, the few who could read deep grain and the many who said they could: old grain from the White held a roar, like a shell held to the ear. The Readers said it was the noise of the Ebb, the great crust forming, caught in the salt as it set. Hester had heard it in the reference Deep, faintly, like wind under a door. Now it filled her: a vast low rushing with a shape to it she could not

grasp, a rise and a fall, a rise and a fall, and the rise coming again before the fall had finished.

And over it, inside it, something else.

A cry. High and falling. Two notes and then a third that cracked. A sound like a gate hinge, or a child calling a long way off, or a cat, though it was not a cat. It came once and then again, closer, and then a third time, and something in the back of her neck went cold. She did not know it. She had grown up on the Rim and lived thirty-three years in Ambry and she did not know what it was. It was a living sound. She was sure of that. Something in that salt had been alive, and crying out, at the moment the salt had set.

She came out of the hold the way you come up from deep water, too fast, with a sound in her own throat. She was on the stool. Daisy had both hands on her shoulders.

"Hes. *Hester*."

"I'm all right."

"You went—you went all still. Like a—like one of *them*." Daisy's round face was blotched. "Your lips went blue."

"I'm all right." Her hands were cold. Her mouth was dry. She found the water jug without looking and drank from it, the whole thing, and her throat was still dry. "Daisy, write this down. Write it in the ledger. In ink."

"Write what?"

"That the *Constant Wren* cargo, Ferrers and Lisk, manifested as Shelf grain for curing, is not Shelf. It is not Middling. It is not Deep." Her voice came out steady. That was good. She would need it steady. "It's Hush grain."

Daisy stared at her.

"And it's quickened."

* * *

There was a scene, of course. Hester had known there would be a scene.

Comptroller Mallory came up the stairs at a speed he would not have attempted for his own house on fire. He stood in the door with his wig askew and told her in a hoarse whisper what she could not do. She could not seize an Exchequer contractor's cargo on the basis of a *taste*. She could not write *Hush grain* in the Customs House ledger, because no such category legally existed in trade. She could

not have Ferrers and Lisk's crates nailed shut and carried into the bond-shed and sealed with the blue seal of the Free City of Ambry, which was what she had already had the excisemen do while he was coming up the stairs.

"It's the Exchequer's own contractor," he said. "Ferrers and Lisk. *Ferrers*. Do you know whose name that is, Vail? Do you know whose cousin—"

"I know whose name it is, sir."

"Then you'll release it."

"I'll not."

The room went quiet. Down on the quay someone was shouting at a winch.

"I'll not release it," Hester said. She had not decided to stand, but she was standing, and she was taller than Mallory, as she was taller than most men, and she let him see it. "Article Nine. No declaration of Hush grain shall be received, there being none lawfully for sale. If there's Hush grain on the *Wren*, then there's grain on the *Wren* that's been unlawfully sold. The Customs House is required to seize it and to notify the Halcyon under the Charter. And there is. And I have. Daisy has it in the ledger."

"In ink," said Daisy, who had gone pink and stubborn.

"And under Article Twelve," Hester went on, "the Halcyon is required to send its Inspector of Trade Grain to confirm or overturn the seizure within the day. If he overturns it, sir, I'll carry the crates down to the quay on my own back and apologise to Mr. Ferrers in writing. If he doesn't—"

She stopped short of *then you'll want to have been on the right side of the ledger*. Mallory had a daughter at the Glassmarket school, and he was not a wicked man. He was a soft man in a hard place, and he had looked, for a moment, frightened, and she did not think it was of her.

"Send for the Inspector," Mallory said at last. His voice was thick. "Send for him, then. On your head, Vail."

"Yes, sir."

He went down the stairs. Daisy let out a long breath and put her face in her hands.

"*On your head,*" she said through her fingers. "Oh, Hes. Oh, you great stubborn *mule*."

"It's Hush grain," Hester said.

"I know. I wrote it down." Daisy took her hands away. "What was it? When you went still. What did you—what's it like?"

Hester thought about the cry. Two notes, and a third that cracked.

"Loud," she said.

* * *

The Halcyon's Inspector of Trade Grain arrived at a quarter past the ninth bell, when the light was gone from the north window and Daisy had gone home to her five children and the assay room was lit by a single oil lamp that smoked. Hester had sent the runner at noon. She had begun to think that the Halcyon, like Mr. Pell, was going to turn out to be at its sister's.

She heard him before she saw him. Somebody was coming up the stairs two at a time and humming. Not a tune: the hum of a man thinking, who has forgotten that other people have ears. The door banged open and a man stood in it, out of breath, in a grey wool gown with a white cord at the shoulder and the hem of the gown spattered to the knee with salt-mud.

"Inspector," he said, "of Trade Grain. Aske. Corvin Aske. I'm sorry, I'm late, I was below when your runner came and then the lift stuck, and the Causeway's solid with ox-drays, so I sailed. Where is it?"

He was about forty-five, thin, with a long clever face and spectacles so thick that his eyes swam behind them like fish in a bowl. His hair stood up. His fingers were stained to the second knuckle with ink, black on the right hand and blue on the left, as if he wrote with both. He was cold; she could see it from the bench in the blue line of his lips and the hands tucked under his arms, as all grain-workers tucked them.

"In the bond-shed," Hester said. "Under seal. I kept back samples." She pushed the tray of numbered dishes across the slate toward him.

"You did? Good. Good." He came to the bench and bent over the dishes, bringing his face close to them, eighteen inches, twelve, six, peering. "Whose bench is this?"

"Mine."

"Yours." He looked up. Behind the spectacles his eyes went over her, her customs blue, the darned elbow, the stool. "You're the assayer."

"I am."

"You're the one who wrote *Hush*." He said it the way a man might say *you're the one who saw the comet*. "On the seizure. Your runner had a copy. *Hush grain, quickened*. In ink. I've never seen a customs house write that. Nobody's supposed

to know what it *means* outside the Halcyon. What made you—no. Wait. Don't tell me." He took a small horn case from inside his gown, and from it a spoon of some white metal she did not know, finer than any on her rack. "May I?"

"It's your Charter."

"Ha. So it is." He took a grain from the third dish on the tip of the white spoon and put it on his tongue.

She had watched a good many Readers taste grain, mostly with an absent-minded grandeur, like men tasting wine at a dinner they were bored by. Aske shut his eyes. He went still, not deeply, but enough; she saw his breathing slow and the colour go out of his lips. For a count of twenty he stood like that in the lamplight, his ink-stained hands flat on the slate.

Then he opened his eyes and said, very softly, "Oh, that's *wrong*."

His hands were shaking.

"That's beautifully wrong," he said. "That's the most wrong thing I've had in my mouth in twenty years. From Quell, the manifest says? From *Quell*." He gave a short laugh that had nothing funny in it. "That didn't come from Quell. That came from under my feet. That came from—" He stopped. He looked at Hester as if he had just remembered that she was a person and not a piece of furniture. "You tasted it."

"I tasted it."

"And you knew it was Hush grain. By taste."

"By weight," Hester said. "Taste gives me the grade. Weight gives me the depth. I've never had Hush grain in my mouth before today, so I couldn't swear to it by comparison. But I've had the Deep at a hundred and forty from the Halcyon reference cupboard, and this is near twice the weight. There's nothing I know of on the open White that goes deeper than that. So it's from under your feet. And it's quick."

"*Quick*." He was staring at her. "You said quick on the seizure, too. Where did you learn that word?"

"An assayer called Thorne. He had this stool before me." She paused. "He's dead."

"I knew Thorne. He couldn't taste quick. Nobody can taste quick, it's not a —" Aske stopped again. He brought out of his gown a flat leather case, the size of a prayer book, and laid it on the slate and opened it. Inside, in twelve wells lined

with green baize, were twelve pinches of grain, each numbered in brass and nothing else. "Would you do something for me, Miss—?"

"Vail."

"Miss Vail. Would you tell me what these are?"

It was a test. She knew it was a test, and he knew she knew. She thought about the blue seal on the bond-shed door, and what it would cost her in the morning if this thin, cold, humming man went back across the White and wrote that the Ambry assayer had seized a Ferrers cargo on the strength of a taste and been wrong.

She rinsed her mouth. She took up a horn spoon.

She did all twelve. It took her the better part of the tenth bell. The Customs House around her was dark and creaking and cold, and somewhere below her the night watchman was singing to himself in the bond-shed. Aske did not speak once. He stood by the bench with his arms folded and his hands in his armpits, and watched her, and hummed under his breath.

"One," she said. "Shelf, under two fathoms, Southern Rim margin, from the taste of the sulphur. Two. Middling, about twenty. Three. Middling, thirty-five, thereabouts, and it's been dried in an oven, badly, because it's lost its sweet at the edges. Four. Deep, sixty. Five. Dead salt. Varrow rock-salt. You put that in to see if I'd guess. Six. Deep. Ninety, a hundred. Old. It's been out of the ground—" She paused, tasting. "Forty years? Fifty. Seven. Shelf. Eight. Middling. Twenty-five. Nine. Deep." That one was strange. She held it on her tongue for a long time. "This one's been kept. It's casing grain. Somebody kept something in it, and then returned it, and then used the same grain again to keep something else. It's—tired. Twice-used. I didn't know you could do that."

"You can't," said Aske, "lawfully. Go on."

"Ten. Middling, Western Rim, about fifteen. Eleven. Deep, two hundred, from the Halcyon's own pits, I'd say. It's got that sort of cleanness the Halcyon reference jars have. And twelve." She tasted twelve. She sat back. "Twelve's the same as the *Wren*."

The watchman was still singing in the bond-shed. Aske was not humming any more.

"Twelve's from the Fifth Fathom stays," he said. "Hush-grade. Pushed up from below. Quickened. I took it with my own hands two days ago, and it is not supposed to exist anywhere on the Rim except in a locked cabinet in my work-

room. And you've just graded the other eleven better than half the Readers on my own Bench could." He took his spectacles off and did not wipe them. Without them his face was naked and myopic and younger. "Who taught you?"

"Nobody taught me. I watched Thorne."

"You read, too. You went into the hold to read the *Wren* grain. Didn't you?" He saw her face. "It's all right. I won't put it in my report. I'm not a Proctor. What did you hear?"

She hesitated. She had not told Daisy. She did not know why she wanted to tell this man, except that he had asked the question like a man who actually wanted the answer.

"The Roar," she said. "Like everyone says. But louder. And—something in it."

"What?"

"A cry. An animal. Something alive." She heard how it sounded and set her jaw. "High, and falling. Like a hinge. I don't know what it was. I've never heard it."

Aske was quiet a moment.

"No," he said. "No, I don't suppose you have."

He put his spectacles back on. He closed the leather case. He looked round the assay room: at the cracked slate, at the dead stove, at the reference cupboard with Mr. Thorne's labels.

"How long have you been on this stool, Miss Vail?"

"Fourteen years on the stool. Twenty-one in the House."

"What do they pay you?"

She told him. He winced.

"I'm going to confirm your seizure," he said. "Tonight. In writing, in ink, under the Charter, with my seal on it, and send a copy to the Proctory and another to the Exchequer, and I'm going to enjoy that last one very much. And then I'm going to make you an offer. You'll say no, I expect. People like you generally do. I'm going to make it anyway."

"What offer?"

"I'm a Reader of the Halcyon," Aske said. "Assay Bench. Once in ten years a Reader may admit a candidate to the Collegium without fees. It's called the Reader's Privilege. I've never used mine. I've never met anyone I wanted to use it on. The Turning Intake matriculates on the sixth. That's five days. You'd have to pass the Entry Assay, but you've just passed it, more or less, on a customs bench in the

dark. I'd sponsor you on my Bench. You'd learn to do properly what you've been doing by instinct, and a great deal you've never dreamed of. I think you might be the best tongue I've ever met."

Hester looked at him.

"No," she said.

"No?"

"I've a brother," she said. "In the Cold House. I pay for him. Six sols a month. The Halcyon doesn't pay its aspirants, I know that much. Fees or no fees, I'd have no wage."

"There are stipends—"

"Thank you, Reader." She stood up. She was conscious of her darned elbow and the smoking lamp, and of her whole life arranged on and around this stool like the tools in their racks. "It's kind. I'm not a child. I've a wage and a debt and a brother. I'll not throw them over for the chance of a gown."

Aske did not argue. He nodded slowly, as if she had confirmed a grade he had expected. He took a card from his gown and wrote something on the back of it in blue ink with his left hand and put it on the slate beside the dishes.

"My lodging," he said. "Harker's the bookbinder. I'm there until the sixth." He turned to go. At the door he stopped, with his back to her, and stood a moment, and when he turned round his face had changed.

"Your brother," he said. "In the Cold House. Has his casing been weeping?"

The watchman had stopped singing. Hester stood very still.

"How do you know that?"

"Because I've seen it," said Aske. "Not at the Cold House; I've never been inside the Cold House. Elsewhere. Things that are kept, weeping. And grain coming up from the Fifth that tastes like that cargo." He looked at the dishes on the slate, at the warm white salt in its waxed paper. "Something is wrong in the deep, Miss Vail. I've thought so for a year. I don't know what it is. I think—" He stopped himself, visibly. "I think it would be useful to have someone with your tongue, finding out."

He went out. She heard him going down the stairs two at a time, humming.

Hester stood in the assay room for a long time. Then she picked up the card. On the front, engraved, it said *Corvin Aske, Reader, the Halcyon.* On the back, in blue ink, in a small fast hand that sloped hard to the right, it said: *Quill St, above Harker's. Come and find out why.*

She put it in her purse, with the four flecks that were all that was left in it, and blew out the lamp.

CHAPTER 3

# *Spitting Pans*



*A pan that spits is a pan that's talking. Listen before you lid her.*

— Saying of the Lowside brine-boilers

THE BOND-SHED WAS EMPTY.

Hester stood in its door at the first bell of the next morning, with the key in her hand and the blue seal of the Free City of Ambry hanging from the hasp by one string. The other string had been cut neatly, with a knife, close to the wax, so that whoever looked at it first might have taken it for whole. She did not take it for whole. She stood and looked at the floor.

The floor was Marrane flagstone, swept. Yesterday afternoon forty iron-banded crates of Hask pine had stood on it in five stacks of eight, sealed, under the yellow chalk numbers she had written on them herself. They were gone. The floor where they had stood was cleaner than the floor around it. Someone had swept up after them.

"The watchman," she said aloud, to nobody. Then she went to find the watchman, who was asleep in the porter's cubby by the quay door with an empty bottle of Quell clear in his lap. She looked at the bottle a long moment. It was not the kind of bottle a night watchman bought on a night watchman's wage.

She went upstairs to the assay room, and opened the ledger at yesterday's date, and found that the page was not there.

It had not been torn. It had been cut, the same way as the seal string, close to the spine with a good knife. Unless you knew the ledger you would not have seen it. Hester knew the ledger. She ran her thumb along the stub. Then she turned to

the back, where Daisy kept her own fair copy of each day's entries in a smaller, neater hand for the end-of-month returns. That page had been cut too.

She sat down on her stool.

The north window was grey. On the slate in front of her stood the tray of numbered dishes from yesterday, with yesterday's samples still in them. Whoever had cleared the bond-shed had not thought to clear the assay bench, because whoever had cleared the bond-shed did not know much about assay benches. Dish three held a little pyramid of white grain, sharp-cornered, clean. She put her hand flat over it, not touching. Warm.

She took a twist of waxed paper from the drawer and tipped the dish into it and folded the paper small and put it inside her shirt. Then she sat and waited for Comptroller Mallory.

* * *

He came at the third bell, which was early for him. He did not take his coat off. He stood in the doorway with his wig on straight for once and his face the colour of tallow and told her, in the voice of a man reading something he had learned by heart, that she was suspended from her post without pay pending a hearing of the Customs Board. The charge was insubordination to a superior officer and the improper seizure of a lawfully manifested cargo. The cargo had been released overnight on the authority of the Exchequer, and the Customs House would be making a written apology to Messrs. Ferrers and Lisk.

"On whose authority?" Hester said.

"The Exchequer's. I said."

"The Exchequer doesn't have authority over a Charter seizure. Only the Halcyon does. Reader Aske confirmed it. He wrote it in ink. Under seal."

"I've seen no confirmation."

"He sent a copy to you, sir. And one to the Proctory, and one to—"

"I have seen," said Mallory, more loudly, "no confirmation." He looked at the cut stub of the ledger, which she had left open on the slate where he could see it, and looked away. "The hearing will be in Fallow. Or Cinder. You'll be written to. You'll hand in your key."

She held it out to him. He took it without touching her fingers. He was sweating, though the room was cold.

"Sir," she said. "Who came for it?"

Mallory looked at her. For a moment she thought he was going to tell her. His mouth worked.

"Go home, Vail," he said. "For God's sake. Go home."

* * *

Daisy caught her on the stairs. She had her bonnet on still, and her basket, and she pressed Hester against the wall of the stairwell with the whole of her round, furious person and said in a whisper like a kettle, "I heard. I heard it in the street. Hes. They came in the small hours, before first bell, with a dray and six men and a paper with the Exchequer's seal on it, and old Dobbs let them in and they gave him a bottle. Ruth Penny saw it from her window. Six men, Hes, and a seventh who didn't lift a thing. He stood by the dray with a lantern and a paper, and Ruth says when he held the lantern up his coat came open and he'd grey wool under it. *Grey wool.* Like a Reader."

"I know."

"And they cut the ledger. Both ledgers. *My* ledger."

"I know."

"Well, they didn't cut this." Daisy dug in her basket and pushed a folded paper into Hester's hand. "Bill of lading. The *Wren*'s. The excise copy. It was in my basket all night, because I took it home to write the duty out fair and then I fell asleep over it, because Marguerite was up half the night, the little madam. So it's the only one. Take it. Take it, before I lose my nerve and go and give it to Mallory."

Hester unfolded it. It was the standard form, printed in Ambry black, filled out in a clerk's fast copperplate. *Vessel: Constant Wren. Master: Jas. Orrick. Consignee: Messrs. Ferrers & Lisk, Exchequer Yard. Cargo: 40 cases Shelf grain (curing), Exch. cert. Quell.* And at the bottom, in the box for the shipper's mark, in a different hand, small and upright and very plain:

*W.L.F. per E.D.*

"Who's W.L.F.?" said Daisy.

"I don't know."

"It's not a firm. I know all the firms."

"I know." Hester folded the paper and put it inside her shirt with the twist of grain. "Ta, Daisy."

"Don't *ta* me. What are you going to do?"

Hester did not know. She stood on the stairs in her customs blue that she would have to take off, with no key, and no wage. She had four flecks in her purse, and a card from a Reader of the Halcyon, and a brother who was weeping in lines toward the east.

"Go home," she said. "Like he says."

* * *

She did not go home. She went to see her father, which was worse.

The Lowside Pans lay on the north edge of the district, where a flume on black trestles brought marsh-brine in from the Weeps. Under a long roof with thirty chimneys, thirty iron pans the size of carts stood over thirty fires, boiling the brine down to a white sludge that was raked, dried, and sold at the Corn Exchange as table salt. Dead salt. It kept nothing, it was worth almost nothing, and three hundred Lowside families had lived on it for two hundred years.

Aldous Vail had pan nineteen. He had had pan nineteen for forty years.

She found him in the steam, raking. He was a short wide man with a short wide face and forearms like a shipwright's. Like hers, they were crossed and recrossed with the white seams of old burns. He did not stop raking when he saw her. He looked up once, through the steam, and down again.

"Hes."

"Da."

"No work?"

She had not told him. She had not told anyone but Daisy. It did not surprise her that he knew. The Pans knew everything that happened in Lowside about an hour after it happened, because the Pans were where Lowside's men went when they had nowhere else to go.

"Suspended," she said.

"Why?"

"I seized a cargo."

"Whose?"

"Ferrers."

He grunted. It might have been a laugh. He raked, and the rake went *hush, hush* in the sludge. The heat came off the pan in a solid wall. Her face was already wet with it.

"Well," he said. "That's a daft thing to have done."

"It was the right thing."

"Aye. Usually is, the daft thing." He knocked the rake on the pan-edge and the white sludge fell off it in lumps. "You want money?"

"No."

"I haven't got any."

"I know, Da."

They stood. Pan eighteen and pan twenty were going on either side, the boilers stripped to the waist, shining, raking. Nobody looked at them. In the Pans you did not look at a man talking to his daughter, the same as you did not look at a man being sick.

"It's Tib," she said.

He did not stop raking. But the rhythm changed. A half-beat.

"His casing's weeping," she said. "Fourteen of them are, in the charity ward. Agathe says they'll thin, and crack, and come back. Pell says it's damp."

"Pell's an arse."

"Yes."

"Is it the damp?"

"No."

Aldous raked. *Hush, hush.* He was sixty-one. His hair, what was left of it, was white, and his face in the steam was red and glazed like a pot. He had not been inside the Cold House in nine years. He had gone twice a month for the first two years. Then once, with drink on him, he had stood at the end of the fourth row and said to Hester, loudly, *What are we doing to him? What are we doing?* Then he had walked out. He had not been back. He paid nothing toward the fee. It was one of the many things they did not discuss.

"Let him go, Hes," he said.

"No."

"Eleven years." He did not look up. "Eleven years and nothing. No cure. No nothing. The bloom's the bloom. They've been keeping bloomers since your grandmother's time and none of them's come back cured, not one, not in the Cold House and not in the fancy houses up the hill neither. They come back and they die. That's all they do. Let the lad go."

"He's not dying. He's kept."

"He's dying slow, is what he is. Slowest a lad ever died."

"He's alive, Da. He's alive in law. Agathe says his casing's clear, he's as clear as the day—"

"I know what Agathe says." He set the rake down against the pan's rim, hard, so that it rang. He turned to look at her for the first time. His eyes were small and pale and bloodshot from the steam, and very steady. "I know what it says on that board over the door. And I know what he said. I was on the stair, Hes. *Let me sleep*, he said. *Just let me sleep*. You think I didn't hear him?"

"He asked to sleep," Hester said. Her voice did not come out as she meant it to. "That's what keeping is. It's sleep. He asked for it."

Her father only looked at her. She had not known that he heard.

It went through her like the cold goes through you on the White at night, when the sun drops and the tiles begin to tick. For a moment the heat of the Pans was nowhere. She could not have said anything if she had tried.

Aldous looked at her. Then he looked away, down at the pan, and picked the rake up again. He seemed smaller.

"Well," he said. "You've your reasons. You always have."

For a long while there was only the rake. Hester stood in the heat with the twist of warm grain against her ribs and the bill of lading crackling when she breathed. She thought that she had perhaps never in her life been so near to walking away from him for good. She did not walk away. Possibly it was only that she had nowhere else to walk to.

Then pan nineteen spat.

It was a small sound, at first. A tick. A pop, like a knot in a fire. A fleck of white sludge leapt from the surface of the brine and landed on the brick floor at her feet. Then another. Then the whole skin of the pan began to shudder and crack. Little craters opened in it and snapped shut, and white gouts the size of a thumb leapt up and fell back. The tick became a crackle. On pan eighteen the boiler looked round sharply and said, "Nineteen's going, Aldo."

"I've got her."

Hester stepped back. She knew what a spitting pan could do. She had the scars on her arms from it, from the summer she was ten and their mother was dying and she had been sent to help on the pans because there was no one to mind her. A pan that spat in earnest would throw boiling brine across a room. Men had lost eyes to it. The trick, the trick that every child on the Pans was taught, was to drop

the lid on. Each pan had an iron lid on a chain and pulley overhead. You let it down fast, smothered the surface, and waited.

Aldous did not touch the lid chain.

He went to the fire-door instead, under the pan, and opened it with his rake-handle. With the iron hook he began to draw the fire out. Not all at once. A shovelful of coals onto the brick, then another, then a long pause while he watched the surface. The pan crackled and jumped. He drew another shovelful. The crackle slowed. He drew a fourth, and stood back, and the pan went *tick—tick*—and a long pause, and *tick*, and then a soft, continuous, grumbling bubble, low, like a cat purring in another room.

"There," he said to the pan. "There, now. Talk it out."

He stood and watched it, rake in hand, for some time. Then he raked the drawn coals together on the floor and shovelled half of them back, gently, and shut the fire-door.

"You didn't lid it," Hester said.

"No." He wiped his face with the back of his wrist. "You lid a spitting pan, she'll blow the lid through the roof. Or she'll go quiet and you think you've done it. Then you lift the lid, and she goes up in your face all at once. All the steam she's been saving." He knocked the rake on the rim. "Pan spits because there's something in her wants out. Air. Steam. Muck in the bottom. You can't stop it wanting. You take her off the heat slow and let her talk, and it comes out a bit at a time, and nobody gets hurt."

"Who taught you that?"

"Nobody taught me. I lost two fingers' worth of skin finding out." He held up his left hand. She had known since she was a child that the last two fingers were shiny and stiff. She had never asked. "Lid's for when you're in a hurry. Most of what goes wrong in this world, Hes, is folk in a hurry with a lid."

He went back to raking.

She stayed a while. She did not know why she stayed. She stood in the heat and watched him work, and he let her, and neither of them said anything else. When she left she put her hand on his shoulder, on the wet hot skin. He did not stop raking. But he said, without looking round, "Mind the step."

* * *

She sat that night at the table in the room in Tanner's Row and counted. It was the room she had lived in since she was eight. Tib's landships were still on the walls in pencil, at the height of a boy's arm; the paper had been changed twice, and both times she had cut it round them.

Four flecks in her purse. Two sols and nine in the jar. Eleven sols in the Lowside Savings Society. Rent paid to the end of Fallow. She did the sum twice, and both times it came out at two months of Tib's fee, three if she sold her mother's coat, which she would not. No grain-house on the Exchequer Yard would take a suspended assayer; they were owned, all of them, by men who dined with Aurel Ferrers. The Pans would take her at three sols a week, and the arithmetic would come out the same, only slower.

The Halcyon's Stay Choir paid three sols a week too, Lowside said. It paid that to the men and women who went down into the deep Fathoms and came home on their days off with blue lips and a way of sitting very still in taverns, and who came home Settled in their fifties, if they came home. Three sols a week was twelve a month. Tib's fee was six.

She thought about Mr. Thorne, who had given her the stool and died on it at sixty-eight, Settled, in the north light, sure to the end that the Halcyon Readers were a pack of jumped-up guessers. *They've got the theory, Hessie. We've got the tongue.* She thought about the bill of lading inside her shirt, and the warm grain, and the beads running east. *Pan spits because there's something in her wants out.*

She thought that she had never in her life done anything because she wanted to, only because it wanted doing.

She put the coins back in the jar. She put the card back in her purse. She went to bed, and did not sleep.

* * *

Harker the bookbinder's was in Quill Street, in the Middle Ward, where the streets were cobbled and the houses had window boxes and nobody's shutters were full of salt because the Sere did not come so far uphill. It was a narrow shop smelling of glue and leather. Above it was a narrow stair, and at the top of the stair was a narrow door. Behind it, when she knocked at the second bell on the fourth of Russet, was Corvin Aske in his shirtsleeves with a pen in each hand and ink on his nose.

"Miss Vail," he said. He looked, absurdly, as if he might burst into tears. "Oh, *good*."

The room behind him was a rented room the size of a ship's cabin, and he had filled it with paper. Paper in drifts on the bed and the chair and the windowsill. Paper pinned to the walls, covered on both sides in the small fast sloping hand, black and blue. There were jars of grain, a brine basin on the washstand where the jug should have been, and a tray of tasting spoons. On top of the wardrobe there was a stuffed salt-lark, which looked at her with one glass eye as if it, too, wanted to know what she was doing there.

"I've been suspended," she said, in the doorway. "Without pay. The cargo's gone. Somebody cut the ledger and released it on an Exchequer paper in the middle of the night. My Comptroller says he never saw your confirmation."

"Ah," said Aske. "Yes. I wondered if that would happen." He did not look surprised. He looked tired. "I'm sorry."

"Is the offer still open?"

"Yes. Oh, yes." He began clearing the chair for her, transferring an armful of paper to the bed, where it slid onto the floor. "Sit, please. Sit. I'll make tea. I've no milk. I've some Hask honey. Do you take salt in it? Halcyon people do. It's a disgusting habit. I can't stop."

She sat. He made tea on a spirit stove by the window, talking all the time. He told her the Entry Assay was a formality for anyone who could do what she'd done on the customs bench, though Reader Crisp would be on the panel and Reader Crisp disliked formalities. He told her to bring wool, and more wool. The Choir stipends were real, he said; he could put her name forward, though the Warden down there ran the Choir like a ship.

"I've thought," Hester said.

"Have you? Already?"

"Three sols a week. I can do sums." She took the tea he gave her. It was very strong, with salt in it. She drank it anyway. "Reader. What you said in the Customs House. About something wrong in the deep. And the weeping."

He had been about to sit on the bed. He stopped, half-bent, and then sat, slowly, among the paper. The tea in his hand steamed.

"Yes," he said.

"I want to know what it is."

"So do I."

"No. I mean—" She set the cup down on a pile of paper, carefully, and folded her hands. "My brother's casing is weeping. It's weeping in lines, east, and the brine on it tastes quick. Like that cargo. Like your sample twelve. There are fourteen in the charity ward doing it, and the director says it's damp. And the cargo came off the *Wren* marked Shelf, and somebody with six men and an Exchequer paper took it away in the night. And the bill of lading's got a mark on it I don't know." She took the paper from inside her shirt and unfolded it and held it out to him. "*W.L.F. per E.D.* Do you know what that is?"

Aske took the bill. He looked at it six inches from his spectacles. Then he looked at her over the top of it. His face had gone careful, as if he had stepped from a lit room into a dark one and was waiting for his eyes.

"I don't know whose mark that is," he said. "Not yet. I've a guess I don't like, and I'll not say it in a rented room with a bookbinder's boy under the floor who sells gossip to the *Courant*." He gave her back the bill. "But I'll tell you one thing, since you've earned it. And then I'll tell you why I want you, and it isn't kindness."

"Go on."

"Sample twelve. The grain that tastes like your cargo. We call grain like that quickened. It comes from places under the Halcyon where the salt goes warm and wet and the brine starts to move. Pockets. The Fathomers hold them down; it's their whole job." He turned his cup in his hands. "Five years ago there were four such pockets in the Fifth Fathom. This summer there were fourteen. It's in the Warden's returns to the Conclave, if anyone reads them, which nobody does. I've raised it twice. The second time the Deputy Chancellor thanked me for my diligence and moved to the next business, which was the price of lamp oil."

Hester said nothing. Fourteen. The same number as the casings. It meant nothing; numbers came round. She noted it anyway, as she would have noted a short weight.

"So that's why," Aske said. "I'm a Reader with a hobby and a reputation for tasting my own experiments, and nobody listens to me. You're a sworn assayer of the Free City with no stake in the Halcyon at all. If this comes to the Assize, and I'm beginning to think it will, the Assize will believe you before it believes me." He smiled, crookedly. "I did say I'd be honest. I want your tongue, Miss Vail. I want your testimony more."

She looked at him. He looked back, thin and cold and ink-nosed among his drifts of paper, with the salt-lark staring down from the wardrobe.

"All right," she said.

"All right?"

"I'll come. On the sixth."

He let out a breath that was almost a laugh.

"You won't regret it," he said. Then: "Well. You might. But not for the reasons you think."

* * *

She went to the Cold House on the way home, though it was not the first of the month.

Ennis looked surprised. She said she would not be long. She went down the six worn steps into the cold sweet air and along the fourth row to the third window. The beads were still standing on Tib's casing in their lines. There seemed to her to be more of them. She did not know if that was true or if it was only that she was looking.

"I'm going to the Halcyon," she told him. "Don't laugh."

He did not laugh. His hand lay curled on his chest, holding its pencil.

"I'm going to find out what this is," she said. "That's all. I'm going to find out what it is, and then I'm going to stop it. It's got nothing to do with gowns." She thought. "They have a Lantern. You'd like that. I'll tell you about the Lantern."

Agathe was at the end of the row with her brush and her oil can. She came up slowly when Hester turned to go. She did not ask anything. She looked at Hester's face and seemed to find what she wanted in it.

"I shall write, my dear," she said. "If anything changes. The Halcyon takes letters. I'll write."

"Ta, Mother."

"Tide willing," Agathe said, "you'll find it."

At the top of the six steps Hester stopped and looked back. From the top step the beads were invisible again; the ward was only light lying in rows, and any of it might have been anyone. She stood a moment, and then she went up into the street, where the Sere was coming down Coldwater Street off the White, as it would all through Russet, out of the east.

CHAPTER 4

# *Below the Line*



*Step over, and be below the sea.*

— Formula of Matriculation, the Halcyon

The Causeway began at Eastgate, where Ambry stopped pretending to be a city on a shore. It ran two miles straight out across the White on a bank of fitted stone and packed salt, wide enough for two ox-drays to pass if both drivers were polite. At this hour there were no drays. There was Hester, with a carpetbag in one hand and her mother's coat over her arm, and the White on either side of her, and nothing else.

The kept-light posts along the Causeway were still lit. They stood every forty yards, and in each glass bulb a little of last summer's daylight was spending itself, slow and gold. When she passed close under one she felt it on her cheek, faint, like the side of a face turned toward a window. Ambry could not afford kept light in its own streets. The Halcyon lit two miles of empty road with it. Lowside called this an outrage, and so it was, and Hester walked under the posts with the summer on her face and was not as outraged as she had meant to be.

Then the light changed.

It came up ahead of her, so that her shadow ran back along the Causeway toward the city, long and thin, and then the whole White went pink. Not the pans along the margin, which were coloured with weed and shrimp and had been pink all her life. All of it. From the Causeway's edge to the edge of the world the plain took the low sun and turned the colour of the inside of a shell. The cracks

between the salt tiles, invisible at noon, ran out in every direction, a net of fine dark lines thrown over the whole plain.

And the tiles were singing. She had heard it from the sea-wall as a child, on cold nights, a faint ticking out on the White like a great many clocks in another room. Out here it was not faint. The night's cold was going out of the salt and the plates were easing against one another, a thin glassy chatter that came from everywhere at once and stopped wherever she looked. As the sun climbed it thinned and slowed, the way rain stops: here, and here, and then a long pause, and here.

At the far end of the Causeway the Halcyon took the light on its dome.

From here it was a hill, low and broad, and it had been shaped. Its western flank stood dark against the sunrise, terraced and cut with deep-set windows, and while she looked, lamps came on behind the salt-glass one after another, so that the whole face of the dome lit up row by row like a ledger being filled in. On the crown, the Lantern. As she watched, its mirrors turned, with a sound that came to her across a mile of salt as a low iron grinding, and found the sun, and flashed it down.

Hester stood in the middle of the Causeway with her carpetbag, and for a while she did not do anything at all.

* * *

There was one other person on the Causeway. Hester did not see her until she was close, because she came up from behind, from the city, walking faster, and she was in grey.

She was near sixty, short and broad, with her hands pushed deep in the pockets of a grey wool greatcoat buttoned to the chin. Her hair under a knitted cap was white, not grey, the white of a much older woman, though the face under it was not old: square, weathered, sensible, high-coloured, with lines at the eyes from squinting at things. Her boots were caked to the ankle with salt-mud. Not the dry white dust of the Sere, which was on everybody, but wet grey mud dried in crusts, the kind you got only down by the old sea-wall where the brine seeped.

She slowed alongside and looked Hester up and down: the carpetbag, the coat, the customs blue.

"You're early," she said. "Gate's not open till first bell."

"I know."

"Then you're keen, or you couldn't sleep." The voice was Lowside. Not put on, not left over: the flat Lowside of the streets behind the Pans, the voice Hester heard every day in her own mouth. "I'd guess couldn't sleep. Tall, Lowside, customs blue. You'll be Corvin Aske's privilege."

"Hester Vail."

"Orsolya Thane. Fathoming." She took one hand out of her pocket and held it out. It was cold: not the cold of a morning walk but bone-cold, like taking hold of a railing in winter. The woman saw her notice and smiled. "Occupational. You'll have it yourself soon enough. Corvin's been crowing about you all week. Says you graded his tray blind in the dark. Says you tasted quick." The smile widened. "Well done, chick. That's the stuff."

Hester had not been called *chick* since her mother died.

"You've come from the city," she said, for something to say.

"Early business. The deep doesn't sleep, so Fathomers don't." Thane glanced back over her shoulder at Ambry, at the black line of the sea-wall and the smoke of Lowside going gold. Something crossed her face too fast to read. Then she tucked her cold hand away. "Go on in. Tell the porter at the Gate I said you could wait in the warm. He'll grumble. Let him." She started past, and stopped. "Your brother's kept, Corvin says. I'm sorry for it. I'm Lowside myself. My da was a delver. I know what a fee is."

She nodded once, briskly, and went on toward the Halcyon. Hester followed at a distance, and did not catch up.

* * *

The Gatehouse was a squat drum of grey stone at the Causeway's end, with a porter who did grumble, and let her sit by his stove. At first bell the doors opened. By the third there were a hundred and more people in the round hall with their bags and boxes and families, and the hall smelt of wet wool and anxiety and the oranges somebody's mother had brought.

They were not the children she had expected. There were a few sons of the Upper Ward, nineteen and pink, in coats that had cost a year of her wages. But most were older: a woman of forty with a baby on her hip; a bald man in a Delvers' Guild jacket with blue lips; two Quellish sisters arguing in Quellish; a Haskish giant with a red beard who had to duck under the lintel. Everyone had given something up to be here, and they stood as if the floor might be taken away.

The floor was what they were all looking at.

Set into the grey flagstones, running the full width of the hall, was a strip of brass as wide as her hand, polished so bright it hurt. At its centre was engraved the halcyon of the Halcyon's arms: a bird on a straight line. Beyond it the floor went on exactly as before. Nobody had stepped over. People walked up to it, and looked, and walked away again.

"The old waterline," said a voice at her elbow. "Before the Ebb. That's where the sea came up to, they say. Everything past it is below the sea."

The speaker was a man of about twenty-five, round-faced, with a gap between his front teeth and a slab of bread and cheese from which he had been eating steadily since before he spoke. A long grey shawl was wrapped round his shoulders, the coarse undyed kind Tider novices wore, pinned with a little brass wave like Agathe's.

"You're Tider," Hester said.

"I was. I am. It depends who's asking and how drunk I am." He swallowed. "Teodor Anselm. Teo. Nine years at Tidewater Abbey, which is to say I can sing the Vigil Office in four modes and have never once been allowed second helpings. I'm making up for it." He held out the bread. "You look as if you walked here."

"From Lowside."

"Ah. Then you'll be the customs woman. I heard about you at the porter's stove. Graded twelve blind for a Reader in the middle of the night. They're laying odds on how fast Crisp fails you." He beamed. "Two to one against inside the hour. I put a fleck on you. Don't let me down. It's my last fleck."

* * *

The Entry Assay was held in a room off the hall, one candidate at a time.

Three Readers sat behind a table. One was a sleepy old man who never opened his eyes. One was a florid gentleman with a gold cord and rings on every finger, who smiled at her as if she were a cake. The third was a woman of about sixty with grey hair drawn back tight enough to hurt and a blue cord at her shoulder. Her mouth looked as though it had been ruled with a straight-edge. The card in front of her said *Reader M. Crisp. Keeping*.

On the table were twelve covered dishes and a basin of brine.

"Grade the grains," said Reader Crisp. "Then tell us which of the objects in the room is kept. Then enter the hold and keep a drop of that brine. Begin."

The grains were easier than Aske's tray. Hester did them fast and aloud, and after the fourth the florid gentleman was making little murmuring noises of pleasure. Crisp wrote on a card and made no noise at all.

"The objects."

There were a dozen: a sprig of lavender under a glass bell, a pewter inkstand, a candle, a pear on a plate, a book, a clock, the Readers' own water-jug and glasses. Hester went and stood beside each in turn and breathed in. At the pear she stopped.

"Not that," said the florid gentleman, delighted. "Everyone picks the pear."

Hester did not pick the pear. It smelt of ripeness and nothing else. She moved on to the jug, and to the third glass beside it, the one nobody had drunk from, with a little water in the bottom. When she leaned close there was sweetness at the back of her tongue and a feather's weight on her eyelids. Shelf grain. Then she saw it: the water stood a hair higher on one side of the glass than the other. It had been kept in the act of being poured.

"The water in that glass," she said.

The florid gentleman began to laugh, helplessly, into his ringed hand. The sleeping man opened one eye. Crisp wrote.

"The hold," she said.

Hester had gone into the hold perhaps a thousand times, but only to read. She had never put her stillness into anything. She took a pipette of brine and let one drop fall, and as it fell she went down, all the way, as she had on the customs stool with the *Wren* grain on her tongue. She did not know what else to do, so she pushed: pushed the stillness out of herself and at the drop, as you put your shoulder to a door.

The drop stopped a quarter-inch below the pipette's mouth, a clear bead the morning light came through. It did not fall.

Her hands went cold to the wrist. There was a grey edge to the room and a roaring in her ears, and when it cleared the clock on the wall had moved a full minute, and the florid gentleman was on his feet.

"Sit down, Bassano," said Crisp, without looking at him. She touched the drop with a glass rod. It came away hard: a bead of salt-glass, round as a pearl, with water locked in it. She held it to the light.

"Crude," she said. "Deep. Square. You lagged a minute on a drop of brine. That's absurd." She laid the bead on her card. "Pass. Next."

* * *

Teo won his fleck, and was still telling her how pleased he was when the Proctor at the inner doors called the intake to order. The hundred and ten who had passed shuffled into a line along the brass, and the porter swung the far doors open.

There was no speech. There was only the Proctor, a heavy grey man with a list, calling names, and at each name a person stepping over the Line onto the stones beyond and being handed a folded grey gown. Some stepped over solemnly. Some hopped. The Haskish giant took it in one stride and looked back at it, puzzled, as if he had expected it to feel like something. The woman with the baby passed the baby to her husband, stepped over, turned, and took it back across, so that the baby was below the sea too.

"Anselm, Teodor."

Teo stepped over as he might have stepped into a church. On the far side he touched the brass wave at his throat and laughed at himself.

"Ferrers, Lucan."

One of the young men from the far wall went over. He was tall and fair and very straight, with a long elegant face and the expression of a man asked to attend something slightly beneath him. He took his gown as if it might be catching. When he turned, his eye passed along the line of waiting candidates and stopped on Hester's customs blue, and went faintly amused.

"I see Customs sends its sweepers now," he remarked, to nobody, not quite loud enough to be rude and not quite quiet enough not to be heard.

"Sweepers and assayers," said Hester. "Somebody has to check the weights. Your father's especially."

Somebody along the Line choked. Lucan Ferrers looked at her for a long, level moment with no expression at all, and turned away.

"Vail, Hester."

She stepped over. It was a strip of brass. It felt like nothing. She took her gown.

* * *

"Well, that was a good start," said a dry voice, as the intake was herded through the far doors. "Below the sea for a count of twenty and you've already insulted the Lord Exchequer's only son."

The woman who had fallen into step beside her was about thirty, small and quick, with a pointed face and dark hair cut square at the jaw. She wore the grey gown already, with a gold cord, and wore it well; she had altered the shoulders. She had a flat, fast Quellish accent and the air of someone pricing everything she passed, Hester included.

"Saskia Orme. Lumen. Bassano's Bench. Thaw Intake, so I've been here half a year longer than you and know where the privies are. Bassano likes to inflict me on people." She glanced at the carpetbag, the darned elbow. "Aske's charity case."

"Aske's privilege."

"Same thing, said nicely." Saskia did not smile. "Keep up. It's nine hundred steps to the Fifth and I'm not carrying anyone."

The tour went down.

That was the whole of it: down. The far doors gave onto a gallery cut in the salt, and the gallery gave onto the Stair, and Hester stood at its rail and looked.

The Stair was a spiral wide enough for four abreast, winding round a central well so deep that its bottom was lost in a soft brown dusk. The walls were salt, polished by nine hundred years of hands to the look of old ivory, and where lamps hung the light went into them a little way, so that they glowed pink near the brackets and paled to cream between. Down the centre of the well, from far above to far below, fell the Lantern's light, sent down from the mirrors through a shaft in the dome, straight and gold and solid as a rope. Salt motes turned in it.

On the walls, all the way down as far as she could see, there were names. Thousands of them, close-written in chalk in a hundred hands, the newest white and sharp, the oldest faded almost to the colour of the salt.

"The Settled," said Saskia. "Everyone who's gone down and not come back up quite right. They rechalk them every year at the Silent Supper. Don't read them. People stop and read them and then they cry and then they're late for Lumen."

The First Fathom: the Benches, tiers of salt seats worn into dishes by nine centuries of scholarly behinds; the Long Table, carved from the living floor. The Second: the Brinestacks, glimpsed through a door, shelves of books going back into the dark and shelves of white tablets that caught the light. At a desk by the

door an old man sat so motionless that Hester took him for a carving until she saw that he was holding a pen.

"Callow," said Saskia. "Under-Archivist. He's past eighty and mostly Settled and nobody's seen him move since the Thaw. We call him the furniture. Don't knock him over."

The Third: a long gallery of numbered doors with brass plates. "Readers' workrooms. They call them Cells, which tells you what they think of us." Kilns breathing heat through a grating; a smell of hot glass. A door marked *3-17* with no name on it, only a tongue drawn in chalk that somebody had tried and failed to rub off.

"Aske's," said Saskia. "His aspirants did that. He thinks it's funny."

* * *

The Fourth Fathom was colder, and still. The Stair here was lined not with doors but with alcoves, and in the alcoves, on plinths, behind brass rails, were keepings.

"The Quiet Rooms," said Saskia, and for the first time her voice went down a little, as voices do in churches whether their owners believe or not.

There was a single red rose, open, in a casing no bigger than a jar: *Kept 304 Y.E.* There was dew on it. Hester looked at the dew, which had been on that rose for six hundred years.

And in the largest alcove there was a thing that stopped the whole group. It was a casing the height of a tall man, rising from a plinth of black stone, and inside it, top to bottom, ran a crooked fork of light. It was white and blinding, so bright it threw shadows on the alcove walls, and it did not flicker. It was a lightning bolt. Somebody, two hundred years ago, had caught one out on the White as it struck, and held it.

*Kept 712 Y.E. Reader Abelard Fenn and seven of the Choir. Of whom four Settled in the keeping.*

Teo had his hand on the brass wave at his throat. The Haskish giant took off his cap.

"Down," said Saskia, after a while, in her ordinary voice.

They passed the Choir, a vast oval chamber with a domed roof, empty, its floor worn in rings, where the sound of their feet came back off the roof a long

time after. Then a pair of tall iron-grey doors with a brass plate: *FATHOMERS ONLY. BY ORDER OF THE WARDEN OF THE LOWER FATHOMS.*

The Stair went on past them a little way and ended in a landing, and on the landing was another door, smaller, of a grey stuff that was neither wood nor stone. It had been grown, Hester thought: salt, latticed in a close diamond pattern like a pantry screen, with a brass halcyon in the middle of it. It had no handle. There was a keyhole.

"And that," said Saskia, "is the Hush. Founders' workings. Nobody goes in, nobody comes out, don't ask."

Hester was not listening. Something was wrong with her teeth.

Not pain: a pressure so low it was not a sound, coming up through the soles of her feet and her shinbones and settling in her jaw, like standing on a bridge while a loaded dray goes over. Her back teeth ached with it. When she put her tongue to them she could almost taste it: a sweetness, an enormous weight. Something under the floor was holding itself still with all its might.

"You feel it?" said Teo. He had gone a little pale. "I hear it. Like a man humming in another room. A very big man. In a very big room."

"The Hush hums," said Saskia. "It always has. You get used to it." She looked at the two of them, and something that was not sardonic crossed her pointed face. "I didn't, much. Come on. Up. You'll want the Lantern before the Hour."

* * *

The Lantern gallery ran round the head of the tower, two hundred feet above the dome and open to the Sere, which came howling across the White from the east with salt in its teeth. Hester held the iron rail with both hands. Around her the mirrors, each the size of a door, turned on their iron arms and threw the sun off in sheets.

To the west lay Ambry. She found Coldwater Street without trying, and the long low roof of the Cold House at the end of it, against the wall.

To the east there was nothing. The plain went out flat and blazing to a place where the light was too much to look at, and landships moved on it, far off, their sails like flakes.

"What's that?" said Teo.

He was pointing down and east. A quarter of a mile out from the foot of the dome there was something dark on the White: a circle the size of a cart-wheel,

crusted round the edge with salt, with a dull iron gleam at its centre and something that might have been chain.

"The Well-Cap," said the Proctor with the list, who had brought the intake up and was leaning on the rail beside them as if he owned it. "Top of the Founders' Shaft. Runs all the way down to the Hush, so they say. Capped and chained before anyone's grandmother was born, and never opened. We walk out once a year and check the chain."

"Lowside children dare each other to go and knock on it," said Saskia. "Your lot, Vail."

Hester looked at the dark circle on the white. It was a lonely thing to put in the middle of a plain.

* * *

By dusk she had a key and a cell. R-41, in the Rookery on the dome's western flank: a room cut in the salt, two cots, two chests, a washstand, a window of salt-glass the size of a tablecloth looking out toward Ambry, and cold. Teo had asked at the Bursar's table whether he might share with her, since he knew no one and she knew no one and they had both walked here. The clerk wrote them in without looking up.

"I should tell you I snore," Hester said.

"I'll hum," said Teo. "Hymns, in my sleep, in the third mode. We'll drown each other out."

Now they sat at the Long Table among a hundred and ten new grey gowns and five hundred old ones. By custom no lamp was lit, so that the only light came from candles: a long double row of small flames down three hundred feet of salt, and the dark going up overhead into the shaft.

Somebody high above rang a bell, once.

And the light came down.

It came from the head of the shaft, where the Glaziers stood on the Lantern gallery with their jars, and it came not as a beam but as a flood, so that for a moment it seemed to fall like water, splashing gold off the edges of the shaft and spilling into the hall. Then it was simply there. Noon. Full summer noon, at dusk, in a hall cut under the ground. Hester felt it on the top of her head and the backs of her hands. All down the table faces came up into it with their eyes shut. The candles went pale and useless. Somebody laughed out loud. There was a smell in it,

faint, of cut hay and hot dust, and under the gold she heard, for a breath, a lark singing high up and a long way off, on some summer noon on the Shelf when the jars were filled.

"Oh," said Teo. Just that. He had not opened his eyes.

The light lasted perhaps a quarter of the bell. Then it went amber, and faded, and the candles came back, and the hall was a hall again, with six hundred people blinking in it and somebody starting to clap.

* * *

The First Taste came after the soup.

Second-years set five bowls of white salt-glass along the table, each with a little heap of grain and a placard: *First Fathom. Second. Third. Fourth. Fifth.* Then they stood back along the walls, grinning like people who know what is about to happen to someone else. The new intake rose a bench at a time and filed past, each taking a pinch from each dish on a horn spoon.

It started at the third dish: a gasp, then a woman laughing in a high startled voice with her hand to her face. At the fourth, people stopped laughing. At the fifth, the Haskish giant, just ahead of Hester, put his pinch on his tongue and stood there while tears ran out of his eyes and into his red beard. He was not crying. His face was perfectly calm. The tears simply ran, and in the candlelight they left white lines on his cheeks as they dried to salt.

And the second-years along the walls, all of them, began to bang their hands on the salt, slowly, a long rolling thunder of hands.

The first four were Shelf, Middling and Deep, and she knew them. At the fifth dish she put a few grains on her tongue.

The weight came down. Not so heavy as the *Wren*'s. Near it. The world went white and pressed against her face, and her eyes streamed, and she let them.

Sweet. Deep. And under the sweet, faint but there, the other thing. Bright and metallic, a bitten tongue: the taste of the beads on her brother's casing, standing in their lines toward the east.

Quick.

Teo was beside her, crying like a fountain, white-streaked, laughing at himself through it. He took her arm.

"You've gone the colour of the plate."

"The Fifth," she said. She wiped the salt from her face with her sleeve. "Do they always use the same grain? Every year?"

"No idea. Why?"

She did not answer. She looked up the table to the dais, where the Readers sat in their grey gowns and coloured cords. Near the middle a white head was bent toward a neighbour: Orsolya Thane, laughing at something, her square face pink in the candlelight. Two places along sat Aske, peering down the length of the table through his thick spectacles, searching, she thought, for her. When he found her he lifted his water-glass an inch, gravely, and drank.

* * *

That night the cold came into R-41 through the salt walls as water comes into a boat, slowly and from everywhere. Hester lay in her cot under her mother's coat and every blanket she owned. Across the cell Teo was not asleep either. She could tell, because he was not humming.

"May I ask you a thing?" he said, after a long time.

"You can ask."

"Why did you come? You don't seem like someone who wanted a gown."

She did not answer that. "Why did you leave the Abbey?"

"I had questions." He said it lightly, to the ceiling. "The Order's answer was more vespers. After nine years I found I wanted to know more than I wanted to be told. Which is either the beginning of wisdom or the end of my immortal soul, and I've a bet on with myself which." A pause. "Your turn."

She lay and looked at the window. Out across the White, Ambry's lights were small and orange and few. One of them, she thought, was the plinth-lamp in the Cold House, which Agathe kept trimmed all night.

"I've a brother," she said. "He's kept. At a brinery in the city. Eleven years."

Teo did not say *I'm sorry*. She was grateful for that.

"What's his name?"

"Tobias. Tib."

"What's he like?"

Nobody had asked her that in eleven years. She lay in the dark and found she did not know how to begin; and then she found she did.

"He draws landships," she said. "On everything."

CHAPTER 5

# *First Principles*



*What is kept is owed.*

— The Halcyon Primer, Law the Fourth

"The hold," said Reader Crisp, "is a posture. It is not a feeling. Anyone who tells you it is a feeling is selling you something, generally a book. Stand up."

Thirty-one aspirants stood up. They were on the Pans, the shallow evaporation ponds on the dome's southern shoulder, in the open air, in the Sere. Each pond was the size of a room and a hand deep, the brine in it the colour of rhubarb, and duckboards ran between them. Each aspirant stood at a little iron stand with a brass pipette and a dish of live brine, mixed fresh from Middling that morning and carried up by a porter in a steaming kettle. Live brine went dead in a few minutes if it was not worked, Crisp had told them, so they would kindly not waste it.

"Feet," said Crisp. "Under your hips. Knees soft. Not bent; soft. Shoulders down. Lower than that, Anselm, you are not a coat on a hook. Hands open. Jaw open. The jaw is where most of you keep your fear and I want it out of there. Now breathe in for six and out for nine. Nine, Ferrers, not seven. Again."

Hester breathed. The wind lifted the brine into ripples and the ripples caught the low sun. Beside her Teo was breathing with an expression of great effort, like a man trying to remember a name. Beyond him the Haskish giant, whose name was Radik, had his eyes shut and was swaying slightly, as if listening to music. At the end of the row Lucan Ferrers stood with his heels together, breathing with the

bored precision of a man who has been taught to do everything correctly the first time and resents being asked twice.

"The heart follows the breath," said Crisp, walking behind them on the duckboards. "The body follows the heart. The attention follows the body. You are not *trying* to be still. Trying is motion. You are arranging yourself so that motion has nowhere to start. When you are arranged, the stillness is already there; you are merely uncovering it. Then you lend it. A drop. One. From the pipette, onto the brine. Keep it as it falls."

Pipettes came up all along the row. Most of the drops fell into the pans with small, ordinary splashes. One, three stands down, a Quellish girl's, slowed in the air like honey and then fell anyway. Lucan Ferrers's did not fall. It hung a quarter-inch under the mouth of his pipette, clear and small and exact, and Crisp, passing behind him, said, "Shallow. Neat. Again," and walked on, and Lucan's jaw tightened.

Hester lifted her pipette. She went down, the way she knew how, all the way, and the Pans and the wind went away and there was only the weight at the back of her eyes and the drop forming at the brass mouth, swelling, letting go.

She kept it.

It did not hang the way Lucan's had hung. It stopped dead two inches below the pipette, and it stopped hard. In the instant before the world came back she felt the stillness go out of her and into it like coins pouring out of a purse, all at once. Then the cold hit. She came up gasping, her hands like ice on the iron stand, a grey fog at the edges of everything, and the knowledge that a little time had gone missing. Not a minute, this time. A few seconds. The wind had changed on the pond.

The drop was not a drop any more. It was a bead of salt-glass the size of a pea, hard and clear and slightly flattened on the bottom where it had begun to fall. Water trembled in it.

"Vail," said Crisp, behind her. "Return it."

Hester did not know how.

"The release," said Crisp. "We covered it in the first quarter of the bell. Were you attending?"

She had been attending. Crisp had said that the release was the reverse of the hold: that one opened the stillness and let it go, as a hand opens. She had said it in five sentences, briskly, as if it were obvious, and Hester had written all five down.

She opened her hands, which were stiff with cold, and tried to do with her mind what her hands were doing.

The bead hung. She went still again and found it, the small hard weight of her own stillness in it, and tried to give it up. She could not. Every time she reached for it, something in her closed round it, the way a fist closes round a coin in a crowd.

"Again," said Crisp.

Down the row, Teo had kept a drop on his fourth attempt, wobbling, and returned it on his first, so that it fell into the pan with a little splash and a puff of steam. He looked at the steam with his mouth open. Saskia, two stands down, kept and returned and kept and returned like someone shuffling cards. Lucan returned his neatly, and then, glancing along the row at Hester's bead, did not smile, quite.

"Again," said Crisp.

It took a quarter of the bell. In the end Crisp leaned past her and touched the bead with a glass rod, and it came away whole, still kept, and Crisp put it in a little dish and set the dish on Hester's stand.

"You hold like a miser, Vail," she said. Not unkindly; as if reading off a scale. "Deep, square, and you'll not let go of a fleck. It is generally the people who have had to hold on to everything who cannot let go of anything." She looked at Hester with her ruled mouth. "That bead's yours. Carry it. When you can return it, you'll have learned something. Next."

* * *

"Horology," said Teo, "is the study of time."

"I know what it is."

"Then you know more than I do. At the Abbey we were told time was a gift of the Tide. I asked what it was a gift *of*, exactly, and was set to scrub the refectory for a month." He was eating a bread roll as they went down the Stair, scattering crumbs on the chalk names. "Reader Sorle is supposed to be a monster. The second-years say he makes people cry. Not salt crying. Actual crying. A Physic aspirant last year walked out in the middle and joined the Glaziers."

"Why does anyone take it?"

"It's required. Without Horology, says the Primer, a Keeper is a cook." He considered. "I like cooks."

The Black Bench was a small steep lecture-room off the First Fathom, its tiers so close that the back row had their knees in the necks of those in front. At the bottom stood a slate on an easel and a table, and on the table two things under a cloth. A man was writing on the slate with his back to the room. He did not turn round.

He was tall, stooped, and thin as a heron. His grey gown had a black cord and was worn to green at the elbows, and his long white hair was tied back with a piece of string. When the last aspirant had sat down he went on writing for some time. Then he put down the chalk, dusted his fingers one by one, and turned.

"I am Sorle," he said. His voice was a surprise: deep and beautiful, the voice of a man who might have been an actor if he had not been something more disagreeable. "This is Horology. You are compelled to attend it, as I am compelled to deliver it, so we may at least begin from a position of mutual resentment. I am told you have learned to keep a drop of brine. Congratulations. So has every washerwoman in Quell." On the slate, in a fine clear hand, was written: *What is kept is owed.*

"The Fourth Law. You will have learned it as a jingle. I am going to tell you what it means. When you kept your drop, you held it in its moment. The drop was falling; it had somewhere to be. You prevented it. Time, however, did not stop. The world proceeded about its business and left your drop behind, and every instant your drop stays kept, the difference between where it is and where the world has got to grows. That difference is a pressure. We call it arrears." He wrote a line of figures. "It is proportional to the mass of what you keep. To the duration. And to the *liveliness* of the thing kept: how much it was doing, how much it wanted to go on doing, at the moment you stopped it. What happens to the arrears when you return the drop?"

The Black Bench studied its knees.

"Ferrers," said Sorle, without looking.

Lucan, in the third tier, sat up. "It discharges, sir. As heat."

"As heat. And?"

"And sound. A small report."

"And? Come, Ferrers. You've had tutors. Gerrit Moll taught you your arrears at the age of twelve, at four sols the hour, and he was a fool, but he wasn't that much of a fool. And?"

Lucan's long face had gone faintly pink. "And motion, sir. If the keeping is large enough."

"Large enough to do what?"

"I—to do damage, sir."

"To do damage." Sorle looked up at him with his pale heron's eyes. "To break bones, Ferrers. To crack stone. To shatter glass at forty yards. A grown man kept ten years and returned in a hurry discharges enough arrears to blow the doors off a Brinery, which is why the Physics return them over six hours in a warm bath, and why it costs what it does to have one's grandmother back. You knew that. You said *damage* because you have never in your life seen any, and you thought it the polite word. There are no polite words in Horology. Sit down." Lucan had not stood up. He sat, somehow, lower. "Arrears are the bill. Time keeps the books, and she is a better clerk than any of you will ever be. Every keeping is a lie we tell time, and time collects."

He took the cloth off the table.

Under it were two keepings on little glass stands. One was a big brown moth with eyes on its wings, kept in flight in a casing the size of a hen's egg, so old that the salt had gone faintly amber. The other was a fresh casing, clear as water, round a single green leaf. Between them, casing to casing, ran a thread of plain white cotton, wet with brine.

"The Fifth Law," said Sorle. "Who has it?"

"Still runs to quick," said several voices.

"Still runs to quick. Stillness is not a property, fixed in a casing like colour in a glass. It is a quantity, and like heat it moves from where there is more of it to where there is less, if you give it a road. A road means live brine. Continuous. Unbroken. Air will not carry it. Dry salt will not. Glass will not. Wishing will not. The moth"—he touched the amber casing with one long finger—"was kept by my late wife, in the year eight hundred and sixty-four. It has been growing stiller for thirty-nine years, as old keepings do, until it is very still indeed. The leaf I kept this morning before breakfast. It is quick. And I have joined them with a thread of live brine." He stepped back. "Watch."

For a while nothing happened. The back rows shifted. Someone yawned.

Then the moth's casing began to weep.

Hester saw it before anyone. She had been watching for it without knowing she was watching, and when the first bead came up on the amber salt she was

already leaning forward with her hands flat on the tier in front of her. A pinhead, on the near side, where the thread was tied. Then another. They were not scattered. They came up in a line, a thumb's length, running across the curve of the casing toward the knot. Then another beside it. All the beads on the moth's casing stood in lines, and all the lines pointed down and across, toward the thread, toward the leaf, toward the quick.

She was not in the room. She was in the Cold House, in the fourth row under the third window, looking down at beads above a boy's curled hand, running in lines toward the eastern foot of the plinth.

"The stiller keeping," said Sorle's voice, from a long way off, "gives up its stillness to the quicker, along the brine. You will observe the weeping. It is not damp. It is not age. It is the casing being drawn down, in the direction of the draw. Leave them so for a month, and the moth would come back and fly, and the leaf would be the stillest thing on this table." He dropped the cloth over them. "It is the only law of the five that has never been disputed, chiefly because it is the only one anybody can be bothered to watch. Questions."

Hester's hand went up. She did not remember deciding to put it up.

Sorle looked at it. Then at her: the white cord on her shoulder, the darned customs blue under the grey.

"Aske's," he said. "The customs woman. What?"

"The weeping," Hester said. Her voice sounded strange to her. "If you saw that pattern on a casing. A kept person. Lines, like that, all one way. What would it mean?"

The room had gone quiet. Sorle looked at her for a long moment, his head a little on one side, like a heron at the edge of a pond who has seen something move.

"It would mean," he said, "that someone had run a thread."

Then he wiped the slate and wrote across it in large letters: *THE STILLNESS OF THE GRAIN*. And began, in the same beautiful, indifferent voice, to tell them where stillness came from.

He said the Conclave held that stillness was a property of the Hollow Sea's salt, formed at the Ebb under pressures no one understood, and that this was what they would be examined on. There was another view, he said, in a tone that made plain it was his and he did not care what they thought of it. Grain did not *have* stillness. Grain *was* stillness: a single moment, held, and the salt was only what that mo-

ment looked like when one dug it up. It was possible, on this view, that the Ostrine Sea had not gone anywhere at all. That it was merely paused.

Somebody in the back row laughed. Then several people did. A voice, not quite low enough, said, *Sorle's Folly*, and the laughing got louder.

Sorle waited until it stopped. He looked, if anything, faintly pleased, as a man is pleased when a dog performs its trick.

"Yes," he said. "That is what they call it. Write that down, too. You will be expected to refute it, and you will receive full marks for doing so." He put down the chalk. "Good morning."

* * *

THE DAYS FELL INTO A SHAPE.

Keeping on the Pans at first bell, in the wind, with Crisp walking behind them like a sergeant. Horology at the third. Lumen with Reader Bassano, the florid gentleman from the Entry Assay, in the Glaziers' kilns on the Third Fathom, among racks of jars of every kind of kept light: candlelight, firelight, the green light of the Weeps at dusk, a single jar of moonlight that he took down with both hands and did not let them touch. "Light," Bassano said, waving a jar so that his rings flashed, "wants to be spent, my darlings. Everything else you keep is sulking in its casing. Light is *waiting*." Reading with Reader Odile Fane, a small dry woman with a green cord who spoke in a whisper and made them sit for an hour at a time with their tongues on tablets of old grain, listening to the Roar.

Hester heard it, a little: a rush, a breathing, like wind at a keyhole. Teo heard it as if someone had opened a door. He sat at the reading-basin with his eyes shut and tears running, and afterward could not say what he had heard. "Water," he said. "And something like voices. But not. Like people talking in the next house through a wall."

The cold, which no amount of wool kept out. The thirst. She drank a jug of water at every meal and woke in the night with her tongue stuck to her teeth, and every morning there was a faint white rim of salt at the corners of her eyes. The Lantern Hour every dusk, which she did not stop noticing.

Teo baking saltcake in R-41 on a spirit stove he had smuggled up the Stair in his laundry: caramel and butter and Mardens honey and flakes of dead Weeps salt crunching on the top, and second-years knocking at all hours to buy a slice at a

fleck apiece. "Commerce," said Teo, pocketing flecks. "The Abbey was very wrong about a great many things."

And Saskia Orme, who sat behind Hester in Horology and kept a running commentary in an undertone on everything Hester did wrong, which was a great deal. On the fourth day Hester's drop hung over the brine unreturned again, and Crisp lifted it off with the rod and set it in a second dish beside the first. Saskia said, quite loudly, "Look, she's starting a collection. They'll put her in the Quiet Rooms." Half the Pans laughed.

"Better than being a jar," said Hester, without turning round. "What are you on Bassano's Bench for again? The light, or the rent?"

There was a silence. Then Saskia laughed, short and startled, as if she had not expected to.

"The rent," she said. "Always the rent. What are you on Aske's for, Vail?"

"The weights," said Hester.

That night the two dishes went on the shelf over her cot in R-41, side by side, with a bead in each.

* * *

On the fifteenth of Russet a note came down to R-41 in Aske's sloping hand, black ink: *My Cell, 9th bell, if you're free. Bring your tongue.*

The Third Fathom gallery was quiet at that hour, its doors shut, the lamps turned low; somewhere a kiln was breathing. The door of 3-17 stood open a crack, and light came out of it, and humming.

Aske's workroom was his Quill Street lodging over again, made larger and stranger: a deep cell cut in the salt with a vaulted roof, and papers in drifts and on every wall. Shelves of jars. Tasting spoons in racks. A brine basin in a stand, a spirit stove, a cot in the corner with a heap of blankets on it where he plainly slept more often than in the Readers' Close. A glass-fronted cabinet with a brass lock held rows of small labelled boxes. On the table under the lamp lay a black leather notebook, open at a page of cramped, quick script that was not quite writing: all hooks and ticks and little circles, like writing made into a code by someone in a hurry.

"Ah," said Aske, looking up. "Good. Shut the door. Sit. Have you eaten? I've a pear. Never mind. Look at this."

He unlocked the cabinet and took out a box, and from a nest of black wool inside it lifted, with a pair of tongs, a crystal the size of a walnut. It was the same

white with a little blue in it that the *Wren* grain had been. Near its centre was a bead of liquid water the size of a lentil.

It was moving. Not sliding, as the bead in the *Wren* crystal had slid when she tipped it. Aske held the tongs perfectly still, and the bead, by itself, swelled a hair, and shrank, and swelled. Slow. Regular. Like a pulse.

Hester sat down.

"From the Fifth," said Aske. "From the edge of a stay, three days ago. The Fathomers pull them out with the residue when they reset a stay, and it goes up in sealed boxes to be disposed of. I took this one before it went." He set the crystal on a square of black felt under the lamp. The bead went on swelling and shrinking. "Do you know what that is?"

"No."

"Nor do I. I've four of them now. They all do that, at different rates. This one's the slowest." He sat on the edge of the table among his papers. He looked thinner than he had in Quill Street, and his eyes behind the thick lenses were red-rimmed. "Fourteen pockets this summer. But that's not what's keeping me up. What's keeping me up is the stays."

"The stays."

"When a pocket quickens, the Fathomers take the Choir down and pour stillness into it until it quiets. Stays. They're bloody hard work; they're what Settle the Choir. You'd think with fourteen pockets the Choir would be on its knees. It isn't. I've been through the Warden's returns. The stays are holding better than they did when there were four. They're taking less stillness from the Choir per stay, not more. The Fathomers are pleased with themselves. The stays are easier than they ought to be. Much easier. As if there were stillness coming into them from somewhere else."

Hester looked at the crystal breathing on its felt. She thought of a thread of wet cotton between an amber moth and a green leaf.

"I went to the Cold House," Aske said. "On the fifth, the day before you stepped the Line. I didn't write to you; I wanted to be sure. Your Mother Agathe walked me down the rows. I counted. Fourteen weeping, all in the charity ward. I went to the Harl Street Brinery and the private house on Varenne Hill, and they've not a bead between them." He looked at her. "And they weep in lines. Don't they? East."

"Yes."

"Sorle showed you the moth." It was not a question. "He shows every intake the moth. I sat in that room when I was twenty and thought, how pretty. I never thought about it again till this summer." He picked up his pen and, humming under his breath without a tune, wrote in the black notebook in the cramped hooked script, fast.

"I tasted the Fifth Fathom dish at the First Taste," Hester said. "It was quick. Like his beads. Like the *Wren*."

Aske stopped writing. He did not look up.

"Yes," he said. "It would be. How heavy?"

"Ten thornes. Not quite eleven."

Now he looked up. "Ten what?"

"Thornes." She felt her face go warm. "It's not a proper measure. Mr. Thorne made me put a number to the weight behind my eyes, so I'd stop saying *heavy* and *heavier* at him. A pinch of Shelf is one, about. The Deep at a hundred and forty is six. The *Wren* was eleven. I've never had anything past eleven."

"Thornes," said Aske. He wrote it down. "The first unit of stillness anybody's made that I'd trust." He sat with the pen lifted. Then he wrote three or four more marks, hard, and put the pen down. "Not tonight. I'm not ready, and I'm too tired to be careful, and I've told you I'm bad at careful. Tomorrow. Come tomorrow night at the tenth bell. I'll have it laid out for you, all of it: the readings, the returns, the Cold House, the stays. I want your tongue on all of it before I take it anywhere. And then—" He stopped. "And then I think we'll go and talk to somebody. Together. I'd rather not do that alone."

"Talk to who?"

"Tomorrow," said Aske. "Tenth bell. Bring your tongue." He smiled at her, tired and crooked. "And eat something first. You'll need it."

* * *

She went back up the Stair with her hands in her sleeves. It was late, and the Lantern's shaft was dark; there was only the lamplight in the walls and the chalk names going up and up.

Near the turn below the Second Fathom someone was coming down: a tall stooped figure in grey, white hair tied back with string, one hand on the rail. Reader Sorle. He looked up as she came round the turn, and his pale eyes went over her face, and down to the white cord at her shoulder, and back.

She stood to the wall to let him by, as an aspirant should. He went past her without a word, on down toward the Third Fathom, and she heard his slow step going round below her long after she had stopped hearing anything else.

CHAPTER 6

# *Kept*



*A person kept beyond hope of return shall be accounted dead in law, and their estate shall pass as though they had died on the day of their keeping.*

— Charter of the Grain, §41 ("the Stillborn Clause")

She ate something first, because he had told her to. Teo watched her do it.

"You're eating like a woman going to a hanging," he said. "Is he going to hang you?"

"He's going to show me something."

"At the tenth bell. In his Cell." Teo raised his eyebrows. "At the Abbey that was what Brother Absalom said to the novices, and it never ended well."

"It's grain, Teo."

"That's what Brother Absalom said."

She left him with his saltcake and went down the Stair a little before the tenth bell. The Halcyon at that hour was a different place. The Long Table was empty and dark, the Lantern's shaft a black hole going up into nothing. The lamps on the Stair had been turned down to small blue flames, so that the walls no longer glowed but only gleamed, like the inside of a shell. Her feet were loud on the steps. Far below, she could feel the Hush in her back teeth, the low enormous hum, as if the whole hill were a bell that somebody had struck a long time ago.

The Third Fathom gallery was empty. The kiln that had been breathing the night before was cold. 3-17 was shut, and there was no light under it.

She knocked.

Nothing. She knocked again, louder, and said, "Reader Aske. It's Vail."

Nothing. She tried the handle. Locked.

The tenth bell rang while she stood there, faint and far off, from the Gatehouse; the sound came down the Stair's well and along the gallery and died. She thought he had fallen asleep. She had seen the cot in the corner with its heap of blankets, and his red-rimmed eyes. She knocked a third time, and then put her ear to the door, which was not wood but grown salt, cold as a cellar step against her cheek. No humming. No breathing. Nothing at all.

She waited. It was the deep still cold of the lower Fathoms, and she put her hands in her sleeves and leaned against the wall opposite the door, because he had said tenth bell and he had said *I'll have it laid out for you.* A man like that did not forget. A man like that might be late; he would come up the Stair two at a time, humming, with ink on his nose and an apology already half out of his mouth.

He did not come.

A little before the half she heard something on the Stair.

It was below her. The sound came up the well and through the open end of the gallery: a slow heavy rolling. Iron wheels on salt steps, *grind* and a bump, *grind* and a bump, as something was hauled up one step at a time. Someone breathing hard. A creak of wood under weight. It was coming up from the Fourth, or lower.

She went to the gallery's end and looked over the rail. The well went down into the dark. On the curve of the Stair a turn and a half beneath her there was a lantern moving, small and blue, and in its light the edge of a trolley, the flat low kind the porters used for brine casks, with something on it under a canvas. Two people, perhaps three, hauling. She could not see their faces, only grey wool and the swing of the lantern. They heaved, and the wheels bumped up a step, and they rested.

Porters, she thought. Brine casks going up to the kitchens for the morning, or residue boxes going up to be got rid of. The Halcyon did a good deal of its carrying at night.

She went back to the door of 3-17 and knocked one last time, without much hope. The wheels below went on coming up, *grind* and a bump. Then they stopped, somewhere on the turn below, as if whoever it was had stopped to rest.

She gave up a little before the half bell. She was cold to the bone and angry in the tired, flat fashion of someone who has been stood up, and she went back up the Stair rehearsing what she would say to him in the morning, and how he would look at her through his thick spectacles and apologise, and mean it, and do

it again. She passed nobody. In R-41 Teo was asleep and humming in the third mode, and she got into her cot in her mother's coat and lay awake listening to him, and was not, after all, as angry as she had meant to be.

* * *

SHE WOKE TO BELLS.

Not the first bell, one stroke from the Gatehouse at dawn. This was a high hard clanging from somewhere below, rung fast and on and on. Doors were opening all along the Rookery terrace. Teo was sitting up with his hair on end.

"What is it?"

"I don't know." She was already pulling her gown over her shift. "Below."

The Stair was full of people in nightshirts and gowns, all going down, all asking each other what it was. On the Second Fathom someone said *a quickening*, and someone else said *no, that's the Fathom bell, this is the Proctors'*, and someone said *it's the Third*. At the Third Fathom the gallery was blocked by a crowd and two Proctors with iron-grey cords holding them back. Hester pushed. She was taller than most of them and stronger than all of them, and she did not apologise. At the front, a Proctor put his arm across her chest.

"Back, aspirant."

"I'm Aske's," she said. "His Bench. Is it Aske?"

The Proctor looked at her, and at her white cord, and lifted his arm.

The door of 3-17 stood open. The lamp inside was lit. There were two Proctors in the room, a porter in a leather apron with his face the colour of dough, a Physic in a red cord kneeling on the floor by the brine basin, and a heavy grey man with close-cropped iron hair and a soldier's back, standing with his hands behind him, looking at the thing that stood between the table and the cot.

It was Aske.

He was standing in his shirtsleeves in the middle of the floor with his right arm half-reached out in front of him, the fingers open, as though he had been reaching for something or someone a little beyond his grasp. His other hand was half-closed at his side. His head was a little forward. His mouth was open as a man's mouth is open in the middle of a word, the lips parted, the tongue just visible behind the teeth. His spectacles were on his nose and, behind them, his eyes were open and fixed on nothing. There was ink on his fingers, black on the right hand and blue on the left.

He was kept. A casing of salt held him from the soles of his feet to the crown of his head, a close clear skin a finger thick, so clear that the lamplight went straight through it and lay on his face. It fitted him as water fits whatever you drop into it. At his feet its edge was broken short, not quite meeting the floor, and it closed over his head in a rounded cap, his hair standing up inside it as it always stood up.

Hester stood in the doorway. She was aware of the porter being sick, quietly, in a bucket in the corner. She was aware of the heavy grey man turning round to look at her. She was not aware of much else, for a while.

* * *

"AND YOU ARE?" SAID THE GREY MAN.

"Vail. Hester Vail. I'm on his Bench." She did not take her eyes off the casing. "His privilege."

"Ah." His voice was flat and clipped, a parade-ground voice worn down by years of indoors. "The customs assayer. Chief Proctor Gage." He did not offer his hand. "You'd better come in, Miss Vail, since you're here, and stand there, and touch nothing."

She stood where he pointed, against the wall by the cabinet. The Physic glanced up at her and back down. She was a young woman with a tired face, measuring something in the brine basin with a dipstick.

"Porter found him at first bell," Gage said, to the room; he was a man who reported. "Came to bring Reader Aske's water. Door unlocked. Reader as you see. Brine basin on the floor, empty, spilt. Residue box open on the table: Hush-grade grain, two ounces short of its label. Reader Aske was known for testing his workings on his own person. There's a note in the Proctory book from three years ago when he kept his own left hand for a day to see if he could read it from inside." He looked at the casing. "It would appear he tried something larger. With Hush grain, which he oughtn't to have had, and which keeps fast and hard. And he got it wrong. That right, Doctor?"

"Hush-grade right through," said the Physic, without looking up. "Thick, too. Kept beyond return, I'd say. You'd never get the arrears out of Hush grain without killing him. Not with a bath. Not with anything."

"Then that's how it'll be written," said Gage. "Kept beyond return. Under the Clause." He looked at Hester. "You understand what that means, Miss Vail."

She understood. Everybody in Ambry understood the Stillborn Clause; the Brineries printed it on the back of the forms. A person kept beyond return was dead in law. His estate passed. His casing went to the house that kept it or, in the Halcyon, to the Quiet Rooms, to stand on a plinth with a card.

"He was expecting me," she said. "Last night. At the tenth bell."

Gage's flat grey eyes did not change. "Was he."

"He was going to show me some work. The door was locked. I knocked. Nobody answered. I waited the best part of half an hour."

"Did anybody see you?"

"I don't know. I saw no one." She remembered the lantern on the Stair. "There were porters on the Stair. Below. With a trolley."

"Porters," said Gage. "On the Stair. At night." He sounded neither interested nor surprised. "There generally are. Well. That gives us a time." He turned to one of the Proctors. "Write that the door was locked at the tenth bell and the Reader didn't answer. He'd begun, then, or he'd done it." He turned back to her. "What work?"

She hesitated. It was a short hesitation. She thought she saw him notice it.

"Assay," she said. "He was teaching me. Grain from trade."

"I see. You'll make a statement to the Proctory this afternoon. Third bell. Now stand there and keep out of the way."

* * *

SHE STOOD THERE. SHE KEPT OUT OF THE WAY. SHE LOOKED.

She did not know, afterward, how long she stood against that wall while the Proctors measured and wrote and the Physic dipped her stick and the porter took his bucket away. It was not long. It felt long. And for all of it, while her face stayed still and her hands stayed in her sleeves, a part of her was at the customs bench with the north light on the slate, grading a sample. She could not stop it. She did not try.

The casing was wrong.

She had seen a thousand keepings, in the Cold House and the Quiet Rooms and on the customs bench in a hundred grades of trade grain, and she had kept two drops of brine herself on the Pans, which still sat in their dishes on her shelf in R-41, unreturned. She knew now how a keeping grew. It grew *out*, from the place where the worker's stillness went into the brine. When you kept a drop, the

salt set first where your stillness touched it and spread outward from there; Crisp had shown them under a glass. A man keeping himself would keep from the skin outward. The casing would be densest and clearest against his body and roughest, a little frosted, at its outer face.

Aske's casing was the other way round. She could see it in the lamplight from where she stood. The outer surface was smooth, glassy, the smoothest part of the whole thing. Close against his shirt and his face the salt grew cloudier, a fine frost of tiny crystals pointing inward. It had set from the outside first. It had been poured over him, and had grown inward toward the body, as ice grows on a pond from the air down.

And there was a pattern in it.

She would not have seen it if the lamp had not been low and to the side. In the thickness of the salt, a hair below the surface, there was a grain. Every casing had a grain, as wood has; she knew that now, from Crisp. Her own two beads, under the glass, had a dense square grain like a chequerboard, like the tiles on the White. This one was no chequerboard but a spiral: fine curving lines turning round and round in a long slow coil that went up his body from the floor. She followed it with her eyes. It turned left, as a screw turns when you take it out. Widdershins.

She did not know what it meant. She stored it.

And it was clear.

That was the last thing. The thick close skin of Hush-grade salt over a man who was dead in law was clear as the day. Clear as Tib's. Not a breath of grey in it anywhere, not a mist, not a bloom. *The living keep clear,* Agathe had said, drawing her finger through the air, *and the dead keep grey. If one goes grey you'll know it's done.*

"He's clear," she said aloud.

Gage looked round. "What?"

"The casing. It's clear. Agathe Linden at the Cold House says the dead keep grey. That if a casing goes grey—"

"Hush grain keeps everything clear," said Gage, before she had finished. "Ask the Doctor."

"It keeps clear," said the Physic from the floor, wearily. "It's Hush. It keeps fast. It doesn't bloom like trade grain. He's kept beyond return either way, aspirant. Clear or grey, nobody's getting him out of that."

Hester said nothing. She knew nothing about Hush grain except its taste, and she had no reason to doubt them. She did not doubt them. She stored it anyway, beside the spiral.

Then the Physic stood up to speak to Gage, and the Proctors were writing at the table, and the porter had not come back. For a few breaths nobody in the room was looking at the floor by Aske's feet.

She knelt as if to retie her bootlace. The broken edge of the casing was a thin glassy lip a hand's breadth from her knee. She touched the tip of her smallest finger to it, lightly, as you might touch a sleeping animal, and put the finger to her tongue.

The weight came down like a door slamming. White. The pressure on the far side of her face. Sweet so deep it was nearly bitter: Hush, the grain from under the Fifth, that nobody might sell. And under it, faint and bright and wet, the bitten tongue. Quick.

The *Wren*'s cargo. Sample twelve. The fifth dish at the First Taste. The beads on her brother's casing.

She stood up. Her eyes were watering. She wiped them and nobody noticed, because by then several people in that room had wet eyes.

* * *

THE BLACK NOTEBOOK WAS GONE.

She noticed that next, when the room steadied. On the fifteenth it had lain open on the table under the lamp, among his papers, the cramped hooked shorthand running down the page. It was not on the table now. Nor were the papers. The table that had been drifted a foot deep in his small fast hand, black and blue, was nearly bare: the open residue box, his tasting spoons in their rack, his blotter, a slab of green felt in a leather frame, a few stray sheets, a sketch of a crystal, a list of grain grades. Nothing in the shorthand.

"His papers," she said.

"What about them?" said Gage.

"He had papers. All over the table. And a notebook. Black."

Gage looked at the table. "He kept a tidy desk for a man in his line of work," he said, after a moment. "Perhaps he tidied before his experiment. Men do, before they risk themselves." He made a note. "We'll look."

She did not believe him. She did not disbelieve him. She looked at the blotter, which nobody was looking at. Under its leather corner, pushed half out of sight, was the white edge of a sheet of paper, folded once.

The Physic said something to Gage, and he turned to answer. Hester stepped to the table to steady herself against it, which was a natural thing for a woman to do in that room. She put her hand flat on the blotter, and when she took her hand away the sheet was in her sleeve.

She had never in her life taken a thing she was not entitled to take. Not a fleck. Not a grain off the customs bench. She stood with the paper against her wrist and her heart going hard and slow, and looked at the casing. He had said *bring your tongue*. He had wanted her to see it all before he took it anywhere. He had laid it out for her, and someone had taken it away, and this was what was left.

She kept her hand in her sleeve.

* * *

Others came. Readers in gowns over their nightshirts, standing in the doorway with their faces gone grey. The Deputy Chancellor, a tall smooth man silvered at the temples, with an ochre cord, who looked at the casing a long while with no expression, spoke to Gage in an undertone, and went away. Crisp, her ruled mouth set harder than ever, who stood beside Hester without speaking and then touched her arm, once, and went.

Then Orsolya Thane came in from the gallery in her iron-grey coat, and stopped in the door, and put her hand to her mouth.

"Oh," she said. "Oh, Corvin."

She came across the room slowly. She did not touch the casing. She stood in front of it, short and square, looking up into his open face behind the salt. Her own face had gone white under its weathered colour.

"You daft man," she said quietly. "You daft, daft man. What did you go and do."

Gage looked at the floor.

After a long time Orsolya turned away and saw Hester against the wall, and something in her face softened and broke at once.

"Hester Vail," she said. She came over and put her hand on Hester's shoulder, and even through the wool of the gown it was cold, deep cold, like a railing in

winter. "You came all this way for him. Sixteen days. I'm sorry, chick. I'm that sorry."

"He asked me to come last night," Hester said. She did not know why she said it to this woman. "At the tenth bell. I came. He didn't answer."

Orsolya's hand tightened on her shoulder.

"Then thank God you didn't get in," she said. "If he'd had you in there when he did this—" She shook her head. "You'll be without a Bench now. They'll tell you today, and they'll not be kind about it; the Registry never is. Come and see me when it's sunk in. I'm on the Fifth, by the Warden's Gallery; anyone'll show you. We'll find you something." She looked back at the casing, and her square face crumpled, briefly, and set again. "We look after our own down there."

* * *

The statement at the Proctory took an hour. A Proctor wrote down what she said: that she had come at the tenth bell, knocked three times, waited, seen no one, gone up before the half. That Reader Aske had been teaching her assay. That she had seen porters with a trolley on the Stair below.

Then Gage came in, and sat down across the table, and asked her again when she had arrived. And again when she had left. Whether she was certain the door had been locked and not merely stuck. Whether anyone could say where she had been between the half bell and first bell. Teo could, if he had been awake, which he had not been. Whether Reader Aske had ever made her uneasy. Whether he had made improper suggestions. Whether she had known, when she accepted his Privilege, that he had a reputation for self-experiment. Whether she had quarrelled with him.

"No," she said, to that one. "Never."

"A porter saw you at the gallery's end, a little before the half bell," said Gage. "Looking over the rail."

"I told you. I heard wheels."

"So you did." He wrote. "You'll understand I ask everyone the same questions, Miss Vail. Reader Sorle was on the Third Fathom at about the same hour; I've asked him. A young man named Ferrers was heard having words with Reader Aske in the gallery yesterday afternoon; I'll ask him. I ask. It's what I'm for." He closed his book. "It was an accident. A clever man, careless with dangerous grain,

alone at night. It happens down there oftener than they put on the Stair. But I ask."

"And the papers?"

"We'll look," said Gage, and stood up.

* * *

The Registrar was a thin anxious man in an office on the First Fathom with a ledger the size of the Cold House's. He found her name in it and cleared his throat, and told her, in a voice that tried to be kind and did not know how, what she had already been told.

An aspirant of the Halcyon must be attached to a Reader's Bench. Her Reader was—he cleared his throat again—no longer able to sponsor her. The Charter permitted an aspirant whose sponsor had died, or been *otherwise lost*, to seek another Bench until the Midwinter Assay on the twenty-first of Rime. An aspirant not attached to a Bench by then could not sit the Assay, and an aspirant who did not sit the Assay was sent down.

"Sent down," she said.

"Removed. From the rolls." He made a small gesture at the ledger, as if crossing out. "The Privilege covers your fees while you seek a Bench, but only until then. I'm sorry, Miss Vail. Reader Aske never used his Privilege before. It's rather sad, really. That he chose you, and then—" He stopped. "The twenty-first of Rime."

She thanked him. She went up the Stair.

* * *

Teo was in R-41, sitting on his cot, with the spirit stove unlit and a cake of saltcake on a plate in front of him that he had not touched. He stood up when she came in. He did not say anything. He looked at her face, as he had looked at it on the first night when she mentioned Tib, and then he went and lit the stove and put the kettle on.

She sat on her cot. The window was full of the White, blazing at noon, and the Sere was throwing salt against the glass in little rattling handfuls. On the shelf over her cot sat her two beads in their dishes, the two drops of brine she had kept and could not return. Somebody had kept Aske like that. Somebody had poured

brine over him and kept him, mid-word, reaching, and then gone away and left him in his own room for a porter to find with his water-jug.

Somebody. She sat with the word, and with what she had stored beside it: the spiral, the clear salt, the casing grown from the outside in, the wheels on the Stair coming up from below. Then she took the folded sheet out of her sleeve, where it had been all morning against her wrist, and unfolded it on her knee.

It was one leaf, torn from the black notebook along its stitching. It was covered on one side, in black ink and a little blue, with the cramped hooked script: ticks and loops and little circles, here and there a number, something that might have been an arrow. She turned it to the light. She could read none of it, except, at the very bottom, in the same quick hand but in plain letters, a single capital: *O*. followed by a full stop.

"I can't read it," she said.

Teo came over with two cups of halcyon tea, salt and milk. He set one down beside her and looked over her shoulder at the paper on her knee. Then he put his own cup on the floor, carefully, and crouched beside her, and took the edge of the page between his fingers and tilted it to the window.

"That's brinescript," he said. "Shorthand. The old copyists' hand; we used it at the Abbey for taking down readings from the tablets, before they faded." He looked up at her. His round face was serious. "It's been a long time. But I can read that."

CHAPTER 7

# *Ask O.*



*Ask, and the tide shall answer. Ask not, and the tide shall answer still.*

— Hymnal of the Order of the Returning Tide, "For the Vigil," verse four

Cell R-41 was eleven feet by eight. Hester had paced it on her first night, from habit, and had not needed to pace it since. Two cots, one under each slope of the ceiling. A table between them, under the window, with a brine basin let into it that nobody used for brine. Two pegs. A shelf. The window was a single pane of salt-glass as thick as a thumb, set into the dome's western flank. By day it looked out over the White toward Ambry, and by night over nothing at all, because the White at night gave back no light and Ambry was only a smudge of orange on the edge of the dark.

It was the eleventh bell. Teo had lit both candles, which was extravagant. He sat on the end of his cot with Aske's sheet on his knee, a pencil behind his ear and his old grey Tider shawl round his shoulders, and he had been silent for nearly a quarter of an hour. For Teo this was something close to a medical event.

Hester sat on the other cot with her back against the salt and her hands under her arms and watched him.

"You're sure you can read it," she said.

"I'm sure I can read it. I'm not sure I can read it *quickly*." He held the sheet up to the candle. "It's Tidewater short-script. Or it started as Tidewater short. The Abbey copyists used it for brine-tablet drafts, so you could get a whole homily onto a tablet the size of a biscuit. I spent four years doing nothing else. My hand still cramps at the sight of a vowel-hook." He squinted. "But your Reader's done

things to it. He's dropped half the vowel-hooks, and he's using an ink-dot for the plural, which is heresy, and—oh, look. This sign's meant to be *tide*. He's using it for *line*."

"Does it matter?"

"Only to God and the Abbot. Give me a minute." He wrote something on the back of his hand. "He's left-handed, isn't he? For this. The slope's all backward. He wrote this fast, in the left hand, and he was cold."

"How do you know he was cold?"

"Because I've written short-script with cold hands for four winters in a stone cell in Harl, and my strokes went exactly like this. See how the long downstrokes break? That's shivering."

Hester looked at the marks: small, dense, sloped hard to the left, hooks and dots and little crossed lines like the tracks of a bird that had walked through ink. She had slid the sheet off Aske's blotter into her sleeve that morning while Chief Proctor Gage was talking to the Physic. She had felt, doing it, exactly as she had once felt at nine years old, stealing a bun from the Corn Exchange: calm, sure, and sick.

She had not told the Proctor. She had not decided not to tell him. She had only not done it, all through the long cold questioning, where he asked her four times what time she had come to the door of 3-17 and four times wrote down the same answer. And then it was too late to do it without explaining why she hadn't, and by then she had begun to think she would not do it at all.

"Got him," Teo said.

He read it out slowly, his finger moving along the lines.

"*Cold House. Fourteen weeping.* Then a line. *Harl Street Brinery. Nought.* Line. *Varenne Private. Nought.* Line. *Charity only?*" He glanced up. "Question mark. *A draw?* Question mark again. Then a sign I'd read as *still*, then *runs*, then a hook that means *toward* or *into*, and then this—" he tapped it, "—*quick. Still runs to quick.* That's the Fifth Law, isn't it? That's what Sorle was banging on about on Thursday with his two little casings and his bit of string."

"Brine thread."

"Brine thread. Then. *Cistern.* Two question marks. *Old lines.* And then right at the bottom, on its own, underlined twice." He turned the sheet to the candle. "*Ask O.*"

Hester held out her hand. He gave her the sheet. She looked at the bird-tracks as if by looking hard enough she could taste them.

"I know the first part," she said. "He told me. On the fifteenth, in his Cell." She put her finger on the first line, where the marks meant *fourteen*. "He went to the Cold House on the third and counted. Fourteen. That's Agathe's number; she told me fourteen on the first, counting Tib. Then the other brineries. Harl Street's for shopkeepers, and Varenne's where the Upper Ward keep their grandmothers. Nought, and nought. Only the charity ward."

"Only the poor."

"Only the poor," she said. "Weeping in lines, toward the east. That's what he was going to lay out for me." She looked at the lower lines, the ones he had not told her. "This is the rest. *A draw. Cistern. Old lines.* He'd got further than he said."

"You'd better tell me the rest of it, then. The brother." Teo pulled the shawl tighter. "You've said *Tib* nine times since the Lantern Hour, and I've been good and not asked, but my goodness is a finite resource."

* * *

So she told him. Not all of it. She told him as she would have read a manifest aloud: the facts, in order, with the weights.

Tobias Vail, fourteen. Bloom fever, the autumn of eight-ninety-two. The Cold House, the charity ward, casing two hundred and eleven. Six sols a month for eleven years. Her father, who had stopped visiting. Mother Agathe, who said the living keep clear. The beads on the first of Russet, standing in their little lines.

She did not tell him what Tib had said. She came to the place in the story where it would have gone and stepped round it, and went on to the Customs House and the cargo and the cut ledger, and she did not think Teo noticed.

He listened without interrupting, which she had not known he could do. When she had finished he sat for a while with his chin on his knees.

"Eleven years," he said at last.

"Yes."

"Six sols a month for eleven years. That's—" He was counting. "Near on eight hundred sols."

"Five, for the first two years. Seven hundred and sixty-eight," Hester said. "I don't round."

He looked at her with an expression she could not read. "The Abbey would call that a vigil. Sitting up with someone who can't wake. They'd give you a candle for it and a line in the book." He rubbed his face. "I'm not sure what I'd call it. I'll think. Do you want saltcake? I have contraband saltcake."

"You have what?"

"I bribed a cook." He reached under his cot and brought out a thing wrapped in a handkerchief: a slab of dark caramel cake crusted with flakes of dead salt. It smelled of burnt sugar and butter, and of the kind of kitchen Hester had not stood in since her mother died. "It's a recognised remedy. For grief, shock, bad news, and Horology."

She took a piece. It was good.

"So," Teo said, with his mouth full. "*Ask O*. Who's O?"

"I don't know."

"Let's be scholarly about it. We're scholars now. I have the gown to prove it." He held up a finger. "Could be the Order. My Order. *Ask the Order*. The Tiders keep half the old charity foundations in Ambry; if anyone has the old water-board papers from before the Cistern was bricked up, it'd be some dusty abbess in a cellar." A second finger. "Could be a person. Could be a place. Could be *ocean*." He grinned. "*Ask the ocean*. That's very Tider. We'd have put it on a banner."

"There isn't an ocean."

"There isn't a lot of things. We pray to them anyway."

Hester did not smile. She was thinking.

"Orme," she said.

Teo stopped chewing.

"Saskia Orme. She's on Bassano's Bench. She runs his light samples round the Fathoms because Bassano can't be bothered with stairs; everyone's seen her with the box. Aske tested grain for anyone who asked. She'd have stood in that room."

"That's not evidence. That's a woman with legs."

"I didn't say it was evidence." But she was folding the sheet along its creases, small, smaller. "O. Somebody he was going to ask about the Cistern, about the old lines. Somebody he thought would know. Before he—" She stopped.

"Before he did what he did," Teo said gently. "Or before what was done to him."

She looked at him.

"You think so too," she said.

"I think," Teo said, "that a man who writes *ask O.* and underlines it twice the night before he's kept was planning to be about in the morning." He brushed crumbs off the shawl. "But I was brought up to believe the sea will come back when we're worthy, so you mustn't lean too hard on my opinions."

* * *

Hester went down to the Brinestacks at the third bell of the eighteenth, between Keeping and the Lantern Hour, with Lucan Ferrers's name in her mouth like a stone.

Everybody knew about the argument. A first-year on Fane's Bench had it from a second-year on Crisp's, who had been in the corridor outside 3-17 on the afternoon of the sixteenth and heard raised voices, Aske's and a young man's, cold, well-bred. The young man had come out white about the mouth and walked off so fast he knocked a sample-tray out of a porter's hands. Everyone agreed it had been Ferrers. Everyone agreed it was interesting. None of them had said so to Chief Proctor Gage, because none of them wanted to be the one who named the Lord Exchequer's son in the Proctory.

Hester did not much care about being the one.

She found him where the porter at the Stacks desk said he would be, in one of the Reading Wells off the north gallery: small round rooms carved out of the salt like the inside of an egg, each with a stone basin of brine at its centre, a lamp, a single chair, a reading-slope, and a curtain of heavy grey wool across the door to keep in a warmth there was not. Lucan was sitting at the slope with a brinescript tablet in front of him and his hands in gloves. He was not reading it. He was looking at it.

She put the curtain back without knocking. He looked up.

"Miss Vail." He did not rise. "The Customs House. You've come to impound me."

"You argued with him."

"I beg your pardon?"

"Reader Aske. On the sixteenth, in the afternoon, in his Cell. Half the Turning Intake knows it, and the other half is on its way. You argued with him, and that night he was put in a casing, and you've said nothing to the Proctor."

Lucan Ferrers looked at her for a long moment. He had a narrow, handsome, guarded face, the kind that had been taught early not to do anything in public.

His gown was the same undyed grey as everyone's, but it fitted him, as if the wool knew whose it was. He wore the ochre cord of Vey's Bench at the shoulder.

"*Was put,*" he said. "Not *put himself.*"

"I said what I said."

"You did." He turned the tablet face down on the slope. It made a soft heavy sound. "Sit down, Miss Vail. No, there's only the one chair. Stand, then. You're good at it." He folded his gloved hands. "Yes. I argued with Reader Aske on the afternoon of the sixteenth. He had asked me to his Cell. I assumed it was about my Assay work; he examined Brinescript students in discernment. It was not. He told me my father's firm had been buying deep grain under false declaration. He asked me whether I knew about it, and whether I would be prepared to say so in writing."

"And what did you say?"

"I said my father buys what the Halcyon sells him." His voice did not rise. "I said that every grain of stillsalt on the Rim comes out of the ground under a Halcyon licence, is graded under a Halcyon schedule and moved under a Halcyon seal. If Ferrers and Lisk had bought something it shouldn't have, the question was who had sold it, and that question belonged to the Halcyon and not to me. And I said that if he wished to accuse my family of fraud he could do it before the Assize like a gentleman, and not ambush the son in an examination room." A muscle moved in his jaw. "It may be that I said it more loudly than that."

"And then you knocked a tray out of a porter's hands."

"I did. I apologised to the porter." He looked at her. "Ask *your* Halcyon, Miss Vail. That's what I told him, and it's what I'll tell you. You've been here twelve days. You think because you've stepped over a brass line in a floor you know which side of the ledger you're on."

That landed. She let it land and did not show it.

"The *Constant Wren*," she said.

Something happened to his face. It was small: a check, as in a horse that sees something in the road and decides not to shy at it.

"I don't know what that is."

"A three-masted freighter. Out of Quell. Chartered to Ferrers and Lisk. On the first of Russet she came into the dry harbour with forty crates of what the manifest called Shelf grain for curing. I put it on my tongue. It was Hush grain, from under your feet, and it was quickened. I seized it. That night six men with

an Exchequer paper took it out of the bond-shed, and somebody cut the page out of my ledger, and in the morning I was suspended without pay. The only other man who'd tasted it was Reader Aske, and he'd offered me his Privilege." She watched his face. "And a fortnight later he's in a casing, and you're the last person anybody heard shouting at him."

Lucan's gloved hands had not moved on the slope.

"I don't know what that is," he said again, but differently.

"Then perhaps you should ask your father," Hester said. "Since you're so keen on people asking."

She let the curtain fall behind her. She had gone ten paces along the north gallery before she heard the chair scrape in the Well, and then nothing, and she did not look back.

* * *

On the nineteenth they moved Corvin Aske to the Quiet Rooms.

She would not have known, except that she came down the Stair at the second bell on her way to Horology and found the Third Fathom landing blocked by aspirants and Fellows standing about with the particular silence of people who have stopped to look at something and are ashamed of it.

Down the corridor toward 3-17 six Fathom porters in leather aprons and iron-grey armbands were working with a long low brine-cask trolley. They had the casing on it already, on its back on a bed of folded sacking, strapped, and they were easing it out through the Cell door a few inches at a time. Each time they eased it a woman's voice said, "Steady. Steady, now. Mind his hand."

It was Warden Thane. She stood at the head of the trolley in her iron-grey gown with one hand flat on the casing, over Aske's chest. She was not doing anything with the hand. It was simply there, as you would put a hand on a horse to let it know you were near.

"Left a bit, Harro. That's it. Easy."

They got it out and turned it in the corridor, slowly, the wheels grinding on the salt floor. Hester had told herself she would not look, and she looked.

He was as he had been. One arm raised, the hand open, reaching for something past the end of the trolley. His mouth open on a word. His spectacles kept on his face, slightly askew, and behind them his eyes open and swimming, not frightened but surprised. He looked like a man who had been interrupted. The

casing was so clear that the lamplight went through it without bending. You saw him, and not what he was in.

*The living keep clear, my dear.*

*Hush grain keeps everything clear*, the Proctor had said. He had said it with the finality of a man repeating a thing he had been told.

"Miss Vail."

Orsolya Thane had seen her. The crowd parted a little, from habit, to let the Warden's look through, and Hester found herself in a small cleared space with everyone watching.

"Come here, chick," Orsolya said. "Come and walk with him. He'd want somebody of his to walk with him."

Hester went. She took a place at the side of the trolley, opposite the Warden, and the porters took up the straps, and they went down the corridor toward the lift at the pace of a funeral. The wheels ground. At the lift the porters stopped and conferred about the weight. Orsolya stood with her hand on the casing, and her face, which had been composed, came apart. It did not crumple; it simply ceased to be held. She looked old. She looked as tired as any woman Hester had ever seen, and Hester had seen her mother at the end.

"Always tasting things," Orsolya said quietly. Not to Hester. To the casing. "Always going where you weren't wanted, with your nose and your notebooks." She drew a long breath. "Well. You're safe now. Nobody'll trouble you now."

The lift came. It took four porters and the Warden to load him, and the cage sank a hand's breadth on its chains as the weight came on. Orsolya stepped in after. She looked back at Hester through the bars.

"You're on nobody's Bench. I know; Registrar told me. Don't you fret about that today." The cold hand came through the bars and touched Hester's wrist, lightly, and was gone. "My door's open. You know where."

The lift bell rang twice. The cage went down into the dark with a sound of brine running in the counterweight tanks, and the casing went with it, glinting, until there was only the empty shaft and the chains moving.

Hester found that her wrist was cold where the Warden had touched it. She rubbed it, and it went on being cold.

She did not go to Horology. She went down the Stair to the Fourth and along the curving corridor to the Quiet Rooms, and arrived as the porters were leaving.

The door-warden, a stooped Fellow with a ring of keys, let her in for a minute because she said she had been his student, which was nearly true.

The Quiet Rooms were long and dim and full of things that had stopped. She did not look at them. She found him at the end of the second room, already on his plinth between a Reader in a gown of a cut three hundred years old and a girl kept in the act of laughing. The label was already lettered, in a neat clerk's hand: *C. ASKE, Reader. Kept 16 Russet 903. Beyond return (Ch. §41).*

She stood with him for a minute, as she had stood with Tib every month for eleven years, with her hands in her pockets.

"You said you'd show me," she told him. "You said, bring your tongue."

He reached past her for whatever it was. His spectacles were crooked.

"I brought it," Hester said.

* * *

At the Lantern Hour she saw Saskia Orme crying.

Not much: the kind of crying that has been done somewhere else and mostly put away. Hester came up the Stair late, with the Hour already begun, the kept noon light pouring down the Lantern Well into the dusk of the Long Table, gold and warm and smelling faintly of hay from whatever summer day it had been pressed on. Every face at the table was turned up into it. Saskia was not at the table. She was standing in the arch at its far end, in the shadow outside the fall of the light, with her back to the wall. Her face was red and swollen about the eyes. She had a handkerchief balled in one fist, and she was looking at nothing.

Hester went toward her. They had not exchanged a civil word since Matriculation. Saskia had called her a charity case on the first morning and Hester had called Saskia a rent-collector, and both of them had been, in their way, accurate.

"You knew him," Hester said, when she was close enough not to be overheard. "Aske. You'd been to his Cell. With Bassano's samples."

Saskia's head came round. Her swollen eyes went over Hester's face in one hard, quick, Quellish look, a glazier checking a pane for bubbles.

"What?"

"I'm sorry," Hester said. It came out stiff. She was not practised at it. "If you knew him. I'd only known him a fortnight. But I'm sorry."

For an instant Saskia's face came open. Then it shut, like a kiln door.

"I didn't know him," she said. "I knew his *door*. I knocked on it, and I left things on his bench, and I went away. That's all I did. That's all I ever did." Her voice cracked on the last words and she stopped it, angrily, as you stop a cup that is going to spill. "Mind your own business, Vail. You've enough of it."

She went past Hester into the corridor and was gone.

Behind Hester, at the Long Table, the light was fading as it always faded, all at once at the end, like a lamp turned down. A sigh went along the table, as it did every evening, a whole intake letting go of the same summer afternoon.

*I knew his door.* She turned it over. She did not like how it weighed.

* * *

That night, in R-41, while Teo slept with his mouth open under the slope of the ceiling, Hester took out the ledger she had brought from Tanner's Row. It was her own, a cheap quarto in marbled boards, half-filled with eleven years of household accounts. She turned to a clean page at the back.

She ruled it as she had ruled ten thousand schedules on the slate bench in the Dry Harbour: four columns, a narrow one for the number, a wide one for the description, one for the weight, one for remarks. At the head of the page she wrote, after some thought: *Declaration of Interest, 3-17, 16 Russet.*

Then she sat with the pen above the paper for a long time, while the candle went down and the night-chime started up faintly, tile by tile, out on the plain.

She wrote:

*1. — L. FERRERS, aspirant (Vey). — Argued with C.A. afternoon 16th re. Ferrers & Lisk deep grain. — Weight: motive, temper, family. — Did not know the* Wren. *Or says he did not. Face moved.*

*2. — B. SORLE, Reader (Horology). — On 3rd Fathom at tenth bell, 16th (Proctory). Passed me on the Stair 15th, going down. Known enemy of half the Conclave. — Weight: opportunity. — No motive known.*

*3. — S. ORME, aspirant (Bassano). — Courier, since summer. Knew his door. Crying at the Hour. "O." — Weight: access; the initial. — Grief? Fear? Not grief.*

*4. — "O." — Somebody who knows the old lines. The Order? Somebody in Ambry? — Weight: unknown.*

*5. — E.D. / W.L.F. — Shipper's mark on the* Wren *bill. A man in grey wool at the bond-shed with a lantern and a paper. — Weight: the cargo. — Not a firm. Not a person I know.*

*6. — The Proctor. — Ruled it a self-keeping before he'd looked. "Hush grain keeps everything clear." — Weight: haste. — Who told him so?*

It was not a good schedule. Half the weights were guesses and none of the remarks would have stood up before the Customs Board. Mr. Thorne would have struck it through and told her to come back when she had something she could put on the scale.

At the bottom of the page, under the last line, she wrote one more entry, smaller, and did not number it.

*— H. VAIL. — At the door at tenth bell. Saw nothing. Heard something heavy on the Stair, coming up from below. Looked over the rail: blue lantern, grey wool, a load under canvas. Thought: porters, casks. Went up. — Weight: —*

She left the weight blank. She sat with the pen in her hand until the candle drowned in its own wax and the cell went dark. Then she lay down in her clothes, with the ledger on her chest, and listened to the White ticking out in the cold, and to Teo breathing, and to nothing at all from the dome beneath her, which was large and full and did not make a sound.

CHAPTER 8

# *The Stay Choir*



*Hold the line, hold the line, breathe it slow and breathe it fine; hold the line, hold the line, so the others can sleep.*

— Work-song of the Stay Choir, refrain (traditional)

Reader Maudelaine Crisp refused her in eight words, on the twentieth of Russet, at the edge of the rose-coloured practice pan with brine to the wrists of her rolled sleeves: "I'm full, and you're unfinished. Next pan, please." The rest of the list went the same way, more slowly. Bassano took her hands in his warm rings and wept a little for Corvin and could not; Rusk of Weathering explained that Lowside constitutions settled early, and that it was not personal; Pym of Cellaring was full with his door open eight inches. Reader Odile Fane of Reading, who had Teo, was full and sorry for it. She was a small dry woman who spoke in a whisper, and she held Hester's eyes and added, lower still: "For what it's worth, you were seen in the Quiet Rooms. Go carefully. The Halcyon is a good place to be noticed, and a bad one." Hester left Benedek Sorle till last, because she expected nothing from him, and found him alone in the Black Bench lecture room wiping slates, a stick hooked over the lectern. He heard her out without turning round. "I am told you were at Corvin's door at the tenth bell on the night he was kept," he said to the slate, "and that you have been visiting him since in the Quiet Rooms, like a widow. I do not take charity cases from the dead. Good afternoon."

* * *

The Warden's Gallery was on the Fifth Fathom, and aspirants did not walk to it.

The Stair went on below the Fourth to the tall iron-grey doors she had seen on the tour, *FATHOMERS ONLY*, with a Proctor beside them now, and beside the doors a single small brine-lift cage, its bars worn bright at the height of a hand. A Fathom porter rode down with her and looked at her once, to see whether she would be sick. The salt of the shaft walls went clearer and darker as they sank, with a grey in it like smoke in glass. The air grew colder, and then, unexpectedly, warmer, and damp, and she tasted under it, faint and far off, the bitten tongue.

"Warden's Gallery," the porter said, drawing the gate. "Straight on, miss. You'll hear her."

She heard her. Orsolya Thane was laughing, down the corridor, through an open door where lamplight lay on the floor. It was a big unguarded Lowside laugh, the laugh of the women on Tanner's Row when the washing was in and the children were somebody else's for an hour. She had not heard one since she crossed the Line.

The Warden's office was a long low room cut into the salt, and it was warm. A real iron stove stood in the corner with a kettle on it and grey wool stockings drying on the rail. Rag rugs on the floor. A dresser of chipped blue-and-white Lowside crockery. On the walls, among the charts of the Fifth Fathom's galleries in coloured inks, were pinned sheets of names and dates, and some of the names had small crosses beside them in pencil. At the big table sat the Warden of the Lower Fathoms in her iron-grey gown with the sleeves pushed up, a teacup in one hand and a pen in the other, laughing at something said by the man at her elbow with a ledger.

"Miss Vail." The laugh changed to a smile without losing any warmth. "There you are. Mr. Dunmore, this is Corvin's girl. Sit down before you fall down, chick. That lift does it to everybody the first time. It's the warm. Nobody expects the warm."

Hester sat on a kitchen chair with a cushion on it. Orsolya poured her tea from a brown pot without asking, and put salt in it without asking, and milk, and pushed it across.

The man with the ledger nodded to her. He was perhaps forty, with a pleasant forgettable face, thinning fair hair combed carefully across, and a clerk's black

coat over his grey gown, its cuffs banded with ink. He said "Miss Vail" in a voice that matched the face, and turned a page, and wrote something.

"Mr. Dunmore keeps me honest," Orsolya said. "Or keeps me in order. I can never remember which." Her hands round the cup were white at the knuckles and bluish at the nails. Hester had noticed them on the Causeway, the first morning: the hands of someone who had been cold for a long time. "Now. Let's not dance. You've been round the Benches, and they've all said they're full, and Crisp said you were unfinished."

Hester looked at her.

"She says it to everyone," Orsolya said. "She said it to me, in eight-seventy. She was right then too." She set her cup down. "I can't sponsor you. I'd like to. I've six on my Bench and two of them are useless, and if I had my way I'd send the useless ones home to their mothers and take you in an afternoon. But the Conclave counts heads, and Vey counts them twice." She said the Deputy Chancellor's name as a woman in Tanner's Row says the name of the landlord. "What I can do is put you in the Choir."

"Reader Aske mentioned the Choir."

"I expect he did. He knew I was short." Her face moved, briefly, at the name, and settled. "Three sols a week, in silver, no deductions; Mr. Dunmore sees to it. Four shifts a week, two of them nights. It's hard work and it's cold work and it'll put years on you if you do it long enough, and I'll not lie to you about that, because I've never lied to a chorister in my life." She leaned forward. "But while you're in the Choir you're on the Halcyon's books, and the Registrar can't send down a working chorister without the Warden's say. And I'll not say. That'll hold you till midwinter. By midwinter something'll turn up. It generally does."

Three sols a week. Twelve a month. Tib's fee was six.

Hester did the sum and found she had done it before she had decided anything, which meant she had decided.

"Why me?" she said. "You don't know me."

"I know you." The Warden looked at her across the table, steady and amused. "You walked the Causeway at dawn on your first morning with a carpetbag in one hand and your other hand in your pocket on your purse. Only Lowside girls walk like that. I walked like it myself, to the Coldbank pithead every morning with my da's dinner in one hand and my pennies in the other, till the Coldbank seam came down on him. I was eleven." She said it plainly, a fact with the weight

already taken off it, and went on. "And I hear you've got a hold like a dropped anvil. Crisp says you can't let go of a thing to save your life, but by God you can grip it. That's a chorister. That's what the Choir *is*. Gripping." She turned her cup. "And Corvin asked me. A fortnight ago, before—" She stopped. "He came down here with you in his mouth, as he came down with everything, and he said *Orsolya, I've found a tongue*. So."

Hester looked down into her tea.

"Dunmore," Orsolya said. "The forms."

He had them ready: a stipend agreement, a declaration of fitness, and a release. *The chorister acknowledges that holding in the Stays may result in lag, cold injury, and the Settle, and holds the Halcyon blameless*. She read every word, because she was a customs assayer and had never signed a thing she had not read. Then she signed. Dunmore wrote her name at the head of each in his own hand, for the file, in small, upright, plain letters. Something about the letters tugged at her, as a familiar face tugs in a crowd. She looked again and it was gone. A clerk's hand. Ten thousand clerks wrote like that.

"Your first shift's Friday," Orsolya said. "Night. Choir hall, Fourth Fathom, the ninth bell. Wear everything you own. Eat first." She drank her tea. Then, in the voice of a woman thinking aloud: "You've come in a good season, at least. The Stays have been kind this season. Kinder than they've any right to be." She shook her head. "I'll not complain. God knows we've had our share of the other kind."

At her elbow, Dunmore turned a page.

* * *

She had seen the Choir hall from the Stair on the tour, empty, its floor worn in rings. Full, it was another room.

It was oval and old, its tiers of shallow steps worn by centuries of sitting into something nearer a bowl. There were no benches. You sat on the salt. A dozen lamps of kept light hung from the ceiling on long chains, pressed on some clear midwinter noon years ago, and they gave the hall the cold lucid look of a snowfield.

There were sixty-one choristers. Hester counted. They came in by twos and threes at the ninth bell of Friday in grey gowns and iron-grey armbands, bundled in shawls and mufflers and fingerless gloves, carrying flasks, and sat down on the steps in no order she could see, and did not talk much. Most were older than her.

A man of seventy with a white beard sat down on the lowest step with a slowness she had only ever seen in Mr. Thorne. They had what she had seen on choristers in Lowside taverns, which was not a look so much as a lack of fidget. When they sat down, they sat down all the way.

A woman sat down next to her: sixty-five or so, small and square, with a face as brown and creased as a walnut and a mass of white hair bound in a red scarf. She wore three shawls, one on top of another, and she held out a fourth.

"You'll want that," she said. "Not now. After. Ama Tessaly." She put out a hand in a fingerless glove. "Forty-one years I've been holding, and I've never seen a first-nighter yet who thought she'd want a shawl. And then she wants it."

"Hester Vail."

"I know. Corvin's girl. The Warden said." Ama looked at her sidelong with small bright black eyes. "Strong hold, she says. Well. That's lucky for you and unlucky for you. The strong ones she puts nearest the line."

"What does that mean?"

"Means you'll find out, lamb." Ama patted her knee. "Here she is."

Orsolya came down the steps into the middle of the floor. She did not raise her voice; the shape of the hall carried everything. She looked round the tiers as a woman looks round her kitchen table at a family she has fed for thirty years.

"Fourteen holding tonight," she said. "Same as last night. Four's warm. Nine's warm. Eleven's warmer than I'd like. We'll go down to Eleven first and give it a long hold and then do the round. Mackey, you're lead on Nine. Ama, you'll take the new girl on Eleven, by the line." Her eyes found Hester. "Don't be frightened, chick. Ama's held more stays than anybody alive. Just do what she does. Right." She lifted her chin. "Let's have the breath."

Sixty-one people breathed in.

It was not loud: sixty-one people drawing breath together over a count of perhaps eight, and letting it out over twelve, a long low *hhhhhhh* that went round the walls and came back. Again, slower. And again. On the fourth breath someone low down on the left was singing.

It was a single note held for the length of the outbreath and dropped a tone at the end. On the next breath a dozen voices took it; on the next, all of them. They were not singing to make music; Hester understood that at once. They were singing to hold sixty-one bodies to the same slow count, so that sixty-one hearts

would slow together. The note was the clock. Then the words came in on the outbreath, ragged and soft:

*Hold the line, hold the line, breathe it slow and breathe it fine—*

By the third time round she did not need the tune. Her breath had gone with theirs without asking her, and her heart had gone with her breath. She sat on the cold salt with Ama's shoulder against hers and felt her body slowing, as you feel a cart slowing on a hill: the whole weight of it easing.

"Good," Ama said, between lines. "Good girl. Now come on."

* * *

They went down singing.

The Choir left the hall by a low door on its eastern side and went down a passage cut in steps, in a long grey file. The salt of its walls went clear and dark, and at one turning a door of iron-grey stood open with a Proctor beside it. Beyond it the air changed.

Warm. Wet. And the taste.

It came up her throat from the back of her tongue before she had put her tongue to anything: sweet, enormously heavy, so that the passage dimmed in front of her eyes. Under the sweetness, bright as a struck match, quick. Quick as the cargo. Quick as the beads on Tib's casing. Quick as the fifth dish at the First Taste, the one that had made half the intake weep.

The Fifth Fathom.

The rest of the Halcyon had been carved. The Fifth had been dug. Its galleries were low and rough, propped here and there with timber gone white with salt, running off in every direction into the dark. Along the floor of each, against the left wall, ran a channel two hands wide, sheathed in brass and full to the brim with brine that did not move. Where the sheathing joined there were valve-wheels the size of plates, painted with white numerals. At every junction more channels came in from the side and joined, as gutters join in a street, until they ran together into a single great channel as wide as a man's body that went away along the main gallery toward the east, out of the lamplight.

"Stay-lines," Ama said, between breaths, seeing her look. "That's the eastern trunk, that big one. All the lines go into her and she goes along to the Old Tap and round. You don't need to know. You need to know your line." She pointed with her chin down a side gallery. "That's ours. Eleven."

Stay Eleven was at the end of a short dead-end gallery where the roof came down low. Most of the Choir went on with Orsolya and Mackey toward the other stays. Twelve turned with Ama into Eleven.

At the end of the gallery the salt was wet.

Not damp. Running. Water stood in shallow pools on the floor and ran down the walls in threads that glittered in the lamplight. The salt had gone soft and grey and translucent, like ice in a thaw. And it was warm; she could feel it on her face from three paces off, a hearth's warmth. In the end wall, at the height of a person's chest, the salt bulged outward in a rough dome the size of a cartwheel, laced with fine cracks and glistening wet. From the cracks came a sound, low and continuous. It was not the Choir coming back off the walls. It came from *inside* the salt.

The brass stay-line ran up the wall from the floor and ended against the bulge in a broad collar sealed with grey wax. Over the whole face of the bulge was a casing, a thick clear shell of new-grown grain like a scab over a wound, and it was weeping. Beads of brine stood out all over it, and ran.

"Hands on the line," Ama said. "Where it comes up the wall. Both hands. Flat. Don't grip, lamb, it's not a rope, it's a bath. Lay them in." She put her own hands low on the brass where the line climbed the wall, and Hester put hers above, and the others ranged out along the line on either side. The brass was cold. Through a slot at the top of the sheathing Hester's fingertips touched the brine inside. That was cold too, and still.

"Now hold," said Ama. "Give it the hold. And sing."

They sang. Hester held.

It was like the Customs House, when she had gone into the hold to read the *Wren* grain: the breath going down, the heart going down, the whole of her settling round a single point like silt in a glass. But on the stool she had held alone. Here, through the line, she could feel the others: not as people but as weight, twelve stillnesses settling with hers. And she felt the stillness *go*. It went out of her hands into the brine, up the wall into the collar, out of the collar into the casing over the bulge, as warmth goes out of your hands into a cold cup, steadily, without your doing anything. *Still runs to quick*. Sorle's bit of string. She felt the quickening at the far end of the line pull like a drain. It wanted what she had. It drank it.

And as she held, the sound from inside the salt came up through the line into her hands, and through her hands into her, and it was no longer a sound behind a wall. It was all round her.

It was the Roar. She knew it from the *Wren*: the vast low rushing, rise and fall, the rise coming again before the fall was done. But on the customs stool it had been the sound in a shell. Here she was inside the shell. It had *shape*. The rises had heads that curled and broke, and the falls had a long drawn hiss after them, like a broom across a floor, like sand pulled back. There was a wind over it, a long steady push, cold, and under the wind a slapping, irregular, close, as of something hollow and wooden knocked against and knocked against. The Roar came in, and broke, and drew back hissing, and came in again. It had been doing that before she was born and before Ambry was built and before there was a Halcyon, and it was doing it now, in her hands.

Far off, under all of it, so faint she could not swear afterward that she had heard it at all, a bell rang once.

She did not know she was weeping until the salt of it stung the corners of her mouth. The tears ran into the neck of her gown, and where they dried they dried white. She was not sad; she was holding, and singing, and the sea was in her hands, and she had never in her life heard anything she wanted so much to go on hearing.

*Hold the line, hold the line—*

The beads on the casing slowed, and stood, and dulled, and dried. The cracks in the bulge went white and closed. The warmth on her face cooled. The sound drew back, and back, as a tide draws off a long shore, until it was the roar in a shell again, and then a murmur, and then only the Choir's voices in the low gallery.

"Ease off," said Ama softly. "Ease it now. Lift your hands. *Slow*."

Hester lifted her hands.

* * *

She came to on the floor of the gallery with her back against the wall and Ama's fourth shawl round her shoulders.

She did not know how she had got there. That was the worst thing. She had been lifting her hands from the brass; now she was sitting, wrapped up, and the

lamps had been moved, and the brass of the line was dry where it had been wet. Ama was crouched in front of her holding a tin cup to her mouth.

"Drink," Ama said. "Don't talk. Drink."

It was water, with salt in it. She drank it and was still so thirsty that her tongue stuck to the roof of her mouth. She was cold in her bones and her teeth, and she could not stop shaking.

"How long," she said. Her lips were clumsy.

"Couple of minutes. Two, maybe three." Ama tucked the shawl tighter. "That's lag, lamb. You gave it more than you had, first time, like they all do. You'll get most of it back." She sat back on her heels. "Told you you'd want the shawl."

Hester put her hand to her face. Her cheeks were stiff with dried salt, and it came away on her fingers in white flakes.

"It was the sea," she said.

Ama looked at her.

"I heard it. In the line. There was wind, and something knocking, and the—" She did not have the words. She had never had any reason to learn them. "It was the sea."

"Aye," said Ama. "It sounds like it, doesn't it." She said it peaceably, as you would agree with a child about the shape of a cloud. "Everybody hears something their first night. Residue, the Readers call it. Noise of the Ebb, caught in the grain." She got up slowly, with a hand on the wall, all the way, as the old man with the white beard had sat down. "Forty-one years I've heard it. Some nights I could swear it was the sea too. Up you come. Round's not done. Four and Nine yet."

Hester took the hand and came up. Her legs held her, mostly. At the mouth of the gallery Orsolya Thane was standing with a lamp, watching them come out. When she saw Hester, something came into her face that Hester had seen in her mother's once, long ago, at a school prize-giving in Lowside: a thing that had nothing to do with the prize.

"There she is," Orsolya said. "There's my girl. Eleven's quiet as a church, Ama says. First night." She put her cold hand on Hester's cheek, on the dried salt. "Didn't I say? Like a dropped anvil."

Hester could not answer. Her teeth were chattering.

"Go on," the Warden said gently. "Do the round. Then up, and eat something hot, and sleep." She turned away down the main gallery, lifting her lamp. Its light ran along the great brass channel of the eastern trunk, full and still, going away east into the dark, toward wherever it went.

CHAPTER 9

# *The Brinestacks*



*Readers are reminded that the tablets remember being touched. Gloves are to be worn. The Stacks accept no responsibility for what a careless hand may leave behind for the next reader to find.*

— Notice, Brinestacks entrance desk, Second Fathom

The Brinestacks smelled of paper, and under the paper, of the sea.

Hester had not noticed that on the tour. She had been looking at the shelves then, everyone had, because the shelves were the thing you were meant to look at. They ran away from the entrance desk in long radiating galleries like the spokes of a wheel, each gallery three tiers high with iron walkways and ladders. They were cut straight into the salt of the Second Fathom, and they held, the Proctor-guide had said, three hundred thousand bound volumes and forty thousand tablets. You could believe it. You could not see the end of any of the galleries. They went off into a soft amber dusk of kept-light lamps, and in the dusk there were the shapes of people on ladders, and the small endless sounds of a library: pages, a cough, a ladder's wheel turning on its rail.

But on the twenty-fourth of Russet, when she came down the Stair at the second bell with Teo and her customs ledger, her mouth was still raw from the Stay. She tasted the air as she came in at the great arched door, and under the leather and the paper and the lamp-oil there was the faint wet sweetness she had had in her hands on Friday night. It was faint and old. The tablets, she thought. Forty thousand tablets of grain, every one of them holding its scrap of the Roar.

"Where do we start?" said Teo.

"With what we can weigh," she said.

* * *

WHAT THEY COULD WEIGH WAS THE EXCHEQUER RETURNS.

Every licensed brinery on the Rim made a return to the Salt Exchequer each quarter, and a copy came to the Halcyon under the Charter, and the copies were bound by the year and shelved in the Cellaring gallery. Cellaring was the dullest gallery in the Stacks, and therefore the emptiest. It had kept goods, trade preservation and the arithmetic of fish. Hester and Teo had a long table at the end of it to themselves, under a lamp that had been pressed on a grey day and gave a light like weak tea.

The returns were in columns. Hester liked them at once. Name of house. Number of keepings at quarter's start. New keepings. Returns by family request. Returns by casing failure. Deaths following return. Number at quarter's end. Fees received. Each column was ruled, each figure was in a clerk's hand, and each page was signed at the foot by the house's director and countersigned by an exciseman. She had been reading documents like it since she was twelve years old. She sat down to them the way another woman might sit down to a piano.

"I can't read these," Teo said, after a quarter of an hour, with real sorrow. "I can read Tidewater short-script and High Marrane and the old Ostrine placenames off a map, but I look at a column of numbers and it simply lies there."

"Then read me the dates. I'll do the rest."

He read her the dates. She did the rest.

It took them till the fifth bell. The Cold House had been making returns since 788, the year of the Great Bloom. For a hundred years, quarter after quarter, the column headed *returns by casing failure* had stood mostly empty. A nought. A nought. A one, in 812, with a note in the margin: *casing cracked in the earthquake of Rime.* A nought. A one, in 851, an old woman kept eighty years whose casing had simply worn thin. Noughts. Hester ran her finger down the column through a century of noughts and ones and found a rate so slow you could set a clock by it. One casing failure every three years, roughly. One every three years, out of three hundred sleepers.

Then she came to this year, and the column was not empty.

*Fourth quarter, 902: nought. First quarter, 903: nought. Second quarter, 903: 1.* A man called Abel Corrie, kept in 879. *Third quarter, 903: 2.* Mary Ann Tees-

dale, kept in 864, and Ezra Hallam, kept 890. And in the next column along, *deaths following return*, the same figures in the same rows. One, and two.

Hester sat back.

"Three," she said. "In six months. Against one in three years for a century."

Teo looked at the page over her shoulder. "Hallam," he said. "Didn't your Mother Agathe say something about a Hallam?"

"The Hallam boy. She said Pell had him recast. Forty sols, from the charity fund." Hester looked at the date beside the name. "This is his father. Or his brother. Kept in eight-ninety. Returned by casing failure last quarter. Died."

"Then they've recast the son, because—"

"Because the son's weeping too." She ran her finger back to the director's signature at the foot of the page. *J. Pell, Director*. The exciseman's countersignature under it was an illegible scrawl. "Three of them. And nobody's written it anywhere but here, in a column nobody reads." She thought of what Aske had said in Quill Street. *It's in the Warden's returns to the Conclave, if anyone reads them, which nobody does*. "Is there anybody in this whole building who reads anything?"

"I'm told Callow does," Teo said. "But he's very slow."

* * *

The Stacks catalogue was in the long hall behind the entrance desk. It was a wall of narrow wooden drawers, three thousand of them, each with a brass label-holder and a brass ring. Each drawer was full of cards written in two hundred years of different hands. Hester stood in front of it on the twenty-fifth with Aske's sheet of shorthand folded in her pocket and one line of it in her head.

*Cistern. Old lines.*

She found the drawer under C. It held three cards for the Cistern. Two were for printed books, a Water Board history of 610 and a pamphlet of 455 complaining about the price of brine. The third card was larger and older, ruled in red, and read in a beautiful faded hand: *The Founders' Cistern & Lines of Supply. Plans, sections & elevations, 41 sheets, fol. Founders' Gallery, Press 9. Restricted: Reader's countersignature.*

Below that, ruled off in the same red, was a column headed *Requisitions*. It was nearly empty. In more than a hundred years three people had asked to see the Founders' Cistern plans, and each had signed the card, with the date.

The first was a Reader called Anselm Brack, in 788. Hester supposed it was the Great Bloom year and the city had wanted to know about its water.

The last, in small fast blue ink sloping hard to the right, was *C. Aske, R. — 1 Russet 903. East trunk survey.*

The first of Russet. The day she had walked down Coldwater Street and put her finger to a bead on her brother's casing. In the morning, while she was tasting the *Wren*'s grain, he had been here on a Fifth Fathom errand, before ever he came to the Customs House at the ninth bell with salt-mud on his gown, and before he could have known her brother's name.

And between Brack and Aske, a year earlier, there was one more line. It was in big plain capitals, leaning a little to the left, not a signature at all:

*W.L.F. (office) — 9 Fallow 902.*

She read it three times. Then she took the bill of lading out of the back of her ledger, where it had lived since the second of Russet. She unfolded it, and held it beside the card under the catalogue lamp, and looked at the shipper's box.

*W.L.F. per E.D.*

The hands were not the same. The card was written in those leaning capitals; the bill in small upright letters that she had seen somewhere lately and could not place. But the letters were the same three letters, in the same order, with the same full stops.

"Teo," she said.

He came. She showed him. He looked from one to the other for some time.

"Well," he said at last. "That's not a firm."

"No."

"*Office*. It says *office*. It's an office. Somebody's office signed for it." He frowned. "We could ask at the desk. They'd know their own abbreviations, surely."

They asked at the desk. The clerk on duty was a young Fellow with a cold and a stack of returns to file. She looked at the card for a while with her head on one side, sniffing.

"Departmental," she said. "Could be anything. Works. Lattice Fund. One of the Wardens. Lantern Fund, maybe. They all have codes; they change them every few years when somebody new comes in and wants their initials on things."

*One of the Wardens*. Something in Hester went toward the Fifth and stopped, like a hand short of a hot pan.

The clerk sniffed again. "Registry keeps the list. Write to the Registrar. They'll answer. Eventually."

"How eventually?"

"Fallow," said the clerk. "If you're lucky. Cinder if you're not."

Hester wrote to the Registrar. She wrote at the desk, standing, with the clerk's pen, a short polite request in the best hand she had, for the list of departmental requisition codes current in the year 902. She knew as she wrote it that it was the second note she had written in a month so that she could say afterward that she had written it. She posted it in the box for internal letters. It fell with a sound of paper landing on paper.

* * *

THE PLANS THEMSELVES SHE COULD NOT HAVE. *RESTRICTED: READER'S countersignature.* She had no Reader. But there was a second set, Teo found by the end of the afternoon. It was a reduced copy, made by the Water Board in 400 at the time of the bricking-up, nine sheets instead of forty-one, and it sat unrestricted in a dusty folio in the Lattice gallery under *Municipal Works (superseded).*

They spread it on a reading-slope in the Lattice gallery at the sixth bell, with the lamps going amber around them and the galleries emptying toward the Lantern Hour. The paper was brown and split along the folds and smelled of mice.

Sheet one was Ambry: not Ambry as it was now, but Ambry in the year 400, smaller, with fields where the Middle Ward was and the old shoreline drawn in a heavy line. Sheet two was Lowside. Hester's finger found Tanner's Row without looking. She found Pell Lane, Chandler's Lane, and Coldwater Street, running down to the sea-wall, with a warehouse at its foot marked *Excise Store.* And under the warehouse, under the whole lower end of Coldwater Street, there was a shape drawn in faint red ink. It was a long oval, ribbed like the inside of a ship, with a legend in the old Water Board hand:

*The Great Cistern. Capacity 40,000 tuns. Founders' work. Bricked 400.*

"The Cold House," said Teo slowly, "is sitting on the old reservoir."

Hester said nothing. She was looking at the eastern end of the oval. From it a single red line ran out under the sea-wall and off the edge of the sheet. Beside the line was written: *Main Line of Supply, E. — cont. sheet 6.*

Teo found sheet six. It was nearly blank, a long sheet of white paper representing the White, with nothing on it at all but a ruler-straight red line running

across it from west to east, two miles at the scale. There were tiny cross-ticks every furlong, and at its eastern end a small drawn dome with a tower on it. Beside the dome, the same hand had written:

*Halcyon. Line enters at 5th Fm. per Founders' sections (restricted).*

They stood and looked at it in the amber light.

"Water," Teo said at last. "It was the water supply. The founders built the Halcyon and they piped water into it from the city. Or out of it to the city. Either way." He did not sound as if he believed it.

"Brine," said Hester.

"What?"

"Not water. It says *supply*, but the Water Board in four hundred called everything water. The founders didn't." She touched the red line where it crossed the sea-wall. "The Cold House was an excise store. Before that, the founders. Under it there's a reservoir that held forty thousand tuns of something. From the reservoir a line runs straight out under the White, two miles, into the Fifth Fathom of the Halcyon." She heard her own voice go flat and careful. "And on my brother's casing the brine runs in lines toward the east."

Down the gallery a Fellow was coming along with a long brass snuffer, putting out the reading lamps one by one for the Lantern Hour.

"It's bricked up," Teo said. "Five hundred years. It says."

"Aske didn't think so," said Hester. "*Cistern, two question marks. Old lines.*"

She folded the sheets back into their folio carefully, along their old splits, and put the folio back on its shelf exactly where it had been, with its spine flush to the next. Then she stood a moment with her hand flat on it.

* * *

On the twenty-seventh, Teo heard the cry.

They had gone back to the Stacks to look for anything about the Cistern in the founders' period. It was a hopeless task, Teo said cheerfully, since nearly everything of the founders' period had burned in the fire of 230, and what hadn't burned was restricted, and what wasn't restricted was in short-script so archaic it would take him a month a page. But there were a few unrestricted brinescript tablets from just after the fire, in the Reading gallery. They were copies of copies, Water Board accounts, nothing that mattered. Teo, who was on Fane's Bench, was allowed to read them.

Fane. Hester turned the name over on the way there. *Odile* Fane: a Reader who listened to old salt for a living, who would know the Water Board tablets if anyone did, and who had told her on the twentieth to go carefully. *O.*

"Fane?" Teo looked pained when she said it. "She was at the Abbey in Harl from the fourteenth to the nineteenth, reading Vigil tablets for the Abbot. She wrote to the Bench from there on the sixteenth; I've the letter. Corvin sat next to her in Conclave. He'd have known she was two days off down the Harl road. You don't write *ask* for the morning about a woman in Harl."

It was a fact, and it weighed what it weighed. Hester struck the name off in her head, and was a little sorry; she had liked the warning.

He took one into a Reading Well and Hester went in with him and drew the curtain.

She had never watched Teo read. He was a poor hand at the hold; everybody knew that. Crisp had said in front of the whole Turning Intake that he held like a man trying to sit still on an ant-hill. He fidgeted, his knee went, his fingers drummed. She had seen him at the Pans trying to keep a drop and lose it three times in a row. But Reading was not the same as Keeping. Reading was listening, Fane said, and listening was a thing you could do with your knee going.

He sat in the Well's one chair with the tablet in his gloved hands. It was a slab of grey-white salt the size of a large book, cut on one face with the close lines of brinescript, its edges worn soft. He took off one glove and laid his bare palm on the uncut face. He shut his eyes. His knee went for a while, and then it stopped.

Hester stood against the curved wall and watched him settle. Not a deep stillness, not the anvil Orsolya had said Hester had: something lighter and stranger. His face went open, as if he were listening to someone speak across a room and was trying not to miss a word. His lips moved. After a minute he was speaking aloud, softly, what he heard. It was not the text cut into the tablet. It was the other thing, the moment the tablet had been made in, held in the grain.

"Scratching," he murmured. "Stylus. Someone's cutting it. A cough. A man with a cold. Fire in a grate. A cart, outside, far off—iron wheels on stone. And—the Roar, under, the residue. It's always there in the old ones, you get used to it, you hear past it—" He stopped.

His face changed.

"What's that," he said.

"What?"

"Hush." He held up his free hand without opening his eyes. "There. In the Roar. Under the scratching. There." His lips parted. "Something crying."

Hester came off the wall.

"High," Teo said slowly, "and falling. Two notes. Then a third that—breaks. Like a—" He frowned with his eyes shut. "Like a hinge, or a—"

"A child," Hester said. "A long way off."

His eyes opened.

She was standing over him. She did not remember crossing the Well. Her hands were cold.

"I heard that," she said. "In the *Wren*'s grain. On the first of Russet, on my customs stool. In the Roar. Two notes and a third that cracks." She took a breath. "What is it, Teo? You've been reading old salt for four years. What is it?"

He sat with the tablet on his knees and stared at her. Then, without another word, he got up and went out through the curtain. She heard him walking fast down the gallery, and then running.

* * *

He came back a quarter of an hour later with a book.

It was a hymnal: not the small black pocket hymnal every Tider carried, but a great old illustrated folio from the Order's shelf in the Religion gallery. It was printed in Harl two hundred years ago, with woodcuts at the head of every psalm, and the leather of its binding was rubbed through at the corners. He laid it on the reading-slope over the Water Board tablet and turned the pages fast and then slowly.

"The Abbey had this edition," he said. "The novices weren't allowed to touch it. I used to sneak in and look at the pictures. They're all of the sea. Everything. Every psalm. It's a book of *things that aren't here*." He found the page. "There."

It was the woodcut at the head of the *Song for the Vigil*. It showed a wave, drawn as a curling line of crests, the way a child draws the sea, and above it a sky with a few lines for wind. In the sky there were three birds. They were not salt-larks. They were long-winged, angled, with heads drawn small and beaks hooked. The woodcutter had carved their wings bent at the middle like a drawn bow. Beneath them, in the small italic of a caption, the printer had set a line from the psalm:

*And the gulls, the birds of the sea, crying.*

Hester looked at it for a long time.

"A gull," she said.

"A gull."

"I've never seen one."

"Nobody has." Teo's voice was not quite steady. "Hester. There are no gulls. There haven't been gulls on the Rim since the Ebb. They lived on the sea. They're in the ballads and the hymns and the Ostrine place-names. Gull Point, out by the Weeps, where there isn't a point and there aren't any gulls. They went when the sea went. Everybody knows that. The Abbot used to say they flew away with it to wherever it went, and they'd come back with it when it came home." He laughed, not happily. "We used to sing about them at the Vigil. Hundreds of us, with candles, out on the White. *And the gulls crying.* I never once thought about what one would sound like."

"It sounds like that," said Hester. "It sounds like a hinge."

They looked at each other across the open hymnal.

"The residue," Teo said. "The Roar. The Readers say it's the noise of the Ebb, of the salt setting. Crisp says so. Fane says so. Every textbook in this building says so." He put his finger on the woodcut. "The salt setting doesn't make a sound like a *bird*."

"No," said Hester.

"Then what—"

She did not answer. She did not have an answer. She had a cargo of warm grain that should not exist, and a brother whose casing wept toward the east. She had a red line on a mouse-eaten map running two miles under the White into the Fifth Fathom. She had a sound in a stay-line that she would have sworn on Mr. Thorne's stool was waves, and wind, and something wooden knocking. And she had a gull. She had all of it laid out like samples on a slate, and she could not put a grade to any of it. She did not know what it weighed.

* * *

They went out of the Stacks at the eleventh bell, when the lamps were half of them out and the galleries were dark and the porters were going round with their keys. The entrance hall was empty except for the desk, which was empty too, and the long table beside the desk where the under-archivist sat.

She had seen him on the tour. The Proctor-guide had pointed him out with a wink: *Callow, our under-archivist, or as the aspirants call him, the furniture.* She had seen him every time she had come to the Stacks since, in the same chair at the same table, under the same lamp. He was an old man, so old that age seemed to have stopped being a process in him and become a material. He was white-haired, white-browed and white-lashed, his skin gone the colour and texture of good paper. His hands lay on the table in front of him, one on top of the other, and in five visits she had never seen them move. His eyes were open. They were pale grey, and as far as she could tell they did not blink. Aspirants said he had been Settled for twenty years and the Stacks had simply never got round to moving him. Aspirants said a great many things.

She had stopped noticing him, as everyone did. She was passing the table, a pace behind Teo, with the hymnal's woodcut still in her eyes, when he spoke.

"Corvin sat there too."

It was so slow that it hardly seemed a sentence. Each word came out separately, with a breath before it, as if each had had to be fetched from a long way off and set down with care. His voice was dry and light, like paper turning. His head had not moved. His hands had not moved. Only his eyes had come round, grey and steady, to rest on her.

Hester stopped.

"I'm sorry?"

The old man took a long time. In the silence the lamp over his table hissed, and somewhere far off down a gallery a porter's keys jingled and stopped. Teo had turned back and was standing quiet at Hester's shoulder.

"There," said Callow. His eyes went, slowly, to the catalogue hall behind her, to the wall of drawers. Then they came back. "On the first of the month."

"He's in the Quiet Rooms now," Hester heard herself say. "Clear as glass. The Proctor says Hush keeps everything clear."

That took longer. The lamp hissed through all of it.

"The dead bloom," said Callow. "A month or so. Whatever the grade."

He said nothing else. They waited. After a long while his eyes went back to wherever they had been looking before, at the lamp or the table or nothing, and stayed there. He did not seem to know they were still standing in front of him.

Hester went up the Stair to the Rookery with her ledger under her arm, Teo silent beside her. The Stair turned round and round in the dark, with the chalked

names of the Settled going by on the walls in the light of the landing lamps. She thought about the old man at his table. He had sat there on the first of Russet while Corvin Aske signed his name in the catalogue with blue ink. He had sat there on the ninth of Fallow last year while somebody wrote *W.L.F. (office)* in big capitals that leaned to the left. He had sat there, she supposed, for every requisition on every card in three thousand drawers, for twenty years, and nobody had ever asked him what he had seen, because he was the furniture.

At the window of R-41, before she slept, she stood a while and looked out. The White lay black to the edge of the world. Two miles off Ambry was a smudge of orange on the dark. Somewhere between here and there, under the salt, under the dark, a line ran straight as a rule from her brother's floor to the Fifth Fathom. She could not see it. She stood with her forehead against the cold glass, and for the first time since she had stepped over the Line she let herself think a thing she could not weigh. Then she went to bed.

CHAPTER 10

# *Lantern Night*



*Summer in a jar, summer in a jar, pour it on the rooftops where the cold folk are.*

— Ambry street-song, sung by children on the last night of Russet

Saskia Orme was a different woman on the Ambry side of the Causeway, and Hester could not decide whether she liked her better.

On the Shelf, Saskia moved through the Halcyon as if every corridor charged a toll. She answered questions in as few words as would pass, and looked at Hester, when she looked at her at all, as a glazier looks at a bubble in a pane. But when they came off the Causeway at the Eastgate at the fourth bell on the thirtieth of Russet, into the smell of hot fat and the shouting of the lantern-sellers, something in her shoulders let go. She pulled the pins out of her hair as she walked and talked round them. She bought three twists of burnt sugar from a barrow without haggling, which Hester had never seen a Quell woman do, and handed them out as if it were nothing.

"Don't thank me," she said. "It's for the walk. The Glassmarket's uphill and Teodor complains."

"I don't complain," said Teo. "I lament. It's a liturgical form."

"You lament uphill."

"Most of the great laments are uphill. It's the incline that does it." He bit his sugar and closed his eyes. "Oh. Oh, that's burnt properly. That's burnt by somebody who understands burning."

Saskia almost smiled. Hester watched it arrive and be put away again, and thought: *so she can.*

Ambry on the last day of Russet was a city getting ready to be lit. Hester had stood in these streets on thirty-three Lantern Nights and it still surprised her. Ladders leaned on every house-front on the Corn Exchange. Men at the tops of them hung iron brackets under the eaves, and women came behind with the jars: Quell glass, round-bellied, the size of a child's head, the stoppers sealed in wax and stamped with the halcyon. Inside each, a pound or so of white grain sat in the bottom. Kept light always looked like nothing until it was let out. You could hold a jar of it up to your eye at noon and see only salt.

"There's eleven thousand of them this year," Saskia said. "Bassano says. Pressed in the Pans between Seedmonth and Highsummer, every one carried over the Causeway by hand in the last three days. Two broke on the Causeway this morning and a carter lost his eyebrows."

"Broke how?" said Hester.

"Badly." Saskia took a pin out of her mouth. "I'll show you. After."

* * *

The Glassmarket was a steep street of narrow shops that climbed from the Corn Exchange to the Middle Ward, all Quell people: glaziers and lens-grinders and the women who painted fine lines on kept-light lanterns for the rich. In the window of every shop, today, there was a jar on a stand, and a child guarding it.

Saskia's mother kept a shop near the top. It had a green door, a bell that rang two notes, and a window of spectacle-glass laid out on black velvet like a jeweller's tray. Hennie Orme was a small square grey woman with Saskia's jaw and Saskia's hands, broader. She came round the counter wiping them on her apron, looked Hester up and down once, as Saskia did, and then looked at Teo and laughed.

"You'll be the monk," she said.

"Former," said Teo. "Lapsed. Fallen, in the technical sense."

"You've crumbs on your gown, fallen." She turned to the back of the shop. "Pip. *Pip*. Your mother's here, and she's brought a monk."

A child came out from under the counter. She did not run. She was six, thin, with a cloud of pale hair that had got loose from two plaits, and she held in both hands a small jar of kept light, her own, the size of an apple. She stopped in the middle of the floor and looked at her mother.

Saskia went down on her knees on the shop boards.

Hester had not seen that face before. Nobody at the Halcyon had seen it, she was nearly sure. Not softer, exactly. More open, as a shutter is more open: the same wood, swung back. Saskia did not reach for the child. She waited, on her knees, with her hands on her thighs, and the child came to her across the floor at her own pace and held out the jar.

"I didn't drop it," Pip said.

"I can see you didn't."

"Gran said if I dropped it there'd be no summer."

"Gran's a liar," said Saskia. "There'd be a bit less summer. Come here."

Then the child was in her arms and the jar was somehow safe between them. Hennie turned to the counter and began rearranging spectacles that did not need it, and Hester looked at the window.

They had tea in the back room, Quell-fashion, which meant no salt and a great deal of sugar. Teo sat on the floor and let Pip explain a game involving buttons, which he lost thoroughly and with evident pleasure. Saskia sat with her cup and her daughter's hair in her free hand, plaiting it, unplaiting it, plaiting it again.

On the shelf above the stove was a small painted portrait of a young man in a pilot's leather coat, laughing, his cap pushed back. It was the only painted thing in the room. Hester looked at it once and away.

"Jory," said Saskia, without looking up from the plait. "My husband. He's dead. You were going to ask."

"I wasn't."

"No. You weren't. You're like me, you don't ask." She tied the plait off with a bit of thread. "He sailed freighters for the Lodge. Quell to Harl and back, the long southern run. Two years ago in Cinder his ship went through the crust on the eastern White, forty miles out. A sink. The whole ship. They found the mainmast sticking up out of the salt like a grave-post, and they found him, because he was at the masthead when she went and he climbed. He'd got as far as the truck." She said it in the voice for prices. "A sink's only open for a minute. Then it skins over and sets. He was standing on the top of the mast with the salt round his chest. They had to cut it."

Pip, on the floor, was teaching Teo to flick a button into a cup. Teo was bad at it.

"That's why the Halcyon," Hester said.

"That's why the Halcyon. A Lodge widow gets a pension of nine sols a quarter. A Reader of Lumen in Ambry gets four hundred a year and a house in the Close. I did the sum." Saskia drank her tea. "I don't do causes, Vail. I do rent."

"I know," Hester said. "I do it too."

Something passed between them over the teacups. Not friendship; something earlier than that, a recognition of weights.

When they left, Saskia gave her mother money for the week. Hester saw the coin go across: a sol, a new one, bright, the edges still sharp from the mint, though there was no reason for that to mean anything. Pip stood in the door with her jar and watched them down the street.

* * *

The Glassmarket's lantern-jars were being loaded off a dray at the bottom of the street, into baskets for the ladder-women. Saskia stopped there and showed Hester what she had promised.

She took a jar out of a basket, over the carter's protests, and held it up against the late sun. "Look at the belly. Through it. At the edge."

The glass was clear and slightly greenish, as Quell glass was. There was nothing in it.

"Now this one." Saskia took another from a basket off a different dray, with a cheaper mark on the stopper.

Hester saw it at once, and was annoyed not to have seen it in the first. Near the base of the second jar there were faint lines, almost not there, like the lines in water that has been stirred and not quite settled. They ran in a stretched curl.

"Stress," Saskia said. "That's the glass remembering how it cooled. When you blow a jar it's all one heat. Then the outside cools first, because the air's on it, and shrinks, and the inside's still hot and big and gets squeezed. Let it cool fast, out on the bench in the draught, and the outside sets hard round an inside that's still pushing. The push stays in it. Months. Years. And one day you knock it, or you warm it, and it just goes. All at once." She tapped the jar with a fingernail. "This one's going to go. You pour kept summer out of a jar and the arrears come off it warm. That's enough. It'll be in pieces in somebody's gutter by Midwinter."

"And the first one?"

"Annealed." Saskia put it back gently in its basket. "You take it off the pipe and put it in a box of hot ash and let it come down slow. A day. Two for a big one.

The outside and the inside cool together, near enough. The stress walks out of it a bit at a time, and when it's cold there's nothing left in it pushing. You can drop that jar on a stone floor and it'll bounce." She glanced at the carter. "Don't drop it on a stone floor."

"The two on the Causeway," Hester said.

"From Hallam's works. They save on ash." Saskia shrugged. "Cool it slow and the stress walks out. Cool it fast and it waits for you. That's the whole of glass. My father used to say it's the whole of most things."

Hester thought, for no reason she could name, of her father at pan nineteen, drawing the coals a shovelful at a time. She did not say so.

* * *

They went down to the Cold House at dusk because Hester said she would like to, and nobody argued. She had expected Saskia to leave them. Saskia walked beside her down the long slope of Coldwater Street with her hands in her coat pockets and said nothing about it at all, which was, Hester was coming to understand, how a Quell woman was kind.

Ennis was not at the desk. A girl Hester did not know sat there, with the Cold House's one charity jar on the felt beside the ledger, unopened.

"We're not open. It's the holiday."

"I'm Vail. Two hundred and eleven."

"Oh. Mother Agathe said you might." The girl looked at Teo and Saskia, then at Hester's gown and the white cord at the shoulder, and decided it was not worth the trouble.

The ward at dusk was not the ward in the morning. The high windows had gone indigo. A small oil flame burned in brass at the foot of every casing, and each casing had taken its flame into itself and held it, so that the long room was full of held lights, three hundred and four of them, in rows. Teo stopped at the bottom of the six steps.

"Oh," he said. "Oh, Hester."

"Don't," she said.

"I wasn't going to."

Tib was where Tib was. The beads on his casing had multiplied. In the lamplight they were a fine dew over the whole eastern flank, running in lines, and in three places the lines had joined into runnels. There was a damp stain on the

plinth's stone at the eastern foot, the size of her palm. It had not been there four weeks ago.

She did not touch it. She had no need to.

"This is your brother," said Saskia. It was not a question.

"Tobias. Tib."

Saskia looked at him for a long moment: at the hand curled on his chest, the pencil-grip, and then at the beads. Her face gave nothing away.

"How old?"

"Fourteen."

"How long?"

"Eleven years."

Saskia nodded slowly. "That's a lot of rent," she said, and Hester, astonishingly, laughed.

Agathe came up the aisle with her brush. She was slower than at the start of the month, or Hester was seeing her differently. She took in Teo's shawl, and the brass wave of the Order still pinned to it, and her face changed.

"A brother," she said.

"Was," said Teo. "Tidewater. I'm sorry, Mother. I left."

"Many do." She took his hand in both hers, briefly, the Tider way. "Tide willing, it'll bring you round again, one way or another." Then, to Hester, low: "Come and see, my dear. I want you to see."

She took them to the sixth row. In the third casing from the end lay a stout woman of thirty or so in a brown dress, on her side, knees drawn up, both hands pressed to her mouth as if she had coughed and been surprised by it. Her hands and chin were dark. Not with shadow.

"Bett Linnow," Agathe said. "Twenty years this Rime. Haemorrhage of the lungs."

Bett Linnow's casing was not beaded. It was running. The whole eastern side was wet, and the wet ran into a groove cut in the plinth and from there into a little brass channel along the floor. And the casing was thinner. Over Bett's shoulder, where it should have been a hand's breadth thick, it was the thickness of a slate. Light came through it differently there. The shoulder of the brown dress looked closer to the air than the rest of her, as a thing looks closer when it lies near the surface of water.

"The brinewright recast her in Highsummer," Agathe said. "And again on the twelfth. Forty sols each time, from the charity fund, and Mr. Pell put up a hand and said there's no more after this. It doesn't hold."

"How long?" said Hester.

Agathe only looked at the casing.

At the end of the sixth row, on a stool beside the plinth, sat a very old woman Hester had taken for a heap of shawls. She had one hand flat on the stone, an inch from the casing. She did not look round.

"Ruth," Agathe said quietly. "Her mother. She'll sit through the light."

Hester went back to Tib for a minute before they left. Then the three of them went up the six steps and out into Coldwater Street, and found Lucan Ferrers on the doorstep.

He was in a long dark coat with a fur collar that cost more than the Cold House's charity fund, and he had the look of a man who had been standing in a cold street rehearsing. As the door opened his face was, for a moment, entirely unguarded: startled, young, guilty as a boy caught in a larder. Then the face she knew came back over it, smooth and finished, like a lid.

"Miss Vail," he said. "I followed you over the Causeway. Badly, I expect. I wanted to talk where nobody from the Shelf would hear." He looked past her at Teo and Saskia. "I hadn't allowed for a deputation."

"My brother's in there," Hester said. "Fourth row."

That stopped him. He looked at the door, and then at her, and did not say *I'm sorry*. She would have thought less of him if he had.

"The *Constant Wren*," he said instead, low. "You said the name to me in the Stacks. I'd never heard of it. The firm's ships aren't considered my department." He said *considered* with a little twist. "I went home. I asked my father."

"And?"

"And he told me to drop it. He wasn't angry. That was the strange part. My father is angry about most things; it's how he shows interest. He put his hand on my shoulder, which he hasn't done since I was nine, and told me the Halcyon's business was the Halcyon's and the firm's was the firm's, and that some laundry kept the lamps lit. Then he went into his study and shut the door." He paused. "He sits at the Assize on Thursdays. The firm's books are kept at the house."

"Naturally," said Saskia.

"Naturally," Lucan agreed, and did not smile.

Down the hill, the city's bells began to ring the eighth.

* * *

The light was to be poured at the ninth bell. They fetched Pip from the Glassmarket at a run, because Hennie would not climb a wall at her age and Pip had been promised, and then they went up onto the old sea-wall at the end of Coldwater Street, because Hester said it was the best place and nobody wanted the crowds on the Corn Exchange. Lucan came. Nobody asked him; he simply walked with them. Saskia gave him one look and decided, visibly, that he was not worth the effort of getting rid of.

So there were four of them on the wall, and a child. Lowside had always come up onto the wall on Lantern Night. The broad top was crowded with families in their coats on blankets on the cold stone, passing bottles, telling children to stop climbing on the parapet. On one side lay Lowside and the slope of the city, dark and full of ladders. On the other, far below, lay the White.

The White at night was not white. It was grey-blue, faintly luminous, as if it had kept a little of the day and was letting it out slowly. Out on it, the tiles had begun to sing. In the cold after sunset the great plates of salt contracted and ticked against each other, millions of them, out to the edge of the world, a sound like a cathedral full of glass beads being poured from one hand to another.

Pip, on Saskia's hip, put her hands over her ears and then took them away.

"It's talking," she said.

"It's cooling," said Saskia.

"Same thing," said Teo, and Saskia, Hester saw in the dark, did not argue.

Two miles out, the Halcyon was a dark shape on the dark plain, and the Lantern on top of it was dark too, the only night of the year it was. The mirrors had been turned away at sunset and the tower stood unlit against the stars like a pin stuck in a map.

Lucan stood a few feet off, at the parapet, with his hands in his expensive pockets. Hester went and stood beside him. She did not know why.

"Have you seen it from up here before?" she asked.

"From the roof of Ferrers House. We have a terrace." He did not look at her. "My mother used to take me up. She'd hold the jar while I broke the wax. She died when I was eleven." He said it in the same tone as *we have a terrace*. "I haven't been on the terrace since."

Hester thought of several things to say and said none of them.

The ninth bell began, from the Halcyon first, faint across two miles: a single deep note. Then the Lantern lit.

It did not flash. It *opened*. Light came out of the top of it as if someone had uncorked the sky: a thick honey-gold, the gold of a wheatfield at four in the afternoon in Highsummer, of the light on a wall when you have been asleep in the heat and woken. It poured from the Lantern's head in every direction and lay across the White in a widening disc, and the salt threw it back up, so that the whole plain between the Shelf and the city was a floor of gold under a gold sky.

And then Ambry answered.

On every roof, under every eave, eleven thousand jars were unstoppered at once and tipped. The light did not come out like water, or like lamplight. It came out like summer. It spilled over the gutters and ran down the slates and filled the streets to the first-floor windows. Lowside below them went from black to gold in the time it takes to say so. Each roof was its own colour: the white-gold of noon, the red-gold of evening, the green-gold of a June morning under trees, all running together in the streets until the city was a pan of molten light. And it was warm. Hester felt it on her face, standing on a sea-wall above the White on the last night of Russet: the sun on the side of her face, as on a summer afternoon when you turn toward it with your eyes shut.

There was sound in it. Every year she forgot that, and every year it came back to her like a smell. Out of the gold in Lowside's streets came birdsong, faint and enormous: the larks of Highsummer over the pans, sparrows at dawn in the eaves, a blackbird somewhere at the end of a long June evening. It was a hundred summer days that had been put in jars and carried over the Causeway and poured out on a winter city.

On the wall, people were crying, not loudly. An old man on a blanket with his face turned up, wet. A woman laughing with her hand over her mouth. Children shrieking through the gold, which fell on them like everything else. Pip had both arms out from Saskia's hip and was trying to catch it. Saskia was not looking at the light. She was looking at her daughter, with the face from the shop floor.

Teo stood straight, as he must once have stood in the abbey choir. His lips were moving. Hester did not ask what he was saying.

She thought of the Cold House: the one jar on the felt beside the ledger, the girl at the desk unstopping it. Down there in the gold, under Coldwater Street,

the light would be pouring down the six worn steps and over the rows, over three hundred and four casings, over Bett Linnow and the old woman with her hand on the stone, and over a boy with a pencil hand. The casings would take it into themselves and hold it, because that was what they did, and the beads on them would shine.

The light lasted a little under a quarter of an hour. Then it thinned, gold to amber, amber to a kind of rose, and the birdsong went quiet one bird at a time, as an evening goes. Lowside came back, roof by roof, to the ordinary dark of a city at the end of Russet with the Sere blowing salt along its streets. Somebody on the wall began, raggedly, to sing the jar-song, and the children took it up.

Lucan had not moved from the parapet. In the last of the rose light his face was quite still.

"I don't think it was an accident," he said, low, so that only she could hear. "Aske."

"No," Hester said.

Two miles off, the Lantern went out, and the dark came back over the White, and the tiles went on ticking into it, cooling, millions of them, as if nothing had been poured at all.

CHAPTER 11

# *The Sink*



*The White does not forgive. The White does not hate. The White is a floor with a hole in it.*

— Weathering field manual issued to first-year aspirants, the Halcyon, rev. 880 Y.E.

The *Gannet* was a school skiff, which meant she was old, slow by the standards of the White, and built to forgive the stupid. She was a two-master, fifty feet from bowsprit to stern, with a broad flat deck and iron runners as thick as a man's thigh, and she had been repainted so many times that the blue of her hull had layers in it, like the strata in a delver's cut. At the second bell on the sixth of Fallow she lay on the salt ramp below the Halcyon's eastern Gatehouse with her sails slatting in a stiff north-easterly, and twenty-two first-year aspirants stood beside her in borrowed wool coats and glare-goggles, looking at her as cattle look at a river.

Hester had spent twenty-one years at a desk above a harbour full of landships. She had tasted their holds and never once set foot on a deck, because a single crossing to Quell cost more than she earned in a month. She looked at the *Gannet* and felt something she had not felt since she was a child: a plain, uncomplicated want.

"Tib would have given his teeth for this," she said, before she could stop herself.

"Then you'll have to enjoy it twice," said Teo. He was green already, and they had not moved. "I'm told one is sick. Copiously. Over the side."

"You're thinking of water."

"I'm thinking of the theology of motion. It's my area."

The Warden of the Lower Fathoms came down the ramp at a walk, in an iron-grey coat with the collar turned up and a fur hat that had seen better winters, and the aspirants straightened without being told.

"Right," said Orsolya Thane. "Morning, all. You've read the manual. Forget it. Three rules on the White. One: you go where the pilot says and nowhere else. Two: if Ballast lies down, you stop. Three: nobody keeps anything unless I say so." Her eye stopped on Hester, and something in it warmed. "And nobody's sick on my deck. Over the side. Into the wind is a lesson you only need once."

Ballast turned out to be a lurcher, a long grey dog with a rough coat and a face like an apologetic horse. He lay on a coil of rope by the mainmast with his chin on his paws and watched the aspirants board with deep weariness.

"Best sink-sniffer on the Shelf," said the pilot, a lean brown Fellow called Marten Coyle with a sky-blue Weathering cord and a face cracked by glare. "Fourteen years on the White and never put a foot wrong. If he lies flat, you freeze, and you don't move till I tell you. He hears the crust go hollow before the crust knows it."

Lucan Ferrers was the last to board, in a coat that fitted him and tortoiseshell goggles of his own. He stepped over the rail as though he had been doing it all his life, which, Hester supposed, he had. He nodded to her as he had nodded since Lantern Night: a nod with nothing in it but the fact of it. She nodded back.

Coyle shouted, two Fellows on the ramp knocked out the chocks, the sails came round with a crack like a slammed door, and the *Gannet* began to move.

* * *

The runners ground on the ramp and the deck jolted and Teo sat down on a hatch-cover. Then they came off onto the open White, and the grind became a hiss, a long continuous rush under the hull like silk being torn slowly, and the jolting smoothed into a hum she felt through her boots and up her shins. The wind took the mainsail, Coyle put the helm over, and the *Gannet* leaned.

She had not known it would be so fast. The ridges between the tiles flickered past so quickly they became a pattern and then a texture and then nothing at all, a smooth white rushing. The wind came over the bow full of fine salt that stung her lips and made her eyes run behind the goggles. Ahead there was no road, no rail, no edge; only the white going out flat under a hard blue sky to a horizon that was not where it ought to be.

She laughed. She held the rail with both hands and laughed into the wind like a child on a swing, and did not care who heard.

"Nine knots," Coyle shouted from the helm, to nobody. "Ten. She'll make twelve on this reach. Old cow."

They ran east and a little north for most of an hour. The Halcyon fell away to a white smudge with a needle on it, and Ambry sank below the rim of the world. The light came off the salt from below as well as above, so that there were no shadows anywhere, and even through the smoked glass the glare was a white hand laid flat on her eyes.

Then the Pull began. It started as a shimmer at the horizon, as on a road in summer, but it did not stay there. It came in. It lifted the far edge of the plain into the sky, so that the world curved upward at its rim like the inside of a bowl, and a line of low dark shapes appeared ahead, rocks or ships or a city, upside down, hanging above their own reflections.

"Pay it no mind," Coyle called. "That's Harl. Ninety miles off. The White likes to show you things."

"It's not real," said a first-year near Hester, a girl named Imke Dorran with a brown Bench cord.

"It's all real," Coyle said. "It just isn't where it says it is. You walk toward what you see out here, you'll walk till you die. Look at the dog."

Ballast had raised his head. He was regarding the upside-down city with contempt.

* * *

Orsolya came and stood at the rail beside Hester somewhere in the second half-hour. She did not hold on. She stood with her feet apart and her hands in her coat pockets and let the deck do what it liked under her.

"You've a face on you," she said, "like a girl at her first fair."

"I've never sailed."

"No. Lowside doesn't, much." Orsolya looked out at the glare. "My da took me out once. On a delvers' skiff, to the Coldbank cuts, when I was ten. I sat on a crate of picks and shrieked the whole way. He laughed till he cried." She was quiet. "Year after, the cut came in on him."

"I'm sorry."

"Long time ago." She turned her head. Under the fur hat her face was weather-reddened and lined, and her eyes behind the goggles were pale and steady. "Choir's treating you right?"

"Yes."

"You're good. You know that? Ama says you've the deepest hold she's sat beside in ten years. Deep and square, like a well. She says you hold like you're carrying something up a ladder and you'll not put it down." She smiled. "That's not always a compliment, mind. But in the Choir it is."

Hester watched the white rushing past.

"How's your brother?" Orsolya said. "Still at the Cold House?"

"Yes."

"Coldwater Street." Orsolya nodded, looking out at the salt. "They're good there. That old Tider woman. She keeps them like a garden."

Hester turned her head.

She had not told Orsolya about the Cold House. She was nearly sure she had not. On the Causeway, the first morning, Orsolya had said *your brother's kept, Corvin says*, and in the Warden's office Hester had said *I've a brother who's kept*, and that was all. She had not said where.

But Aske had known where. Aske had counted the weeping casings himself, and Aske had been Orsolya's colleague for twenty years, and Readers talked. Corvin told her, Hester thought. He told everybody everything; he couldn't help it.

"She does," she said. "Agathe. Like a garden."

"Good." Orsolya patted the rail twice, as if it were a horse. "You hold on to that."

Then Coyle called *site in sight*, and she went forward.

* * *

The bloom-site lay five miles out from the Shelf on the north-eastern reach. From a mile off it was a faint discolouration in the white, as if someone had breathed on a mirror. From a quarter-mile off it was a stain. Coyle spilled the wind and dropped the brakes, and the *Gannet* came down off her hiss into a long shuddering scrape, and stopped. In the silence Hester heard the tiles ticking in the sun, and Teo, behind her, being quietly and thoroughly sick over the side.

"Into the wind," said Orsolya, without turning round. "Well done, Anselm."

They went down a rope ladder onto the salt in pairs, Coyle first with Ballast on a long lead. Orsolya laid out the rules again, flatly: walk in the dog's track and nowhere else; stop when he stops; touch nothing with a bare hand. Each of them carried a mixing flask on a strap across the chest, a squat brass thing with two chambers, grain in one and water in the other, divided by a wax seal. You cracked the seal with your thumb, shook it, and for a few minutes you had live brine. After that it was salt water.

They walked in single file toward the stain.

A hundred yards out, the hard ringing crust, which gave back each step like a plank floor, went dull, then soft. The colour went from white to grey to a faint green-grey. Then she smelled it. It was a green smell, a wet smell, rotten-sweet like the Weeps at low water in summer, but not rotten: under it was something sharp and clean, the smell of a thing that is growing.

"Weed," said Orsolya, from the front. "That's what the old ballads called it. Don't ask me how they knew."

The site was a rough circle about forty yards across. In the middle the crust had gone dark and wet and soft, like snow in a gutter in Thaw. Small pools of brine stood in it, the size of plates, and every few breaths the surface of every pool shivered at once, as if something had been dropped into it from a height. Steam came off the dark crust faintly. Hester felt the warmth on her face from twenty feet off, as she had felt the light on Lantern Night.

"This is a bloom," Orsolya said. They stood in a half-ring at the edge of the dark crust, behind the dog. "A quickening that's come up near the top. We've a dozen like it on the north-east reach and three on the south. The Fifth's full of them, in the deep. Most never come up. When they do, they do this, and then they skin over in a month or a year and you'd never know." She crouched and put a gloved hand flat on the dark salt. "Feel it. Gloves on. Go on."

Hester put her gloved palm on the crust. It was warm through the wool. And under the warmth, so faint that she thought at first it was her own blood in her ears, there was a sound. A long slow hush, and a pause, and a hush. Like breathing. Like the noise in a shell held to the ear.

She had heard it in the Choir, in the deep, with sixty voices round her and the stay-line cold under her hands. *The sea.*

"What is it?" said Imke Dorran. Her voice was small.

"Pressure," Orsolya said. "Residue. Ask Reader Sorle and he'll tell you it's the Ebb trying to un-happen, and charge you a sol for the privilege." Some of them laughed. "It's grain that's gone quick. It's warm, it's wet, it moves, and if you see it on the White, you go round."

"And the sound?"

Orsolya was quiet, with her hand on the salt.

"The sound's the sound," she said. "Up you get."

Ballast whined.

Hester heard it because she was nearest. The dog had been standing at the end of his lead with his ears up. Now he did not lie down so much as fall, all four legs going out at once, chest and belly pressed to the salt, ears flat to his skull.

"*Freeze*," said Coyle.

Twenty-two aspirants froze. For a moment there was no sound but the tiles ticking and the dog whining and the long slow hush of the bloom.

Then the White opened under Lucan Ferrers.

* * *

It did not crack. There was no sound of breaking. Lucan was standing at the end of the half-ring, three paces to her left, a little forward of the line, where he had stepped to see the pool better. The crust under his boots simply went soft and down, like a sheet drawn off a bed. A hole the width of a cart opened in the white, black and wet, and he went down into it.

He did not cry out. His arms went up. His face, as it went, was surprised.

Hester had the flask off her chest before she knew she had moved. She cracked the seal with her thumb, shook it once, hard, and threw.

Not the flask. The brine. She flung it out of the open neck in a long flat arc, as she had flung slops across a yard every morning of her childhood. It went out of the brass in a sheet, glittering, and came down across Lucan's raised arms and head and shoulders and the black wet lip of the sink at the instant his chest went under the rim.

And she held.

There was no time to decide. She went down into the hold as you go down a stair in the dark, all at once, by the feel of your feet. Breath gone. Heart slowed to nothing. Every muscle set like mortar. She had kept a falling drop of brine in

Crisp's class, a leaf, a moth. She had never kept anything larger than her hand. She had never kept a living person.

She kept him.

It came out of her like water through a broken sluice. The stillness poured from her into the brine, down her own arm, still outstretched from the throw, and across the air between them, and she felt the brine take it and set. Then there was a weight on her, enormous, as if she had caught the whole falling man by the wrists and was holding him over the drop with nothing under him but black.

When she could see again, Lucan Ferrers was hanging in the mouth of the sink.

A casing had set round him, rough and lumpy where the brine had splashed, clear in places and white in others. It ran from the top of his head to just below his ribs, and below that there was only black, wet, open nothing. His arms were up, the hands spread, and where the brine had splashed across the lip of the sink the casing had fused to it. It held him by its own edges at the rim of the hole, like a stopper in the neck of a bottle. His mouth was open. One lock of the wet-straw hair stood up from his head, held, mid-fall.

Then Orsolya was beside her, and Coyle was flat on his belly at the rim with a rope, and somebody in the half-ring was screaming, and Ballast was howling.

"*Don't touch him*," Orsolya was saying, sharp, not to Hester. "Coyle. Rope round the casing, below the arms. Don't you *touch* that rim. Anselm, Dorran, on the rope with him. Gloves." Then, close to Hester's ear: "Hester. Can you hear me?"

"Yes."

"Good. You kept him. You did right." Orsolya's voice was steady and fast. "Now listen. That casing's on the rim, and the rim's soft, and it's going to go. When it goes, the weight takes him down, and the sink skins over in a minute and he's under the White kept, and there's nobody on the Rim can get him out. Do you understand me?"

"Yes."

"So you've to return him. Now. While they've the rope on him."

The rim was going. A thin black crack had opened in the softened crust a hand's breadth from where the casing was fused, and wet was coming up through it. The casing tilted a quarter of an inch. Coyle, Teo, Imke and two others had the rope round it and were leaning back with their heels dug in, white-faced.

"Return him," Orsolya said.

Hester tried.

She knew how. Crisp had taught it again and again, and she had failed it nearly every time. You stayed in the hold; you put your attention on the keeping; you *let it go*. Crisp's word was *unclench*. Hester tried, and what came instead was the feeling of a fist closing tighter. Her hands were shaking out in front of her, and she could not tell if they were open or closed. If she let it go he would fall. That was the thing her body knew and would not be talked out of. She held.

"I can't."

"Yes, you can."

"He'll fall—"

"He'll not fall. They've the rope. Look at them, they've got him." The crack widened. The casing tilted another half-inch. The rope creaked. "Hester. Don't push it out. You're trying to shove it out of you like a cart. That's not how. You're holding him in your fist and trying to throw him, and you can't throw what you won't let go of." Orsolya's cold hand came down over Hester's shaking one. It did not grip. It lay there. "Open your hand."

"I—"

"Open your hand, chick. That's all. Just open it."

Orsolya's hand on hers was cold as stone and perfectly still. Hester thought, for no reason, of Saskia on her knees on the shop boards, not reaching, waiting with her hands on her thighs, while the child came across the floor at her own pace.

She opened her hand.

The weight went out of her all at once. The casing went with a sound like a pane of ice dropped on a stone floor, one great flat *crack* that came up through her boots and slapped her in the face. White dust burst from the sink's mouth, and out of the dust came a hot wind, hot as an oven door opening, that knocked her back on her heels. In the middle of it Lucan Ferrers, whole and wet and gasping, was hauled over the lip on the end of a rope and dragged across the soft crust on his belly, five yards, ten, coughing, alive.

Behind him the sink skinned over. She watched it happen: a slow wet white closing, like a mouth.

Lucan lay on his side on the hard salt with Coyle kneeling on him, making a sound she had not heard a man make before, a high, airless, astonished wheeze, one hand clutching at his side.

"Ribs," said Coyle. "Two at least. The snap. Hold still, sir, you've no breath to waste. Hold *still*—"

"Good," Orsolya said beside her. "Oh, that's good. That's a lovely release. That's—"

Hester turned her head to look at her, and the world stopped.

* * *

It did not go dark. She did not faint, and there was no pain. There was just no time.

She was looking at Orsolya's face, at the cold red cheeks under the fur hat and the mouth open on *that's*. And then she was looking at the sky.

It was a different sky. The same hard blue, but the sun had moved; she could see it had moved. The few shadows there were had swung round, as shadows swing on a sundial. She was lying on her back on the salt with a coat under her head. Teo was kneeling beside her with her hand in both of his, his face grey under the freckles, his eyes wet. Lucan was not on the salt any more.

Her mouth was so dry her tongue stuck to her teeth.

"Water," said Teo, and she drank all of it, and it was not enough.

"What—"

"You lagged," Orsolya said. She was crouched on Hester's other side. "You kept a grown man, first time, with a throw, and then you returned him, and the lag waited till you'd put the weight down. That's how it comes. Four minutes. You've been out four minutes."

Four minutes.

She lay on the salt and looked up at the moved sun. She had been here, all of her, eyes open; Teo said afterward that they had been open the whole time. Orsolya had talked to her and she had not answered. Teo had held her hand and it had been as cold and stiff as a gate-latch. And there was nothing. Not even the memory of an absence. Orsolya had said *that's*, and then the sun had moved.

She had stood beside Tib's casing a hundred and thirty times and told him the news. *Sere's in. Daisy's had another one.* She had never once in eleven years thought about what it was like for him, inside. Whether it was like this. Whether it was like anything at all. Whether, if they returned him tomorrow, he would think he had blinked.

She started to shake.

"Here." Orsolya was wrapping her in a blanket, in Coyle's coat. "It's the cold. It's only the cold. It takes everyone like this the first time. Anselm, rub her hands. Not like that. Like you mean it."

Teo rubbed her hands like he meant it.

"Is he—"

"Ferrers? Two ribs, maybe three, and a bruise where his pride was. He's on the *Gannet*, telling Coyle how to splint himself."

Hester shut her eyes. That was a mistake. The dark behind her lids felt too much like the four minutes she did not have, and she opened them again at once.

"Four minutes," she said.

"Aye." Orsolya's hand rested on her hair, cold and light. "You'll not remember them. But you'll get used to there being a gap. Everyone below has a few." She looked out toward the bloom, steaming quietly in the sun. "I've lost about a month, all told, in thirty years. A minute here, an hour there. You stop counting."

* * *

They sailed home at a walking pace under a single reefed sail, because Coyle said the deck was full of invalids and he would not have them shaken. Lucan lay on a pallet by the mainmast with his chest strapped and Ballast's chin on his ankle. He did not look at her. Hester sat on a hatch-cover in two blankets, drinking from a flask Teo kept refilling, and did not look at him. She did not suppose there was a correct thing to say. She had kept the son of the Lord Exchequer in salt over a hole in the world and then dropped him on the White like a sack of meal, and broken him.

Halfway home, when the Halcyon was a needle on the horizon again, Lucan spoke without opening his eyes.

"Vail."

"What."

"You threw it. The brine. You didn't pour it, you threw it, like—" He breathed in carefully, around the ribs. "Like a scullery maid. With a bucket."

"Laundress," Hester said. "My mother was a laundress. Slops go across the yard."

He was silent a while.

"Remarkable," he said, and went back to sleep.

* * *

The aspirants scattered off the ramp quickly and quietly, as people leave a funeral. Orsolya took Lucan to the Physic ward herself on a litter. Before she went she put her cold hand on Hester's shoulder and said, "Hot bath. Hot food. Drink till you're sick of it. You did well, chick." Then she was gone down the Stair, and Teo was steering Hester up through the Rookery passages, talking the whole way about the probable theological status of a lurcher, and not once letting go of her elbow.

There was someone waiting at the door of R-41.

He was leaning on the passage wall in a black-corded gown that had been good once, with a stick in one hand. His white hair was tied back with its piece of string, and the Sere had pulled half of it loose. He was older than she had thought him from the lecture benches, and thinner. He looked her up and down, blankets, salt-crust, blue lips, without any expression at all.

"Reader Sorle," Teo said, and stopped walking.

Sorle looked at Hester.

"You kept a man," he said. "On the open White. With a *throw*."

She was too tired to be anything but honest. "Yes."

"Badly."

"Yes."

"Lumpy casing, splash-fused to the rim. A release like a cart going over a cliff. Two of the Lord Exchequer's son's ribs, which I gather the Lord Exchequer will want to discuss with somebody." He tilted his head. "And four minutes of lag, Coyle says, on a first keeping of a grown man. Some don't come back at all." He looked at her a moment longer, his mouth turned down at the corners in an expression she could not read. "Interesting."

He pushed himself off the wall with his stick.

"My study. Second Fathom, the black door at the end of the Horology gallery. The day after tomorrow, at the fourth bell. Don't be late. I've no patience and less time." He limped away down the passage, and stopped, and said over his shoulder: "And bring your tongue, Miss Vail. Corvin always said it was the best thing about you."

His stick tapped away toward the Stair.

"Did he just—" Teo began.

"I don't know," said Hester. She went into the cell and lay down on her bed in her boots and her coat and her two blankets, with her eyes open, looking at the salt ceiling, faintly pink in the last of the window light, and did not close them.

CHAPTER 12

# *Sorle's Folly*



*Reader Sorle's hypothesis was found to be without foundation in observation, unsupported by the arrears calculus as correctly applied, and an embarrassment to the Bench. The Conclave records its censure. The Reader is thanked for his candour.*

— Minutes of the Conclave of Readers, 14 Cinder 871 Y.E.

The black door at the end of the Horology gallery had no name on it. It had a brass knocker in the shape of a closed eye, and a card pinned beneath the knocker that said in a thin furious hand: *NOT NOW*. Hester knocked anyway, at the fourth bell exactly, because she had stood outside it for ten minutes waiting for the bell. The door opened before her hand had left the knocker.

"You're punctual," said Benedek Sorle. "I find that suspicious in a person. Come in. Don't touch anything. Don't sit there, that's Lise's chair. Sit there."

*There* was a three-legged stool beside a desk so heaped with paper that the desk itself was a rumour. Hester sat on it.

The study was long and narrow and cold. It was one of the old Readers' rooms on the outer gallery of the Second Fathom, with a slit of salt-glass for a window, high in the wall. It let in a grey light that came from a light-shaft somewhere above and had been reflected too many times to have any warmth left in it. Every wall was shelves, and every shelf was books, and where there were no books there were slates. Dozens of slates, the size of tea-trays, stacked and leaning and propped. Every one was covered edge to edge in chalk: columns of numbers, curves, the strange compressed notation of the arrears calculus that Sorle wrote on the Black Bench board in lectures and that half the aspirants copied without understanding. Some of the slates had been rubbed half out and written over. Some

had dates on them. One, propped against the coal-scuttle, said at the top *870*, and the chalk on it had gone yellow.

There was a fire, small and bad. There was a kettle on it.

On the desk, among the paper, under a glass bell the size of a teacup, there was a moth.

It was kept. She knew it before she looked properly; she could feel it from the stool, a small weight at the back of her eyes, as if somebody had laid a single grain of salt on each lid. It was a grey moth, an ordinary house-moth with soft dusty wings, held in a casing so fine and clear she could only see the casing's edges where it caught the grey light. Its wings were open. It had been kept mid-flight, a quarter-inch above the surface of the desk, so that the casing touched the wood only at one point, a sort of glass stalk. The moth hung above it, flying, going nowhere.

On the wall beside the window there was a portrait. It was a small oil, not well painted. A woman of forty or so with a broad face and her hair pinned up untidily, in a Physic's red cord, laughing at whoever was painting her.

"Lise," said Sorle, following her eyes. "My wife. Dead twenty-three years. The Settle. She was a Physic on the Brinery wards. Kept people for a living. I'm told I'm very bad company." He lowered himself into the chair that was not Lise's, which creaked. He had his stick across his knees. In the grey light his face was all lines and nose, and his eyes, deep under the white brows, were pale and bright and unkind. "Tea?"

"Please."

He did not move to make it. He looked at her.

"Tell me about Ferrers," he said.

* * *

She told him about Ferrers. It took a long time, because he would not let her tell it.

"You threw it," he said. "Not poured. Threw."

"Yes."

"From how far?"

"Three paces. Four."

"So the brine was in the air for—what? A second? Less. And you went into the hold *before* it landed, or after?"

"I don't know. Before. As I threw."

"*Before*." He leaned forward. "Before. So you were holding while the brine was in flight. You lent your stillness to a stream of brine in the air, which by any orthodox account should have been impossible, because the brine wasn't touching anything you were trying to keep. Except you, at one end, and Ferrers, at the other, and the air between. And by the time it reached him it was already setting. You were keeping the throw." He sat back. "Crisp will have a fit. Go on."

She went on. He stopped her again at the casing.

"Describe the grain."

"Rough. Lumpy where it splashed. Clear in the thick places, white where it was thin."

"Which way did it grow?"

She looked at him.

"Which way," Sorle said patiently, as to an idiot, "did the casing grow? From him outward, or from outside in?"

She thought. She saw it again, the glitter of the brine coming down in a sheet across his raised arms, the setting.

"From outside," she said. "In. It started where the brine landed and grew in toward him. The outside set first."

"Yes," said Sorle. "Yes, it did. Because you poured it. Or threw it, which is the same thing with more swagger. Every poured casing grows from the outside in, Miss Vail. It's the first thing Crisp should have told you, and the last thing anybody remembers, because nobody pours casings any more except on the Brinery wards, where they brush it on." He reached for the kettle, finally, with a hand that was not quite steady, and began to make tea. "Whereas when a worker keeps himself—and it can be done, it's been done, it's a stupid thing to do and Corvin did it every other month to test his own reading—the casing grows from the skin outward. It has to. The worker's lending his stillness from inside. It starts where he starts. It grows out from him like rime from a twig."

He poured. The tea came out black. He put a pinch of salt in hers without asking and handed it to her.

"Which way," he said, "did Corvin Aske's casing grow?"

Hester held the cup in both hands. It was scalding. She did not drink.

She saw it. She had stood in the corridor outside Cell 3-17 in the press of gowns at first bell on the seventeenth of Russet, looking at a thin man held standing in

the middle of his own workroom with one arm reaching. She had looked at the casing with her assayer's eye, because there was nothing else she could do with it. She had seen the grain, and the way it lay, and she had thought, before the Proctor's voice came down on all of it, *that's wrong*. And then she had put the thought away, because there was a Proctor and a verdict and a hundred people in the corridor, and she was nobody.

"In," she said. "From outside. It was poured."

Sorle nodded slowly, as if she had passed a test he had not expected her to pass.

"Corvin couldn't keep himself in a pickle jar," he said. "Not a whole-body casing. Not like that. He'd sleeve a hand to test his reading, or keep a finger, and come to my door with his hand in a block of salt like a boy with his fist stuck in a vase, wanting me to release it, because his release was worse than yours. And his hold was radial. Fine and radial, like a star. Every casing he ever made had a little starburst in the grain where he started it." He drank his tea. "That casing in 3-17 has no starburst. It was poured, from outside. By somebody else. A child could see it. Gage saw it. Gage isn't a child; he's a soldier, which is worse, because a soldier knows when he's been told to stop looking."

"Then why—"

"Why didn't I say so?" Sorle put the cup down. "I did. I said so to Gage on the morning of the seventeenth, and I said so in writing to the Deputy Chancellor on the eighteenth, and I said so to the Conclave on the twenty-second, where I was thanked for my candour." The word came out of him like something spat. "*Thanked for my candour*. They've a phrase for everything in Conclave, Miss Vail. That one means *sit down, Benedek, nobody believes a word you say*. They've been thanking me for my candour for thirty-two years."

* * *

He told her about the sixteenth of Russet without being asked.

"Corvin came to my door that afternoon," he said. "Third bell. He'd a sheet of figures in his hand and ink on his face, which was usual, and he was frightened, which wasn't. He wanted me to look at some numbers. Pressure figures. Stay returns from the Fifth over five years. He wanted me to run them through the calculus for him, because Corvin's sums were like his release; he got there, but you wouldn't want to watch. I said I was busy. I was busy. I was writing a reply to a Fellow in Harl who'd published something stupid." His mouth turned down. "He

said: come to my Cell tonight, then. The tenth bell. Hester Vail's coming at the tenth; come at half-past. I'll show you both, and you can tell me I'm mad in person. I said I'd think about it."

"And you came."

"I came. At the half after the tenth. I don't sleep. I thought I might as well be insulted by Corvin as by the Harl Fellow." He turned the cup in his hand. "The corridor was dark. His door was shut and there was no light under it. I knocked. Nobody. I thought he'd gone up to bed and forgotten, as he did; he'd forget his own name if it weren't written on his gown. So I went back up to the Second."

"By the Stair?"

"By the Readers' back stair. I came down it and I went back up it. My rooms are on the Second, above his, and I've not used the main Stair after dark in ten years." He looked at her. "Why?"

"Because I was there. At the tenth. I waited outside the door and he didn't come. And while I waited—" She stopped. She had told the Proctory this, and Teo, and nobody had thought it worth a second question, and she had stopped thinking about it. "While I waited I heard wheels on the Stair, below, and went to the rail. A trolley, coming up from the Fourth or the Fifth. Two or three people in grey, and a blue lantern, and something under a canvas. Bumping up a step at a time. I thought it was porters with brine casks."

"At the tenth bell? On the Stair?" Sorle's eyes had narrowed. "The porters use the lifts after the eighth. The Stair's for feet. Nobody drags a trolley up the Stair. It's a hundred and nine steps from the Fourth to the Third, and they're worn into bowls."

"Then who—"

"Somebody who didn't want to use a lift," Sorle said. "Lifts have lift-men. Lift-men have mouths." He sat back. "And when did you leave?"

"Before the half. Just before. I was cold, and I was angry. I went up."

"Up the Stair."

"Yes."

"And the trolley?"

"It hadn't got far. They kept stopping to rest. It was still below me when I went."

They sat. The fire made a small sound. On the desk the moth hung above its stalk of glass, flying.

"So you went up the Stair just before the half," Sorle said slowly, "and I came down the back stair at the half and went back up it, and the corridor was dark, and his door was shut. And at first bell a porter found him in the middle of his workroom in a poured casing of Hush grain with his arm out. And between the half and first bell, somebody brought something up the Stair on a trolley, from below, and didn't use a lift." He looked at the slates on the wall as if they had personally failed him. "Well. I don't have a sum for that."

"He wasn't in his Cell," Hester said. It came out of her flatly, the way her grades came out. "When I knocked. He wasn't there. He'd gone below. Something happened below. And then he was brought back up."

Sorle said nothing for a long time.

"Yes," he said at last. "I think that's very likely."

* * *

"What's the Held Moment?"

She asked it because she had to ask something, and because the slate by the coal-scuttle with *870* on it had been looking at her for an hour. Sorle's mouth went thin.

"Do you want the version they teach second-years as a cautionary tale," he said, "or the version that's true?"

"The one you believe."

"That's not the same as the one that's true. Nobody in this building knows the one that's true. That's my whole complaint." He levered himself up out of the chair with the stick and went to the coal-scuttle and picked up the old slate and blew the dust off it and looked at it, as a man looks at a likeness of himself young. "All right. Here it is. Grain keeps. Why?"

"Nobody knows."

"Nobody knows. Correct. The mineral school says stillness is a property of the crystal formed under pressure at the Ebb, like hardness, or colour. That's not an answer, that's a description with a hat on." He put the slate on the desk in front of her, beside the moth. "Look at this."

It was a curve. A long curve, chalked in a firm young hand, rising slowly and then more steeply, labelled at intervals with depths in fathoms and with numbers she did not understand.

"Stillness by depth," Sorle said. "Every grade, every boring, every reference jar from the Shelf to the deepest the Fathomers had reached in 870. I spent four years getting the numbers. Grain gets stiller as you go down. Everybody knew that. But nobody had ever plotted it. Look at the shape."

She looked.

"It's not a straight line," she said.

"No. If stillness were a property of crystal formed under pressure, it ought to go up with depth more or less in a line: more pressure, more stillness. It doesn't. It goes up like *that*." He drew his finger along the curve, up into the steep part. "It goes up like the arrears on a keeping. Exactly like. Mass times duration times liveliness. The same curve you get if you plot the stillness of a casing against the size and life of what it's keeping." He tapped the slate. "Grain from the Hollow Sea has the stillness curve of a *keeping*, Miss Vail. Not a mineral. A keeping. The deeper you go, the more it behaves like the casing round something enormous, and alive."

Hester sat on the stool and looked at the curve.

"So I stood up in Conclave," Sorle said, "in Cinder of 871, thirty-two years old and stupid with it, and I said: the sea didn't go. The sea's still there. It's held. The salt is the casing. The Ebb wasn't the sea leaving; it was the sea being kept, all at once, in one instant, by God knows what. And every dram we dig and dissolve, we're spending a bit of that held moment, like lamp-oil."

He put the slate back against the scuttle.

"They laughed," he said. "Not all of them. Some of them were very polite. And then a young Fathomer stood up—twenty-six, Lowside, sharp as a delver's pick, three years in the Choir and a gift for sums like nothing I'd ever seen—and took me apart. In public. In an hour." There was something in his voice that was not bitterness, or not only. "She showed that my numbers from below the Fourth were bad. They were; the borings were contaminated, I'd been careless. She showed that my arrears terms were wrong at the top of the curve. They were; I'd used Halloway's constants and Halloway was an ass. She showed that if the Hollow Sea were a keeping, the arrears on nine hundred years of a sea would be so large that the crust should be warm to the touch from here to Quell, and it isn't. And she was right about all of it." He sat back down in the chair. "She was right about my maths. She was wrong about the world. And I couldn't prove that, and I still can't, and that's the whole of my career. Orsolya Thane."

Hester's cup was cold in her hands.

"The Warden," she said.

"She wasn't Warden then. She was a chorister with a slate. She made her name that day. I lost mine." Sorle looked at the moth. "We haven't exchanged forty words since. She runs the deep like a ship's captain and she's very good at it, and she thinks I'm a dangerous old fool, and she may be right. She's right about most things. That's what makes her unbearable."

Hester thought about the bloom on the White, and the warm crust under her glove, and the hush and pause and hush in it. She thought about Orsolya crouched beside it with her hand flat on the salt, saying *the sound's the sound.*

"The bloom-sites are warm," she said.

Sorle looked up.

"On the White. The quickenings. When they come up. They're warm. I had my hand on one two days ago. And there's a sound in them." She stopped. "And in the Choir. When we stay. You hear it through the line. Everybody does. They call it the Roar. But it's not a roar." She did not know how to say it. She had not said it to anyone, not even Teo, not properly. "It has a shape. It goes up and down. Like breathing. Like—"

"Like waves," Sorle said quietly.

She had never seen waves. Nobody on the Rim had seen waves. She had seen the pictures in the tavern signs and the drawings in the ballad-books, curling white lines like a row of fingers.

"I don't know," she said. "I've never heard waves."

"No," said Sorle. "No. None of us have."

* * *

He would not sponsor her. She had not asked; she had gone to him a fortnight ago and asked, and he had said *I don't take charity cases from the dead*, and she had not forgiven him for it. She did not ask again. He told her anyway, at the door, as she was going, as if she had.

"I'll not take you onto my Bench on a story," he said. "Not on a taste and a trolley and a casing that grew the wrong way. I've been thanked for my candour for thirty-two years, Miss Vail, and I'll not be thanked for yours. If I stand up in Conclave again, I'll stand up with something I can put on a slate." He leaned on

his stick in the doorway, thin and old and furious. "Bring me evidence. Not tastes. Evidence. A thing I can weigh. A thing Gage can't lose."

"And then you'll sponsor me."

"And then," said Sorle, "I'll think about it." He began to close the door. Then he stopped it with his stick and said through the gap, in a different voice: "You lagged four minutes. On a first keeping. Do you know how many people on the Shelf could have done what you did on the White?"

"No."

"Nor do I. I'd like to find out. That's all." And he shut the door, and the card that said *NOT NOW* swung on its pin.

* * *

The Physic ward of the Halcyon was on the Third Fathom, behind the Glaziers' kilns, in a long low room that smelled of camphor and warm brine. It had a row of iron beds along one wall and a row of shallow baths along the other, sunk in the floor. They were tiled in white and steaming faintly, for the slow returns. Two of the baths had kept people in them, lying under a hand's depth of warm brine, their casings softening by degrees. A Physic in a red cord sat between them on a stool, reading a book and touching each casing every few minutes with two fingers, like a woman testing bread.

Lucan Ferrers was in the end bed by the wall, propped on pillows, with his chest strapped and a book open face-down on the blanket. He was looking at the ceiling. When he saw her he did not look away, which she had half expected. He watched her come down the length of the ward with no expression at all.

"Vail," he said.

"Ferrers."

"Have you come to see the damage?"

"I've come because Teo said if I didn't he'd bake me nothing till Midwinter." She stood at the end of the bed with her hands in her gown. "How many?"

"Three." He breathed in carefully. "Two cracked, one broken. The Physic says I'm to lie still for a fortnight and think about my sins. I've told her I haven't enough to fill a fortnight. She wasn't amused." He looked at her. "My father's written to the Chancellor."

"About me?"

"About the *Gannet*. About the Warden letting first-years walk a bloom-site in Fallow. About the dog, possibly; I didn't read the whole letter. My father writes letters the way other men break furniture." He moved a hand on the blanket. "Your name is not in it. I asked him to leave it out."

She had not expected that. She did not know what to do with it.

"Why?"

He was quiet for a while. The Physic between the baths turned a page.

"I've never owed anybody anything," Lucan said. He said it to the ceiling. "Do you understand? Not once. Not in my life. Everything I've ever had was either mine already or bought. Even my tutors were paid in advance. And then I went through the floor of the world in front of twenty people, and the last thing I saw was you, with a brass flask in your hand, and your face." He stopped. "You had a face like somebody catching a pot off a shelf. Annoyed. As if I'd fallen on purpose to inconvenience you."

"You had," said Hester. "You stepped forward. The Warden said walk in the dog's track. You stepped forward to see the pool better. You always step forward to see better."

His mouth moved. It was nearly a smile.

"Yes," he said. "That's fair." He looked at her at last. "Thank you. That's what I'm trying to say. I'm bad at it. I've never had to practise. Thank you."

"You're welcome," Hester said, and found that she was bad at it too, and that her face was hot. She looked at the baths. "It was a lumpy casing. Sorle says."

"Sorle." Lucan's eyebrows went up. "You've been to see Sorle?"

"He asked."

"He never asks anyone anything. He tells them they're wrong." He paused. "What did he want?"

She looked at him. She looked at the Physic, who was absorbed in her book. She looked down the length of the ward toward the door. Then she sat down on the edge of the bed, carefully, so as not to jog him. She told him, low, about the casing that grew from the outside in, and the trolley on the Stair before the half, and Sorle at the half.

Lucan listened without interrupting. When she had finished he reached, wincing, for the book on the blanket, and took from between its pages a folded paper: a page torn out of a ledger. He had torn it badly, she noticed, with the clumsiness of a man who had never needed to tear evidence out of anything.

"Thursday," he said. "While my father was at the Assize. The *Wren*'s cargo isn't in the firm's books, not under that name. But there's a supplies ledger, brine and Middling to brineries all over the city, and there's this. Highsummer."

Hester tilted it to the lamp over the bed.

*Cold House. 40 fk. live brine (Deep). Cistern mntce. Acct: Halcyon — per W.L.F.*

Three letters at the end of the line, in a clerk's copperplate. She had seen them at the foot of a bill of lading and on a catalogue card in the Stacks, each time in a different hand. This was the third.

"The Cold House hasn't a cistern," Lucan said. "I went down on the Friday with my Exchequer face on and walked round the whole building, and the yard. No tank. No reservoir. Only a drain in every row of that ward, running east. I put my hand down one. It was wet. Water doesn't run in a dry house in a dry season." He looked at her. "What's under that building, Vail?"

"The founders' Cistern," Hester said. "Bricked up in four hundred, the Water Board says. And a line out of it under the White, to the Fifth."

He lay with that for a while. She gave him back the page.

"Keep it somewhere better than a book," she said. "It's your father's."

"Yes," he said slowly. "I suppose it is." Then: "And Sorle wants evidence."

"Something he can weigh. Something Gage can't lose."

Lucan turned his head on the pillow and looked at her, and his face was not smooth at all.

"Then we'll have to go and get some," he said. "Won't we."

"*You*'re lying still for a fortnight."

"I'll lie still for a week. I'm a fast healer. It's the only thing about me my father admires." He shut his eyes. "Go and find out how to get under that building, Vail. I'll find out how to pay for it."

She sat a moment longer on the edge of his bed, in the warm camphor air, with the steam coming off the baths and the Physic turning her pages. Then she got up and went out, up the Third Fathom corridor toward the Stair. She passed the shut door of Cell 3-17, which had a Proctory seal across it now, red wax on black ribbon. She did not stop. She had seen the map in the Brinestacks. She knew where the Great Cistern lay. She knew which street was over it, and whose cellar would have the door. She went up the Stair to find Teo, already counting in her head what a lantern would cost, and a rope, and a saw that would cut brass.

CHAPTER 13

# *The Cistern*



*The founders' cistern beneath Coldwater and the Eastern Wards is bricked, and shall not be reopened, its brine being unwholesome and its passages unsafe.*

— Minute of the Ambry Water Board, 400 Y.E.

Lucan Ferrers brought a saw.

He brought it up the Rookery stair at the ninth bell on the thirteenth of Fallow, wrapped in a good wool blanket, and laid it on Hester's bed as if he were laying out a body. It was a short bow-saw for metal, with a rosewood frame.

"Where did you get this?"

"From the estate carpenter at Ferrers House. He was asleep." Lucan sat down on Teo's bed without being asked, which he had begun doing, and held himself upright, which he had not stopped doing since the sink. The ribs were mending; she could see it in his breathing, shallow at the top and careful at the bottom. "I left him a note. And a sol. I think he'll consider himself well paid for a saw that cuts brass like cheese."

"You think we'll need to cut brass."

"I think you think so, or you wouldn't have asked me for plans." He took a roll of paper out of his coat. "The Water Board survey of 398, two years before they bricked it. My father keeps the originals of everything that might one day be worth money. I traced them last night. Don't look at the lettering."

Teo spread the roll on the boards between the beds and weighted the corners with his boots and a plate of saltcake, and they bent over it, all three, in the light of the one lamp.

Hester had seen the shape before, in faint red on a mouse-eaten sheet in the Lattice gallery: the long ribbed oval under the foot of Coldwater Street, the line running out of it straight as a rule. This was the same thing drawn by a man who had walked it. *Great Cistern: capacity 40,000 tuns*, in heavy ink, ribbed across with vaulting. A short passage ran west from it, up under the street, to a square marked *Excise Store — cellar — inspection grate*. And from the cistern's eastern end the double line ran out under the sea-wall and the dotted shore and on across two feet of blank paper that was the White. The draughtsman had written along it every few inches, in a small precise hand: *Main. Main. Main.* Where the paper stopped he had written: *to the Collegium. Not surveyed beyond.*

"It isn't a pipe," Lucan said, pointing to an inset: a horseshoe of brick with a man drawn in it for scale, his hat brushing the crown. "It's a tunnel. You could drive a pony down it."

Hester put her finger on the square marked *cellar*. She had walked over that spot on the first of every month for eleven years.

"Agathe said yes?" said Teo.

"Agathe said yes."

She had written on the ninth, and the answer had come with the carrier on the eleventh, in Agathe's round copybook hand. *Mr. Pell is to go to his sister's in Harl on the fourteenth for three nights, it being her lying-in. The cellar door is mine to keep, as the oil is kept there. I do not ask what you want with the cellar, my dear, and I do not want to know, except that if it is to do with the weeping I shall pray for you, and if it is not I shall pray for you anyway. Come by the yard. Eleventh bell. A.L.*

"She's seventy," Lucan said. "And a Tider. And you're asking her to let three Halcyon aspirants into a bricked civic works in the middle of the night. If it's found out, she'll lose her place."

"I know."

"Does she?"

"Yes," said Hester, "she does," and Lucan looked at her a moment longer and nodded.

They planned it on the floor, over the plan. Three kept-light lamps, which needed no air and would not go out if the tunnel was foul. Rope. A crowbar. The saw. Water, because Hester did not intend to come out of that hole without doing grain-work. A tin box lined with oilcloth for anything they took. Teo's chalk.

"And if somebody's down there?" Teo asked.

"Then we come back up," said Hester.

"And if they don't let us?"

Lucan touched his ribs lightly. "Then I'll tell them who my father is," he said. "It's nearly the only thing I'm good for."

* * *

The fourteenth of Fallow was a dark night with no moon and a hard thin wind out of the north. They took the last Causeway dray into the city at the tenth bell, on the tailboard among sacks of Halcyon laundry, and by the eleventh bell they were in the yard behind the Cold House among the oil-drums and empty brine casks, and Agathe was standing in the cellar door with a candle, in her grey shawl, looking exactly as she looked at the second bell of the morning.

"You'll be the Ferrers boy," she said to Lucan.

"I am, madam."

"You've your mother's chin. She came here once, to give money. She stood in the ward and wept like a child." Agathe looked at Teo. "And you're the one from the Abbey. They'll have taught you to be quiet." She stood aside. "Mind the step. There's eleven of them and the sixth is gone."

The cellar was low and long and smelled of lamp-oil and old brick. Oil barrels stood in racks along one wall, the brinewright's stores along the other. At the far end, where the cellar ran under the charity ward, iron gratings the size of a door were set flush with the brick.

Agathe stopped by the last of them and lowered her candle.

"I come down here for the oil every morning," she said. "Thirty-one years. And in the spring, about the time the first of them started weeping, this grating was different. Somebody had had it up." Round its edge the mortar had been raked out and renewed, pale and clean against the old black iron. "I asked Mr. Pell. He said it was Halcyon maintenance on the old cistern taps, under the Charter, and no business of mine." Her mouth did not move. "I've kept the oil thirty-one years. I know what's my business."

Lucan went down on one knee, carefully, favouring the ribs, and put his fingers to the mortar.

"This has been opened more than once," he said. "They've raked it out and reset it, and raked it out again. There's three colours."

"Then they come and go," said Teo.

"One of them was a Reader," said Agathe.

Hester looked up.

"Yours, my dear. Reader Aske." Agathe's candle did not waver. "He came in Russet to count the weeping, and I walked him round. Then he came back on the twelfth, after dark, by the yard, as you have, and asked me for the cellar key. Mine, not Mr. Pell's; there's only the two. He said it'd go easier if Mr. Pell didn't hear of it. I gave it him." She looked at the grating. "He was down two hours. He came up white to the lips with his boots wet, and gave me back my key, and said, *Mother, I'll tell you when I'm sure.* Five days after, the Board had a letter from the Halcyon saying he was dead."

Hester had known that Aske had counted the casings. She had not known he had been under them.

"You never said."

"You never asked me about the cellar till the ninth. And he asked me not to tell anybody, and I'd no notion who *anybody* was." Agathe's voice stayed gentle. "I've thought since that I should have. Tide forgive me, I didn't know what to be afraid of."

"Then we're going where he went," said Hester. She took the crowbar off her shoulder.

The new mortar came out in crumbs, and the grating, lifted lately, wanted to lift. When they had it up and leaning against the wall, a breath came out of the hole beneath it. It was too slow for a draught. The air simply moved, upward, past their faces.

It was cold. It was sweet. Hester knew it before it reached her mouth: the cellar-of-apples sweetness of the charity ward on the six worn steps. And under the sweetness, far down at the back of the tongue, the thing she had come for.

Quick.

Agathe stood with her candle and looked at Hester's face.

"Go on, then," she said. "I'll not leave the hole." And then, which Hester had not expected: "Tide carry you."

* * *

An iron ladder went down twelve feet into a sloping passage, just high enough to walk in if you stooped, that ran east perhaps thirty yards.

Then the walls fell away on either side, and the lamps that had been filling the passage with amber were lighting nothing at all.

Lucan opened his shutter wide, and the light went out and up and up and found, at last, a ceiling.

The Great Cistern was a hall. It had been built to hold water, and had held it for a hundred years before the Ebb, and had held nothing for nine hundred since. Rows of brick piers as thick as houses marched down its length, each rising into a vault, so that the roof was a field of shallow domes, like the underside of a quilt. At about twice a tall man's height a pale line ran round every pier and every wall, exactly level. It was where the water had stood.

Down the centre of the dry brick floor, from the west wall to an east wall they could not see, ran a gutter of dressed stone a foot wide and a foot deep. The channel was not dry.

It was full of brine. It lay in the stone black and motionless in the lamplight, with a skin on it like the skin on milk, and the sweetness came up off it so thick she could taste it with her mouth shut.

"That," said Teo quietly, "is live."

"Yes."

"It shouldn't be. Live brine dies in minutes." He crouched, not touching. "Somebody's keeping it alive."

"Nobody's keeping it," Hester said. "It's being fed."

She did not say what with. She knew what she thought, and she would taste it before she said it. You did not grade by hoping.

They followed the channel east.

The brick swallowed every sound. Somewhere far off something dripped, with a long interval between each drop.

Every twenty yards a smaller gutter came into the channel from the north side, from under the street. Each arm ran back to the foot of a pier, and above each pier, set into the vault, was a round iron grating. Hester stopped under the third and held up her lamp. From the grating, eight or nine feet over her head, hung a rod.

It was brass, perhaps an inch thick, and it was new: bright, unscratched, with none of the green that brass took in damp. It came down out of the grating and ran down the pier in iron clips, then bent and ran along the floor, sleeved for its whole length in a trough of hammered tin. The trough was full of the black

brine, and the rod lay in it like an eel in a river. It joined the arm. The arm joined the main.

Once she had seen one she could see them all, glinting under every grating along the north side of the hall. She walked down the row with her lamp and counted.

Fourteen.

"Hester," said Lucan.

She had stopped under the seventh, at the iron clip that held the rod to the pier. On its plate was a small clean punch-stamp: a square grid, three by three, like a window, or a crystal of grain seen end-on, and under it the number *23*.

"That's a Lattice mark," said Lucan behind her. His voice was strange. "The Lattice Yards. Third Fathom. They stamp everything they make. My father has a gate of theirs on the Exchequer Yard, and it's on the hinges."

"Halcyon work," said Teo.

"Halcyon work," said Lucan.

Hester took off her right glove.

She had been an assayer since she was nineteen, and what an assayer does with a thing she does not understand is put it on her tongue. She knelt and put the tip of her smallest finger into the black brine. It was so cold it burned. She put the finger in her mouth.

The weight came down on her like a roof.

She had tasted the Deep at a hundred and forty, and the *Constant Wren*'s cargo, and the First Taste on the Long Table that made a hall of adults weep. None of them was this. This did not press. It *settled*. It came down behind her eyes and lay there and went on not moving. Its stillness was so old and so complete that for a moment she could not tell if she was breathing.

It was stiller than grain. It was stiller than anything that came out of the ground, because the ground had not put it there. Ten, twenty, thirty years of a life held still had put it there, the stillness soaking into the salt around a body, day after day, until the salt was saturated. *Old keepings are the stillest things in the world*. Sorle had said it in the Black Bench with his chalk, and she had written it down without understanding it.

And under the stillness, faint, as there had been on the bead on Tib's casing: the bright wet startle of the brine around it, moving. Being drawn.

She took her finger out of her mouth.

"This is them," she said.

She was on her knees on the brick, and her voice was the flat level voice she had used to read a grade aloud to the excisemen, and she held on to it. "This is what's weeping off the casings. It's going down the drains into these rods, and the rods are taking it to the channel, and the channel's taking it east." She swallowed. The weight was still behind her eyes. "This is Tib."

* * *

Teo knelt beside her. He put out his hand, and she nodded, and he dipped one finger in the black brine and put it, not in his mouth, but against the hollow under his ear where the bone was thin, as Reader Fane taught her Bench to listen. He shut his eyes.

It took him longer than it took her. His hold had always been bad. She watched his breath try to slow and fail and try again. Then it caught. The colour went out of his lips. His face emptied, as faces did in the hold, all its quick warmth draining away until it was only a face.

He was gone long enough that Lucan shifted and looked at her, and she shook her head.

When Teo came out he sat back on his heels. He was crying, and she did not think he knew it. The tears left white tracks on his cheeks.

"What did you hear?"

"The Roar. Like always. But it's far off. Thin. It's not the sea in this. It's not old enough." He wiped his face with his sleeve and looked at the white on the wool. "Under it. Under the Roar." He stopped.

"Teo."

"Breathing," he said. "People breathing. Lots of them. All at once and none of them together. Like a ward at night. Like the infirmary at the Abbey when the fever came through and I sat up with the brothers." He looked at her. "And some of it's small. Quick and small and light. Hester, some of it's children."

The brine lay in its sleeve, black and perfectly still, and fed, and was fed upon.

Lucan said, in the voice he used in Vey's Brinescript class to say something rude politely: "Then I think we had better take one with us."

He unwrapped the saw.

* * *

Lucan chose the length of the seventh rod between the last clip and the bend, where it stood clear of its sleeve. Hester held the lamp. Teo held the rod above the cut with both gloved hands, wincing at the cold through the leather.

"If this is full," said Lucan, "it'll spill."

"Then it spills."

"It's *people*, you said."

"It's what's been taken off them. It's no more them than the water you wring out of a shirt is the shirt. What's in that rod is going east whatever we do. Cut it."

He looked at her a moment, then put the blade to the brass and drew it.

The saw went into the brass with a high thin singing that the brick swallowed at once, so that the noise was in their ears and nowhere else, as if the three of them were inside a bell no one outside could hear. Halfway through, the rod began to sweat. Beads stood out on it above and below the cut, in lines. They ran away from the cut along the rod, east, toward the bend, toward the channel.

"Still runs to quick," Teo whispered.

"It's going where it's going," said Hester. "Keep cutting."

Lucan's breathing had gone short. He stopped with his hand pressed flat to his side, and Hester took the saw from him and finished it herself. The last of the brass parted with a little *tink*. The downstream end gave a single slow bubble, and brine welled out of it, black and cold, and she caught it in the oilcloth of the tin box. A spoonful. The rod was hollow, she saw: a brass tube bored fine, with brine running down its heart.

They cut again a foot lower, quicker now that they knew how. When it parted she had in her hands a foot of brass tube as thick as two fingers, so cold she felt it through her gloves, with a stamped band round its middle: the three-by-three lattice and the number *23*.

She was wrapping it in the oilcloth when the light came round the pier.

* * *

It was a tin lantern with a horn window, held high by a man breathing hard through his nose. In his other hand he had a carter's oak cudgel. He was heavy, pale and balding, in a coat buttoned wrong. Hester had seen him perhaps five times in eleven years, always leaving.

"Mr. Pell," she said.

"Who's there?" His face in the lantern-light was grey and wet. "You've no right—this is a closed works—this is *Halcyon property*—"

"You're at your sister's," Hester said. "In Harl."

"I came back." He had seen the tin box in her hands, and the saw, and the cut ends of the rod with the black brine welling slowly out of the stub. His face changed. "Oh, God. What've you *done*? They'll know. They'll know straight off. They always know. Put it *back*—"

He came at her. He held the cudgel badly, but he was heavy and frightened, and frightened men do not stop. Hester stepped back and her heel went into the channel. The brine took her boot to the ankle, so cold she cried out. Teo grabbed at Pell's coat, and Pell flung him off, and Teo went down hard on the brick with his lamp skittering away, its light wheeling across the vaults.

"*Stop*."

Lucan had not raised his voice. He had straightened, all of him, the ribs and the shoulders and the long Ferrers neck, and turned his lamp full on his own face so that Pell could see it.

"I am Lucan Ferrers," he said. "My father is the Lord Exchequer of this city. My father signs the charter of your Charitable Board. My father signs the warrant that pays your salary, Mr. Pell. If you lay that stick on anyone in this hall, I shall see that he signs another one, and you will not care for it." He paused. "Put it down."

Pell's hand opened and the cudgel fell out of it onto the brick. Then he sat down on the floor as if somebody had cut his strings, and put his face in his hands.

"Ferrers," he said through his fingers. "Of course. Of course it's Ferrers."

Hester got her foot out of the channel. It was numb to the shin. She hobbled to him.

"Who are *they*, Mr. Pell?"

"The Halcyon. It's maintenance, it's Halcyon maintenance on the old cistern taps under the Charter, it's all *permitted*—"

"Who told you that?"

"The gentleman." His shoulders were shaking. "From the Warden's office. He came in the spring. He had papers. Seals. He said it was a Charter matter and the Board needn't be troubled with it. Would I see the cellar was open when his men came, and that nobody went down. And there'd be ten sols a month for my trouble." He took his hands from his face. "Ten sols, Miss Vail. Do you know what

the *Board* pays me to run three hundred and four casings on charity money and Pell this and Pell that and not one of them—"

"You knew they were weeping."

"I didn't *know*."

"I left you a note. On the first of Russet. Directional, east, quick. I wrote it down for you."

"I didn't know what it meant!"

"You knew enough," Hester said, "to come back from Harl in the middle of the night because you were afraid somebody might be down here."

He looked at her with pale eyes and said nothing.

"Which Warden?" said Teo, from the floor, nursing his elbow.

"What?"

"You said the Warden's office. There are four Wardens. Which?"

"I don't *know*. He said the Warden's office. He had a paper with a seal. He was a clerk. He wore a coat over his gown and he never gave his name and I never asked it." Pell laughed, a terrible small laugh. "I never asked. That was the whole of what the ten sols was for."

Somewhere behind them, at the western end of the hall, a bell rang. A hand-bell, shaken hard. Faintly, down the passage, Agathe's voice was calling.

"Somebody's watch," said Lucan. "Time to go."

They left Pell sitting on the floor of the Great Cistern beside his cudgel with his lantern guttering. Behind them the cut stub of the seventh rod went on welling, slow and black, into its sleeve.

* * *

Agathe had heard boots in the yard. Three men, she said. She had rung the cellar fire-bell and sent them round the front to a sleeper in distress, and by the time they got there the three aspirants were over the yard wall and running down the alley toward the sea-wall. Hester did not stop to find out whose men they were.

The first dray back over the Causeway went at dawn. They spent what was left of the night in the lee of the old sea-wall at the foot of Coldwater Street, and when the sky over the White went grey they climbed the worn stair and sat on the top among the iron mooring rings, legs hanging over the drop. Hester's right

foot was a dead thing in a wet boot. Teo had his elbow in his hand. Lucan sat with his arms folded tight across his ribs and his face turned east.

Out on the White the Fallow dawn came up as a line, then a band, then the whole flat edge of the world going rose. Two miles out, on the only rise in all that flatness, the dome of the Halcyon caught the first light.

Hester looked down at the foot of the wall. Under all that salt the double line ran. *Main. Main. Main.* On the Lattice gallery sheet it had had an ending: *Line enters at 5th Fm.* She had copied that out three weeks ago as a fact about the year 400. She had not thought of it as a fact about tonight.

"It's not smuggling," she said. "I thought somebody was taking grain out. Out of the Halcyon, to sell. The *Wren.* I thought that was what it was." She opened the box and looked at the foot of brass in its oilcloth, the little lattice and the 23. "It's not coming *out.* It's going *in.* They're not taking the grain out to Ambry. They're taking Ambry in to the grain."

"The stillness," said Teo.

"Out of the casings. Down the drains. Into the rods. East." She shut the box. "Somebody inside the Halcyon is drawing the keep off three hundred sleepers in a charity ward and piping it two miles under the White into the Fifth Fathom, and paying Pell ten sols a month to keep the cellar shut. And Aske went down there on the twelfth of Russet and saw it, and four days later he was in a casing."

"The Warden's office," said Lucan.

"There are four," said Teo.

On the dome the Lantern's mirrors came round and flashed. Hester sat on the cold wall with the box in her lap and her brother's stillness in a foot of brass, and looked at it. She thought of Corvin Aske in his casing in the Quiet Rooms, one hand out, his mouth open on a word he had never finished. *Ask O.*

"Then we find out which," she said.

CHAPTER 14

# *What Is Owed*



*Every keeping is a lie we tell time, and time collects.*

— B. Sorle, Lectures on Arrears (unpublished; circulated in fair copy among the Black Bench)

"Don't," said Sorle.

He did not look up. He was at his desk with his back to the door and a moth-eaten black shawl round his shoulders, writing small and fast and crossing out as much as he set down. The kept moth sat in its lump of clear grain at his elbow with its wings half open.

"Don't what?"

"Don't take it to Gage." He blotted a line, examined it, and crossed it out. "You are standing in my door at the second bell with a box under your arm and a face like a summons, Miss Vail, smelling of wet brick and Lowside. I deduce that you have been somewhere you were not supposed to be and brought something back. I further deduce, from the way you are holding the box, that you mean to carry it straight down to the Proctory and put it on the Chief Proctor's desk. Don't."

"It's evidence."

"It is a length of brass."

"With a Lattice Yards mark on it. Out of the founders' cistern under the Cold House, drawing the keep off a charity ward and carrying it two miles east, to here." She put the box on the one corner of his desk that was not under paper and opened it. "You told me to bring you evidence. Not tastes. Something you could put on a slate. That's it."

Sorle turned round in his chair.

He looked at the brass for a long time without touching it. Then he looked at Hester's right boot, still dark to the shin with salt-tide, and then at her face.

"Sit," he said.

She told him all of it, from the grating to the sea-wall, in order. When she came to Pell, and *the Warden's office*, and *ten sols*, he shut his eyes. When she had finished he kept them shut a while, and then said, "And now you wish to take it to Halloran Gage."

"He's the Chief Proctor. Somebody in this building is drawing stillness out of living people without their consent or their families'. That's—" She had looked it up in the Brinestacks on her way down, with her boot squelching. "That's Article Thirty. Improper working upon a kept person. It's his job."

"It is his job," Sorle agreed. "So is closing files." The chair complained as he leaned back. "Let me tell you what will happen. Gage will listen to you with every appearance of gravity, because he is a grave man and it costs him nothing. He will take the rod, and give you a receipt, and promise an inquiry. And then the rod will go wherever things go in this Halcyon when they are inconvenient to someone who outranks the Chief Proctor. And you will have nothing. Not even a length of brass."

"You don't know that."

"I have been a Reader of this Collegium for thirty-four years and censured by it for thirty-two. I know it as you know Shelf from Middling."

"Then what would you have me do? Sit on it?"

"Yes. Keep it. Show it to no one. Find out which Warden, and why. And when you can prove it, go over Gage's head and over the head of whoever is over Gage's. Go to the Assize, if you must." He paused. "If you take it down the Stair today, you take it down alone. I'll not come with you."

She looked at the rod, at the lattice and the 23. She thought of Pell on the floor of the Cistern: *that was the whole of what the ten sols was for*. She thought of Tib in the fourth row, weeping east.

"I've sat on things before," she said. "Eleven years. It's not done him any good."

She closed the box. Sorle did not try again. He turned back to his desk and said, to the paper, "Shut the door on your way out. The moth dislikes a draught."

* * *

The Proctory lay on the First Fathom behind the Hall of Assay, down a short corridor hung with framed copies of the Charter. It had a front room with a rail and a sergeant behind the rail, and an inner office with a desk of Hask oak and a map of the Fathoms stuck with pins.

Chief Proctor Halloran Gage listened to her from behind the desk. He was a broad, grey, close-cropped man of fifty-odd who sat as if the chair had been issued to him and would have to be returned in good condition. He wrote in a leather book in a clerk's hand.

When she had finished he picked up the brass, turned it over, and held it to the window so the light went down its bore.

"Twenty-three," he said.

"I don't know what the number means."

"Lot number. The Yards stamp one on everything they cast. Twenty-three would be—" He stopped himself. "That's for the inquiry." He set the rod down. "You understand, Miss Vail, that you entered a closed civic works at night without a warrant."

"Yes, sir."

"And interfered with Halcyon property."

"With something that has a Halcyon mark on it, sir, in a place the Halcyon has no warrant to be either, so far as I know. I looked. Article Thirty."

He considered her. His eyes were small and pale and steady, and she could read nothing in them, which she supposed was the point of them.

"I know Article Thirty," he said. "I'll take this, and your statement, signed. I'll open an inquiry. It'll go to the Master of the Lattice Yards for the lot, and to the Water Board for the works, and—" He paused. "And to whatever office is concerned. You'll hear from me."

"When, sir?"

"When I've something to tell you." He wrote her a receipt on a printed slip. *Received from H. Vail, aspirant, one length brass tube, stamped, approx. 12 in., in connection with a matter under Article 30. H. Gage, Ch. Proctor.* As she turned to go, he said, in a slightly different voice: "Miss Vail. Do you go to the Cold House on the first of the month?"

She stopped. "Yes."

"Then go on the first of the month," said Gage. "And not otherwise. Not at night. Good morning."

* * *

She heard nothing on the fifteenth, or the sixteenth. On the morning of the seventeenth a sergeant in a buff coat was waiting at the door of the Benches after Crisp's class. Miss Vail was to step down to the Proctory.

Gage was standing at the window of the inner office with his hands behind his back. The chair behind the Hask oak desk was not empty.

The man in it was tall, silvered at the temples, handsome in an expensive way, his gown open over a dove-grey coat, with the ochre cord of the Brinescript Bench at his shoulder and over it the narrow silver chain that only one man in the Halcyon wore. Deputy Chancellor Ilario Vey. She had never spoken to him. Her signed statement lay on the blotter in front of him.

"Miss Vail," he said, as if they were old acquaintances. "Do sit."

She sat. Gage did not turn round.

"I've read this twice," said Vey, touching the statement with one finger. "It's very good. Dates, times, distances. Fourteen rods; you counted. A lot number. Article Thirty, cited correctly, which is more than half my Bench could manage. Corvin always said you had an eye." He smiled. "He was a diligent man too. The Conclave thanked him for it."

"The brass, sir."

"Is a Halcyon matter, and is with the office that concerns it." He said it pleasantly, as if he were telling her where the Bursary was. "The Chief Proctor has been good enough to pass it on. You'll keep your receipt, of course. Receipts are important. I'm told you were in customs."

She looked at Gage's back. It did not move.

"There are thirteen more," she said. "Under the Cold House. I can show you tonight."

"I'm sure you could. I'd rather you didn't." Vey turned a page of her statement that did not need turning. "You walked here from Lowside with a dead man's privilege on your shoulder. I admire that; I do. But a privilege is not a Bench. An aspirant without a sponsor holds her place at the Chancellor's pleasure, and the Chancellor"—a small, regretful movement of the hand—"tires. These things come to my desk now. Midwinter isn't far off." He squared the statement against

the blotter's edge. "And your brother is kept on a charity form, I think. The Board is very careful with its charity forms. So am I."

It was said so kindly that it took her a moment to hear it.

"Is that all, sir?"

"That's all. Diligence is a fine quality in an aspirant." He stood, so she stood. "So is discretion. The best of them learn both."

He went out past her, unhurried. The sergeant behind the rail stood up straight, and Vey's steps went away down the corridor of framed Charters.

Gage turned from the window. For the first time something moved in his small pale eyes, and was put away again.

"You've your receipt, Miss Vail," he said. "Keep it. Good morning."

* * *

Sorle did not turn round. "Well?"

"Gone," said Hester.

He laughed, once. It was not a pleasant sound, and it was not, she thought, aimed at her.

"Sit down, Miss Vail."

She sat. Afternoon light came down the shaft in the corner of the study, a long dusty bar of it from the Lantern's mirrors. It lay across the chalked slates against the bookcases and across the portrait of the broad-faced woman with Physic red at her collar.

She told him: Gage at the window with his back to her; Vey in Gage's chair; *diligence*; *the Chancellor's pleasure*; the charity form.

"Vey," said Sorle, as if tasting the name and not caring for the vintage. "Who thanked Corvin for his diligence in Conclave and moved on to the price of lamp oil. Who has the Chancellor's ear, because the Chancellor no longer has the strength to hold it herself." He tapped his pen on the blotter. "It need not be Vey. Vey is the sort of man through whom things pass. That rod may have passed through him on its way to somewhere else. But it passed."

"You told me so."

"I did. I've been right about the Halcyon for thirty-two years and it has never once given me pleasure." He swivelled to face her properly, and the shawl slipped off one bony shoulder, and he let it. "What will you do now?"

"I don't know."

"An honest answer. Rare."

"I've a receipt," said Hester. "And a Cistern with thirteen more rods in it that somebody will have had out by tonight, if they've any sense. And a man in a cellar who'll swear he never saw me. And a brother whose casing is thinner every week." She heard her voice go and brought it back. "And no Bench. The Registrar's written again. Midwinter, or I'm sent down. Crisp's full. Bassano's full. Orsolya can't take me till her third-years assay out, and she's been kind, but kind isn't a Bench. The rest of them look at me as if I'd come to read the meter."

Sorle looked at her for a long while.

Then he worked loose the top right drawer of his desk, which stuck, and took something out of it, and held it a moment before he put it on the blotter between them.

It was a Bench cord, looped and knotted in the Halcyon fashion. It was black, and not new. The black had gone brown at the knot, where a thumb had worked it.

"I have two aspirants," said Sorle. "Both third-years. Both will assay out this Rime, with distinction, God help the Fellowship. After that I had intended to have none. I've taken no one new in nine years; the Registrar has stopped sending me lists." He looked at the moth, not the cord. "It is not a good Bench to be on. You will be known as Sorle's, which is not a recommendation in this building. It will close doors Aske's white cord would have opened, and Aske's cord, you will forgive me, is no longer opening anything. Some of your examiners will mark you down for the colour on your shoulder before you have lifted a spoon. Crisp won't, because Crisp is honest. Vey will."

"Why are you doing it?"

The bar of light had moved onto the portrait, across the broad face and the red collar.

"Because Corvin asked me to," he said at last. "Not in words. Corvin never asked anyone for anything in words; he was too busy talking. But he spent his privilege on you, which in twenty years he had not spent on anyone. And on the sixteenth he asked me up to his Cell, and I found a dark corridor and a shut door and went back to bed in a temper. You know that part." His mouth twisted. "I owe him a half-hour. I can't pay it to him. You'll do."

He pushed the cord an inch toward her.

"And because I have nothing left to lose," he said, "and you have even less. That's a Bench."

She did not pick it up at once. She thought of the white cord on her shoulder, which Aske had looped there in the Gatehouse on Matriculation Day, fumbling, humming. Her eyes had gone hot. She did not let them do anything about it.

She took off the white cord, clumsily, folded it and put it in her pocket, where she would keep it. Then she looped the black one at her shoulder and pulled the knot tight.

"Ta," she said.

"Don't thank me. You'll hate it within the week." Sorle pulled a slate toward him and picked up the chalk. "Thursday. The fourth bell. Bring paper; I don't lend it. We'll begin with the arrears calculus, since you clearly can't be trusted to understand anything without first putting it in your mouth."

* * *

The arrears calculus was, Hester discovered over the next three days, a great deal of arithmetic dressed up as philosophy. She was good at arithmetic. She was not good at philosophy, and said so. Sorle said that put her ahead of most of the Conclave, who were good at neither but could tell the difference at dinner.

He wrote fast, in a hand that sloped backward, and wiped out what he had written with the side of his fist.

"Arrears," he said, "is pressure. Not a metaphor. A keeping holds a thing at one moment. The world goes on to the next, and the thing does not. Between where the thing is and where the world is, there is a difference, and the difference *wants*. It wants to close." He drew two lines, one flat, one rising away from it. "That wanting is arrears. It grows with time. It grows with the mass of what is kept." He drew the line steeper. "And it grows with how *lively* the thing was. A stone hardly minds being kept. A man minds a great deal. A man running minds more than a man asleep. A sea—" He stopped, and wiped the slate with his fist. "Never mind a sea. Not today."

"Why not today?"

"Because today you are learning arithmetic. Every casing pays its arrears out of its own stillness: the grain's, and what soaks into the grain from what it holds. And so. *Still runs to quick*. You've seen it twice now, once in my class and once on

your knees in a hole in Lowside. Join a full old casing by live brine to something with a great deal of arrears and little stillness to pay them with. What happens?"

"The stillness runs out of the casing," said Hester. "Into the thing that's owing."

"It pays the other thing's debt." He drew an arrow. "And if the other thing is large enough, and old enough, and owes enough, it will drink a charity ward dry and still be thirsty."

She looked at the arrow.

"A quickening," she said.

"I didn't say that."

"You didn't have to." The study was always cold, but she was colder. Two miles east, and a Halcyon at the end of it, and five fathoms down, pockets that were warm and wet and owed a great deal, and a Choir that sang slow to pay them. She had stood in that line and poured herself into it with sixty others and felt it drink.

She looked at the thought, and then she put it down, as you put down a sample you have not yet weighed.

"There are a great many rooms in the Halcyon," said Sorle, watching her. "You have a pipe that goes east and a building at the end of it. That is all you have."

"I know."

"Then go on with the arithmetic." His eyes were sharper than his voice. "If a stay is a pouring-in of stillness to pay a quickening's arrears, what does the quickening do?"

"Quiets."

"For how long?"

She thought of the brass stay-lines in the Fifth, and of a pocket that had been held down on the Tuesday and was warm again by the Saturday.

"Not long," she said. "And then it's back. Worse."

"Why worse?"

"Because you've not paid anything. You've just added to it. You've kept the keeping. It still owes everything it owed, and now it's had longer to owe it."

"Stays saturate," said Sorle softly. "Pour enough still into a quickening and it quiets, and grows hungrier. The Fathomers know it. Orsolya Thane knows it better than anyone alive; she's been pouring for thirty years. They've no other tool, and they've never wanted one. A stay is a lid, Miss Vail. That is all a stay is."

Hester did not move.

*You lid a spitting pan, she'll blow the lid through the roof.* Her father in the steam, drawing the fire out a shovelful at a time.

"What if you let it out?" she said. "What if you didn't pour stillness in. What if you let the owing out. A bit at a time. So it's paid."

"Then the moment *proceeds*." Sorle's voice was quiet. "A kept thing let out goes on from where it stopped. That's the Third Law; a child knows it. A kept apple goes on being an apple. A kept man goes on bleeding; a kept corpse blooms grey in a month or so, whatever the grade, and goes on being a corpse. And a quickening—" He put down the chalk. "A quickening is not an apple. We do not know what a quickening is. We know it is warm and wet and sounds like surf. If you let one go on, you would find out what it stopped *in the middle of.* In the Fifth Fathom of a building with three thousand people in it."

"Not in the Fifth. Somewhere else. Somewhere it couldn't—"

"No." He wiped the slate, all of it, the lines and the arrow and the rising curve. "That is not a thought for a first-year with a black cord three days old. You know what one thought about the sea has cost me. I am still paying for it." He turned back and wrote, fast, a line of arithmetic that had nothing to do with anything. "Arrears of a moth. Kept forty years. Mass a quarter-grain. Work it."

She worked it. She got it right. He grunted.

But when she looked up his chalk had stopped. He was looking at the portrait on the wall, at the broad-faced woman with the Physic red at her collar, with the expression of a man listening for something in another room.

"*A bit at a time,*" he said, under his breath. "*So it's paid.*" And then, without turning: "Arrears of a man, kept three months. Mass ten stone. Hush grain. Work it."

She looked at him.

"Work it, Miss Vail."

She worked it. It was a very large number. She did not say whose it was. Neither did he.

* * *

Agathe's letter came with the carrier on the twentieth of Fallow, in the round copybook hand.

*My dear. Mr. Pell has been quiet since he came back from his sister's and has had the cellar grating mortared over in the old way, thick, by a man from the Water Board. He has said nothing to me and I have said nothing to him. On the morning after, I went down for the oil and the drain was dry, and the weeping on our people stopped for two days. On the third day it began again. I do not know what that means. I expect you do.*

*There is a thinness at the foot of your lad's casing that I can see my candle through if I hold it low.*

*A.L.*

Hester read it twice at the window of R-41, with the White going grey behind the glass. She put it in the tin box under her bed, where the rod had been and was not, and sat down on the bed with the black cord at her shoulder and looked at her hands.

Teo came in at the sixth bell with saltcake wrapped in a cloth and found her still sitting there. He did not ask. He put the saltcake on the sill and sat on his own bed and waited. She held out the letter, and he read it, and gave it back.

"Two days," he said.

"Two days."

"One rod cut, out of fourteen, and it stopped for two days, until they'd mended it." He turned the cloth over in his hands without opening it. "So it can stop. That's what it means, Hester. It can be stopped."

"For two days."

"Two days," said Teo, "is not nothing."

The Lantern came round and flashed, and the light went across the White and the window and the two of them, and was gone. Hester sat with her hands on the letter and did the arithmetic of a thinning casing in her head. She did it again. It came out the same both times.

CHAPTER 15

# *Ferrers*



*The Purchaser shall make no enquiry as to the provenance of the said grain beyond the Vendor's warrant, and shall hold the Vendor harmless in any matter arising from its resale.*

— Contract of sale between the Office of the W.L.F. and Messrs. Ferrers & Lisk, clause 7

Lucan went home on the twenty-second of Fallow and came back the same night with a face like a shut door.

Hester was on the Choir Steps when he found her. It was the hour after the Lantern Hour, and most of the Halcyon was still at the Long Table. The outdoor amphitheatre on the dome's eastern flank was empty, its tiers of salt gone blue in the dusk. In Fallow nobody came, which was why Hester did. She sat on the third tier with her gown wrapped round her knees, looking east, where there was nothing but white going grey and, a quarter of a mile off, the low dark hump of the Well-Cap on its chains.

He came down the tiers behind her carefully. The ribs were a fortnight mended, and he still took steps as if each one might have an opinion. He sat on the tier above hers, a little to the side.

"I've seen my father," he said.

She waited.

"We had a turbot at dinner, kept, from Hask. My father is fond of fish. It reminds him that he can afford to be." His voice was perfectly even. "Afterward I opened the drawer where he keeps the year's Ferrers and Lisk contracts, because I was eleven when I found out where he hides the key, and he has never moved it. It

is inside a hollowed copy of *The Duties of a Magistrate*, which no one in our family has ever opened for any other reason."

"Lucan."

"I'm coming to it." He took a folded paper from inside his coat. "I didn't take the original. I copied it at his desk, by his lamp, with his pen, and put everything back. Then I went and asked him about it." He held it out without looking at her. "Read it first."

It was a long sheet in Lucan's tidy, slanting schoolroom hand, faster and less tidy toward the bottom.

*Articles of agreement made this 3rd of Thaw, 903 Y.E., between the Office of the W.L.F., the Halcyon Collegium of the Grain (hereinafter the Vendor), and Messrs. Ferrers & Lisk, Exchequer Yard, Ambry (hereinafter the Purchaser).*

*1. The Vendor shall supply, at such intervals as are convenient to the Vendor, quantities of residual stay grain, being grain removed in the course of maintenance from the lower workings, in sealed cases, at the Purchaser's landing at the Dry Harbour.*

*2. The Purchaser shall convey the said grain by its own vessels to such markets beyond the Rim as it sees fit, and shall not offer it for sale within the Free City or within one hundred miles thereof.*

There were prices per case, and they were high. There was a clause about relabelling at the Purchaser's discretion for the convenience of foreign customs. There was clause seven, about provenance. And at the bottom Lucan had copied the signatures as he found them, imitating the hands as far as he was able:

*For the Vendor: E. Dunmore, clerk, per W.L.F.*

*For the Purchaser: A. Ferrers.*

Hester read it twice, and the signatures a third time.

"*Not within one hundred miles,*" she said. "And the *Wren* came into the dry harbour with forty crates of it marked Shelf for curing."

"I asked him about that." Lucan was looking at the Well-Cap. "I said, Father, this grain is not Shelf. It's from the stays, below the Fifth very likely, quickened; the Customs schedule hasn't even a word for it. It is a felony under the Charter to sell it at all. And you have been sending it to Quell to have its papers changed and bringing it back into Ambry to sell to the curing-houses at Shelf prices with Deep profits, because the Hask market has gone soft this year. Which," he said, "I had worked out on the Causeway dray, and was rather proud of."

"What did he say?"

"He asked me if I wanted more port." Lucan's mouth moved. "Then he said that the Halcyon sold him the grain, and the Halcyon's warrant was on the contract, and if the Halcyon had a Charter it might look to its own Charter. Then he said the thing about laundry and lamps again. He'd said it to me in Russet, with his hand on my shoulder. This time he didn't bother with the hand." When he went on, his sentences had got shorter. "He said I was to stay out of it. He said that if I had any notion of carrying tales to the Proctory I should remember who paid my fees. And who got me onto the Deputy Chancellor's Bench, and why. He was calm. He's never calm with me."

The salt of the Choir Steps was cold through Hester's gown. The last light went off the Well-Cap.

"Why did Vey take you?" she asked.

"Because my father asked him to. Over a turbot." He laughed, slightly. "I thought it was because I was good."

"You are good."

"I am adequate. I am also the son of the Lord Exchequer." He turned and looked at her for the first time. In the dusk his face was younger and more tired than she had seen it. "That is how it works, Vail. Everything in this building is somebody's favour to somebody. My father does the Deputy Chancellor a kindness and the Deputy Chancellor does my father one, and somewhere at the bottom of it is a ward full of people in the Cold House. And the man at the top eats turbot and tells his son to stay out of it." He looked at the paper in her hands. "He signed it. *A. Ferrers*. I watched him sign things my whole childhood. I'd know that A anywhere."

There was nothing to say that would not have been a kindness, and she did not think he wanted one. She folded the paper and held it out to him. He shook his head.

"Keep it," he said. "I've no drawer that isn't his."

* * *

SHE DID NOT NEED TO LOOK IT UP. SHE LOOKED IT UP ANYWAY, BECAUSE that was what she did.

The Halcyon Calendar was printed every Thaw by the Collegium press and stood in a row of fat grey volumes in the Brinestacks reference alcove, one for

each year back to 612. At the front, under *Abbreviations Used in Collegium Correspondence*, it listed the offices by their initials. She had glanced at that page on her second day. She had not remembered what was on it. She had remembered that it was there.

She found it by lamplight at the eleventh bell, with the Brinestacks empty round her except for Callow on the far side of the gallery, so still at his desk he might have been one of the cases.

*W.U.F. — Warden of the Upper Fathoms.*

*W.L.F. — Warden of the Lower Fathoms.*

*W.S. — Warden of the Stacks.*

*W.L. — Warden of the Light.*

She sat with the book open in front of her for some time.

*Warden of the Lower Fathoms.* Orsolya.

Then she did what she had spent twenty-one years teaching Customs House clerks not to do. She did it carefully, step by step, as a clerk adds a column he wants to come out a certain way.

The contract was signed *E. Dunmore, clerk, per W.L.F.* Not by the Warden. *Per.* On behalf of the office. And the office of the Warden of the Lower Fathoms was not one woman. It was a gallery in the Fifth with three clerks in it, and a store, and the Choir rolls, and the pension book, and letters to the Delvers' Guild and the Lattice Yards and the Water Board. It put its initials on a hundred letters a week, most of which the Warden would never see.

And there had been a man in grey wool at the dry harbour, by the dray, with a lantern and a paper. A clerk. Pell had said it too: *a clerk; he never gave his name.*

*E.D.* Edwin Dunmore. The bland man with the inky cuffs who sat at the outer desk of the Warden's Gallery, wrote down the Choir's hours, and handed out the stipend on Fridays. Hester had collected three sols from him every week since Russet and could not have told you the colour of his eyes.

Dunmore, who signed for the office and had the seals. Who, if he was selling quickened grain to Ferrers and Lisk behind the Warden's back, would want the stays held down whatever it cost. Who answered, perhaps, not to the Warden at all but to somebody who could make a length of brass disappear out of a locked Proctory store. To a man in a dove-grey coat who had sat in the Chief Proctor's chair and praised her diligence.

It added up. It added up quite well, if you were careful which figures you carried.

She knew she was carrying some figures and not others. She carried them anyway. Orsolya had put a cold hand on her shoulder at Aske's door. Orsolya had stood over her after her first stay, while Ama wrapped her in a blanket, and said *well done* in a voice that could have come from Coldwater Street.

Orsolya was Lowside.

Hester shut the Calendar and put it back on its shelf, in its place, between 902 and 904.

* * *

"And the Warden?" said Lucan.

They were in the Reading Well off the north gallery of the Brinestacks the next afternoon, a small round room with a brine basin set in the floor and a bench round the wall. Teo sat with Lucan's copy of the contract on his knee. Hester had laid it out for them: Dunmore; the office; *per*; the clerk at the dray; the clerk in Pell's cellar; the vanished rod; Vey in Gage's chair.

"It isn't her signature," Hester said. "It's her clerk's. Clerks sign for their offices every day. Mallory's sub-clerk signed for the Customs House forty times a morning." She heard her voice harden and could not stop it. "She's not a thief, Ferrers. She's held the Fifth for thirty years. She's buried eleven of her own. You've not stood in that line. You don't know what it costs her."

"I know what it costs the Cold House," said Lucan.

The basin in the floor had a skin of dead brine on it. Teo looked down at it and did not look up.

"I'm not saying she did it," Lucan said, more gently. "I'm saying you've not asked."

"I'll ask. She's offered to help me with my release. Private lessons, Wednesday. I'll ask her then about the residue contracts. I'll ask her about Dunmore."

"And if she says what you want her to say?"

"Then she'll have said it."

Lucan looked at her a long moment. Then he said, without any heat at all, "You know, you are doing what I did with my father. For about twenty-three years."

She had no answer. She went out. Behind her she heard Teo say, low, "Leave her be," and then the door of the Reading Well swung shut on its weight, and she was among the stacks, where ten thousand salt tablets in their cases glimmered in the lamplight, remembering being touched.

* * *

Crisp's release hour fell on Wednesdays too, at the Pans. Hester kept her drop and tried to give it back, and could not; it hung over the dish in its bead of salt while the first-years either side of her let theirs fall, one and then another. Crisp stopped behind her. "You let one go on the White, Vail, with a boy's life on it. So it's in you. You're sitting on it." She lifted the bead off with the rod and set it in the dish with the others. There were nine.

The Warden's Gallery was the last landing before the iron gates of the Fifth, a long low room cut into the raw salt. Dunmore's desk stood at one end and the Warden's at the other, and between them were the Choir rolls on their racks, a stove, a horsehair settee and a stack of grey wool blankets. On Wednesday at the fifth bell there was no one but Orsolya, because she had sent them all away.

"Sit down before you fall down." She poured. "You look like a wet week in Thaw. That Sorle working you?"

"Arithmetic."

"Ha. He would." Orsolya put the cup into Hester's hands and closed her own round it briefly. Her fingers were cold as stone. Thirty years of holding had done that; it had started whitening her hair at thirty and slowed her heart to something Hester could feel, if she stood close, like a clock in another room. "Black cord. I saw. There's worse than Benedek, though I'd not say it to his face. He hates me, you know. I took him apart once in Conclave. I was twenty-six and pleased with myself, and he was wrong in a way that would have got people killed." She sat down on the settee with her own cup. "Still. He's no fool. If he's taken you, he's seen something."

"He says I hold like a miser."

"Crisp said that. Everyone heard it." Orsolya laughed, a short Lowside bark. "She's not wrong. You hold like a Coldwater landlady with the rent. Nothing comes out once it's in. There's no shame in it; in the line, it's what's wanted. But you'll not pass the Assay if you can't let your own moth go, and Maudelaine'll not

give you so much as a *wanting* if you can't. So." She set down her cup. "Let's see you."

They worked for an hour. Orsolya kept drops over a basin of live brine by the stove, and Hester put her wet hand to each bead and went into the hold and tried to come out of it the other way.

She could not do it. She could feel the drop in its casing, still, held, owing; she could feel exactly what it wanted. She could not open her hand. Each time she tried, something in her closed tighter, as a fist closes round a coin when someone jostles you in a crowd.

"No. You're pushing." Orsolya's cold fingers were on her wrist. "You can't push a release. It's not a door. Open your hand."

"I am opening it."

"You're thinking about opening it. That's not the same." Orsolya sat back with her head on one side. "Who taught you to keep?"

"No one."

"Somebody did. Everybody learns it off somebody. You learned it off somebody you watched, who never let anything go." She did not wait for an answer. "I'll tell you what my da used to say. He was a delver at Coldbank, the old pit east of the Weeps. Haskish man, big as a door; he married a Lowside girl and never went home. He used to say, the salt's not yours, Orsi. You only borrow it. Hold it like a borrowed thing." She looked at the stove. "The Coldbank roof came in when I was eleven. Eighty men. He was in the third gallery. The Halcyon had a Physic on the site, and she kept him with Middling out of a bucket, standing up, as they found him, under the beam. The women at the pit-head kept saying *if they'd shored it, if they'd only shored it*. I can hear them yet." She drank her tea. "He was in the Cold House nineteen years. Then the casing started weeping, and the brinewright said it wouldn't take another coat. I signed for him at thirty. That's how I know your Coldwater Street, chick. I've stood where you stand."

Hester had not known that.

"Well," said Orsolya, briskly. "Enough of that. Watch me. Maybe it'll go in through your eyes, since it won't go in through your hands."

She lit an ordinary tallow candle at the stove and set it on the stand beside the basin. The flame stood up in the still air of the Gallery, yellow, smoky at the tip. Orsolya dipped her left hand in the brine to the wrist and held it, dripping, beside the flame.

"Kept flame," she said. "You'll not have seen one. They're not allowed in lamps; somebody always forgets and returns one in a hayloft. But it's good for teaching. A flame's nothing *but* motion. If you can keep a flame and let it go clean, you can keep anything." She went still. Hester watched it happen: the slowing breath, the colour leaving her lips, the stillness spreading down through her shoulders into her arm. Then Orsolya flicked her wet fingers at the candle.

The brine took the flame in mid-air.

It did not put it out. That was what caught Hester's breath. The flame stopped. It hung on its wick inside a skin of clear salt the size of a hen's egg, yellow and smoky-tipped and perfectly motionless, every edge of it sharp, as if somebody had cut it out of a painting of a candle and stood it on the stand. It gave no heat. It gave light, and the light did not flicker.

And in the salt around it, as the casing set and cleared, a pattern came up into the grain.

It was fine. Hester would not have seen it if she had not been looking for nothing, as she looked at everything. Faint lines in the crystal, like the whorl in a thumb, all curving the same way. A spiral. It began at the base of the casing where it met the wick and wound up round the flame and closed at the top. It turned to the left, against the sun.

"There," said Orsolya, coming out of the hold, blinking, with a craftsman's satisfaction. "See that? Every worker leaves a hand in the grain. Like your writing. Yours is all squares. I've seen it. Like a ledger. Maudelaine's is flat, like pages in a book; Corvin's was all spokes, God rest him, like a cartwheel." She tilted her head at the spiral. "Mine's a corkscrew. Always has been. My mam said I came out twisting."

Hester looked at the spiral.

Something in her went toward it as a tongue goes toward a broken tooth. There was a place in her mind where she had put something down, at a cold door on the Third Fathom on the seventeenth of Russet: Aske's casing under a low lamp, and in the clear salt a hair below the surface, fine curving lines in a long slow coil that went up his body from the floor. Turning left. *Widdershins*. She had noted it and not understood it, and then there had been Gage, and the porters, and Orsolya's hand on her shoulder. She came back to it now. It was the same hand.

She kept her eyes on the flame. It was the hardest hold she had done in the Halcyon, and there was no brine in it. "It's beautiful," she said, because it was, a fold of fire stood up in glass, and because her face needed something to do. Tib would have liked it. And when Orsolya said, "Now. Watch the release," she watched the release.

Orsolya put her wet fingertips to the casing and went still again, and this time Hester saw something. The stillness did not go out of Orsolya so much as *loosen*, as a knot loosens when you stop pulling on both ends. Her hand did not move. It opened from inside. The salt clouded, softened, ran, and the flame was flickering on its wick in a little puddle of brine, warm and ordinary. It gave off a single sharp tick of heat that Hester felt on her face, like an oven door opened and shut.

"Arrears," said Orsolya. "Half a minute's worth of candle. See how I did it? I didn't push. I just stopped holding on. Now. Try it with the drop."

She tried it with the drop. She could not do it. But she was nearer, she thought; for an instant she felt her hold go soft at the edge, like the skin on a pan, before it closed again.

"Better," said Orsolya. "That's the first time I've seen you *want* to."

* * *

Afterward, with the kettle on again, she asked. She had decided how on the Stair: plainly, looking at her cup, so that she could watch Orsolya's hands and not her face. She said she had seen the office's initials on some papers in the Brinestacks, and did not say which papers. She said she understood the Warden's office sold off the grain it took out of the stays, and wondered how that worked under the Charter. Whether it was quickened grain. Whether it was Hush. She had worked in Customs, she said, and could not help wondering.

Orsolya neither stiffened nor looked away. She leaned back on the horsehair settee and stretched her cold hands toward the stove and said, comfortably, "Oh, that's Edwin's. The residue contracts. Edwin handles all that; I'd not know a bill of sale from a hymn sheet." She nodded down the room at Dunmore's empty desk, with its neat stacks and its inkstand. "What we take off the stays has to go somewhere. You can't put it back in the ground, and you'd not want it in the Halcyon; it spits. So it goes for sale abroad. Hask buys it for the mines. They want quick grain for blasting, of all things; it's got a kick to it. It's all above board.

Conclave-approved, years since. The money goes back to the Choir. Pensions. Widows. God knows they need it."

"It's Hush grain, though," said Hester. "Some of it. The schedule says—"

"The Customs schedule." Orsolya smiled at her, fond and a little rueful, a Lowside woman's smile for a Lowside girl who has been reading too much. "That was written by a man in Ambry who's never been below the First Fathom. Stay residue's not Hush grain, not as the Charter means it. It's spent. It's had its stillness poured out of it into a stay, like your twice-used casing grain. There's nothing in it but a kick." She drank. "Edwin keeps it all in order. He's a dull dog, but he's never lost a sol."

Her hands had stayed open toward the stove the whole time. It was a good answer, warm and plain, with the clerk's name in it before Hester had asked for one.

"Ta," she said.

"Don't *ta* me. Drink your tea. You've a shift at the ninth."

* * *

The ninth-bell shift went down singing slow on the Stair, forty of them in grey wool. Hester was in the second rank, between Ama Tessaly and a broad young delver's son from Coldbank called Fenwick, who sang flat and held like a wall. They went through the iron gates of the Fifth and down the long galleries, where the brass stay-lines ran along the walls in their sheaths, to the eastern stay, which had been warm on the Monday.

It was warm again. The salt underfoot was damp and soft, and the gallery smelled of something green and cold that Hester had no name for. Behind the walls, faint, a sound like breath drawn in through teeth and let out, and drawn in.

They took their places along the line and laid their wet hands on the brass. They sang the first slow bars of the work-song to lock their breathing, *hold the line, hold the line.* Then they went down into the hold together and poured.

And it was easy.

It had been easy on the Monday, and the Friday before, and every shift since she had joined. She had nothing to compare it to, only Ama's face and Fenwick's. Fenwick said, after, that he'd never known a season like it; some autumns in his three years the stays had nearly had him off his feet. Ama, forty years on the line, said nothing at all.

Tonight Hester felt it, because tonight she was feeling for it. In the hold, with her stillness running out through her wet fingers in the brine-slots of the brass and away toward the warm wall, she felt that the brass was not empty. Something was in it already, before her, beside her, under her: something cold and old and deeply still, already in the line when the Choir's pour reached it. It took the weight of the pour as a full bucket takes the next cup, without needing much. And it came from the other direction, from behind her, from the east trunk, where the main stay-line came in through the gallery wall from somewhere far off.

The line was already full.

She could not taste it. You could not taste through your hands. She could only feel it, as you feel through a floor that there is somebody in the room below.

She came out of the hold at the end of the shift cold and slow, the lag sitting on her like wet wool, and Ama put a blanket round her shoulders. Up in the Gallery, Dunmore was at his desk writing down the hours in his neat hand, not looking up. At the other end of the room Orsolya was on the settee with her eyes closed and a cup going cold in her lap. The kept flame was gone from the stand. Only a ring of dried salt showed where it had been.

Hester stood in the doorway with the blanket round her and looked at the ring of salt until Ama touched her elbow.

She went up the Stair slowly, because her legs were slow, and on the long climb she carried all the figures, the ones she had been leaving out.

W.L.F. A spiral round Aske's arm, and the same spiral round a candle-flame, turned by the same left wrist. A line that came in full from the east, and a Warden who had held these stays for thirty years and called them kind. It added up without any care at all about which figures you carried.

She could not prove a line of it. A hand in the grain was not a signature. And the woman it pointed at had signed for her own father at thirty, and paid the three sols a week that kept Tib in the fourth row. If Hester said it aloud, Teo would not be able to look down the Long Table without Orsolya knowing by the end of supper, and Lucan would want the Proctory, which had already lost one piece of brass. And if she was wrong, she would have said it of the one person in the building who talked like home.

She wanted to be wrong. She noticed that, and did not trust it.

So she would tell no one. She would stand in the line on Friday, and on the Monday after, with her hands on the brass, and find out what was in it. By the

time she reached the Rookery she had put the name where no one else could reach it, as she had once put away the last thing Tib said to her, and she knew exactly what she was doing, and did it anyway.

CHAPTER 16

# *Annealing*



*Glass remembers how it cooled.*

— Proverb of the Quell glassmakers

THE BOOTS WERE THE FIRST THING.

They were Quell boots, which meant they were good: black calf, cut high, laced through brass eyes, with a welted sole that would take the Rookery's salt-glazed floors for ten winters without splitting. Hester knew what boots like that cost because she had once seized forty pairs of them at the dry harbour from a Hask trader who called them "personal effects," and Daisy had valued them at a sol and a half the pair, wholesale. Saskia Orme came down to the Long Table in them on the second of Cinder and ate her porridge as if her feet had always been inside good leather.

Hester noticed; she noticed most things that had a price. People bought boots.

The second thing was the hours. Saskia's cell was three doors along from R-41, and its door had a hinge that shrieked. Twice that week Hester, lying awake with the Fifth Fathom's cold in her bones from a Choir shift, heard it shriek after the twelfth bell. The second time she got up and looked out. Saskia was coming along the passage in her outdoor coat with her collar up, carrying her boots so as not to wake anyone. There was salt-mud on the coat's hem to the knee. Not the grey mud of the Pans or the Causeway: the white paste of the harbour ramps, where the harbour-men raked the salt smooth every morning and the landship runners churned it every night.

The third thing was the money.

Hester did not go looking for it. She was in the Bursary on the First Fathom on the third, paying her Choir fine; she had lagged at the Stay the day before and come round ten minutes after her relief should have taken over, and the Choir docked you for that whether it was your fault or not. While the clerk, a Harlish boy with a cold, wrote her receipt, she read the open ledger at his elbow upside down, because she had read ledgers upside down for twenty-one years and could not stop. *Orme, S. Lumen. Fees Thaw and Turning, paid in full. Additional: remitted to Glassmarket Infant School, Ambry, for P. Orme, the year in advance, 6 sols.*

Saskia paid her fees by the term, late, with a note; Hester had seen her do it in Russet at this same window with her jaw set.

Hester took her receipt and went up the Stair doing the sum, and did not like the answer.

* * *

She found her in the kilns.

The Lumen kilns were on the Third Fathom, at the end of a corridor that grew warmer every yard: the only warm place in the Halcyon below the Crown. By night only the annealing ovens were kept going. The glaziers called them lehrs: long brick tunnels, warm as a bread oven, where the day's lantern-jars crept on iron trays from the hot end to the cool end over twelve hours. Somebody had to sit with them, turning the dampers and walking the trays forward a hand's breadth at a time. Saskia took that duty three nights a week for a fleck an hour. She had told Hester so in Russet, when they were still needling each other, as evidence that some people had to work.

She was sitting on an upturned crate at the cool end of the long lehr, in her shirtsleeves, with her new boots crossed at the ankle and a ledger of tray-times on her knee. In the dull red of the lehr's mouth and the gold of three kept-light jars on a shelf, her face was all angles.

"Vail," she said, without looking up. "If you've come to borrow heat, it's a fleck a quarter-hour. Bassano's rule."

"I've come about your boots."

Saskia did look up then. "They're very nice. Thank you. Quellish. My cousin makes them."

"Your cousin charges a sol and a half, wholesale. I've valued them." Hester stood just inside the door. She had come down the corridor with the sum in her head and nothing else. "And you paid two terms' fees on the first. And six sols for a year at the Glassmarket school. That's thirty sols, near enough, since Russet. You're on a Lumen bursary and a fleck an hour for watching ovens."

Saskia set the ledger down on the crate beside her, carefully, as if it were a tray of glass.

"You read my bursary page."

"It was open."

"You *read my bursary page*." Her voice was level. "Do you do this to everyone? Or only the ones from across the White? Do you go through people's pockets for contraband?"

"Only when there's contraband in them."

It was the wrong thing to say, and she knew it as she said it. Saskia stood up.

"Get out of my kiln."

"Who pays you, Orme?"

"Get *out*."

"You come in at the twelfth bell with harbour paste on your coat to the knee," Hester said. "Ramp-salt, from the landship quays. I walked on it for twenty-one years. Three nights a week, and not the nights you sit with the lehr." She heard her voice go flat and hard, the voice she had used on Mallory, and could not find another. "There's a man in grey wool who oversaw forty crates of felony grain being carried out of the Ambry bond-shed in the middle of the night. Somebody carried that grain out of here in the first place. Was it you?"

The lehr ticked.

Saskia looked at her a long time. Then she sat down again on the crate, slowly, and put her elbows on her knees and her face in her hands. When she took them away her eyes were dry and her mouth was tight with something nearer disgust than shame.

"Two sols a run," she said.

* * *

It came out in pieces, not in order but in the order they were hit.

She had come over from Quell in Thaw with Pip and her mother and forty sols, which was what was left of Jory's landship after the Exchequer took its cut and the insurers found a clause. Forty sols, in a city that charged rent like a toll-gate. Bassano's bursary paid her fees and nothing else. She had sold Jory's sextant in the spring—"before you say it, Vail, yes, his father's, I sold it to a Hask trader for nine sols and I'd do it again"—and by midsummer she was choosing between her mother's coal and Pip's shoes.

"And then a man came to the kilns," she said. "One night at midsummer. A clerk. Bland, ink on his cuffs. Pleasant. He'd heard I was a hard worker who needed evening hours. He said the Warden's office wanted a courier who could keep her mouth shut and her hands steady. Residue grain. Stay salt, up from the Fifth in sealed boxes, down to a Ferrers freighter at the harbour, under contract. Conclave-approved. They wanted somebody from outside the Choir because Choir people talk, and somebody poor because poor people turn up."

"Dunmore," Hester said.

"I never asked his name. It was on a docket once. E. Dunmore." Saskia's mouth twisted. "He gave me a pass for the box-lift and a barrow. It runs from the Fifth to the Third and stops nowhere between but a locked service gate at the Fourth. Three nights a week I'd meet it at the tenth bell at the Third Fathom landing, and he'd bring the boxes up. Four, five, sometimes ten. I'd barrow them out through the Gatehouse on the porters' road and down the Causeway, and a freighter's mate would sign for them. Two sols, every time. In silver, in my hand."

"You didn't ask what was in them."

"I knew what was in them. Grain. It said so on the docket."

"You didn't ask why a Conclave-approved contract needed a woman with a barrow at night and not the porters' drays."

"*No*, Vail. I didn't ask." Saskia's voice came up for the first time. "Because if I'd asked, he'd have found someone who didn't. I've a daughter. She's six. Her feet grow. Have you ever had to look at a child's feet and do sums? No. You've a brother who doesn't grow at all. You're lucky."

The word stayed in the hot air between them.

"The boxes were warm," Hester said. "You'd have felt it through the wood. Quickened grain is warm. And you see colour at the edges of things, Orme; you'd have seen it bleeding round the corners like a lamp through a sheet. I tasted that grain at the Customs House. It came in on the *Constant Wren* labelled Shelf for

curing, which was a lie. It was quickened Hush, which is a felony to sell, and it tastes exactly like the brine beading on my brother's casing. You've seen that casing. You stood by it on Lantern Night. And somebody walked that grain down the Causeway in a barrow for two sols a run."

"The *Wren*." Saskia had gone pale under the red light. "That was high summer. Some of them went east. I didn't know—"

"They went to Quell and came back with a new label."

"I didn't *know*—"

"You didn't ask."

"And you did?" Saskia was on her feet again. "You *did*? Look at your own shoulder, Vail. What's that?"

Hester did not look. A Choir badge: the little iron wave on a grey ribbon, pinned under the black cord of Sorle's Bench.

"Three sols a week," Saskia said. "Out of the Warden's office. The *same office*. Paid over by the same bland little man with ink on his cuffs, I'll lay money. Where do you think the Choir stipends come from? The Conclave wouldn't pay for a candle-end if it could keep it. You take his money every Friday, Vail, to pay your brother's fee, and you go down into the Fifth and do whatever it is they do there, and you've never once asked where the silver comes from. Have you? Have you *asked*?"

Hester said nothing.

"No," said Saskia. "Because you needed it. Because it was for Tib." She laughed, short and ugly. "You took that gown on a dead man's privilege. You took a Choir place from a Warden you'd known a fortnight. You'd have taken it from the Chancellor's own hand if it paid the Cold House. You're Lowside, so you think you're clean. Lowside isn't clean, Vail. It's just poor. Ask anyone in Quell."

"I didn't carry felony grain to the harbour in a barrow."

"No. You just let other people's dead pay your rent."

That one went in, under the ribs. And because it went in, Hester did what she had done all her life when something went in. She hit back with the nearest heavy thing.

"Jory would be proud," she said.

She saw it land. Saskia's face went still, not with the grain-stillness but with the other kind, the kind that comes before a person decides whether to strike you.

She did not strike. She looked at Hester for three ticks of the lehr. Then she sat down on her crate and opened the ledger of tray-times on her knee.

"Get out of my kiln," she said, quietly. "Please."

Hester went.

* * *

She walked. It was what she did. She went up the Stair to the Crown and out onto the dome, and round the Lantern's foot in the cold with her hands in her armpits. It was a hard clear night. The White lay under the stars like a sheet laid out for a body, and far to the west the lamps of Ambry were a smudge of yellow at the edge of the world.

She knew she was right about the grain. Saskia had carried felony salt for money, and some of it tasted like Tib's beads. But Saskia was right too. The silver in Hester's own purse came up the same Stair from the same office, and she had never asked. Orsolya had sat her down in that warm office in Russet and given her tea and said *I need holds like yours*, and Hester had been so grateful, so Lowside-grateful, to be wanted by someone who talked like her mother's sister, that she had not looked at the money at all. She had only counted it. She was looking at it now, and at the woman who paid it.

And she had said the thing about Jory, who had gone into a sink on the eastern White with a full crew. Saskia had told that story on Lantern Night in the Glassmarket, quickly, with Pip on her hip, as if it were the price of something.

Hester stood at the dome's edge and looked toward the Well-Cap on its chains, never opened. She thought of her father drawing the fire from under a spitting pan a shovelful at a time. *Lid's for when you're in a hurry.*

She went back in.

* * *

Teo was baking.

Nobody was supposed to bake in the Rookery. Fires were forbidden on the dome, and the Proctors checked. Teo had solved this in his first week with a spirit stove smuggled up the Stair in his laundry, which he lit with the window cracked and a towel along the foot of the door, and which baked one small saltcake, badly, under a covered tin. A cracked kept-light jar on the sill did for a lamp. R-41

consequently smelled most nights of burnt sugar and hot salt. Teo sat cross-legged on his bed in his grey Tider shawl, watching the tin as other men watch a sick child.

"You've been fighting," he said, without looking round.

"How do you know?"

"You've got your customs face on. And Saskia Orme came past an hour ago and didn't sneer at our door, which she always does, so either she's dead or she's been in a fight and lost, and she doesn't lose." He lifted the lid a crack and let it down again. "Ten minutes. Sit."

She sat and told him, badly, in the wrong order: the boots and the bursary and the barrow and the *Wren*, then what Saskia had said, and at the end what she had said herself. Teo listened without interrupting.

"Well," he said. "That was a horrible thing to say."

"I know."

"No, I mean truly horrible. It was well made. You've a gift for it." He lifted the lid again. "And she's right about the stipend. And you're right about the grain. And she's right that you're Lowside and think you're clean, and you're right that she should have asked. I don't think anyone in this conversation was wrong about anything, Hester, which is generally how the worst conversations go." He let the lid down. "In the Order we'd have said you were both in a state of grace and both damned, and sent you to scrub the refectory together. It works better than you'd think."

"I'm not going to scrub anything with her."

"No," said Teo. "But you might eat something."

There was a knock at the door. Not a Proctor's knock, which was three and loud. One knock, hard, as if whoever made it had thought about it for some time and decided it would be only one.

Saskia was standing in the passage with a bottle of Quell clear in one hand and her new boots in the other. She held up the bottle.

"I've come about your manners," she said.

"I've no manners."

"No. I noticed." Saskia came in without being asked, sat on the end of Teo's bed, and put the boots on the floor and the bottle on the window ledge. "That's my cousin's clear. It's illegal on this side of the White. You can seize it if you like. It's for drinking."

Teo produced three tin cups from somewhere in the shawl.

Quell clear tasted like having your mouth set on fire by a person who loved you. Nobody apologised. Hester did not know how she would have done it if she had tried, and Saskia, she suspected, knew even less. They sat on the two narrow beds with the White outside the salt-glass and the burnt-sugar smell of Teo's tin. After the second cup Saskia said, to the window, "Jory would have asked."

"I shouldn't have said it."

"No. But he would have. He asked about everything. He asked the insurers why their clause was in Ambry black and the rest of the contract in Quell blue. They didn't pay out anyway, but he asked." She turned the cup in her fingers. "I'm not Jory. I'm the one who does sums."

"So am I," Hester said.

"I know. That's why I hate you." Saskia drank. "Some days."

The saltcake came out black on the bottom and raw in the middle and sweet as a sin, and they ate it with their fingers off the lid. Teo said a Tider grace over it, composed, he said, for the breaking of a fast after the death of an abbot, and suitable for most occasions involving sugar and recrimination.

* * *

"Tell me about the lift," Hester said, later.

The tenth bell, Saskia said. The Third Fathom landing, where the box-lift from the Fifth came up behind an iron grille that was locked at night. Dunmore in the cage with the boxes stacked round his feet like a man in a pantry. Always alone. He never let her go down.

"How did he open the grille?"

"Keys. He's got a ring. He keeps it in his desk in the Warden's antechamber, the left-hand drawer. He took it out in front of me the first time, showing me the route." Saskia frowned, remembering. "A big ring with a brass tag: *W.L.F. Duplicates*. Twenty keys, near enough. Grilles, stores, the Choir lockers. And one big ugly old one, black iron, longer than my hand, with a bird on the bow. A little bird sitting on a line." She drew it in the air. "I asked what that was for, as a joke. He said it was for the Hush, and nobody went there, and I should mind my barrow."

Hester and Teo looked at each other.

"The Hush key," said Teo. "On a duplicate ring. In a clerk's desk."

"Bureaucracy," said Saskia. "It's the same in Quell. The keys to the bishop's crypt are in the sacristan's tea-caddy."

"Did he ever speak about the Warden?" Hester said. "Did she ever come to the lift?"

"Never. I never saw her once." Saskia hesitated. "He said once, when I dropped a box on the landing, *Careful. The Warden says the Choir eats on this.* I thought it was a manner of speaking."

*The Warden.* Hester thought of a coil of grain turning left round a candle-flame, and of brass in the Fifth that was full before the Choir's pour reached it, and she kept her face exactly where it was.

"He'd use her name," she said. "He's her clerk. Mallory used the Exchequer's." It came out easily. She had said true things in that flat voice for twenty-one years; she had not known it would serve as well for the other kind. "It's Dunmore. He signs for the office. He has the seals and the keys and the lift. Dunmore's the one we watch."

Teo said nothing. He was looking at her with the expression he had sometimes in Fane's lection classes, when he had heard something under a tablet that nobody else in the room could hear and was deciding whether to say so.

"There's one more thing," Hester said, because it had to be asked. "Aske's note. It ends *Ask O.* Did Aske ever speak to you? About the boxes? About anything?"

Saskia stared at her. Then, for the first time that night, she laughed properly.

"*Orme?* You thought O was *Orme*?" She shook her head. "Vail. Corvin Aske didn't know I existed. I said good morning to him once on the Stair and he walked into the wall. He was reading a sample." She laughed again, less certainly. "I'm flattered. Nobody's suspected me of anything interesting since I was nineteen. So who's O.?"

"Somebody Aske meant to ask," said Hester. "Somebody who knows the Fifth."

"That's half the Choir."

"Then it's half the Choir," Hester said, and reached for the bottle, so that she had something to do with her hands.

* * *

So Hester told her the rest. Saskia had stood in the Cold House on Lantern Night and seen the beads. She had not seen what came after.

Hester told her about the casing in Cell 3-17 and the sheet in the blotter; Lucan's torn page, *per W.L.F.*; the Cistern, and the brass rods with Lattice marks sleeved in brine so still it made her eyes ache; the rod that had gone into the Proctory and not come out; Lucan's contract, signed by *E. Dunmore, clerk*, and what the letters stood for; and her brother's casing thin enough at the foot to see a candle through.

She did not tell her what Tib had said on the night they kept him, or what she had seen in the grain round a candle-flame. There were limits.

Saskia did not interrupt, though she made faces, and once she said, "*Lattice* marks? Then they were made here," and Hester said yes. When it was finished she sat looking into her empty cup.

"Who else knows?"

"Teo. Sorle. Lucan Ferrers."

"Ferrers went down a hole in Lowside with you?" Saskia looked as if she had bitten a lemon. "With his ribs? Against his own father's firm?"

"He's—" Hester stopped. She did not know how to describe Lucan Ferrers to someone who had last seen him standing a careful yard apart from them on the sea-wall. "He's not what he looks like."

"Nobody is. That's the whole trouble with people." Saskia set the cup on the ledge. "What do you want from me?"

"I don't know yet."

"Well, decide. I've a lehr to walk at the first bell." But she did not get up. She sat in her stockinged feet with her good boots on the floor beside her and looked out at the dark White. "I don't do causes, Vail. I told you so on Lantern Night. I do rent."

"I know."

"So understand me. I'm not doing this because I'm sorry." She said it to the window, evenly. "I am sorry. I'm sorry I carried that grain, and sorrier I didn't ask, and I'll be sorry for longer than you'll be angry, I expect. But that's not why. There are three hundred people kept in that ward, and some of them have daughters. And if somebody in the Warden's office is bleeding them to pay my two sols a run, then my daughter's school was bought with them. I'll not have that. I'll not

have her feet in their shoes." She turned from the window. "So. At cost. Whatever this is, I'll do it at cost."

"At cost," Hester said.

They did not shake hands. Teo poured the last of the Quell clear into the three tin cups, and they drank it without a toast, because nobody could think of one.

* * *

Lucan came the next night, because Teo sent for him.

He stood in the door of R-41 in his Upper Ward wool with the ochre cord of Vey's Bench on his shoulder and took in the cell: the two beds, the burnt tin, Saskia Orme cross-legged on Hester's blanket with a ledger, Hester at the window. His face went to the polished blank that meant he was thinking fast.

"Orme," he said.

"Ferrers."

"I was told there was a meeting."

"There's cake," said Teo. "Of a kind."

Lucan looked at the cake, and at Saskia, and at Hester, and she saw him understand that Saskia knew everything and that it had been Hester's choice. He did not argue it. He folded himself onto the floor by the door with his back to the wall, ribs still careful, and accepted a piece of black-bottomed saltcake from Teo with the gravity of a man accepting a treaty.

"Well," he said. "Here we are."

Hester stood at the window with her back to them and listened to the three of them start to talk, cautiously, then less so. Saskia asked Lucan about the contract seal; Lucan asked Saskia about the docket. Teo read Aske's sheet out again in his careful brine-script voice: *Cold House, fourteen weeping. A draw? Still runs to quick. Cistern?? Old lines. Ask O.* Then Lucan turned and asked what she made of the clerk, and Hester gave them Dunmore: the ring, the drawer, the lift, the docket hand. She said his name three times before the cake was finished. Each time, under it, like the low note under the Choir's work-song, she heard the other.

Her ledger lay open on the sill. Under the heading she had written in Russet, *Declaration of Interest*, she had crossed out *Orme* that afternoon with a single neat line. Below it she had written *E. Dunmore*, plainly, where anyone in the room could read it. The other name she had not written anywhere.

She looked at the page in the glow from Teo's cracked jar. Then she closed the ledger and sat down on the floor with the others, and took the last piece of cake before Lucan could, because he was nearer and slower and had cracked ribs, and somebody had to teach him.

CHAPTER 17

# *The Silent Supper*



*On the ninth of Cinder, at the Lantern Hour, the whole Halcyon shall be still for one minute, and the Settled shall be named.*

— Customs of the Collegium, as recorded by the Warden of the Stacks, 412 Y.E.

They gave out the chalk at the sixth bell.

It came up from the Bursary in wooden trays, one stick for every soul in the Halcyon who could hold one: Readers and Fellows and aspirants, porters and cooks, the delvers who worked the Halcyon's own pits under the Shelf, and the Proctors, who took theirs without expression and went to their places like men on parade. Hester's stick was new and square and left a powder on her fingers that tasted of nothing at all. Varrow chalk. Dead stone. Teo said it was the one place in the Halcyon where nobody wanted anything kept.

The Stair ran from the Crown to the Fifth Fathom in a single great spiral cut into the living salt, nine hundred years of feet worn into its treads, and its outer wall was written on the whole way down. Names, in columns, each with a year. Salt drew damp out of the air and damp drew the chalk out of the salt, so that by Rime the oldest names near the Crown were ghosts, legible only by a lantern held flat to the wall. On the ninth of Cinder they were all written again.

Every aspirant was given a stretch of wall and the Bursary's list for it, and told to write each name over its ghost exactly. Hester's stretch was on the Second Fathom, and it ran from 641 to 655 Y.E. *Odo Marchant, Choir, 641. Wenna Hale, Choir, 641. Brother Cole Ansty, Fathoming, 642.* She went down the column on her knees with her lantern on the step, and found she was writing in her best cus-

toms hand, the hand she used for seizure notes, as if somebody were going to check.

*Hesk Rowan, Choir, 649. Tobit Marr, Choir, 649.* There were a great many Choir. In some years the whole column was Choir.

Below her, round the curve, Teo was saying names under his breath as he wrote them, half to himself, as he said grace. Above her someone was crying quietly. She did not look up. That was the custom too.

When she had finished she sat back on her heels and looked at the column of fresh white letters on the pink salt. Then she went on down, because the Choir was to gather on the Fifth Fathom landing at the seventh bell, and she was Choir.

* * *

THE WARDEN OF THE LOWER FATHOMS WROTE HER OWN NAMES.

Hester came round the last turn of the Stair with Ama Tessaly and two others, and there at the foot, in the cold blue light of the Fathom lamps, was Orsolya Thane, kneeling on the bottom tread with a stick of chalk in her left hand.

These were the newest names. They had their own panel at the bottom of the Stair, a smooth stretch of salt the width of a door where the Fathom's own dead went. There were eleven, from the last five years. The Bursary's list lay folded on the step by Orsolya's knee, unopened. She did not need it. She wrote each name in big plain capitals, slowly, pressing hard, so that the chalk squeaked. Her hands were blue at the knuckles with cold, as they always were.

*IDRIS FELL, CHOIR, 898. MARRA COLE, CHOIR, 899. JONAH SAINT, CHOIR, 899.*

The Choir stood on the stairs above her and waited. Orsolya wrote all eleven. Then she sat back on her heels and looked at them, and put the chalk in her pocket, and stood up stiffly, one hand on the wall.

"Right, then," she said, in a perfectly ordinary voice. "Supper. Up you go. Mind the Stair, it's wet at the turn."

"She does that every year," Ama said softly. "Won't let anyone else. Says it's her hand put them there."

Hester looked at the eleven names in their white capitals as Orsolya went up the Stair ahead of them.

The capitals leaned, every one. A small steady lean to the left, as if drawn by a wrist that turned against itself.

She looked for exactly as long as a chorister might look at the names of the dead, and then she went up after the Warden, and said something to Ama about the cold.

* * *

There were six hundred people at the Long Table, and more standing.

Hester had eaten there every day for two months and had stopped seeing it. Tonight she saw it: three hundred feet of table down the centre of the great hall on the First Fathom, carved from the living salt nine centuries ago and worn by elbows until it shone. There were no dishes yet, only a tallow candle at every place. No grain lights. The Lantern Well, which on every other night of the year poured kept noon onto the table at the Lantern Hour, was dark. On the ninth of Cinder they kept no light. They burned it.

The Chancellor was at the head of the table.

Hester had seen her twice, at a distance. Perpetua Holm was seventy-eight and had been Chancellor for thirty-one years, and she was Settled further than anyone Hester had seen still upright. She sat in a high-backed chair of black Hask wood with a rug over her knees and her hands on its arms, white as the salt, and in the twenty minutes Hester watched her she did not visibly move them. Her eyes moved. Slowly, face by face, down the length of the table, as a lighthouse travels a coast. Beside her Vey sat upright and elegant in black, saying something now and then in her ear.

The Choir sat together at the foot, nearest the Stair-head. Hester was between Ama and a broad silent delver-born man called Pask. Three places down, Orsolya sat with her hands round a cup of halcyon tea, her face tired and calm. Further up, among the first-years, Hester could see Teo's grey Tider shawl and Saskia's dark head beside it, and, among the Upper Ward aspirants at Vey's end, the back of Lucan's.

"First time?" said Ama.

"Yes."

"Nothing to fear, lamb. It's only a minute." Ama was sixty-six, small and round-shouldered, with the sweet slow voice of the long Choir. She had wrapped Hester in a blanket after her first stay in Russet and had been wrapping her in things ever since: scarves, advice, slabs of Hask honey-cake from a tin in her

Choir locker. Her lips were blue, and when she laughed, which was often, it took her a long time to stop. "You hold if you can. Most of the Readers do. But with all of us together, lamb—" She made a bowl of her hands. "You'll feel it. It's like the Choir, only the whole house."

The Chancellor's bell rang.

It was a small handbell of old brass at Holm's elbow, and Vey lifted it, because her hand could not. The hall went silent in a wave from the head of the table down, a ripple of hush running three hundred feet along the salt like wind over grass. When it reached the Choir's end it stopped. Six hundred people sat at the Long Table and did not move.

* * *

Hester did not decide to hold. She found, after some seconds, that she was already doing it, as you find you have fallen asleep in a warm room.

Breath slow. Heart slow. Hands flat on the cold salt. It was the hold Crisp had drilled into her at the Pans, and she went into it as she had a hundred times since Russet, the coins coming down on her eyelids, the weight settling behind her face. Only this time she did not go in alone.

She felt the table first. It was one stone, the dome's own living grain, and six hundred hands lay on it. A good half of them belonged to people with the sense, and most of those were holding, or nearly. She felt them as she felt grain, through her palms, as weight. Here a Reader holding deep and steady, like a lead sinker in a pond. There a nervous first-year holding in little jerks. Three places down, someone holding so cold and so deep it was like a well: Orsolya. Beside her, Ama, soft and sure. And all of it running into the one stone, joining, a slow vast stillness spreading through the salt from six hundred places at once.

The candles stood up straight.

Before the Minute the flames had been leaning and fluttering in the draughts from the Lantern Well. Now, one by one down the whole length of the table, they stood up. They did not go out. They did not flicker. Six hundred small yellow spear-points burned in a line in the dark, so steady they looked painted, and the smoke rose from them in six hundred straight grey threads to the roof.

She could hear her own heart. Between one beat and the next there was time to count to four.

And under the stillness, in the stone, the sound.

It was the Roar, the thing she had first heard in the *Wren* grain and heard every Choir shift since: the long low rushing, the rise coming again before the fall had finished. She had never heard it in the Long Table. The dome's own grain was Shelf-depth, too shallow to hold more than a whisper. But with six hundred of them holding together, the whisper was there under her hands, a breath going in and out of the salt beneath the whole Halcyon. She thought, from a long way off, *it sounds like something asleep.*

Ama's hand found hers on the table and held it, cold and dry.

*Idris Fell*, Hester thought. *Marra Cole. Jonah Saint.* She had never met them. The names came up through the stillness like bubbles through brine. *Odo Marchant. Wenna Hale.* And somewhere behind her eyes, where the coins were, Tib's hand curled on his chest, holding its pencil.

Then the bell rang.

Not the Chancellor's handbell. The other one.

* * *

IT WAS IRON, AND IT CAME FROM BELOW.

Every Fathom had a bell in its Stair-head with a rope that ran down through the floors to the Fathom beneath. Hester had learned the rings her first week in the Choir. One and one was a summons. Two and two was fire. Three and three, iron on iron, hard and fast, meant a pocket had broken.

*Clang-clang-clang.* A breath. *Clang-clang-clang.*

The Minute broke like a plate.

Hester came out of the hold too fast and felt the world tilt and right itself. The candles were leaning again, all six hundred, thrown sideways at once by six hundred people moving. Near the head of the table a chair went over backward with a crack like a shot. A first-year girl was saying "What is it, what is it?" to nobody. And at the Choir's end, before Hester had her breath, Orsolya Thane was on her feet.

"Choir," she said.

She did not shout. Her voice went down the table like a hand laid flat on it, and the Choir rose: sixty people in grey wool rising in one movement out of six hundred, like a flight of salt-larks off a pan. Ama's hand pulled out of Hester's, and Ama was up, and Pask, and Hester with them before she had thought about it at all.

"Pask, the stay-lines from the Fourth store, all of them. Ama, the trunk valves. Edwin—" Dunmore was at Orsolya's elbow from nowhere, ink on his cuffs. "Edwin, the Proctors. Clear the Fourth east gallery. Everyone out who isn't Choir." Her eyes found the rest of them. "With me. Run if you can. Don't if you can't. Down."

In the one glance Hester gave back before the Stair took her, the Chancellor sat in her black chair with her white hands on its arms and did not move. Her eyes followed them to the Stair-head, the lighthouse look, travelling the coast. Then the curve of the wall cut it off.

* * *

They went down the Stair in a grey river, past the fresh white names.

The Fourth Fathom held the Quiet Rooms and the Choir hall and, to the east, the long gallery where the Brinestacks kept their overflow: records too bulky or too damaged for the shelves above, much of it salvage from the old fire, in iron cases floor to ceiling. It had always been cold, dry and silent.

It was not silent now. The sound came up the passage to meet them as they ran, a sound the Halcyon did not make: a rushing, and a slapping, and under it a long hollow boom that came and went, so that the floor gave a small shiver each time it came.

"Tide take it," said Pask, beside her, quietly. He was a delver's son. He had heard the White crack under him before.

Then they were through the door, and Hester saw water.

It was running across the floor of the east gallery, a sheet of it an inch deep, black in the lamplight, carrying scraps of paper on it like leaves on a stream. Fifty yards down, the gallery's end wall was wet from floor to ceiling, shining like a cliff in rain. Out of a crack at about the height of a man's shoulder, water was coming in a thick clear rope. Every few breaths the rope swelled and spat, and that was the boom: a deep thump from inside the wall, and a gush.

The smell hit her a second after the sight. It was cold, and green, and strong, a smell she had met only once, faintly, in the warm wet salt of her first stay. It was like the Weeps at low water in summer, but cleaner, and brighter, and enormously more. It was the smell of a great many things growing in water.

"Sweet sea," someone whispered.

The water came over Hester's shoes, bitterly cold, the cold of deep winter. She bent and put two fingers in it and put them to her mouth before she had decided to.

Salt, but not grain, not brine that anyone had mixed. It tasted as the *Wren* grain had tasted under her tongue at the Customs House: bright, metallic, startled. And there was something living in it, green and faintly of iodine. It tasted of the cry she had heard in that cargo, if a cry could have a taste. It tasted *quick.*

"Vail!" Orsolya's voice. "Line. *Now.*"

* * *

The stay went up in four minutes. Hester did not see most of it, because she was part of it.

Pask and the others came at a run with the stay-lines, long hoses of oiled leather sleeved in brass, coiled on their shoulders like rope. They ran them from the trunk valves at the gallery door, where Ama knelt with a spanner opening the cocks, out across the flooded floor to the wet wall. The Choir followed them in and formed. Hester had done it a dozen times in drills on the dry Choir floor, never in water with the boom in the walls. It made no difference. The Choir knew its own shape: sixty in a long curved line facing the wall, each with a hand on the shoulder of the one before, each line-leader with a stay-line clamped to his belt and its brass mouth pressed to the weeping salt.

Live brine came rushing down the leather from the trunk. Every chorister put a pinch of Middling under the tongue, as they always did, to tune, and went in.

And Orsolya sang.

It was a note, low and long, held for a full breath, then let go, then held again, and every voice in the line took it and held it with her. The note was a rope you could all hold at once. Your breath went out on it as slowly as hers did, and your heart came down to meet your breath, and sixty holds became one hold, poured down the stay-lines into the wet salt.

*Hold the line,* Orsolya sang. *Hold the line.*

*So the others can sleep,* the Choir answered.

The stillness went out of Hester through her hands and the soles of her feet in the cold water, down through Pask's shoulder under her palm and into the brass and the wall. She felt the wall take it. A quickening was a hungry thing; that was

the first thing they taught you in the Choir. The boom came again, weaker, and the rope of water thinned and shuddered.

She was deep now. The coins had become a weight on her whole face, and the cold of the water had stopped being cold and become simply a fact, like the dark. She was listening, as she had learned to, to the line itself: the long brass trunk running from the valve at the door away into the Halcyon's walls, to the stores, to the Fifth, to wherever stays drew from.

Something was coming up it, from behind her. From the east.

She had felt this before. In Fallow, on the night shift after the candle-flame, with her palms on the brass in the Fifth: something cold and old already in the line before the Choir's pour reached it. You could not taste through your hands. She had stood in the line every shift since, waiting for a mouthful.

It came now in a flood. Not the Choir's stillness, which she knew after six weeks as she knew her own breath: sixty human holds, warm at the edges, a little ragged, smelling of wool and fear. This was colder than any hold she had ever felt, and perfectly smooth, the stillness of something that had not moved in years and years. It came up the trunk and into the wall like a tide of cold oil. Under its weight the quickening's boom faltered, and went *tick*, and *tick*.

The stay-line at Pask's belt bucked with the load. Where its brass mouth met the wall it spat, a short hard jet, and brine struck Hester across the cheek and the mouth.

The Middling under her tongue was long gone. What was on her lips was the line itself.

She knew it at once, as she knew the reference jars on her old bench. She had tasted it in Fallow, on her knees in the founders' brick under Coldwater Street with Lucan's lantern shaking, a fingertip of brine from the sleeve round a brass rod. *This is them.* She had smelled it for eleven years in the cold sweet air of the charity ward, standing by casing two hundred and eleven. It was the stillness of the Cold House, the stillest thing in the world, because old keepings were.

It was Tib.

It was coming up the stay-line past her and pouring into the wall, and the wall was drinking it, and the stay was holding.

*Hold the line,* Orsolya sang.

Hester held. She did not know what else to do. Her hand was on Pask's shoulder and her brother was on her lips and going past her through the brass a

yard away, into the Warden's stay, under the Warden's song. She held, and the Choir held, and the rope of water thinned to a trickle and then to a weep and then to nothing. The black sheet on the floor slowed and began, at its edges, to frost into salt.

* * *

The hold broke in a long ragged ending, the Choir coming out of it one by one like people waking in a cold room. Somebody coughed. Somebody was sick into the water. The lag took Hester for a moment, the world going grey and soundless, and then let her go. She was standing in water iced to the ankle with her hand still on Pask's shoulder, and her teeth were chattering so hard she could hear them.

"Down," Pask was saying. "Down, down. Ama, love. Ama."

Ama was sitting in the water.

She was sitting where she had stood, at Hester's left, in the line. She had folded down so gently that Hester had not felt her go: knees bent, back straight, hands open on her lap. The water had frozen to salt around her skirt and her shoes. Her eyes were half open. Hester bent beside her in the ice, and heard, faintly, the note.

She was still singing. Not aloud; the breath of it. The long low Choir note was going out of her on a breath that did not end, the hold still in her, held past the place where it could be let go.

"Ama," Hester said.

The note went on. Then it was quieter. Then it was a breath. Then it was not anything.

Hester put her fingers to the old woman's throat, as her mother had taught her when she was ten, and felt for the beat. It was there, a long way off. One. She counted to twenty. She counted to forty. It did not come again.

"She held too long," Pask said above her, roughly. "She always held too long. Every stay, a breath past the rest of us, the old fool. She said someone ought to be last out." He knelt in the water on Ama's other side. "Oh, you old fool."

Feet in the slush. A lantern. Hester knelt with two fingers on Ama Tessaly's throat and did not let herself think it. She did not take her fingers away, because taking them away would make it a fact.

Then Orsolya was there.

She came through the Choir, which parted for her, and looked down at Ama sitting in the frozen water with her hands open, and her face did not change at all. She went down on her knees in the ice and took Ama's face between her two cold hands, carefully, as you might take a bowl of something hot.

"Ama," she said. "Oh, my girl. Oh, my girl."

And then she wept.

Hester had seen people cry in the Cold House every first of the month for eleven years. This was not like that. Orsolya knelt in the frozen sea with her friend's face in her hands and wept without a sound, without bending. The tears whitened as they ran. By the time they reached her jaw they were salt, little ridged crusts on her skin, the long Settle showing in her as it showed in all of them. She did not wipe them. Somewhere far behind the wall there was a sound like the sea turning over in its sleep.

"Twelve," Orsolya said at last. To nobody. To Ama. "That's twelve."

She looked up. Her eyes found Hester's across Ama's bowed head, a foot away, wet and grey and tired beyond anything Hester had words for. Hester looked in them for guilt, because she had been looking for it since Fallow. There was none, and no fear, and no calculation. Only grief, and under it something that might have been love, for the whole cold shivering line of them standing in the dark.

"Help me get her up, chick," Orsolya said. "She'll not want to be sat in the wet."

* * *

They carried her down on a Choir blanket, Pask and Orsolya and Hester and three others, past the fresh white names. At the Fifth Fathom landing they laid her at the foot of the panel where Orsolya had written the eleven, and Orsolya stood looking at it.

Hester did not stay. She went back up the Stair alone, round and round, past the Fourth and the Third, to her own stretch on the Second Fathom: Odo Marchant and Wenna Hale and Brother Cole Ansty in her best seizure hand. Below the last of them was a smooth blank stretch of pink salt above the step. Nobody would mind, she thought. Nobody would look.

She took the chalk out of her pocket and wrote, in capitals, pressing hard so that it squeaked:

*AMA TESSALY, CHOIR, 903.*

Then she sat on the step under it with chalk on her fingers and the Cold House still on her lips.

She did not suspect any longer. She knew. The Warden's stays drank the sleepers. Not Dunmore's: the Warden's, sung down by the Warden's voice and held by the Warden's line, and Hester had laid her hands on that brass every shift since Russet and poured herself in beside her brother, and been paid three sols a week for it, and sent the three sols to the Cold House to keep him in the casing they were drinking. She thought of the eleven names at the foot of the Stair, leaning a little to the left. She thought of Orsolya on her knees in the ice with Ama's face in her hands, and could not make the two women into one, and could not make them into two. She thought of Orsolya's voice in the dark, *so the others can sleep*, and of Orsolya in Russet, in the warm office, saying tiredly, as if it were a small mercy: *The Stays have been kind this season. Kinder than they've any right to be.*

She licked her lips, and tasted it again, and sat there until the first bell.

CHAPTER 18

# *The Fourth Sleeper*



*Signature of next of kin. Relationship to the kept. Date. The house accepts no responsibility for what returns.*

— Form of Release, Ambry Charitable Brinery

Agathe's letter came up the Causeway on the sixteenth of Cinder with the afternoon post, in a cheap grey envelope with the Cold House's name printed on the flap. Hester's name was on the front in a round careful hand that had been taught its letters by Tider sisters sixty years ago and had never seen a reason to change them.

*My dear. Bett Linnow is coming back. The casing has cracked at the foot and the brinewright says there is no more to be done and Mr. Pell is at his sister's. Her mother is here. She asks for someone who understands the salt. I do not, not as you do. If you can come, come. A.L.*

Hester read it standing in the Rookery passage. Then she put on her coat and went.

It had been raining on the Rim for two days, the short hard rain of Cinder that came over the Varrow and fell on Ambry and never reached the White. The Causeway was black and shining, and on either side of it the salt was bone-dry, as if the rain had come to a wall. She walked the two miles fast, with her collar up and her hands in her armpits, and was at the Cold House by the ninth bell.

Nobody was at the desk. The great ledger lay open on the felt with a pen across it. She went past it and through the double doors and down the six worn steps. On the third step she smelled it: not the cold sweet cellar smell of the charity ward, but something warm. Warm, and sharp, and faintly like hot iron.

* * *

Bett Linnow's plinth was the third from the end of the sixth row.

Agathe had shown it to her on Lantern Night. Before that Hester had passed it a hundred and thirty times on the first of the month without looking: a stout woman of about thirty in a brown dress, kept on her side with her knees drawn up and both hands pressed to her mouth, as if she had coughed and been surprised by it. From the aisle she had looked asleep. Most of them did.

She did not look asleep now. Agathe had hung a lantern above the plinth and the casing in its light was not clear any more. It was white. Not the grey of the dead, but a fine white crazing, like ice on a puddle when you put your heel on it, spreading from a crack at the casing's foot as long as Hester's hand. Brine was running out of the crack in a steady thread. The thread did not drip onto the floor. It ran sideways along the plinth's edge and down the eastern side and into the drain-grille beneath, as if it had somewhere to be.

The casing was warm. She could feel it from a yard away, like a stove going out. The arrears were coming.

An old woman sat on a stool beside the plinth with both her hands flat on the stone, as close to the casing as the stone allowed. She was small and upright, in a black wool coat that had been good once and a black bonnet. Agathe stood behind her with a hand on her shoulder.

"Ruth," Agathe said. "This is Hester. Tobias Vail's sister, from the fourth row. She's at the Halcyon now. She understands the salt."

The old woman looked up. Her eyes were pale and wet and enormously tired.

"Can you stop it?" she said.

* * *

Hester tried.

She knew before she began that she could not. She tried anyway, because the old woman had asked, and because it was the only thing in the world she knew how to do.

The house kept its recasting brine in a copper tank in the brinewright's closet, Middling grain dissolved in water, to be worked within the hour. Agathe drew a

jugful. It was not good brine, and not fresh, and Hester was not licensed, and there was no Reader in the building to say so. She knelt by the cracked foot of the casing, poured a thin line of brine along the crack, and went into the hold.

To recast you had to find the hand that had made the casing and lay your own stillness along it, as a mason lays a new course of brick on an old wall. Bett Linnow's casing had been made twenty years ago by some Cold House brinewright long dead. Its hand was coarse and quick, a charity hand. Hester found it with her eyes shut and her palms flat on the crazed white salt, the warmth coming up through them. She laid herself along it, and held, and felt the fresh brine begin to take.

Then she felt it go.

It went east. As soon as the new stillness was in the crack it was moving, not down but sideways, along the brine-thread, into the drain, under the floor, away. She held harder. It went faster. She was pouring into a sieve. Under her hands the crack widened with a sound like a fingernail drawn across slate.

"No," Hester said aloud. "No, no, come on."

"My dear." Agathe's hand was on her shoulder, harder than Hester had known it could be. "Leave it now. You'll lag."

She left it. She sat back on her heels with her hands burning cold. The crack was longer than it had been. The white was spreading up the casing toward Bett Linnow's hands.

"I'm sorry," she said to Ruth Linnow. "It's being drawn. Something's pulling it out faster than I can put it in."

The old woman nodded slowly, as if this were what she had expected.

"Then sit with me," she said. "Please. Until."

* * *

Bett Linnow had been a laundress at the Glassmarket. Her mother told it while they waited, in a low steady voice, to the casing and not to Hester, as if Bett could hear.

On the twelfth of Rime in 883 a brewer's dray had come down Glass Street too fast on the ice, and its near-side wheel had gone over Bett where she had slipped at the kerb with her basket. She had been thirty-one, with a husband who drank and a boy of four. The dispensary physician said she was bleeding inside and would not see the morning, and the Cold House had a bed. Ruth had signed. Bett's hus-

band had been at the Anchor and could not be found until the next day. By then it was done.

"He's dead now," Ruth said. "Ten years. The boy's twenty-four, a cooper in Harl. He comes on her birthday. He doesn't remember her, only from me telling." She looked at the casing. "I've paid twenty years. I sold the house in Glass Street to pay. I live in one room over the chandler's. I told myself, Ruth, they'll find a way. They'll mend the inside of a person, and then I'll take her home." She smiled. It was a terrible thing to see. "I'm seventy-nine. I thought I'd see it."

Hester said nothing. There was nothing in her mouth to say.

"Do you think she knows?" Ruth said. "That it's been twenty years?"

"No. It's no time at all, for her. It's the same moment."

"Then she'll not know me."

The casing cracked.

It was not loud. It was a sound like river ice going in Thaw, a deep flat crack that Hester felt in her teeth. The white crazing ran over the whole casing at once, top to bottom. Then the warmth came off the plinth in a wave, the arrears of twenty years, a dry hard heat like opening an oven. The lantern on its hook swung. The casing fell in.

It did not shatter. It slumped, as a snow-figure slumps in sun, all at once. The salt lost its hold and became hot brine, pouring off the plinth on every side and steaming on the cold floor. Inside it, Bett Linnow moved.

She drew in breath, a great dragging gasp, the second half of a breath begun twenty years before in the gutter of Glass Street. And she screamed.

It was the scream she had been screaming when they kept her. Hester understood that a moment after she heard it. It was not a new scream; it was the rest of an old one. It went up and broke. Bett's body arched on the stone. Her hands came away from her mouth dark and wet and there was blood on the plinth, a great deal of it, running into the hot brine and turning it pink.

"The wheel," Bett Linnow said. "Mam. The *wheel*—"

"I'm here," said Ruth. "I'm here, my lamb."

Bett's eyes opened. They went round the ward, the high windows, the lantern, the rows of glittering casings, and understood none of it. Then they found the small old woman in the black bonnet bending over her, with a face like a dried apple. Hester saw them look.

"Mam?" said Bett Linnow, uncertainly. Not as if she knew. As if she were asking.

"Yes," said Ruth. "Yes, my lamb. It's me."

Bett frowned. It was a young woman's frown, puzzled, a little cross. She opened her mouth to say something else. Then her eyes went past her mother's face to the window, and stopped there, and the frown went out of them, and so did everything else.

It took perhaps three minutes from the crack. Hester counted afterward. Three minutes, for twenty years.

* * *

Agathe did what had to be done. She had done it before. Hester helped her because her hands needed something to do. They washed Bett Linnow in the warm pink brine, and closed her eyes, and laid her straight under a grey Cold House sheet. Ruth sat on her stool and held her daughter's hand through the sheet and did not cry. When the porters came with the long basket she walked beside it to the door without looking back. At the foot of the six steps she turned and said to Hester, in a perfectly clear voice, "Thank you for sitting with me." Then she went up, a step at a time, holding the rail.

Hester stood in the aisle. After a while she went to the fourth row, and under the third window, in the dark, found casing two hundred and eleven by memory.

Agathe hung the lantern over Tib's plinth without being asked and stood back.

The beads were still there, more of them than in Russet, and fatter, running in their lines toward the eastern foot and joining into runnels. At the foot itself, where the casing curved down over his heels and his rough boy's boots, the salt had gone thin. A month ago it had been a full two inches of clear grain. Now, at the very heel, it was perhaps half that. She could see the leather of his boot more sharply than she had ever seen anything of him through the salt. She could see a thread hanging loose from the stitching, a thread their mother would have snipped.

It was still clear. It was not crazed. It was not white.

"How long?" Hester said.

Agathe looked at the heel for some time. She was seventy and had walked these rows twice a day since before the Great Bloom, and Hester had never heard her say anything she did not believe.

"Weeks, my dear," Agathe said. "Not months." She hesitated. "I'll write. Every day, if you want."

"Every day."

Tib lay with his head turned a little to the window, his eyes half open, the pink of the bloom high on his cheeks. Hester looked at the pink, as she always did.

"Do you know what it is?" she said. "The bloom. Where it comes from."

"Nobody knows that." Agathe drew her shawl round her. "It's an old sickness. Older than the Ebb, they say. The old ballads have it. The sea-cough, they call it there. *She coughed the sea-cough and she went down to the water.* My grandmother used to sing that one." She looked at Tib. "It was in the world before the salt was. That's what the Order says. It came with the sea and it stayed when the sea went, like the tide-marks on the harbour wall."

"The sea-cough," Hester said.

"It's only a song, my dear."

* * *

She did not go to her father that night, or the next. She went back over the Causeway and did a Choir shift with her hands on the brass, knowing what ran in it, and the taste of hot iron still at the back of her throat. Agathe's first letter came on the seventeenth: *No change. A.L.* On the eighteenth Hester went down to the harbour and found her father at the Drowned Man.

It was the tavern he drank in when he did not want to be found in Lowside. It had a bowed ceiling and a fire that smoked, and over the bar the bowsprit of a real sea-ship, black with age, carved with a woman's face worn to a smooth knot. Aldous sat under it on a bench by the wall with a pot of Harl cider between his burned hands. He looked up when she came in. He saw her face and put the pot down.

She sat across from him and told him about Bett Linnow, plainly, in order. The crack, and the heat, and the scream, and *Mam?*, and the three minutes. Then she told him about Tib's heel.

He listened without moving. When she had finished he drank the whole pot, slowly, and put it down.

"Weeks," he said.

"Agathe says."

"Agathe's right, generally." He turned the empty pot on the table. "I'll go up tomorrow."

She did not understand him at first. Then she did.

"No," she said.

"I'll go up tomorrow and I'll sign the paper. Release. I'm his father, Hes. I'm next of kin before you, in law. I let you sign the first one because I was drunk and you were twenty-two and I hadn't the stomach. I've the stomach now." His eyes were small and red and steady. "I'll not have him come back like that lass. Screaming. In the dark. With nobody he knows."

"He'll come back with me."

"He'll come back with a woman of thirty-three he's never seen. He'll come back in the last hour of the bloom with his lungs full and he'll die in three minutes, *like that lass*, and that'll be the last thing he sees. If they do it now, quiet, with a physician and a draught—"

"They can't do it quiet. Nobody can. The arrears—"

"Then they'll do it loud. But they'll do it *for him*." His voice had come up. People at the bar were looking round. He did not lower it. "Not because a crack ran up the side. Not because you couldn't make the fee. Because it's time, and it's been time for eleven years, and somebody in this family's got to say so."

"He's *alive*, Da."

"He's kept."

"He's alive in law. His casing's clear. If they find a cure—"

"Who's they?" Aldous put both his burned hands flat on the table. "Who's *they*, Hes? You've been at the Halcyon two months. Have they a cure? Have they so much as looked for one? Or are they too busy keeping their lamps lit?"

She had no answer to that. She did not try to find one.

"I'll not let you," she said.

"It's my name on the form."

"I'll stop you."

"How?"

She did not know. She sat across from him in the smoke with her hands clenched in her lap and could think of nothing. Not law, not money, not a single argument that would stand up in the Drowned Man under the black bowsprit with its worn-away face. All she had was *no*, and she said it again. Her father looked at her across the table for a long time. Then he said the thing.

He said it quietly. He was not a cruel man and he did not say it cruelly. He said it as if he had been carrying it a long way and had finally set it down.

"You didn't keep him for him," Aldous said. "You kept him for you."

She stood up.

She did not remember deciding to. She was simply standing, and her bench was over on the floor behind her, and the whole Drowned Man had gone quiet. She could not see her father's face clearly, and did not know why until she understood that her eyes were full. She felt the tears come over her lids and run down, and felt them, as they ran, go stiff and gritty on her cheeks. *Salt.* Eight weeks in the Choir. It was starting already.

"Hes," her father said, differently.

She went out.

* * *

She did not remember the Causeway. She remembered the brass Line in the Gatehouse floor, and stepping over it in the dark, and the Stair, and the door of R-41, and Teo looking up from his bed in his Tider shawl with a book in his lap and the cracked kept-light jar glowing on the sill.

He took one look at her and put the book down.

She sat on her own bed. She told him about Bett Linnow, and Tib's heel, and the Drowned Man, and what her father had said. Teo listened, as he always listened, without moving and without helping. When she stopped he said nothing for a while. The jar on the sill made its faint summer sound, a hum like bees, the ghost of a July noon.

"Was he right?" Teo said.

"I don't know."

"Yes, you do."

She looked at him. He was not being unkind. He had the face he had in Fane's classes when he heard something under the Roar and had decided, this time, to say so.

"You told me about the night he was kept," he said. "In Russet, the night we read Aske's sheet. The fever, and your father, and the desk. You told it well. But there was a place in the middle where you went round something. I could hear it. Like a step missing on a stair."

The jar hummed. Out on the White the tiles ticked in the cold.

"He said *let me sleep*," Hester said. She heard her voice from a long way off, flat and exact. "He opened his eyes and he looked at me and he knew me. He was quite clear. He said, *Let me sleep, Hes. Just let me sleep.* And he said, *I'm so tired.* And he said, *Don't make me do it any more.*" She stopped. "He meant breathing. He'd been fighting to breathe for three weeks. He didn't mean sleep. He meant let him die. He knew it. I knew it when he said it. I knew it all the way down Coldwater Street."

Teo did not say anything.

"And I went to the desk," Hester said, "and I signed. Because I was twenty-two and I'd buried Mam and I wasn't going to bury him. Because it was there and it was six sols a month and I could keep him. So I did. And for eleven years I've told everyone, I've told myself, that keeping's sleep. That I did what he asked." The salt was stiff on her cheeks. She did not touch it. "He asked me to let him go and I kept him. That's what I did. That's all I've ever done."

She had not said it aloud before. Not to Agathe. Not to Daisy. Not to her father, who had heard it from the stair and known. Not even to herself, alone in the room in Tanner's Row with the landships on the walls. Saying it now was like returning a keeping. Something came out of her with a crack and a heat, and left a space behind it that had been full for eleven years.

Teo was quiet for a long time.

He did not say *it's all right.* He did not say *you did your best.* She had known he would not, and she had told him for that reason. He had sat nine years in the confessional at Tidewater Abbey and he did not give absolution lightly; she suspected he did not believe he had any to give. He got up and came and sat beside her on her bed, close, his shoulder against hers. The cold of him came through his shawl. He was always cold, like all of them.

"Then you've been keeping two people, Hes," he said.

It was the first time he had called her that. She heard him choose it.

"Him," Teo said. "And the girl who signed. Eleven years. Both of them. Exactly as they were." He did not look at her. He looked at the jar on the sill. "That's a great deal of stillness for one person to hold."

She did not answer. After a while she put her head down on his shoulder, on the rough grey wool of the Tider shawl, and he let her, and neither of them said anything else. The jar hummed out its old July. Outside on the White the cold came down and the tiles ticked, ticked, ticked.

* * *

She did not sleep. In the small hours she got up and dressed and went out, and Teo did not wake.

She went down the Stair, past the Second Fathom and Ama Tessaly's name in her own hand, past the Fourth, where the east gallery was boarded off with fresh planks and a Proctor's notice and smelled, still, faintly green. Down to the Fifth.

Every stay down here was fed from the Cold House, and every one of them was Orsolya's. Hester could go over Gage's head to the Assize, as Sorle had said. If they believed her, they would cut the line, and the Cold House would keep its own again. And the stays would starve. Nine days ago she had watched one quickening come through a wall with sixty of them holding and the Cold House pouring in behind. Take the Cold House away and the Fourth was the whole Halcyon: three thousand people, and whatever the salt had stopped in the middle of. To save her brother she had to name Orsolya, and naming Orsolya would drown the house. She could not find the third thing. She went on down looking for it.

Her Choir pass took her through the grille at the landing. The Fathom lamps were turned low and blue, and somewhere far off a skeleton watch of four choristers was holding the night stays in a slow murmur. She kept away from them. She went along the inner gallery to the Choir store: a long low room cut into the salt, with shelves of oiled stay-lines and racks of brass fittings and barrels of Middling for tuning. And behind a cage of iron wire at the back, the residue.

She had seen it on every shift and never looked at it. The warm wet Hush-grade crust the Choir scraped off the stays after a quickening was held, packed into sealed boxes to be carried up the lift. A dozen of them stood stacked inside the cage, numbered in chalk, waiting for a clerk with ink on his cuffs. The cage was padlocked. The wire was old. On one box near the front the lid had been knocked askew in the stacking, and through the gap, in the blue lamplight, she

could see grain: white, faintly blue, sharp-cornered. She could feel the warmth of it through the wire.

If she could not stop the draw, she could outrun it. Hush grain kept anything clear, almost at once. A handful in fresh brine, laid along the heel of casing two hundred and eleven, would close that thinning in a single hold, better than any recast. Nobody counted residue by the handful. Nobody would know.

She put her fingers through the wire.

The gap between the box and the cage was a hand's width. She could reach the grain. It was warm, a warm-stone warmth, and the taste of it came up her arm into her mouth before it ever reached her tongue, the vast bright startled weight of it. *Quick*. Her fingers closed on a little of it. Enough, perhaps. She stood in the cold blue dark with her arm through the cage to the wrist and her fist full of felony salt.

*Kept beyond return.*

The Physic's voice, in Cell 3-17, over Aske's reaching arm. *You'd never get the arrears out of Hush grain without killing him.*

She would mend his heel, and she would be laying along the foot of her brother a stillness no one alive knew how to give back. She would never be able to let him go. Not for a cure. Not for her father. Not if Tib himself sat up in his casing and asked her. She would have made sure of it.

And some part of her—she felt it quite clearly, standing in the cold with her fist in the cage—*wanted that*. It wanted it more than it had ever wanted anything. To have him kept so well that no one could ever take him, not the draw, not the arrears, not her father with his paper, not the boy himself.

*You didn't keep him for him.*

She opened her hand.

The grain fell back into the box with a small dry hiss, like sand. She drew her arm out of the cage. Then she stood in the Choir store with her hands at her sides and found that she was shaking from head to foot, as she had shaken in the ice of the east gallery. Not from cold. From the lag of something she had nearly done.

The four night choristers murmured on somewhere in the blue dark, holding the line.

She went up as far as the Rookery well-room and no further. The pump-handle was furred with frost. She worked it until the water came, and held her

hands under it, and washed the salt-dust off her fingers, front and back and between, and under the nails, slowly, until there was nothing left on them at all.

CHAPTER 19

# *The Notebook*



*The archive is a keeping like any other, and like any other it is owed.*

— Wynn Callow, Under-Archivist, the only sentence he is known to have published (Proceedings of the Brinestacks, 851 Y.E.)

Agathe wrote every day, as she had promised. Most of the letters were a line long. *No change. A.L.* The one dated the nineteenth of Cinder was longer, and Hester read it standing at the post-tray in the Gatehouse with her back to the room.

*My dear. Your father came to the desk this afternoon. He asked Ennis for the form and he gave it him. He sat with the pen in his hand for as long as it takes to say the Ebb-prayer twice through. Then he put the pen down and went out. He did not sign. He did not come down to the ward. I thought you would want to know it from me. Tib is as he was. A.L.*

She folded it along its creases and put it in her pocket with the others. She did not go to the Pans. She thought of her father's burned hands round a pen, holding it the way he held a rake, and could not think about it for long.

* * *

Wynn Callow had been sitting at his desk in the Brinestacks for longer than most of the Readers had been alive.

He sat at the foot of the Second Fathom's main stair, behind a desk of black oak worn pale where his forearms rested: a small man in a grey gown so old the wool had gone the colour of ash, his white hair standing out a little from his skull

like a dandelion's. His hands lay on the desk one over the other and did not move. He had the Settle so deep in him that he breathed perhaps four times a minute, and an aspirant could stand at the desk asking for a catalogue number for a full minute before deciding there was nobody there. Hester had decided exactly that on her first day. Teo said everyone did.

*Corvin sat there too.* He had said it to them in Russet as they were leaving, out of nowhere, and then, *There. On the first of the month.* The only words she had ever heard him speak. She had taken them for an old man's remark about a dead colleague. They came back to her the night after Bett Linnow died, lying awake in R-41. *Sat there.* Not *read there.* Sat, as you sit at someone's elbow when you want something from them and know it will take time.

She wanted proof. She had had a name in her since Fallow, since a candle flame in the Warden's Gallery, and she had said *Dunmore* aloud to Teo for a month while she thought it. A name was not proof. Aske had been taking his proofs somewhere.

So on the twenty-fifth of Cinder, at the fifth bell, when she should have been in the Black Bench taking down Sorle's lecture on the decay curves of kept light, she took a stool from the reading room, set it at the end of Callow's desk, and sat down.

He did not look at her. She had not expected him to.

"Under-Archivist," she said. "I'm Hester Vail. Reader Aske's privilege. Reader Sorle's Bench, now." She waited. "You said Corvin sat here too."

Nothing. Two second-years went up the stair behind her arguing about the Assay. The lamp on Callow's desk was an old kept-light lamp, its glass yellowed, giving off the faint unchanging warmth of a summer afternoon that had been over for decades.

She folded her hands in her lap and let her breathing slow, not into the hold, only toward it.

After a time Callow's eyes moved. They came round from the middle distance to the corner of the desk, where her hands were, and rested there.

The sixth bell rang somewhere above. Faint through the salt she heard the Long Table being laid for the Lantern Hour. Her left foot went to sleep. She did not move it.

"He brought," said Callow.

His voice was dry and soft and astonishingly clear, like paper being unfolded. Then it stopped. She counted, and got to forty.

"Something back."

"Back where?"

Fifty. Sixty. Somebody laughed in the reading room and was shushed.

"Where it was not," said Callow, "to be looked for."

"Where's that?"

He did not answer for so long that she thought he had gone. Then, with a deliberation she would not have believed of a living man, Wynn Callow stood up.

It took him nearly a quarter of an hour. Callow did not so much stand as unfold, a joint at a time, each movement starting so slowly that she only knew it had happened because his shoulder was higher than it had been. She did not help him. It would have been like helping a glacier. Then he drew a key on a black string out of the breast of his gown, a long brass key with a halcyon on its bow, and held it in his palm.

"Where the founders," he said, "sleep."

* * *

The Founders' Gallery was at the far end of the Second Fathom, through a door of lattice-grown salt with a brass grille in it and a sign: RESTRICTED. BY LEAVE OF THE WARDEN OF THE STACKS. It took Callow twenty minutes to walk there. Aspirants coming the other way stopped and stared, and stopped again at the corners to look back.

The key turned with a sound like a cough.

Inside was cold and dry and dark. Hester found a kept-light lantern on a hook by the door and dissolved its cake, and a spring morning came up yellow-white around them and showed her a long vaulted room lined to the roof with drawers: thousands of them, small and shallow, in black wood, each with a label in faded copperplate.

*230 Y.E. — Fire-salvage — Founders' Tablets — I.*

On and on along the wall, into the dark, drawers of salt tablets burnt black and slumped like candle-wax.

Callow had already started down the gallery, trailing his fingertips along the drawer-fronts. At XIV he stopped. Then his hand came up, a fraction at a time, toward the brass pull.

"I'll do it," she said.

He took his hand away.

The drawer was full of char, like the others. She pulled harder and it came out of its runners altogether, heavier than she expected, and she set it on the floor. Behind it, where the back of the drawer should have met the back of the cabinet, there was a gap of perhaps four inches. Wedged upright in the gap was a bundle in brown oilcloth tied with tarred string.

It was the size and weight of three thick books. Something small and hard shifted inside it. She sat back on her heels and untied the string.

Two marbled stationer's notebooks of the kind the Glassmarket sold for four flecks, their pages swollen from use; and the black leather one from his table, with a stub of torn stitching near the back where a leaf was gone. Ink showed through in black and blue in a small fast sloping hand. Tucked between them was a horn case no bigger than a thumb. She knew it before she opened it. Inside, on green baize, lay a tasting spoon of fine white metal, finer than any on her old rack at the Customs House.

*May I?*

She closed the case, and had to sit a while.

When she looked up, Callow was watching her. Not the middle distance: her. It might have been grief in his pale eyes, or satisfaction, held still so long they had become the same thing.

"He said," Callow said, "if anyone came."

She waited.

"Who sat."

* * *

Teo did not go to bed that night. Neither did she.

They sat in R-41 with the door wedged shut and the candle on the floor between them and the three notebooks open on Teo's blanket. Teo had his Tider shawl round his shoulders, a pencil behind his ear and another in his hand, and a slate on his knee. He had eaten, by her count, four slices of saltcake since the tenth bell without noticing any of them.

"It's not a cipher," he had said at the start. "Don't hope for anything dramatic. It's cutters' shorthand. The Abbey used it for the tablet copies. Nobody uses it any more except old copyists and, apparently, Reader Aske, who uses it badly, with

personal abbreviations, in two colours, for reasons known only to God." He had squinted. "Blue is grain. Black is people, I think. Give me an hour."

It had taken him six.

He read aloud as he went, in pieces, and sometimes stopped for twenty minutes over a single line and swore at it softly in the vocabulary of a man who had spent nine years in a religious house. Hester sat against the wall with her knees up and refilled his water.

The first marbled book began in Thaw of 902 and was grain, in blue: a crate of curing salt from a Ferrers yard that tasted of the Fifth. Another. *Warm. Bead. Spat in the basin.* By midsummer he had stopped being surprised.

The second was people. Black ink. It began with Dunmore.

*E.D. — Edwin Dunmore, clerk to the Warden's office. Handles the residue contracts. Residue = quickened grain cut out of the stays when the stays are re-laid. Should be dissolved in the Fifth and the brine pumped to the sinks. Is not. Is boxed. Boxes go up the box-lift, Fifth to Third, at the tenth bell, three nights a week, carried by aspirants paid two sols a run.*

Teo looked up. "That's Saskia."

"I know."

"He doesn't name her. Just *aspirants*." He read on. *Ferrers & Lisk freighter. East to Quell, a Ferrers warehouse, relabelled Shelf, then back west and sold as curing grain to the Hask kept-fish trade. Hask buyers complain their fish spit when the keep is broken. Nobody listens to Hask buyers.* And under that, in a different pen: *W.L.F. per E.D. on the ladings. Warden of the Lower Fathoms, per Dunmore. Bold as brass. The office has signed residue contracts for two hundred years. Nobody reads them.*

"You knew that," Teo said.

"I knew that." She had known it since Lucan came back from the Upper Ward with the contract in his coat. She had given Teo a small, neat, clerkish theory to go with it, with Dunmore at the centre: a bland man who sold what he was told to destroy, and a Warden who signed what her clerk put in front of her. She had not believed a word of it herself.

Teo opened the black book. The ink was blue again.

*1 Russet. Stacks: Founders' Cistern plans, for the east trunk survey. Why from the city?*

*1 Russet. Miss Vail. Taste and weight. Graded my twelve blind. Named No. 9 as twice-kept. Heard a cry in the Wren grain, did not know it. I did not tell her. God forgive me, I want to see her face when she hears it in the Stacks.*

Teo stopped and looked at her over the candle. She looked at the window.

"Go on," she said.

*5 Russet. Cold House, Coldwater St. Director at his sister's; Mother Agathe walked me down the rows. Miss V.'s brother in 211. 14 weeping. All east. Taste: quick. Tasted the run-off myself. Quick, and under it something stiller than I have ever had in my mouth. Old keepings get still. These are being bled.*

*Harl St Brinery — 0. Varenne Private — 0. Charity only. Of course charity only. Nobody audits charity.*

*A draw? Still runs to quick. It wants a brine contact. A line. Cold House stands on the old reservoir—Cistern?? The founders' lines. Bricked in 400. Bricked by whom?*

"That's the sheet," Hester said. "From his blotter." She put her thumb to the torn stitching. "That's the leaf. He tore it out for me and took the book away."

Teo read ahead with his lips moving. "Hester. He went into the Cistern."

*12 Russet. Under the Cold House by the cellar. Agathe's key. The old main line is open. Brass sleeves, new, Lattice marks. Live brine in the sleeve. Still as death. Runs east.*

*13 Russet. Walked the plans. The main line runs under the White, two miles, and comes up in the Fifth Fathom at the Old Tap. Founders' brass. I have passed it a hundred times. The east gallery stay-lines are fed from it. The stays have been holding beautifully all summer, and I am a fool.*

*14 Russet. Measured. The east stays draw 30 parts in 100 of their stillness from the Old Tap. Without it they would have failed in Seedmonth. Without it the Hush would be in the Fifth by now.*

Teo put down the pencil.

"Thirty parts in a hundred," he said. "From the Cold House."

Hester did not answer. She had tasted it at the Silent Supper, with the brine splashing her mouth and the sea roaring in the walls: the cold, old stillness of the line under Coldwater Street, coming up the stay-line from the east. She had known since that night that the stays were fed by the sleepers. Here it was in a Reader's hand, measured. Tib had been in the line that night, holding the east gallery up with her.

"Is there more?" she said.

"The last page."

"Read it."

Teo read it slowly, in the voice he used for scripture when he did not want to mock it, and she listened with her eyes shut.

*15 Russet. Told Miss V. tomorrow at ten. Showed her the beating bead. She went white. She has the tongue for this, God help her, and she has a brother in the line.*

*I know whose office this is. I have known since the 13th and pretended not to, because I have known her near thirty years and she taught me to hold in the Choir when I was nineteen and too frightened to breathe. She is the best of us. I think she has done this because she is the best of us.*

*She is right that it will flood. She is wrong that it must be held. The pressure wants a road, not a lid. Vent? Let a little of it go somewhere it can do no harm, a little at a time. Need Sorle's arrears for the shaft—he'll crow for a decade, let him. I'll ask O. tomorrow, before I tell Gage. I owe her that.*

*If anything—tell Hester to taste it.*

The candle had burned to a stub. The moon had gone behind the Lantern, and its mirrors made a thin black bar across the White.

"She," Teo said quietly.

"I heard."

"Dunmore's not a she."

"No."

He closed the notebook and sat with his hand flat on its black cover, and looked at her, and saw that she was not surprised.

"How long?" he said.

"Since Fallow. She kept a candle for me in the Gallery and showed me her hand in it." She heard how flat it came out. "I wanted to be wrong. I'm on her books. She put a blanket on me after my first stay. I wanted it to be Dunmore so badly I said it out loud to you every night."

He did not say the name either. He was too kind to, and she loved him for it and hated him for it, both at once.

"*Ask O.*," he said instead. "And you let me go on about the Order."

"Yes." She stood up. Her knees were stiff and she was thirsty, the Halcyon thirst, as though she had been holding. "He said taste it. I haven't. I've had a

candle and a notebook. A notebook says *she*." She took her gown from its peg. "If I'm going to say it, I'll say it off the salt. Off my tongue."

"It's the middle of the night."

"Then nobody will be in the Quiet Rooms."

He looked at her over the guttering candle, crumbs on his chin.

"I'll be here," he said.

* * *

The Fourth Fathom in the small hours was dark and cold, and there was no sound but the hum, the long low pressure from below that she had felt in her teeth on her first day and long since stopped noticing. She noticed it now.

The Quiet Rooms were not locked. Nobody locked them. Who would steal a keeping?

Aske's casing stood where the porters had set it in Russet, between a girl kept in the act of laughing and a Reader in a gown three hundred years out of fashion. Hester set the lantern at the plinth's foot and looked up at him.

He had not changed. That was what keeping meant, and still it went through her. His arm was out, the ink-stained fingers spread. His mouth was open on whatever he had been about to say. Through the casing, clear as clean water, she could see the frayed cuff of his shirt, and a fleck of salt-mud on his gown at the knee.

The casing was smooth as glass at its outer face and frosted against his skin, set from the outside in. Poured, by someone standing in front of him. Sorle had said it in Fallow: *a child could see that casing was poured.*

She knelt, took off her right glove as she had in the Cold House on the first of Russet, and put the tip of her smallest finger to the casing where it met the plinth. She touched the finger to her tongue.

The weight came down. Hush grain: the door closing, the white, the vast pressing on the far side of her face. She went into the hold. It came easily now; three months ago it had been something she found by accident on a customs stool, and now she could put it on like a coat. The taste opened, and she read.

She did not try to read Aske. She did not want to hear what he had been saying when the brine went over him. She went past the moment and into the hand of

whoever had set it. She knew what she was looking for. She had known since Fallow. She had come down here to be told she was wrong.

The grain turned. Under the weight and the white she felt it as a slow corkscrew of set salt, layer winding on layer, every one turning the same way: from the right hand toward the left, widdershins, against the sun. At the end of each turn there was a small hard counter-flick, like the snap of a wrist.

*Every worker leaves a hand in the grain.* Orsolya in the Warden's Gallery in Fallow, a tallow candle between them and a dish of live brine, her wet left fingers flicking at the wick, the wrist snapping back. The flame going still, a little yellow tongue in a bead of clear salt. *Mine's a corkscrew. My mam said I came out twisting.* Both of them laughing, and something at the back of Hester's mind giving a small hard tug, like a fish on a line. She had felt it then. She had gone up the Stair with it and told no one.

It was the same hand. Not like it. The same.

She came out of the hold too fast, with a sound in her throat.

She was on her knees on the Fourth Fathom floor, her bare hand flat on the plinth. Above her Aske reached out of the salt toward nothing.

She had carried the rest for weeks, figure by figure, and had told herself each one could be carried another way. She went down them now with the hand under her tongue, and none of them could.

The Causeway at dawn on the sixth of Russet, and a woman in iron-grey coming up behind her from the city, bone-cold of hand, with salt-mud dried to crusts on her boots. There was no salt-mud on the Causeway. There was salt-mud at the end of Coldwater Street, by the old sea-wall, where the brine seeped up between the cobbles from the reservoir underneath.

The Warden's Gallery, and tea. *The Stays have been kind this season. Kinder than they've any right to be.* Thirty parts in a hundred.

The skiff on the White in Fallow, Orsolya easy at the rail. *How's your brother? Still at the Cold House?* Hester had never told her which brinery. Orsolya's da, nineteen years in the Cold House, explained the street. It had never explained how she knew Tib was in it.

The sixteenth of Russet, a little before the half, the cold corridor outside Cell 3-17. Iron wheels on the turn below; Hester at the rail; a small blue lantern and a trolley under canvas, and two or three people in grey wool, hauling, and then,

when she turned back to the door, stopping. Waiting, she saw now. Waiting for her to go.

*Edwin handles the residue contracts; it's all above board, Conclave-approved.*

*Oh, Corvin. Oh, you daft man.*

Hester knelt by the plinth with her hand on the cold salt, and the hum came up through the floor into her knees, and she did not get up for a long time.

* * *

She went back to Callow on the twenty-eighth.

She had not slept much in between. She had done a Choir shift in the east gallery and felt the cold old stillness come up the line from the east, and had held anyway, because the stay needed holding and there were twenty people in the line whose lives depended on it. Orsolya had walked the line in her iron-grey, a hand on a shoulder here, a word there. *Steady, chick. That's it.* She had put her hand on Hester's shoulder. Hester had not moved. When Orsolya walked on she had found that she was shaking, and had told the chorister beside her it was lag.

She had gone to Crisp's release hour at the Pans as well, because it was on the board and missing it would be noticed. Crisp walked the rim with her hands behind her back. "You are strangling it, Vail. Again." Hester kept a drop and closed on it, and closed on the next. On the third the drop went soft along one edge, a hair's breadth of water, before her hand clamped. Crisp stopped behind her. "Better," she said, and walked on, which from Crisp was a medal.

There was one thing left. He had said it to her in Russet, and she had heard it as an old man's kindness: *The dead bloom. A month or so. Whatever the grade.* She had been carrying it for two days like a stone in her shoe, not looking at it, because looking at it would mean hoping.

She sat on the stool at the end of Callow's desk. It was the fifth bell again.

"Under-Archivist," she said. "I need to know something about Hush grain."

She waited.

"The living keep clear and the dead keep grey. The Chief Proctor told me, the morning they found Reader Aske, that Hush grain's different. That it keeps everything clear, so the clear casing meant nothing. And I took his word, because I'd never had Hush grain in my mouth. You told me otherwise, and I didn't listen. Is it true?"

She counted to sixty, and past it. She watched his face, which did not move, and his hands, which did not move.

At a hundred and twenty his eyes came round to the corner of the desk.

"Hush grain," said Callow, "keeps clear."

Her heart went down like a dropped weight.

He breathed. One breath. It took a long time.

"Quickly."

She waited.

"Then it blooms," said Callow, "like any other."

The lamp gave off its old summer warmth.

"How long?"

Another breath.

"A month."

She did not move. She did not trust anything she might do if she did.

"He's been there since the sixteenth of Russet," she said. "Two months and more. I was in the Quiet Rooms three nights ago with a lantern. His casing is as clear as the day it was poured."

Callow said nothing. Then, so slowly that she was not sure until it was done, one of his hands turned over on the oak, palm up, and lay open there in the lamplight.

She looked at it, and understood that it was not helplessness. It was a release, as Crisp taught it at the Pans to first-years who could not do it, as Orsolya had taught it on the White over a man-shaped casing hanging in the mouth of a sink. *Don't push it out, chick. Open your hand.*

The living keep clear.

* * *

She went down to the Quiet Rooms again that evening, in the Lantern Hour, when the whole Halcyon was at the Long Table under the poured noon light and the Fourth Fathom was empty.

She took no lantern. There was light enough from the Well, where it passed through the Fourth on its way down to nowhere: gold and borrowed, a summer noon from some year she did not know, falling in a long column through the dark and making the casings along the gallery glitter like ice on a pond.

Aske reached out of the light toward her. His spectacles were full of gold.

She stood with her hands in the sleeves of her gown, against the cold.

"You daft man," she said.

He did not answer. He was not dead. He was between one moment and the next, and had been for ten weeks. In the moment he was in, he had his arm out to stop a woman he had known for thirty years from doing what she was doing. And she had a dish of live brine in her left hand, and had turned her wrist back on itself, and poured.

"I tasted it," Hester told him. "Like you said."

It was not so different, she found, from the fourth row of the Cold House. You stood beside a casing and told the person in it what you knew. You did not expect anything back. She had not said the name aloud to anyone, not even to Teo.

"It's Orsolya," she said.

The words sat in the cold air. The Well-light poured past. Far above, faint through two fathoms of salt, the Long Table was laughing and scraping its benches, six hundred people at their supper.

"It's Orsolya," Hester said again, as though she were writing it in a ledger in ink, so that it would be there in the morning. "And you're alive."

CHAPTER 20

# *The Warden*



*I have buried eleven of mine. I'll not bury more.*

— Orsolya Thane, Warden of the Lower Fathoms, address to the Stay Choir on the Silent Supper, 899 Y.E.

She told nobody.

It did not feel like a decision. It felt like reasoning, and she reasoned it through in the cold of R-41 with Teo asleep across the cell and the three notebooks wrapped in their oilcloth under her mattress. But it had been settled before she began, somewhere at the back of her, in the place where she had settled the night at the Cold House desk eleven years ago without consulting anyone, least of all herself.

If she told Sorle, Sorle would go to the Conclave with his slates and his thirty-two years of being laughed at, and Vey would thank him for his diligence and move to the price of lamp oil, and the notebooks would be fire-salvage for good.

If she told Lucan, Lucan would go to the Assize, and if by some miracle they were believed, the first thing the Assize would do was order the draw cut. *Without it the Hush would be in the Fifth by now.*

If she told Teo, Teo would come with her.

And under the reasons, which were good reasons, there was a thing she did not look at directly. *I'll ask O. tomorrow, before I tell Gage. I owe her that.* Aske had owed Orsolya thirty years and a Choir bench at nineteen. Hester owed her twelve weeks. A blanket on the Choir floor after her first stay, a voice on the White saying *open your hand.* The only Lowside voice under the Shelf except Hester's own.

Aske had gone to ask, and had been standing in the Quiet Rooms with his arm out ever since.

She knew that. She went anyway.

She wrote two lines on a page of her ledger, folded it, and slid it under Teo's pillow without waking him. *If I'm not back by the first bell, take the notebooks to Sorle. Under my mattress. H.* Then she put on her gown and her gloves and went down.

* * *

It was the second of Rime, the eleventh bell. The Assay was nineteen days off and the Rookery had gone quiet early all week, aspirants in their cells with their slates and their dishes of practice grain. On the Second Fathom the chalk-names went past her in the lantern-light, and among them, in her own seizure hand, AMA TESSALY, CHOIR, 903. She did not stop.

The Fifth Fathom was never asleep. A half-Choir of twenty-two held the east gallery through the night in four-hour watches, and their singing came up the galleries faint and slow, like a congregation heard through a church wall. She felt it in the soles of her feet as she came off the last turn of the Stair. The Warden's Gallery opened off to the left: a long room cut into the salt, with a row of brass gauges along one wall, needles trembling behind glass, each labelled for a stay; a table, a stove, a kettle; shelves of returns bound in iron-grey cloth; a single kept-light lamp.

Dunmore was coming out as she came in, a stack of ledgers under his arm and ink on his cuffs, with the bland, faintly put-upon courtesy of a clerk who has been kept late.

"Miss Vail. The Warden's in."

"Ta."

He went past her toward the lift. She heard the cage rattle and go up. A man who did what he was told and went home at a reasonable hour.

Orsolya was at the table with her back to the door and a shawl round her shoulders, writing.

"Is that you, chick? There's tea in the pot. It's stewed. I'll make fresh."

"Don't."

Orsolya's pen stopped.

She put it down. She sat a moment with her hands flat on the table either side of the page. Then she turned round on her chair, slowly, as Settled people turned, and looked at Hester in the doorway. She looked at her face for a long time, and Hester let her.

"Well," Orsolya said. "Sit down before you fall down."

* * *

Hester did not sit. She stood on the other side of the table, under the lamp, and told it in order, evidence first. Her voice came out steadier than she had any right to.

The *Constant Wren* and *W.L.F. per E.D.* The fourteen casings weeping east. The founders' line under Coldwater Street, sleeved in new Lattice brass, running to the Old Tap. Pell's ten sols a month. Thirty parts in a hundred. *She is right that it will flood. She is wrong that it must be held.*

"And his casing," Hester said. "Poured, not grown. The grain turns widdershins, with a flick at the end of every turn, like a wrist snapping back. I watched you keep a candle flame in Fallow. You showed me." She did not stop. "On the sixth of Russet you came up behind me on the Causeway from the Ambry end with salt-mud on your boots. There's salt-mud at the end of Coldwater Street, where the old reservoir seeps. And on the White you asked me if my brother was still at the Cold House. I never told you which brinery. I never told anyone."

There was nothing more. She had laid it all on the table, and it lay there.

"It's you," she said. "It's been you all along."

The kettle on the stove ticked as it cooled.

Orsolya turned her left hand over, palm up, and looked at the wrist as though she had never seen it before.

"My mam always said I'd get caught by it," she said. "That wrist. Said I'd never pass for anybody's hand but my own." She almost smiled. "Corvin knew it too. That's what he said, at the Tap, before. *I'd know your hand anywhere, Orsolya.* Like it was a compliment."

"Tell me why."

"You know why."

"I want you to say it."

Orsolya looked up at her. In the lamplight her face was older than Hester had seen it: the white hair, the slack skin of the neck, the slow blue at the lips that

every Choir worker carried. The eyes were the eyes Hester had liked on the Causeway, quick and grey and Lowside-shrewd. They were not ashamed. They were tired past shame.

"All right," Orsolya said. "But I'll not say it to you standing over me like a Proctor. Sit."

Hester sat.

* * *

Orsolya got up, slowly, and took down a ledger bound in iron-grey cloth and opened it on the table between them, turned so the columns faced Hester. Returns: stays by number down the left, dates across the top, in each square a figure in Orsolya's upright hand.

"That's 896," Orsolya said, putting a cold finger at the top of the page. "Four quickenings in the Fifth. Same as my first year as Warden, same as it had been for as long as anyone kept the returns. We'd stay them, and they'd quieten, and every few years one would break out again and we'd stay it again. Like weeding a garden." She turned the page. "897. Six." Another. "899. Nine." Another. "This summer, fourteen. And bigger. Hotter. Coming up through the Fifth from the Hush like water through a cellar floor, and I've had one break into the Fourth, you were there. Above the stays. That's never happened. Not in nine hundred years of returns."

She turned to the back of the ledger. There was a list of names, eleven of them, with dates, and at the bottom a twelfth, the ink still dark. *Ama Tessaly. 9 Cinder.*

"Them," Orsolya said. "That's what a stay costs, chick. You've held. You lend it and it doesn't all come back. Choir does twenty years if it's lucky; it's not lucky now. With fourteen pockets and twenty-two in a half-Choir, you hold double watches and you Settle double fast. Danny Horrocks was thirty-four. He sat down on the floor of the east gallery in Thaw of 901 and didn't get up. Leni Ash was twenty-nine. She had a baby." Her finger moved down the list without touching it. "I buried them. Me. I went to their mams."

"You could have—"

"I went to the Chancellor." Orsolya's voice did not rise. It went flat and plain. "Seedmonth of 901, with that ledger under my arm. I showed her the figures and the names. I asked for an inquiry. I asked for money for twice the Choir. I asked for the Delvers to be stopped cutting the Shelf pits any deeper, because every

fathom they take off the top is a fathom of weight off the Hush. And she sat there, the old woman, still as a stone, and the Deputy did the talking. The Halcyon could not afford to be *seen* to have a problem in the deep. Not with the Exchequer renegotiating the Charter tithe. Not with the Lodge at Quell petitioning the Concord. *Manage it quietly, Warden. You've always managed. We have every confidence.*" She shut the ledger. "No inquiry. No money. No noise."

Hester thought of Aske in Quill Street, turning his cup: *the Deputy Chancellor thanked me for my diligence and moved to the next business.*

"So I managed," Orsolya said.

She sat down again and put her hands round the cold teapot, as if for warmth.

"I went to the Stacks looking for anything the founders had done about pressure in the deep. They built down here. They must have known. And I found the Cistern plans, the old ones, from before the Fire. Water Board had them filed as municipal brine supply." She laughed, a short dry sound. "Nobody pipes brine two miles under the White to fill Lowside's washtubs. It's a stay-line. The biggest ever cut, from the old reservoir under Coldwater Street straight to the Old Tap. There's a halcyon cut on the valve-wheel. I've had my hand on it. They built the Cistern for this. To feed the stays from the city, when the stays ran short." She looked at Hester. "It was always meant."

"Meant to feed them with what?"

"With whatever was stillest. Whatever the city kept. Cellars of kept fish, in their day, I suppose. I don't know what the founders kept." She shrugged, a small heavy movement. "I know what we keep."

* * *

"Tell me about the sleepers," Hester said.

Her voice cracked on *sleepers*, like a pan-skin. She put both hands flat on the table and held them there until it passed.

"There's three hundred and four in that charity ward," Orsolya said. "You've walked the rows. Bloomers, mostly. Girls kept in childbed. Old folk kept with growths nobody's found a cure for in a hundred years. And the Coldbank men from 856, that the Guild paid to keep and stopped paying for in 870." She did not look away. "My da was one. I paid the rest of him myself. Nobody's coming back from that ward. Not cured. Agathe knows it. Pell knows it, God knows. They're kept because somebody couldn't bear the bill of letting them go. And the families

pay. Six sols a month, year on year. Ruth Linnow paid for Bett twenty years on a laundress's wage. That's the better part of fifteen hundred sols, for a lass who was never going to wake up and live. And when they can't pay they borrow, and when they can't borrow they sell the chairs. I've seen Lowside rooms with nothing in them but a bed and a Cold House receipt pinned to the wall. So have you."

"So you took them."

"I took what they had." Orsolya leaned forward. "Old keepings are the stillest things in the world. Sixty years in a casing, eighty, and the salt soaks up the life inside it till you could stay a quickening with a fingernail of it. Three hundred of them in a cold room on top of the founders' own line, costing their mams' furniture. And down here I've a Choir dying at thirty and a pocket in the east gallery that'll put the sea up the Stair the night it breaks." She opened her hands. "I didn't kill anybody, Hester. I let them go. Slowly. Usefully. Every one of them that's held up that gallery this summer has kept fifty of my Choir alive. They're holding the line so the others can sleep."

"Bett Linnow died gasping on a plinth," Hester said, "with her mother holding her hand."

"Bett Linnow was dying gasping in 883. That's when she was kept. I didn't do that to her. Somebody else did, by signing a paper. All I did was spend the twenty years she'd been given, that weren't doing her a blind bit of good."

"You didn't ask."

"Ask who?" Orsolya said. "Bett?"

The kettle ticked on the stove.

"I'll tell you about asking." Orsolya's voice had gone quiet and very plain. "Nineteen years I stood by my da on the first of the month. He was kept standing up, the way they found him, under the beam. When his casing wept and the brinewright said it'd not take another coat, I signed. I was thirty. I'd been paying since I was twenty-five, on a chorister's three sols, and I'd have paid till I died, and I signed. They took the beam off him in the bath and he came back with his chest stove in and the third gallery's dust in his mouth, and he looked at me, a woman of thirty with white coming in her hair, and called me by my mam's name. Then he died. It took about as long as it took your Bett." She turned the cold teapot a quarter-turn on the wood. "That's what nineteen years bought him. Not a day. Not an hour he could use. So don't tell me what I'm taking off them. I know to the fleck what I'm taking off them. It's nothing they'll ever have." She looked at

Hester. "Nobody asked him, either. He'd have been hard put to answer, under the beam. Did your lad sign his own form, chick?"

Hester could not move. Everything in her was running too fast to be still and too fast to move, the hold turned inside out. Orsolya watched her, not unkindly. She could not know. She could not possibly know. It was only that she was Lowside, and so was Hester, and on Coldwater Street nobody signed their own form.

"No," Hester said at last.

"No. Nobody does." Orsolya sat back. "So don't tell me about asking."

* * *

"Reader Aske," Hester said.

That one landed. Orsolya's face did not change, but her hands came off the teapot and lay in her lap, and for a while she said nothing at all.

"He sent a line down that afternoon," she said. "The sixteenth. *Old Tap, ninth bell, a word.* I knew what it meant, and I went down early. He was there before me, with his hands on the wheel." She swallowed. "He'd found it all, you'll have read it. And he'd made up his mind, Corvin, all at once, like a man jumping off a wall. He was going to shut the Tap, and be back up the Stair for you at the tenth, and go to Gage in the morning."

"And you stopped him."

"If he'd shut that Tap, the east stays would have starved inside the hour, and the gallery with them. Twenty-two of my Choir were on watch. I told him. I begged him. He kept saying *there's another way, Orsolya, there's always another way*, like he was explaining a sum. And the wheel was turning." Her left hand moved in her lap, a small twist back on itself, and stopped. "I had the dish in my hand. I'd brought it down to top the stay. Hush brine, from the line. And I—"

She stopped.

"I kept him," she said. "God help me. I didn't kill him. I kept him. It's the only thing I know how to do."

Hester's throat had closed. She waited for it to open.

"You knew," she said. "When Gage was saying *kept beyond return.* You knew he was alive."

"Of course I knew. What d'you take me for?" It was the first anger she had shown. "Edwin and I brought him up on a cask-trolley. It took us both; a casing

weighs. We were coming up the turn below his Cell when you looked over the rail. I saw your face. We stopped, and turned the lantern down, and stood there with him under the canvas till you'd gone." She did not look away from it now. "Then Benedek came round by the Readers' stair at the half and stood in the dark and went back up, and we waited for him too. We had him in a little after the half. We put him in his own Cell, and I put the dish in his basin so Gage would have something to write down, and I went to my bed and didn't sleep. And in the morning I came up and stood there and cried over him, and every tear of it was true." Her mouth worked. "You can't return a Hush keeping fast. The arrears would stop his heart. I'll bring him back myself when the Hush is quiet. Slow, in a warm bath, the way Physic does the old ones. I'll sit with him every hour of it. I kept him till it's over, chick. That's all."

"And when is it over?"

Orsolya did not answer that.

* * *

They sat across the table for a time Hester did not measure. The half-Choir's singing came and went down the gallery. A needle on the wall dipped and steadied.

"What are you going to do?" Orsolya said at last.

"I don't know."

"You'll go to Gage."

"Gage lost the rod I brought him."

"So he did. Vey had a word. Vey doesn't want anybody looking at the deep." She considered Hester with the quick shrewd Lowside look she had given her on the Causeway. "You'll go to Benedek, then. He's waited thirty years to see me in the dock; let him have his day. But you go to Benedek, or Gage, or the Assize, and somebody shuts that Tap, and the east gallery wakes. And then it's my Choir on the floor, and then it's the Fifth, and then it's the Stair, and then it's the Rookery with three hundred aspirants asleep in it. Your Teo. That Quell lass with the little girl." She said it plainly, not as a threat. "That's the bill. You're an assayer. You know how to read one."

She reached across the table. She did not take Hester's hand. She put her own cold hand down on the wood beside it, close, not touching.

"Your lad's line," she said softly. "Two hundred and eleven. Fourth row, under the third window. He's got a pencil in his hand."

Hester went cold to the roots of her hair.

"I go down to the reservoir every week or two to check the sleeves. I come up through the cellar in the small hours, before first bell, when there's nobody but Agathe asleep in her chair. I've walked the rows. I know where they all lie." She paused. "I didn't know he was yours. Not till Corvin put your name on his privilege and I looked you up in the Customs returns and saw *Vail*. I've been sorry for it every day since."

"Don't."

"I can route round him."

The words lay on the table, next to the ledger with the twelve names in it.

"It's just sleeves," Orsolya said. "Brass, and a bit of lattice. Each plinth's got its own drain to the main; I put them in myself, in Thaw. I can close his. I can go down tonight and close it, and his casing'll dry inside the day, and he'll hold. Till spring and past. As long as he's held these eleven years. Nobody need know. Not Pell. Not Agathe. Not your clever friends." She sat back. "There's three hundred and three others in that ward and I'll not pretend I can spare them all. But I can spare one. I'd like to do it for you."

Hester looked at the cold hand on the table. She looked at the twelve names, and the gauges trembling behind their glass, and the doorway to the gallery where twenty-two people were singing slowly in the dark so that the sea would stay where it was.

She did not say yes. She did not say no. She sat with her mouth shut and her hands flat on the wood. She knew that she had not said no, and she knew that Orsolya knew it.

After a while Orsolya nodded, as if that were an answer.

"Go on up," she said. "It's late, and you've the Assay in nineteen days, and you'll want to pass it, whatever else you want." She went to the stove and lifted the kettle and shook it, and set it back. "I'll not stop you. Tell who you like. I'll not lay a finger on you; I've not that in me, not for you. But you think about what it costs, before you tell." She turned round, and looked at Hester as she had on the Choir floor in Russet, with a blanket in her hands. "You're Lowside. You know what it is to choose who drowns."

* * *

Hester did not remember the climb. Teo was asleep on his side with one hand under his pillow, over the folded note. She drew the note out without waking him and put it in the stove. Then she lay down in her gown on top of her blanket and did not close her eyes until the window went grey.

She went to lectures. She sat in the Black Bench while Sorle talked about the decay of kept heat, and wrote down every word and heard none. Twice at the Long Table Teo looked at her across the bench, and twice she looked away.

The letter came at the Lantern Hour, on the post-tray with the Rookery letters: a single sheet folded in three, sealed with a blob of tallow, *Miss H. Vail, Aspirant, the Halcyon* on the outside in Agathe's careful schoolroom hand. Hester broke the tallow with her thumbnail and read it under the poured noon light with the whole Long Table chattering round her.

*My dear,*

*I write because I promised. Something has changed and I think it is for the good. When I went round after noon today your Tib's casing was dry. Not a bead on it. The lines are all gone, and the salt at his feet is as dry as the day he was kept, and I put my hand near it and it is cold and still, as it should be. The others are as they were, I am sorry to say, but his is dry. I do not know why. Mr. Pell does not know. I have told him nothing.*

*Tide willing it will last. Come when you can.*

*A.L.*

She read it twice. She folded it along its creases and put it inside her gown, against her ribs, where her purse used to sit when she had a purse.

*I can go down tonight and close it.*

She had not said yes.

She had not needed to.

* * *

Later, when the Long Table had emptied and the Well had gone dark, she went down the Stair to her own stretch of wall on the Second Fathom and sat on the step under the chalk.

The salt was cold through her gown. Above her head, in her square hand, it said AMA TESSALY, CHOIR, 903, and above that, in older hands, the names of the Settled went up the curve of the Stair into the dark.

Below her the hum came up out of the deep into the step and into her bones. Below that, so faint she could not be sure she was not imagining it, the half-Choir was singing. *Hold the line, hold the line.*

Two miles west, under Coldwater Street, in the fourth row, under the third window, her brother lay in a casing as dry as the day she had signed for it, and held. He was not holding the east gallery up any more. Somebody else's brother was, or somebody's mother, or somebody's girl with a red ribbon in her hair. They were holding it in his place, because a woman who was the best of them had closed a brass sleeve in the night, for Hester, without being asked.

She sat on the Stair with Agathe's letter against her ribs and did not move for a long time.

CHAPTER 21

# *Still Runs to Quick*



*Law the Fifth. Still runs to quick. Stillness moves through continuous live brine from the stiller to the quicker, as heat moves through iron from the hot end to the cold. It does not leap a gap. It does not answer a wish.*

— The Halcyon Primer, for the use of aspirants

She told them in Sorle's study on the fourth of Rime, everything, in order.

There were five of them in a room built for one old man and his books. Sorle had the chair behind the desk. Saskia had the other chair, because she had got to it first and did not apologise. Lucan stood under the slit of salt-glass with his arms folded over ribs that still pained him in the cold. Teo sat on the floor against the bookshelves with a cup of halcyon tea going cold between his feet. Hester stood.

She told them about the office in the Fifth and the spiral and the notebook. She told them about the twelve names, and the Chancellor who had given Orsolya nothing. She told them that Aske was not dead, only waiting, because the woman who had kept him meant to let him out when she was finished. She told them about the offer.

Then she told them the rest.

"Agathe wrote yesterday," she said. "Tib's casing's stopped weeping. The east foot's dry." She looked at the floor between Teo's boots. "I didn't say yes. I didn't say anything. She did it anyway."

Teo set his cup down.

"So that's where I am," Hester said. "My brother's safe because a woman I'm going to see arrested decided to make him safe. There's a dozen others still weep-

ing in that ward, and there'll be more. And if the draw stops, the Hush comes up through the floor and drowns everyone in this building. That's the account." She turned to Lucan and Teo. "You'll be going under the Cold House again. To count the rods."

"On the seventh," Lucan said. "Why?"

"Open his sleeve. Two hundred and eleven, fourth row, under the third window. Put him back on the line with the rest of them."

"Hes," said Teo.

"He's drawn like the others till the cut, or I'm hers." Her voice did not stay as level as she wanted. "I'll not be hers. I'll not have him held up by her and the Corries bled for it."

"Salt and sorrow," said Teo softly.

Saskia was looking at her as she looked at a lantern-jar with a flaw in it, deciding whether it would hold.

"You could have kept your mouth shut," she said. "About the lad. We'd never have known."

"I'd have known."

Saskia held her eyes a moment longer, and nodded once.

* * *

They went at it for two hours. It was the most honest argument Hester had ever been part of. Nobody in it was stupid and nobody was wrong, and the room got hotter and the tea went undrunk.

"The Chancellor," said Lucan. "It's the obvious course, and I'd like it on the record that I proposed it before anyone sneered."

"I sneer in advance," said Sorle. "It saves time. Go on."

"Thane has committed a felony under the Charter and kept a Reader against his will. The Chancellor must act."

"Thane went to the Chancellor," Hester said. "Before any of it. Holm gave her nothing. Told her to manage it quiet."

"So Thane says."

"I believe her."

"You believed her before," said Lucan, not unkindly.

That went in. Hester let it.

"Gage lost the rod," said Teo from the floor. "And Vey was coming out of his office. I'd want to know who I was telling before I told them."

"The Assize, then," said Lucan. "I know four aldermen who would give their teeth for a scandal under the Charter."

"And the Assize sends the watch along the Causeway," said Sorle, "and the Proctors close the Gatehouse, and there follows a fortnight of very fine correspondence, during which the Hush continues to fail." He took his spectacles off and pinched his nose. "Mr. Ferrers, your instinct is admirable and your sense of time is a lawyer's. The Hush does not attend hearings."

"Then we cut it," said Saskia. "Tonight. Lucan and Teo know the way down from the Cold House cellar. Saw the rods out and let the sleepers keep their own."

"And the stays starve," Hester said. "The Choir's a third short. They've been holding the Fifth on the sleepers for a year. Cut the line and they've nothing to hold with."

"Then what?" Saskia said. "Three doors, and we've just walled up all three. Tell the people who already know. Tell people who can't do anything. Or drown everyone to save a dozen. Pick one."

"That's what she said," Hester said. "*You're Lowside. You know what it is to choose who drowns.*" She found she had sat down after all, on the edge of Sorle's desk among his papers. He did not object. "That's the whole of her case. A weight on one side and a weight on the other, and you pick the lighter one to lose, and you hate yourself, and you do it."

"Isn't that what grown women do?" said Lucan quietly.

"I don't know." Hester looked at her hands. "I've spent eleven years thinking there were two choices for Tib. Keep him, or let him go and die. I picked one and hated myself and paid for it on the first of every month, and I never once thought there might be anything else. That's the thing about a scale. It's very good at telling you which side's heavier. It doesn't tell you whether you've put the right things on it."

"Go on," said Sorle.

* * *

She did not know, when she began, that she knew it. It had been lying in her for weeks in separate pieces, and she had only needed to be angry enough to tip them out on the table.

"Aske's last entry," she said. "Teo. Read it again."

Teo had not let the notebook out of his reach since the night they found it. He opened it at the ribbon.

"*She is right that it will flood. She is wrong that it must be held. The pressure wants a road, not a lid. Vent? Need Sorle's arrears for the shaft.*"

"A road, not a lid," Hester said. "My father said that, near enough. About a pan." She saw Lucan's face. "Brine-pans. When a pan spits, the trick everyone's taught is to drop the lid on it. My father doesn't. He draws the fire a shovelful at a time and lets her talk. Lid her, and either she blows the lid through the roof, or she goes quiet and you lift the lid later and it all comes up in your face at once. Everything she's been saving."

"The stays are lids," said Teo slowly.

"Every one of them. You pour still in on top of a quickening and it goes quiet, and the Fathomers write it off as held, and it isn't. It's saving. That's why they come back bigger. Sorle, you said it, in Fallow. *Pour enough still into a quickening and it quiets, and grows hungrier.*"

"I said it," said Sorle. He had put his spectacles back on. "I also said, when you asked what would happen if one let it out, that the moment would proceed. I said it as a warning. You appear to be repeating it as a recommendation."

"It is one. Saskia. Lantern Night. The jars. Tell him what you told me."

Saskia frowned. Then her face changed.

"Annealing," she said. "Glass that's cooled fast keeps its stress inside. One day you put it down on a table and it bursts. So you put it in the lehr and bring it down a few degrees at a time, hours, days for the big pieces, and the stress walks out of it. You don't stop the stress. You can't. You give it time to leave." Her eyes had gone narrow and bright, the look she got in the kilns. "Hold, drop. Hold, drop. Too big a drop, it cracks anyway. You'd have to know how much stress was in it to set the steps."

"Arrears," said Lucan.

They all looked at Sorle.

He sat with his hands flat on the desk on either side of the place where Hester was sitting, and looked at the wall of slates behind her, and his lips moved slightly, as they did when he was counting.

"No," he said at last. "It's quite mad. You propose to take a pocket of the held moment under nine centuries of arrears and let it *go*. Into what? Into the Fifth?

You will flood the Fifth. Into the Hush? It *is* the Hush. The pressure wants a road, Corvin says; Corvin always did write like a man composing his own epitaph. A road to where? We are in a dome of salt in the middle of a dead sea. Every direction is down or sideways, and down and sideways is more salt and more moment and more—" He stopped.

"Up," said Hester.

He looked at her.

"The Well-Cap," she said. "The Proctor showed us, the first day, from the Lantern gallery. A quarter-mile east, an iron lid on the salt with a chain on it. The Founders' Shaft, he said, all the way down to the Hush, and nobody's opened it since they capped it."

"The Founders' Shaft," said Teo.

"It goes up," said Hester. "Out onto the White. Where there's nothing to drown but salt."

Sorle got up. He walked round the desk, past her, to the long wall of slates, took the cloth off its nail and wiped the first slate clean in four strokes. Then he took a stick of chalk from his waistcoat pocket and began to write.

* * *

HE DID NOT STOP FOR FOUR DAYS.

He wiped every slate in the study, then sent Teo for the six big slates from the Black Bench lecture room, then sent Lucan to the Brinestacks with a list. Lucan came back with the founders' survey of the Hush under his coat and did not say how he had got it out. When the slates ran out Sorle wrote on the plaster between the shelves.

On the first evening Lucan asked, as if reading from a contract, whether Reader Sorle would consider a transfer to his Bench of an aspirant presently attached to the Deputy Chancellor's. Sorle did not turn round. "Can you do sums?" "Yes." "Then sit down and do these, and stop dripping on my floor." In the morning there was a black cord on the chair where Lucan had slept. Hester saw him touch it twice before noon.

She did not understand most of the slates. But she sat with him through long hours of it, because he needed someone to tell him what things tasted like.

"Quickened grain at the Fifth east gallery," he would say, without turning round. "How heavy?"

She gave it to him in thornes, her private scale since the customs stool, named for old Mr. Thorne, and watched Sorle's face as he learned that a unit of Horology was now called after a dead customs man. The *Wren* cargo was eleven thornes. The Fifth east gallery was fourteen. The line under the Cold House, the stillness of three hundred sleeping people flowing east through the dark, was forty. Sorle put them through something that took up most of a slate, and stood back from it for a long time.

"What?" said Hester.

"It agrees with Corvin. Corvin and I have never agreed on anything in twenty years, except the quality of the Harl cider." He wiped his chalky hand down his waistcoat, leaving a white stripe. "It can be done. I want to be exact, Miss Vail, because it will be quoted back to me at my trial. It can be done if the following things are true." He ticked them on the slate with the side of the chalk. "One. The pocket must have a continuous road to a place where its motion does no harm. That's your shaft, if the founders' survey is honest. Two. The release must be staged. Annealed, as Mrs. Orme says. A third of the arrears at a time, with a hold between, or the shock cracks the Hush floor and we all go into the dark together. Three. Someone must make the release. A worker, in the brine, at the boundary of the pocket, hands on the salt, giving the held moment leave to proceed a step at a time." He looked at her over his spectacles. "It will be the hardest release ever made in this building. It is also, by your own account and Maudelaine Crisp's, the thing you are worst at in the world."

"I know."

"And four," said Sorle, "which is not on any slate. The moment proceeds. Whatever is held in that pocket will move again. Water, certainly, nine hundred years old, up the shaft and out onto the White." He set the chalk down on the ledge, precisely. "And if I have been right for thirty-two years, it will not only be water. I will find out that I was right in public, at the worst possible time. I find I don't greatly mind. But you should know what you're starting."

She thought about the cry in the *Wren* grain. Two notes, and a third that cracked.

"I know what I'm starting," she said.

"No," said Sorle. "Nobody does. That's rather my point."

* * *

They chose the night on the sixth of Rime, in R-41, with the frost feathering the corners of the window. It was Saskia who said it, and as soon as she did, it was obvious.

"Assay Night."

After the Assay, by a custom older than the Charter, the whole Halcyon fed, the doors open to Ambry and half the city come over the Causeway. The Choir was stood down for the night, all but a skeleton watch, because you did not keep your own from the Assay Feast. The Fifth on Assay Night, said Saskia, who had met its box-lift three nights a week all summer and heard what came up in it, was emptier than on any night of the year.

"Fewer people down there if it goes wrong," said Teo.

"Fewer people to stop us," said Lucan.

"Both," said Hester. "Mostly the first."

Nobody wrote anything down. Hester's ledger-mind was screaming at her to, and she did not.

Lucan and Teo would go to Ambry after the Assay with the crowd, and down through the Cold House cellar into the Cistern. Agathe would let them in; she had said yes before Hester finished asking. At the twelfth bell they would saw the draw-rods out of the founders' line, every one, and the sleepers' stillness would stop at the Cold House, where it belonged.

"And the moment we cut," said Lucan, "the stays begin to starve."

"The moment you cut, I'll know," said Hester. "I'll be on the line in the Hush. I'll taste it go. And from then till the shaft takes the water, there's a skeleton watch on the east stays with nothing in the line. That's the hole. I'll not pretend it isn't."

"Then fill it," said Saskia.

"Orsolya will fill it."

There was a silence in R-41 of a kind Hester had not heard in it before.

"She'll be at the Feast," Hester said. "She'll feel the line go soft before you've put your saws down; she's had her hands on it every day for a year. She'll come down. And when she sees the shaft take water, she'll hold the stays."

"Or she'll shut the shaft," said Lucan. "Or you. She has already kept one person who stood in her way at that Tap."

"It's not a plan," said Saskia. "It's a prayer with a name in it."

"Miss Vail," said Sorle, quite gently, "that is madness."

"I know her." Hester heard how it sounded, and said it anyway. "She's buried twelve of them. She went to their mams. Whatever else she is, she'll not stand in the Fifth and watch the Choir go under when there's a road open. She'll not let them drown."

Saskia would get the key from Dunmore's left-hand drawer: the brass-tagged ring, *W.L.F. Duplicates*, and on it the long black iron key with a little bird sitting on a line on its bow. She would take it during the Feast, when Dunmore would be at the Long Table eating for once.

"And if he's not?" said Teo.

"Then I'll think of something. I'm a widow with a child and a Quell accent. People tell me where things are to get me out of their offices."

Hester and Sorle and Saskia would go down through the empty Fifth and across the Hush to the foot of the Founders' Shaft, and open the plug, a lattice-grown salt seal six feet thick. Then, when Hester tasted the cut, they would go to the boundary of the east quickening and begin.

"Three steps," said Sorle. "Mrs. Orme counts. Mrs. Orme has the best sense of an interval of anyone I have met in forty years."

"I'll allow it," said Saskia.

"And you?" said Teo.

"I hold the slate," said Sorle, "and I tell Miss Vail when to stop. And if she cannot stop, I hold her."

"Hold her how?" said Teo.

"You will see. I hope you will not."

"Every part of this is a felony," said Lucan, in his precise voice. "Breaking the Hush seal. Unlicensed release. Interfering with Halcyon infrastructure. I wanted to be sure I'd said it, so that afterward I can't pretend I didn't know." He unfolded himself from the floor, wincing at his ribs, and stood in the low doorway with his head bent under the lintel. "I'll cut your line, Vail. I'd have cut it in Fallow if you'd let me."

* * *

Agathe's letter came on the morning of the ninth of Rime.

*My dear. Your Tib is wet again at the foot since the seventh, the beads running east as before. I am sorry. I know you will want it plain. And the Corrie twins have begun to craze, Nell first and Jem after her, fine lines all down the east side*

*like a cup that has been in the oven too long. Mr. Pell says a crazed casing may go a month or may go in a week. A.L.*

She read it twice at the post-tray. Then she took it to Sorle's study and put it on the slate he was working at, over the chalk.

"Sooner," she said.

He read it. They went through it aloud, and she could not make the sums come out another way. The key was in Dunmore's drawer and Dunmore never left his desk but for the Feast. The Fifth was never empty but on Assay Night. The plug wanted the survey Lucan had not finished copying. And she could not yet give a drop of brine back out of her hand.

"Assay Night is not the convenient night," Sorle said. "It is the first one. I am sorry, Miss Vail."

She went to see her father that afternoon.

He looked up when she came along the pans. He stopped raking, which he had never done for her in her life, and stood with the rake in his hand in the steam and waited.

"Da."

"Hes."

She had come with a speech. It went out of her head at the sight of him. He looked three weeks older.

"Agathe says you came to the desk," she said.

"Aye."

"You had the pen."

"Aye."

"Why didn't you sign?"

He drew the rake through the crust to the far rim and back, and knocked it on the iron, and did not answer for so long she thought he would not. The steam came up between them and went away.

"Pen was heavy," he said.

She waited. She had learned waiting from Callow.

"Lad put the form in front of me and I read it. All of it, every line. Takes me a while." He looked at the pan, not at her. "There's a box at the bottom. *Signed for the family*. And above it, where they put who signed before, *H. Vail*. Your hand. Square, like you do it. Eleven year old, that ink, and still black." He laid the rake across the rim. "And I sat there and I thought: she put him in on her own, at

twenty-two, with her mam a month buried and me on the stair with my mouth shut. And now I'll take him out on my own, and she'll come up the street on the first and find him gone. That's two of us did it alone, and him in the middle. That's no way to finish a thing. You don't carry half a load and call it delivered." He looked at his burned hands. "Your name's on the first one, Hes. The last one wants both. I'll not sign it without you. And you'll not keep him without me, neither. Not any more."

She could not speak for a moment.

"I said a hard thing to you," he said. "At the Drowned Man."

"It was true."

"Aye. Didn't make it kind." He was quiet a while. "Agathe says he's wet again. She says he was dry four days."

"He was. Somebody dried him who'd no right to, for my sake. I had him put back."

He looked at her a long time through the steam. Then he nodded once, as if she had told him the price of coal and it was what he'd expected.

"Then there's summat you mean to do."

"Yes. And I need to ask you something."

He waited.

"How do you let a pan down slow?"

She thought he might laugh, or tell her to go away. He wiped his hands on his apron, and when he spoke it was in a voice she had not heard from him since he had taught her to read the tide-marks on the harbour wall.

"First thing is you listen to her. Before you touch anything. Every pan talks different. A pan with muck in the bottom ticks, small and quick, like a clock. A pan with air under the iron where the bed's cracked thumps. Slow. Deep. Like a heart. The one wants the fire down quick and the other'll crack her iron if you do it quick. So you stand there and you count and you listen, and you don't do anything at all for as long as you can stand, and longer.

"Then you go to the fire-door. You don't open it wide. You open her a hand, and you wait for her to answer. She'll go louder first. Always does. That's the bit that frightens the young lads, and they drop the lid. She goes louder because she's felt the change and she's not sure of it yet. You let her be louder. You stand there and let her shout at you. Then she goes quieter, a bit, and then you draw the first coals. A shovel. Lay them on the brick to the side where you can get them back if

you need them. And she'll go louder again, not so loud, and quieter again, and you draw the next. Each time you wait till she's said all she's going to say before you take the next shovel. You hurry her and she'll go up all at once, and then it doesn't matter how careful you've been.

"And the last thing." He looked down at his left hand, at the two shiny stiff fingers. "When she's talking, you don't stand over her. You stand to the side, with your face out of it. Because you're letting something out, Hes, and it's coming out where it wants, not where you want. You've given it the road. You don't get to pick which way it looks when it comes up." He picked the rake up. "That's how. Took me forty year and two fingers. You can have it for nowt."

She stood in the heat with her eyes stinging, and told herself it was the steam.

"Ta," she said.

"Hes." He did not look at her. "Whatever it is. Stand to the side."

"I will."

She did not tell him about the Assay.

* * *

The release was the thing she could not do, and there were twelve days to learn it.

Sorle could not teach her. He said so at once. "I am a theorist with indifferent hands. I could no more teach you a release than teach you to whistle."

Crisp's release hour had got her, since Fallow, to a drop half back on a good night. Only one person had ever got a whole release out of her: on the White, with Lucan's casing hanging in the rim of the sink, a low Lowside voice in her ear. *Don't push it out, chick. Open your hand.*

She would not go to Orsolya. She went instead to the Pans on the Crown every night at the eighth bell, when the rose and green water was black under the stars and nobody else would be fool enough to be out in the cold. She knelt at the edge with a flask of live brine and a dish. She kept a drop, and returned it. Kept a drop —

And it would not come back. It sat in her palm, clear and round as a seed pearl, and she could feel herself holding it, all of her clamped round it as her fist clamped round her purse in a Lowside crowd. She knew the theory. Every time she reached the place where she should have let go, something in her said *not yet, it'll be lost*, and closed.

On the fourth night Teo came out and sat on the rim of the pan beside her with a blanket round both their shoulders and watched her fail for an hour.

"What are you thinking about," he said finally, "when you try?"

"The drop."

"No, you're not. You're thinking about what happens if you let go and it isn't there any more. You're not holding the drop. You're holding the not-losing it." He pulled the blanket tighter. "At the Abbey, at Vigil, you carried a candle cupped in both hands down to the water-stair, and at the bottom you let the wind take the flame. The novices always held their hands round it to the last second and then snatched them away, and the flame went out because they'd snatched, not because they'd let go. The old sisters did it like this." He held his hands out over the black water, cupped, and then, slowly, turned them palm-up and flat, and opened his fingers. "You don't take your hands away from it. You take your hands away from *round* it. It's still in your palms. It just isn't trapped."

"Did you ever manage it?"

"Once. In my last year. I'd stopped believing the sea was coming back by then." He smiled, a little crooked. "Maybe that's why I could. I wasn't trying to keep anything for it any more."

She kept a drop. She did not try to let go of it. She thought of Teo's hands turning over in the dark, and her father standing to the side of the pan with his face out of it. She opened her hand: not away from the drop, but out from round it, flat, as you hold your palm out to a horse.

The drop went soft. It slid down the crease of her palm, live brine, warm for an instant with the tiny shove of its own arrears, and dripped off the side of her hand into the pan, and was water among water.

"Again," she said.

She did it eleven times more that night, and failed on seven. On the ninth night she failed on two, and afterward, in R-41, she took down the two dishes that had stood on her shelf since Russet with her first two kept drops in them, both from the Pans. She held her hand over them a long time. Then she put them back on the shelf. *Not yet.*

On the eleventh night Sorle came out onto the Crown in two coats with a kept moth from his desk, a brown one six years in its casing, and stood over her while she returned it. It sat on her palm for the length of a breath, stunned, with

the faint heat of six years coming off it, and then opened its wings and went up off her hand into the dark, toward the Lantern.

The rush came after it: a racing in her chest, a heat in her face the frost could not touch, the stars too sharp. Sorle knelt, stiffly, and tipped his flask into her dish over her wet hand, and laid his own hand flat on hers in the brine. It was cold, and very still.

The racing slowed. She felt it go out of her as warmth goes out of a cup.

"That is how," said Sorle. "Physic does it at the bath when a returner's heart runs away with him. Still runs to quick, Miss Vail. It runs into a racing heart as well as into a quickening." He took his hand away and looked at it. "It is not free. It is merely shared."

She thought: one moth. She thought of the east gallery, fourteen thornes, and the black water at the Silent Supper, and the Founders' Shaft going up through six hundred feet of salt to an iron lid in the dark.

She thought of Tib's hand, curled on his chest, holding its pencil.

Then she filled her flask from the pan and went in, because it was the nineteenth of Rime, and in two days she would have to do it in front of the whole city, and then again in the dark, where it counted.

CHAPTER 22

# *The Midwinter Assay*



*Discern. Keep. Return.*

— The Assay formula, spoken by the presiding Reader before each candidate

The Hall of Assay held eleven hundred people, and on the twenty-first of Rime it held more.

Hester had seen it empty, in Russet, on the tour. A dome of carved salt rose from the First Fathom floor so high that the light-shafts let into it from the Lantern were only threads at the top. Galleries ran round it in three tiers. Twelve chandeliers hung on chains as thick as her wrist, salt grown by the Lattice-masons over years on wire frames into branching trees of crystal. Empty, the hall had been dark, and had smelled of cold and old dust.

Full, it smelled of wet wool and oranges and people, and it was lit.

At the first bell the Glaziers had gone up into the dome on rope-cradles and dissolved a measure of kept noon into each chandelier's heart, and the light had gone out along the crystal limbs. It ran from cube to cube and broke on every face. The twelve trees hung burning over the hall, white-gold, and threw on the packed galleries and the upturned faces a light like nothing on the Rim in winter: the light of a particular afternoon in Seedmonth, warm and slanted, with a faint sound in it, if you listened, of bees.

Hester sat on the aspirants' benches on the hall floor with the rest of the Turning Intake in grey, and listened to the bees, and was afraid.

Agathe's letter had come up in the first-bell post-bag. It was inside her gown now, folded small against her breastbone.

*My dear. Jem Corrie came back on the nineteenth, near the tenth bell. The crazing went right through him all at once and he was out on the plinth before I could get Mr. Pell. He knew me, I think. He was gone by the half. Nell is holding, tide willing. I have oiled her more than I should. Do not come. Do what you must. A.L.*

The nineteenth. She had been on the Pans that night, opening her hand over a moth. She had had Agathe's letter of the ninth, *the Corrie twins have begun to craze*, and had sat in Sorle's study with his slates and chosen the twenty-first anyway, because the Assay emptied the Fathoms and no other night did. Twelve days. She had done the sum, and Jem Corrie was the remainder. She had shown the letter to no one. It was hers to carry.

She had sat on a customs stool for fourteen years and never been frightened of a grade in her life. But she had never graded anything before a thousand people. The galleries were full to the rail: Upper Ward furs, Exchequer black, and Lowside in its Sunday coats, packed into the top tier where tickets were free, leaning over the rail with oranges. Children sat on shoulders. Three Proctors stood at the doors in their dark-blue capes trying to look as if this happened every day, which, once a year, it did.

And on the dais at the hall's east end, under the biggest chandelier, the panel.

There were five of them at a long table draped in grey. Reader Crisp, in the centre, presiding, small and upright. Reader Bassano on her left, in a gown that was technically grey and actually silver. Deputy Chancellor Vey on her right, smooth, attentive, with a slight smile that he seemed to have set at the first bell and would take off at the ninth. Warden Thane at the end.

And at the table's other end, in a chair a little apart from it, the Chancellor.

Hester had seen Perpetua Holm twice before, both times at a distance, both times sitting. She was very old and very small, swaddled in grey wool to the chin, with a white cap and white hands folded in her lap. Her face had the pale glaze of a Settled worker's face, like a pot that had been fired too often. She had not moved since the hall filled: not her hands, not her head, not her pale eyes, fixed on some point in the middle of the hall floor. If it had not been for the faint lift of the wool at her breast, every half-minute or so, slow as a tide, you would have taken her for one of the Quiet Rooms' keepings, set out on the dais for the occasion.

Orsolya was looking at the aspirants' benches. Hester did not look back.

* * *

They went in order of name. Anselm was the third called.

Teo walked up the dais steps in his grey gown with the green cord at the shoulder and his old Tider shawl folded underneath it, where nobody could see it but Hester. He looked, going up, like a man walking to the gallows who has decided to be polite to the hangman. He turned and bowed to the panel. Crisp spoke the formula, *Discern, keep, return*, in her dry small voice that somehow reached the top tier. The Assay began.

Discernment was a tray of seven grains in seven silver dishes, set by the panel. The candidate named each aloud for grade, depth and provenance, and a Proctor with a ledger wrote it down. Most aspirants named grade and depth and stopped, sweating. Teo did not taste. Teo never tasted. He put his fingertip to each dish, and bent his head close, and went into a light hold, and *listened*. Then he straightened up and told the panel, in his warm, slightly apologetic voice, what each grain had heard on the day it set. The sixth dish had been taken from a pan on the Harl margin in a hailstorm; you could hear it on the tiles. The second had been kept, briefly, round a dead bird. The fourth had come up out of the Fifth Fathom, and there was singing in it. *Choir singing, I think, Reader. Low. They were holding something.*

Bassano laughed aloud and applauded, alone, until Crisp looked at him.

Then the keeping. A Proctor lifted the cover off a jar, and a brown moth climbed out onto its rim. When it flew, the candidate was to keep it in the air with a flick of live brine, and then, when the panel had examined the casing, return it and let it go.

Teo's hold was the worst in the Turning Intake. Crisp had once said in class that holding with Anselm was like trying to frame a picture of a fountain. When the moth flew he flicked the brine and missed, and the hall drew one breath. He flicked again and caught it. The moth went still in the air with one wing kept and one half-kept, crooked, a casing like a broken lantern. It dropped into the dish with a click. The panel bent over it. Crisp's mouth went thin.

Then Teo put his fingertip to the casing and returned it, and his return was beautiful. It was easy and complete, like a man setting down a cup. The moth sat up in the dish with both wings whole and went off the dais toward the chandeliers, and the hall let out its breath in a long sigh.

"Assayed," said Crisp.

It was the lowest pass. Teo bowed to the panel as if he had been crowned, and came down the steps grinning so widely that Hester, who had not smiled all morning, found that she was.

* * *

It went on. It went on all morning and into the afternoon. The kept-spring light from the chandeliers did not change. Hester's backside went numb on the salt bench, and her hands went cold, and she drank from her flask until it was empty and then sat with it in her lap.

Ferrers was called in the early afternoon. Lucan went up with his black cord at the shoulder, new enough that the knot still sat stiffly. In the second tier, among the Exchequer men, a tall grey-haired man in black sat forward and did not take his eyes from him. Lucan did not look up at that tier once. He discerned all seven grains for grade and depth and named two of them by the pit they had come from. He kept the moth in a casing so precise and so thin that you could see the dust on its wings through it, and returned it cleanly. When Crisp said "Assayed with distinction," the man in black stood up slowly and clapped three times, and sat down. Lucan came down the steps with his face like a shut door. When he passed the bench he caught Hester's eye, and for an instant the door was open on something that looked more like grief than triumph.

Orme was called after the fifth bell. Saskia walked up the steps as she walked into the kilns, briskly, rolling her sleeves. She named the grains in her flat Quell voice as if she were pricing them. Her keeping was the best of the day. She did not flick the brine at the moth. She held the flask still and let the moth fly into the drops, and the casing closed round it as smooth as poured glass, and the light from the chandeliers went into it and came out the other side in colours. People in the galleries said *oh* aloud. Bassano put both hands to his heart. Her return was neat and dry. "With distinction," said Crisp, and Saskia nodded to her as one tradeswoman to another. Then, coming down, she looked up at the top tier, where a small fair-haired girl was standing on the rail with her grandmother's arms round her middle, waving with both hands. Saskia waved back once, briefly, with her whole face changed.

Then there were others. The light did not change. The bees went on.

At the eighth bell the Proctor with the ledger said, "Vail. Hester. Bench of Reader Sorle," and she stood up.

* * *

Her knees were stiff. She went up the dais steps carefully, as if they were the six steps down to the charity ward, worn into dishes in the middle.

At the top she turned and bowed to the panel, the way the others had. Crisp looked at her without expression. Bassano smiled. Vey's set smile did not alter. The Chancellor did not move.

Orsolya looked at her.

Hester had known she would. She had spent nineteen days making herself ready for it, on the Pans every night, failing and then, slowly, not. It was still worse than she had prepared for. Not accusing, and not pleading: the look Orsolya had given her on the Causeway on the first morning, with the salt-mud on her boots and her hands tucked under her arms against the cold. *You're Aske's privilege. Well done, chick.* It was warm, and tired, and proud of her.

Hester turned to the tray.

"Discern," said Crisp. "Keep. Return."

There were seven silver dishes. She rinsed her mouth from the jug the Proctor held, and spat into the basin, and took up the horn spoon from the rack. Behind her, eleven hundred people went quiet. It was the quiet of an assay room at the second bell before Daisy came in. She found she had stopped being afraid.

She tasted the first grain.

"Shelf," she said. "Two fathoms. Southern margin. Somebody's dried it in an oven, and too fast. It's lost its sweet at the corners." The Proctor's pen scratched. "Second. Middling. Thirty fathoms. Halcyon pits, the north face. It's been out of the ground a month."

She went down the tray. Third, Deep at ninety, old, with a tiredness in it that meant someone had kept something in it once and returned it, and she said so. The Proctor's pen stopped. Crisp said "Go on" without inflection. Fourth, dead salt: Varrow rock, put in to trap the unwary. Fifth, Middling, Western Rim, perhaps fifteen. Sixth, Deep at two hundred, from the Halcyon's own reference cupboard, so clean it was almost a pleasure.

The seventh dish was on the end of the tray nearest Orsolya.

Each dish carried a small brass tag on its rim with the setter's initial, face-down. Hester did not turn the tag over. She did not need to. She put the spoon into the seventh dish and lifted a single crystal, white with a little blue in it, sharp-cornered, warm. Warm through the horn. She put it on her tongue.

The weight came down behind her eyes like a door closing.

Fourteen thornes. Sweet to the edge of bitter. Under the sweetness, bright and wet and metallic, the bitten tongue, the startle: quick. And under that, so faint she would not have caught it in Russet, a sound she had not known in Russet. A long low rushing, rising and falling, and the rise coming again before the fall had done.

She put the spoon down in the rack.

"Seventh," she said. Her voice came out clear to the top tier, and she let it. "Hush-grade grain. Quickened. Below the Fifth Fathom, and pushed up into it. It was taken from a stay in the east gallery of the Fifth, within the last week." She lifted her eyes from the tray. "There's sea in it."

The hall did not understand what she had said. She could hear it not understanding: a mutter in the galleries, a rustle, the word *Hush* going along the top tier where the Lowside people were. On the dais, the five of them understood perfectly.

Vey's smile came off. It did not slip; it was taken off, cleanly, and put away. Bassano looked at Crisp. Crisp looked at the brass tag on the seventh dish, and turned it over, and looked at it. Then she looked down the table at Orsolya.

"The east gallery," said Crisp. "Within the week. Vail, that is a level of specificity I would not expect from a Fellow of twenty years. How can you possibly—"

"It tastes of it, Reader."

"She's right," said Orsolya.

Her voice was quiet, Lowside and level, and it carried. "Taken the fourteenth. East gallery, stay nine. I set it." She was still looking at Hester. "Mark it, Maudelaine. She's right."

Crisp looked from one to the other of them for a long moment. Then she nodded to the Proctor with the ledger, and the pen scratched.

At the far end of the table, the Chancellor had not moved. But her eyes were no longer on the middle of the hall floor. They were on Hester. Pale, and wet, and very old, and fixed.

"Keep," said Crisp.

* * *

The Proctor brought the jar and lifted its cover. The moth climbed out onto the rim. It was brown, like all of them, with a darker bar across each forewing. It sat in the burning spring light and opened and closed its wings, and Hester took up the flask of live brine and the dish and stood with them, and went into the hold.

That part was easy. That part had always been easy. Breath slow. Heart slow. Down and down, silt settling in a glass. The hall went far away. The bees went far away. There was the moth, and the brine in her hand, and the deep square stillness in her that Crisp had once called a miser's. Hester had come to think of it as simply her own: the stillness of a woman who had stood at the end of a fourth row once a month for eleven years and not touched anything.

The moth flew.

She did not flick. She had watched Saskia. She lifted the flask and let the brine go in a short flat arc across the moth's path, and the moth flew into it, and she *held*. The brine closed on it in the air. The casing came down round it dense and squared, like a stone fitted in a wall, and the moth hung for an instant in the light, a brown thing in a clear cube. Then it dropped into the dish with a sound like a dropped coin.

The panel bent to it. Bassano took out a glass. Crisp looked a long time.

"Dense," said Crisp. "Squared. Heavy-handed." She sat back. "Not a flaw in it. Return."

Hester set the dish on the table in front of her and put out her right hand, palm down, and laid her fingertips on the casing.

This was the part. She had known it would be, since the first day at the Pans in Russet, when the drop had sat in her palm and stayed there and Crisp had said *You hold like a miser, Vail*, loud enough for Lucan Ferrers to smirk. She could feel it already: the clench. Everything in her that had been settling and stilling began, at the touch of the casing, to close. Not yet. It'll be lost. If you let go of a thing, it isn't there any more.

She thought of Teo on the rim of the pan in the dark, turning his hands over.

She thought of her father standing to the side, with his face out of it.

She did not take her hand away. She turned it. Slowly, in front of eleven hundred people, her right hand turned over on the casing until it was lying under it

rather than over it, palm up, as you hold your hand out to a horse. She opened her fingers. Not away from it. Out from round it.

The casing went soft. It ran. It was brine in her palm, warm for a moment with the small shove of the moth's arrears. The moth sat in the middle of her hand in the wet, a brown moth with a dark bar on each wing, and she felt the rush come up in her, small, a flush and a quickening of the heart. The light seemed for an instant too bright and the bees too loud.

The moth opened its wings. It shut them. It opened them.

Then it went up off her palm in its jerky, stupid, moth's flight, up over the dais and the panel, toward the nearest chandelier, toward the light. It went up and up until it was a speck among the burning crystal limbs, and then she could not see it at all.

Someone in the top tier began clapping: hard hands that had raked a pan for forty years, slapping together slow and loud and alone. Hester looked up, and saw her father standing at the rail of the top tier in a coat she had never seen before. It was a good dark coat, brushed, too tight in the shoulders, and he was clapping with his face set and his chin up as if he were daring the whole of Ambry to tell him to sit down.

Daisy Fenn was beside him with a baby on her hip and four children round her knees, and she began to clap too. Then the Lowside tier, and then the second tier, and then, for a moment, the whole hall.

"Assayed," said Crisp, over it, in her small voice that reached the roof, "with distinction."

* * *

She came down the steps without feeling them. Teo caught her at the bottom by both arms and said something she did not hear. Saskia, on the bench, gave her a short nod. Lucan, two places along, did not look at her at all, which she understood to be his version of the same.

She sat. Her palm was still wet. She closed her hand on it.

When she looked up at the dais again, Orsolya was looking at her.

The hall was loud round them. Through all of it the Warden of the Lower Fathoms sat at the end of the panel table with her cold hands folded in front of her and looked down at Hester Vail across forty feet of salt floor and a winter's worth of lies. Hester looked back.

Orsolya knew. Hester saw her know it. It was in the slackening of her face, the way a sail slackens when the wind drops: not surprise, and not anger. Orsolya had seen her name the seventh dish and seen her open her hand. She knew there would be no answer to her offer, because the answer had been given, out loud, in front of the city. Whatever Hester meant to do, Hester had decided to do it.

Then Crisp said "Warden?" for the second time, about the next candidate's tray, and Orsolya turned her head and answered, and it was over.

* * *

The Assay ended at the ninth bell. Crisp spoke the closing formula, and the Glaziers went up in the rope-cradles and let the chandeliers run out. The spring light drained along the crystal limbs and went, and the hall seemed small and cold. Then the great doors at the west end were opened onto the Gatehouse yard, and the smell of roasting came in, and the noise of Ambry on the other side of the Line, and the Feast began.

The Long Table under the Lantern Well was laid from end to end, three hundred feet, with every Reader and Fellow and aspirant in the Halcyon crammed along both sides. In the Gatehouse yard there were trestles and braziers for the porters and cooks and delvers, roast mutton and saltcake by the yard and Harl cider in barrels, and the Lowside Bench singing a ballad about the sea, very badly. Above it all the Lantern's mirrors stood still, turned to the night, and down the Well came the last of the year's kept midsummer, gold, poured out by the Glaziers in honour of the Assayed.

The Choir came up from the Stays in its grey wool at the tenth bell and was cheered along the Long Table. Hester counted them as they came. Fifty-one. She knew the Choir's roll: sixty-two. Eleven left below, then. A skeleton watch, as Saskia had said.

Orsolya came up with them. She sat at the Readers' end of the table between Crisp and the Chancellor's empty chair, and did not eat, and did not look down the table.

Aldous found Hester in the yard. He had his good coat buttoned to the throat and a cup of cider he had not drunk, and he stood in front of her among the braziers and did not seem to know what to do with either of them.

"Didn't know you could do that," he said.

"Nor did I. Till this week."

"With the moth." He turned his hand over in the air, palm up, clumsily. "That."

"You taught me."

He looked at her. He looked down at the cider. Then he drank the whole of it in one swallow and gave her the empty cup, as if that were a thing a man did, and said, "Stand to the side," and went off through the gate toward the Causeway without looking back.

At the half bell after the tenth, Lucan and Teo went out through the gate with a crowd of Ambry people going home. Teo had a sack over his shoulder that clanked once when he set it down to pull his collar up. Lucan, among the furs and black coats, was suddenly only another Exchequer man's son walking his friend into town. Neither of them looked back at her. Teo, at the gate, lifted one hand above his head without turning round, the fingers open.

Saskia had gone a quarter of an hour before. She had kissed Pip goodnight at the gate and walked back in along the First Fathom past the Long Table. As she passed the clerks' benches she looked at a gap in them: an empty place halfway down, where a plate of mutton sat untouched with a knife and fork laid neatly across it. Hester had seen her see it.

Then Saskia had gone down the Stair.

Hester stood in the yard with her father's empty cup in her hand and the brazier-smoke in her eyes. Her palm was dry now, but she could still feel the place in the middle of it where the moth had sat. Against her breastbone, Agathe's letter had gone warm.

At the eleventh bell, Sorle came out of the Gatehouse door in his black gown with a lantern and a canvas satchel over his shoulder. The satchel was full of slates, and they knocked together as he walked. He looked at her across the yard, and did not need to speak.

She set the cup down on the edge of a trestle, and went in.

CHAPTER 23

# *The Old Tap*



*Take her off the heat slow.*

— Saying of the Lowside brine-boilers

The Stair was empty all the way down.

On ordinary nights there was always someone on it. Tonight the whole Halcyon was up at the Long Table or out in the Gatehouse yard. The noise of the Feast came down the Well behind them, fainter at every turn, until by the Third Fathom it was only a murmur, like the sea in the Roar. Then it was nothing.

Sorle went ahead with the lantern. He took the steps one at a time, his free hand trailing along the wall, over the chalk-names of the Settled. Hester came behind with the satchel of slates, which he had let her carry after he had stopped twice to breathe. Neither of them spoke. On the Second Fathom she passed one that was newer than the rest and still sharp at the edges, in her own square hand. AMA TESSALY, CHOIR, 903.

At the Fourth they left the Stair. The Choir hall opened out to their left, black and empty. On a bench near the bottom tier someone had left a grey wool scarf. Sorle looked at it as they passed and did not stop.

Saskia was waiting at the box-lift's Fourth Fathom gate, as she had said she would be.

The box-lift was the porters' cage at the back of the Choir hall. It ran from the Fifth to the Third, with a gate here at the Fourth. Three nights a week all summer, at the tenth bell, it had carried sealed grain boxes up from the Stays to the Third Fathom landing, where Saskia had met it with a barrow on Edwin

Dunmore's pass. Saskia sat on an upturned crate beside it with her sleeves still rolled from the Assay, a shuttered lantern at her feet and a canvas sack across her knees. She stood and held out her hand, palm up, and on it was a black iron key longer than her hand, with a little bird sitting on a line on its bow.

"Took you long enough," she said.

"He's sixty-four," said Hester.

"I am present," said Sorle, "and sixty-four and a half. Was there any difficulty?"

"No." Saskia closed her hand on the key again. "That's what I don't like." She looked at Hester. "His desk was locked. I had the drawer open in a count of twenty. The ring was there, *W.L.F. Duplicates* on the tag. The key was there. And his chair was empty, and his coat was gone off the hook. And his plate at the Long Table hadn't been touched."

"Dunmore doesn't miss a Feast," said Hester.

"Dunmore doesn't miss anything." Saskia hitched the sack onto her shoulder; it clinked. "And the key to the Hush was sitting in his drawer where anyone could take it. So either he's stupid tonight, which he isn't, or he's somewhere else with something better to do."

They looked at each other in the lantern-light. Nobody said *Orsolya.*

"Well," said Sorle. "We knew we should not have the night to ourselves. We merely hoped." He held the lantern up to the lift-cage. "In we go."

* * *

THE FIFTH FATHOM WAS WARM.

The Fifth was warm as a cowshed is warm, damply, as if something large were breathing in it. The walls sweated. The salt underfoot was tacky, and their boots made a faint sucking sound on it. Brass stay-lines ran along the walls at shoulder height in sheaths green with age, and where they passed into the salt to feed a stay, the joint was beaded with brine like a glass of cold beer on a summer table.

Far off along the galleries to the west, people were singing.

Eleven voices, Hester thought, low and slow. The skeleton watch, holding the east stays from the Warden's Gallery. The song came along the stay-lines more than through the air; she could feel it in the brass when she put her palm flat on it. *Hold the line, hold the line.* It went on and on, patient, like a woman rocking a cradle in another room.

"This way," said Saskia. "East. Service passage. Nobody comes this way at night."

The service passage was narrow and low and smelled of weed. They went along it in single file. The warmth grew and the singing faded behind them, and another sound came up under it, out of the salt itself. Hester had heard it first in the *Wren* grain, at the Customs House, in another life: a long, low rushing. It rose and fell, and the rise came again before the fall had finished.

"Do you hear that?" said Saskia, low.

"Yes," said Hester.

"I never heard that in the summer."

"No," said Sorle. "I don't suppose it was so loud in the summer."

* * *

The passage came out at the lowest gallery of the Fifth, at the foot of a short flight of steps cut by the founders: shallow, worn into dishes, much older than the Stair. At the bottom the gallery widened into a round chamber. On its far side was the Hush door.

Hester had imagined it many times, and wrongly. It was a door a little taller than a man, set flush in the salt wall. But it was made of salt, lattice-grown so fine and so thick that it was nearly white, like frost on a window, and grown in the shape of the Halcyon's emblem, the bird with its wings folded, sitting on a single straight wave. In the centre of the wave, at the height of Hester's breast, was a keyhole of plain dark iron.

And to the left of the door, coming out of the floor and going into the wall, was the Old Tap.

She knew it from Aske's small sloping hand. A pipe of founders' brass as thick as her thigh, pitted and green-black, rose out of the chamber floor, bent once, and went into the wall beside the Hush door. At the bend was a valve-head the size of a cartwheel. Its spokes were cast in the shape of fishes, worn smooth by centuries of hands. The green on the spokes was rubbed through to bright brass in four places, recently, where hands had been.

From the valve-head a newer pipe ran off along the gallery wall toward the west, brass still yellow under its varnish, to join the stay-lines. The eastern trunk. The line from the Cold House came up out of the floor here and fed every stay in the Fifth.

Hester put the satchel down. She went to the Old Tap and laid her palm on the great curve of the pipe below the valve, slowly, as you lay a hand on a sleeping animal.

It was cold. It was the only cold thing in the Fifth.

There was a tasting-cock at the bend, a small founders' tap the size of a thimble with a fish for a handle, for drawing samples from the line. Someone had used it often; the fish was bright. She turned it a quarter-turn. A bead of brine swelled at its lip, clear, and hung. She took it on her fingertip and put it on her tongue.

Forty thornes.

The weight came down behind her eyes not like a door but like a mountain: the stillness of three hundred people lying in rows under high windows, drawn out of them through the dark. In it, under it, fainter than anything, she could taste—not taste, there was no word, there would never be a word—something that was not stillness at all, but was in the stillness as a voice is in a room. A boy who had whistled. A pencil.

She stood with her hand on the pipe and her finger in her mouth like a child.

"Hester," said Saskia, quite gently, behind her.

"I know." She took her finger out of her mouth and wiped her eyes with the back of her wrist, and was not surprised to find salt on it. "It's his. It's all of them." She turned. "It's not twelve yet."

Sorle had his watch open under the lantern, a fat Hask silver turnip that had been his wife's father's.

"Seven minutes before the half," he said. "Something over half a bell before Mr. Ferrers puts his saw to it, if Mr. Ferrers keeps time, which he will. He is the kind of young man who arrives early to his own funeral." He snapped the watch shut. "Mrs. Orme. The key."

* * *

The key turned stiffly, with a long grinding sound in the lattice. It went round once and stuck, and Saskia leaned on it with both hands and her whole weight, swearing in Quellish, and it went round again. Something deep in the door let go with a soft heavy click, like a bone going back into its socket.

The door swung inward on no hinge she could see. And the hum came out.

She had felt it in Russet, on the tour, as a faint pressure in her back teeth. It came out now through the open door and went straight into the bones of her face. It was quiet, and it was in her jaw and her breastbone and the roots of her hair. The lantern-glass sang faintly with it. Sorle put his hand to his ear and took it away.

"Well," he said. His voice was not quite steady. "There you are."

They went in.

The Hush was not a room. It was a floor.

It went back beyond the lantern's reach in every direction, flat and level, its low roof held up here and there by pillars of lattice-grown salt, white and slender, like birch trees in a winter wood. Old founders' brass with fish-head joints ran pillar to pillar and across the floor in channels, and every channel was dry. Here and there something brass glinted that she did not understand at all: a wheel, a great ring set in the floor, a bank of small handles like the stops of an organ.

The floor was salt. Not white salt. Clear.

Saskia had stopped. She was holding her lamp out at arm's length and looking down, and Hester looked down too, and stood still.

The light went into the floor as it would go into clear water, and it did not stop. It went down a fathom, two fathoms, more, and the salt below them was shot through with the fine planes of its crystals like the grain in a sheet of glass. Below the lantern's last reach, where the light failed, the dark had a shape.

She could not have said what shape. It was too large to be a shape: a darkness that had edges, far down, and the edges went on past where the light could follow. Rock would have been grey. This was black, and it was long, and at one place, where Saskia's lamp swung, Hester thought she saw a line along it, ruled, as straight as a thing that had been made. Then the lamp swung back and it was only dark.

"What is that?" said Saskia. Her voice was hardly a breath.

Sorle did not answer. He was standing beside them with the satchel of slates over his shoulder, looking down. His lips moved.

"Benedek," said Hester.

He did not move.

"Benedek. *Don't.*"

He looked up at her. In the lantern-light his face was naked. He had been looking for something under the salt for thirty-two years, and they had laughed

at him in Conclave for it. Now it was under his feet. He could have stood there till he Settled.

"Not now," said Hester. "After. I swear to you. After, we'll come back with every lamp in the Halcyon and you can look till you're blind. Not now."

He looked at her a moment longer. Then he nodded, once, and took his eyes off the floor, and she saw what it cost him.

"East," he said. "The survey says east."

* * *

They heard the quickening before they saw it.

The rushing in the salt had been growing all across the Hush floor, rising under the hum until it was louder than the hum. Then there was a smell, and it was the smell from the Silent Supper: cold weed, green and alive, nothing rotten in it. The salt underfoot went from dry to tacky to wet. Then the lantern found the east wall.

It was wet from roof to floor. Not beaded, running. Brine came down the salt in thin glittering sheets and pooled in the old channels at the foot of the wall, and the channels were not dry any more. The wall was warm to the hand. It *moved*. When she put her palm on it she could feel it under her skin, a slow thrust and fall, like the side of a horse when it breathes. And the sound came out of it, and it was the sea: waves breaking on something a long way off, and wind, and once, far and faint, a cry she knew. Two notes, and a third that cracked.

Fixed into the wall at shoulder height was a great stay-cock of founders' brass. A founders' line came to it from the Old Tap, all the way across the Hush roof, to pour the trunk's stillness into the face of the quickening. The cock was open. The pipe was cold. Where it went into the salt the wall was not wet but dry, a great dry fan spread out round the joint like a hand laid flat over a mouth.

A lid, Hester thought. A lid with a hand on it.

"There," said Saskia.

The Founders' Shaft was ten yards along the wall to the north, at the foot of it. A collar of bronze as wide as a cartwheel, green with age, was set upright into the salt at the floor, and filling the collar, flush with it, was the plug: a disc of lattice-grown salt, white, smooth as a millpond and hard as marble. Behind it, the survey said, a short adit ran six yards into the wall and turned straight up, six hundred

feet through the dome to the surface, a quarter-mile east of the Lantern, to a lid with a chain on it.

"Six feet thick," said Sorle. "Per the survey."

"Per the survey," said Saskia, "the founders were honest men."

She swung the sack off her shoulder and opened it. In it were two crowbars, a mallet, her glazier's chisel and a copper pan with a lid. Packed in sacking were six of the Lumen kilns' heat-jars, salt kept round a summer afternoon at the furnace mouth, which were not supposed to leave the kilns. Saskia unstoppered the first into the copper pan with a dipper of live brine from Hester's flask, and the summer let go into the brine with a soft cough, and steam came up off the pan in the warm dark.

"Well?" she said. "It won't dissolve itself."

* * *

IT WOULD NOT DISSOLVE AT ALL.

Sorle's slates said they need not go through it: free the seam where nine centuries had grown the plug into its collar, all round the rim, and the plug would come out like a cork. He had allowed an hour for it. They poured the hot brine into the seam and it ran off. They poured it again, slower, a cupful at a time into a notch Hester cut with the point of the crowbar, and it hissed and ate in a little and stopped. Lattice-grown salt was not mined salt. It had been grown on purpose, crystal locked into crystal along a worker's template, and it was as hard as a thing is when somebody has meant it to be.

So they did it the slow way. Hot brine into the notch; the chisel into the soft; the bar behind the chisel. Lever, crack, prise, and a flake of white came away no bigger than a coin. Hot brine again. Saskia worked the pan and the jars and set the chisel for each cut with a glazier's tap of the mallet. Hester lay on her side in the wet and worked the bar, because she had the arms for it; she had raked pans at ten and carried crates for twenty years, and the old work came back into her shoulders as if it had been waiting. Sorle held the lantern and read the watch and, when he could not stop himself, took the second bar, useless and stubborn, until his breath was coming in long hoarse pulls and his hands were bleeding where the iron had taken the skin. Hester took the bar off him without asking.

"Sit down."

"I will not—"

"Sit *down*, Benedek, before I keep you sitting."

He sat on the wet floor with his back against the wall, and the lantern in his lap, and the watch in his bleeding hand, and laughed. It was a short cracked sound.

"Corvin would have enjoyed this," he said. "Corvin always said I'd never done an honest day's labour."

They worked the south side first, where the seam was widest. The notch became a groove, and the groove a slot that took the bar to half its length, and she was working with her cheek on the wet salt and the steam in her eyes. The brine ran back down her sleeves to the elbow, hot and then cold. Every so often she stopped to breathe and Saskia went in with the dipper, and every so often Sorle said the time. Eleven and three-quarters. Twelve, less ten. Less five.

"Hester," said Sorle.

She came out from the plug. He was holding the watch up to the lantern.

"Twelve, less two," he said. "If you want to be at the line when it goes."

She went to the stay-cock and found its tasting-cock, and drew a bead, and put it on her tongue.

Forty thornes. The mountain. Tib.

She stood with the bead on her tongue and her eyes shut, and waited. Behind her the bar had stopped. The wall beside her breathed in and out against her shoulder, and the sea went on breaking a long way off inside the salt. Six fathoms above her, beyond hearing, the Halcyon was ringing the twelfth bell.

"Twelve," said Sorle.

The weight changed.

It did not stop. It thinned. A door had opened very far away and a draught had come down a long corridor; she felt it go out of the stillness before she knew what it was. Thirty-five thornes. Thirty. Then faster, all at once, as if a rope had been cut and a weight had dropped off the end of it. Twenty. Ten. The coins came off her eyelids one by one, and the mountain went, and the weight behind her eyes went light, lighter, gone. On her tongue was a bead of nothing but brine. Old brine. Flat. Tasting of nothing but the pipe it had come through.

Two miles away, under Coldwater Street, a young man who arrived early to his own funeral had put his saw to a brass rod, and Teo had put his to another.

"They've cut it," she said.

Her voice did not come out as she meant it to. She found she had both hands flat on the stay-cock, holding on.

"They've cut it. It's not coming any more." She turned round. "It's *his* again. It's staying with him."

Saskia's face across the lantern was wet, from the steam or not, and she did not wipe it.

"Good," she said. "Now get back on that bar."

* * *

The quickening knew before they did.

The wall beside the stay-cock gave a long shudder under Hester's hand. The great dry fan of salt round the joint, the hand over the mouth, went dark from the edges in, as a cloth goes dark when you drop it in water. Then it was wet. Then it was running. Then, with a sound like a cork coming out of a bottle, a jet of water as thick as her finger shot out of the wall a foot from her face and hit the brass and broke into spray.

Salt water. Cold as the sea at the bottom of the world. It ran down her cheek and into her mouth, and she tasted it before she could stop herself. Not brine. Not the sweet weight of grain. It was salt, and something green, and something alive, and there was not a grain of stillness left in it. It was water that was going somewhere.

"*Hester!*"

She went back to the plug. The noise was rising behind her, the whole east wall a drum. Water ran ankle-deep in the old channels, and the founders' brass in them rang faintly, like a struck glass. The hum of the Hush had risen too, and was in her teeth so hard that her eyes watered.

"Bar," she said.

Saskia put the bar into her hands. Hester lay down in the water and drove it into the slot. The brine ran down her arms. She struck and levered and struck. Saskia poured, and poured again, and swore, and opened the last of the heat-jars into the pan without measuring, and the summer coughed out into the steam. Sorle was up off the floor again. He stood with his back to the breathing wall and the lantern high and the watch open in his other hand, saying *steady, steady, steady*, to nobody, or to all of them.

The bar went in to its full length, and something gave: a long low groan inside the plug, like a ship's timber taking strain, and the whole south side of the disc shifted under the bar by a hair and settled. A thread of cold came out of the seam over Hester's face. Air. Cold, dry, smelling of frost: air from six hundred feet above, from the open White under the midwinter stars, coming down the Founders' Shaft through a hole she could not see.

"It's through," said Saskia. "Hester, it's *through*—"

"Not enough." The thread of cold was the width of a straw. Hester put her hand on the north rim, and the north rim might have been part of the wall. "Loose this side. Not that. It'll want the whole throat."

Behind them a second jet broke from the east wall, and a third, and the sea in the salt roared.

And far above them, faint, and then not faint, a bell began to ring.

It was not any of the Halcyon's hours. It was a bell Hester had heard only once before, in Cinder, in the middle of the Minute: hard, flat, fast, the alarm from the Warden's Gallery in the Fifth. It came down the stay-lines into the Hush and rang in the brass all round them. Under it, faint, she heard the skeleton watch's song in the west galleries break off in the middle of a note. A little later it started again, ragged, louder, more voices than eleven, as the alarm went up the Stair into the Feast and the Choir came down.

Saskia looked at Hester. Hester looked at Sorle.

"The stays," said Sorle. "With the draw cut, every stay in the Fifth is starving. They'll have felt it go in the Warden's Gallery the moment it went. They'll think it's the Hush failing. They'll be right." He closed his watch. "They'll be coming down."

"Not to us," said Saskia. "To the stays. They don't know we're—"

"One of them knows," said Hester.

She knelt by the plug with the bar in her hands and the brine running down her arms and the sea breaking at her back. Across the Hush, far off, in the open door under the lattice bird, a light had come.

A lantern. Then two. Then three. They came through the door into the Hush and stopped, and swung slowly as their bearers looked out across the floor of clear salt. Then they came east. The bearers did not hurry, and they did not need to look for anyone. They walked steadily across the Hush toward the one place where anyone could be.

The first lantern was carried low, and the hand under it was steady, and the face above it was in shadow. But Hester knew the walk. She had seen it on the Causeway on the first morning, coming from Ambry with the salt-mud on its boots. She had seen it come down the gallery at the Silent Supper with the water running round its ankles, leading the Choir.

"Hester," called Orsolya Thane across the Hush.

Her voice was low and Lowside and level. It carried over the water and the hum and the sea as if they were not there.

"Hester. Lass. What have you done?"

CHAPTER 24

# *The Hush*



*Hold three. Open two.*

— Chalked on the back of one of Reader Sorle's slates, 21 Rime 903

THE PLUG MOVED.

It moved a finger's width, no more, with a grinding sound that Hester felt in her knees before she heard it. A breath of air came out of the crack around it, cold, smelling of frost. Sorle, on his back with the long crowbar braced across his chest, swore in Harlish. Saskia poured the last of the hot brine from the copper into the crack. It steamed and sank and the crack drank it.

"Again," Hester said.

"I am sixty-four years old, Miss Vail."

"Again, Reader."

He set the bar. She put her shoulder under the other end of it. For nine hundred years the plug had sat in its bronze collar and grown into it, as a stone grows into a field. After an hour they had it loose on one side. On the other it held.

Behind them, the Hush roared.

It had only hummed when they came in. Now the quickening at the east end had felt the sleepers' stillness stop, and woken.

She could hear it over the grinding of the bar: surf, loud, close, inside the wall, as if the wall were a cliff and the sea were throwing itself at the far side of it. The whole face of the wall over the pocket was running, and the warmth came off it in a breath.

"It's climbing," Saskia said. She had her watch out on its ribbon, and her lantern on it. "Seventeen minutes since the cut. It's twice as loud as it was at ten."

"I can hear it."

"I'm telling you the rate, Vail. Not the volume."

The plug moved again. The crack opened wider, a dark half-moon along its lower edge, and the cold of the White at night came down six hundred feet and out of it. Sorle let go of the bar and lay back on the salt and breathed like a broken bellows.

"Enough," he said. "That will have to do. The water will take the rest."

"Will it?"

"If it doesn't," said Sorle, with his eyes shut, "we shall none of us be in a position to complain."

* * *

The three lanterns came on across the Hush.

She had known Orsolya would come. She had bet on it. The cut would show in the stays above within a quarter of an hour; the Warden would feel it in her hands before any alarm was rung. Hester had known all that. She had not known what it would be like to see her.

Orsolya covered the last yards with her lantern held high. Two Fathomers in iron-grey followed her, a young man and an older woman. Behind them came Dunmore, in his coat, holding his lantern too low, as if he thought he could avoid being seen by it. Orsolya's white hair was loose. She stopped at the top of the founders' steps at the east end, three shallow treads where the brass trunk of the stay-lines came down out of the roof, and looked at it all: the plug, the bars, Sorle on his back, Saskia with her watch. Then she looked at Hester, standing at the east wall in brine to her ankles with her sleeves rolled to the elbow.

"Oh, lass," she said.

"We cut the draw," Hester said. "That's what I've done."

"I know you've cut the draw. I've two hundred feet of stay-line up there going soft as butter. I've the east gallery of the Fifth sweating like a cheese." She came down the steps. Her voice was quite level. Her hands, Hester saw, were shaking: the Choir's hands, white with cold. "You've killed us all. You know that? You've killed us all, and whoever you've got at the Cistern, and your brother's folk in Lowside. When this goes, it'll not stop at the Hush. It'll not stop at the Halcyon."

"It's not going to *go*. It's going up." Hester pointed at the shaft. "That's the Founders' Shaft. It comes out at the Well-Cap, on the open White. We're giving it a road."

Orsolya looked at the black half-moon under the plug. Then she laughed, short and dry, like salt underfoot.

"A road," she said. "You've been talking to Benedek."

"I've been talking to Corvin."

That stopped her.

"I read his notebook," Hester said. "*She is right that it will flood. She is wrong that it must be held. The pressure wants a road, not a lid.* He'd worked it out. He was coming to tell you. And you kept him."

Behind Orsolya, the young Fathomer turned his head sharply and looked at his Warden. Dunmore, on the bottom step, did not look at anyone.

"Warden," said the older Fathomer. "Warden, the gallery. The Choir's at the east stays and they're failing. Half of them are on the floor."

As if it had heard her, the east wall spoke.

* * *

It spoke as a change in everything at once. The surf behind the salt stopped, as a man stops between one breath and the next. In the silence the lantern flames leaned toward the wall, all of them together, every flame in the Hush bowing east. Then the skin of salt over the pocket broke.

It did not crack. It *opened*, all along a seam the height of a man, the way a fish's belly opens under a knife. Out of the seam came the sea.

It was black as ink in the lantern-light, and colder than any water she had ever put her hands in, and it came out of the wall in a solid curved sheet and hit the clear floor of the Hush and spread. It was round her ankles and then round her shins before she had taken a step. It smelled. Oh, it smelled: weed and salt, green and cold and living, nothing rotten in it at all, the smell of a thing that had been alive in great quantities, all together, nine hundred years ago, on the last afternoon there was a sea.

And it was alive. She knew it in her mouth before she knew it any other way. The spray hit her lips and she tasted it, and it was not grain. It was not stillsalt, not sweet, not heavy on the eyes. It was quick. Everything in it was quick. It was

the bead in the crystal at the Customs House and the beads on Tib's casing, all at once, the startle and the bitten tongue. There was nothing still in it anywhere.

Saskia was shouting. Sorle was on his feet, somehow, with his slate in one hand. The water reached the open plug and found the half-moon crack and went into it with a sound like an enormous throat swallowing. For an instant all of it went into the shaft.

Then the seam in the wall opened wider, and more came, and the shaft could not drink fast enough.

Where it ran, the clear floor went soft under it. It pitted, and then it was gone a finger deep, a hand deep, as frost goes off a step under hot water. When the next surge slapped up Hester's arm she tasted it again, and it had changed: quick still, but sweet now, and heavy behind the eyes. The sea had eaten the clear floor. It ran thick with dissolved Hush, live brine to the elbow.

"*Hold it!*" That was Orsolya. She had come down into the water, waist-deep in it now at the bottom of the steps, and she had her hands out in front of her, under the surface. She was going into the hold. Hester could feel her going, as you feel cold coming off a window, a deep old practised stillness reaching out through the brine toward the seam. "Hold it, all of you, hold it shut—"

"No!" Hester was at the wall. She did not remember crossing to it. She was standing in the black water to her knees with her hands flat on the salt on either side of the open seam, and the cold of it was in her wrists like knives. "No. Don't hold it. Give it the shaft. Saskia. *Saskia.* The count."

"I know the count!" Saskia had climbed onto the founders' brass housing beside the plug, out of the water, her lantern on her watch. "On your release. Hold three, open two. Hold three—*Vail, you have to open it.*"

She had to open it.

Hester stood with her hands on the salt and the sea coming past her knees. She went into the hold, because that was where you started, and the hold came to her as it always came: deep, square, immovable, a door shutting. The salt under her palms answered it. She felt the seam stiffen and the water slacken through it. The stillness went out of her into the wall, the way it went into the stay-lines in the Choir, the way it had gone into the brine over Lucan's falling body on the White. The seam began to close.

"*No!*" Saskia's voice cracked. "You're holding! Vail, you're *holding* it—"

She knew. She could feel herself doing it. It was like watching her own hand close on a coin. She told it to open. It did not open. The sea pressed on the far side of the salt, nine hundred years of it, and her hold met it and held. The pressure climbed. She felt it climb through her palms into her wrists and her elbows and her teeth. This was no longer the warmth of the quickening but the arrears, the whole debt of the moment piling up behind the seam like water behind a dam. She was the dam.

"Release it, girl," said Sorle, close beside her. He had come into the water. "Release it. If it builds behind you and you let go all at once, it'll take the floor out."

"I can't."

"You can."

"*I can't.*" She had never in her life been able to. She had kept a falling drop for Crisp and stood there with it kept until Crisp sighed. She had kept Lucan Ferrers in the mouth of a sink and stood over him while the casing dragged, until Orsolya talked her through it. She had stood in front of a moth in the Hall of Assay and— She had done the moth. She had opened her hand for the moth. But a moth was a moth, and this was the sea.

The salt under her hands was creaking, a long low groan like a ship's timbers in a story. Little fractures ran out from the seam across the clear floor of the Hush, white lines in the black water, spreading.

* * *

Behind her Saskia was still counting, hold three, open two, to a woman who could only hold.

Hester thought of her father.

Not the man in the tight coat at the rail of the top tier. The man at the fire-door of pan nineteen with his face out of the steam, drawing the coals one shovelful at a time and laying them on the brick where he could get them back. *You hurry her and she'll go up all at once.* She had the fire-door clamped shut, and the pan was cracking its iron.

And under that, under everything, a boy's voice in a hot room above Tanner's Row. He had opened his eyes in the middle of the night and found her and said, as clearly as he had ever said anything: *Let me sleep, Hes. Just let me sleep.*

She had known what he meant. She had stood at the desk on Coldwater Street with his voice in her ears and known what he meant, and signed. She had told herself every month for eleven years that keeping was sleep and he had asked for it. She had kept him because she could not open her hand. Not for him. For her.

She was holding the sea shut for the same reason.

*Open your hand.* She had first heard it on the White, in another woman's voice, and then it had been a thing done to her. It was hers now. She had learned it on the rim of the Pans in the dark, failing seven times in twelve and then two, with Teo's hands turning over beside her: not away from it. Out from round it. Flat, as you hold your palm out to a horse.

"Saskia," she said. "Count."

"Hold," said Saskia. Her voice was steady now. "Hold—hold—*now*."

Hester opened her hand.

Keeping was a door shutting. This was a door opening onto a wind, and the wind was the sea. She let the stillness go out of her palms, not pushed but let go, and felt the salt soften under them, and the seam give, a little, a hand's breadth. The water came through it harder and went across the floor and into the shaft-mouth. The plug, under the weight of it, tore loose from its socket with a crack like a tree going over, and the sea took it into the adit and up the shaft ahead of itself like a cork. The whole round mouth of the Founders' Shaft stood open, black, roaring.

"Hold," said Saskia. "Hold—two—three. *Now*."

She opened again. The sea went up.

She could hear it going: a long hollow rising roar inside the shaft, climbing as the water climbed, like nothing she had a word for. She could feel the arrears go with it, the piled-up debt of the moment running out of the salt through her hands and away. A shovelful, and a pause.

Then the cold at her back lifted, as a hand lifts off a shoulder. Orsolya had stopped holding.

Hester looked round. The Warden stood waist-deep at the foot of the steps with her hands still under the water, holding nothing, and her face the colour of the salt. She was looking at the shaft: at the open black mouth of it, and the sea going into it in a hard black rope, and up.

"It's taking it," Orsolya said.

"Yes."

"Up to the White."

"Yes."

Orsolya looked at the shaft for three breaths. Hester knew what she was seeing, because Orsolya had told her twice. A girl of eleven at the Coldbank pit-head among the women, on the day the roof came in. Under her feet, in the third gallery, the Physic was keeping her father standing under the beam, and all round her the men were saying *if they'd only shored it, if they'd only.*

"*Shore it,*" Orsolya said. Then, louder, turning: "*Shore it, lads.* Brannoc. Iley. Up the steps, both of you. Fingers in the trunk, every slot you can reach, and hold it. All of it. Every stay in the Fifth. You hold that gallery dry while this lass does what she's doing, and you don't let go till I tell you."

"Warden—"

"*Now*, Brannoc."

They went. The young man went first, splashing, and the older woman after him. At the top of the three steps, where the brass trunk of the stay-lines came down out of the dark from the Fifth and ran along the Hush wall, they knelt and pushed their fingers into the brine-slots in its flank, where the live brine stood in the brass. Hester felt them go into the hold together, a smaller, colder stillness, running up the line.

"Mr. Dunmore," Orsolya said. "Go with them."

There was no answer. On the bottom step where Dunmore had stood there was a lantern, set down carefully, still burning. Far back across the Hush, in the dark, feet were running on salt toward the door. Then they were not.

Orsolya made a small sound that might have been a laugh. She waded back through the water to the steps and climbed them and knelt at the trunk between her two Fathomers, and put her white shaking fingers into the slots. Her stillness went out of her into the line, deep and old and enormous. Hester felt it pass along the wall above her head, a cold river going upward, and somewhere above them in the dark the stays of the Fifth Fathom took it and stiffened and held.

"There," Orsolya said, to no one, to the line. "There, now."

*I know her*, Hester had said in Sorle's study, to people who thought her mad. *She'll not let them drown.*

"Hold four," said Sorle. He was beside her in the water with his slate held up out of it, a stub of chalk in his blue fingers, writing. "The floor's taking strain on the north side. Give it four, Mrs. Orme."

"Hold four," said Saskia. "One. Two. Three. Four. Now."

Hester opened her hand. The sea went up.

It went on like that. Sorle said, later, forty minutes; Saskia said fifty-two, and hers was the watch that had stayed dry. Hold and open. Hold and open. Each time she opened, the sea went into the shaft in a black pulse and rose, roaring, until she lost it six hundred feet above her head, where the Well-Cap sat on the salt under the stars. Each time she held, the white fractures in the floor stopped spreading. Each time Saskia said *now* it was a little easier to open, and a little harder to come back.

Because it cost. The rush, the Primer called it, as if it were a thing that happened to other people. Every time she let go, the stillness she let go came back up her arms as heat, and the heat was in her chest, and her heart was going faster and faster: not the pounding of fear but something simpler and worse, a wheel spinning free. Sweat ran into her eyes and did not sting. The lanterns had got too bright. Saskia's voice came to her too fast, each word clipped off at the end, as if someone were winding the world on a key. The sound of the sea went up in pitch until it was nearly a whistle.

"Hold," said Saskia, from a great way off. "Hold. Vail? *Vail*. Now."

She opened her hand, and this time, when Saskia said *hold*, the roar did not fall back.

It went on, long and steady, no longer in pulses. The sea was going up the shaft without her: a river climbing, the pressure behind the seam running out evenly, of itself, the way a pan goes on talking quietly for an hour after the fire is drawn.

"It's going." Saskia's voice cracked upward. "It's going on its own. Vail, it doesn't need you. Take your hands off—"

She could not take her hands off. The wheel in her chest had no brake on it any more.

The whole Hush went white.

* * *

She was on her knees in the water. She did not remember kneeling. Her heart was going so fast it was no longer a beat but a hum, like the Hush's hum, like a bee in a jar. Her hands were still flat on the salt. She could not take them away. She could not see. Someone had her by the shoulders.

"Still runs to quick," said Sorle's voice in her ear, and it was the first time she had ever heard him sound frightened. "Still runs to quick, damn you, hold *on*—"

He had his hands over hers on the wall, in the water: the Physic's way, a still hand laid over a racing one in shared brine. The live brine was over all four of their hands, thick with the dissolved Hush. She felt his hold go into it, an old man's hold, thin and dry and enormously patient, a stillness that had sat at a desk for thirty-two years with nothing to do but think. It ran out of him into the brine and through the brine into her, because that was the law, because still runs to quick, and nothing in the world had ever been quicker than Hester Vail at that moment. It went into her hands and up her arms. It found the spinning wheel in her chest and laid itself across it like a palm across a top.

The hum slowed. It became a beat. Fast, too fast, but a beat. She could hear it. She could hear Saskia sobbing somewhere and saying *now, now, now* to nobody, and the sea going up the shaft on its own in its long steady roar.

Then Sorle's hands went slack on hers. He sat down in the water.

"Reader," she said. Her voice was nothing. "Reader."

He did not answer. He was sitting up to his chest in black water with his eyes open and his chalk still in his fingers. She knew what it was. She had done it herself on the White, for four minutes, and come back with the sky changed. He had given her his stillness, and now he was lagging.

She held his hand and waited. She counted. At a hundred and eighty he blinked, once, slowly, like an owl. At two hundred he said, in a perfectly ordinary voice, "—*on*, Miss Vail," finishing the sentence he had started three minutes before. Then he looked down at himself, at the water, and said, "Ah."

He lifted his left hand out of the brine. It was white to the wrist, the white of a Choir hand, and it stayed as it had lain over hers on the wall, flat, the fingers a little parted. She watched him tell it to close. It did not close.

"Ah," he said again, more quietly.

She meant to answer that. Then Saskia had her face between both hands and was saying her name, and Sorle was sitting further off on the edge of the brass housing, and the lantern had been moved. She had lost a minute. Two. The lag had waited, as lag did, until she put the weight down.

The roar in the shaft was dropping.

It dropped as a wind drops at evening on the White, in long lowering breaths. The seam still ran with water, but less, and less. The black flood across the clear

floor of the Hush had stopped rising; it was going down, drawn back toward the seam in long slow currents, into the hollow behind the wall where the quickening had been. The lantern flames had stopped bowing east. They stood up straight.

The surf behind the wall was gone. The hum of the Hush came back, the old pressure in the teeth. But it was lower, Hester thought. Lower than it had been. As if something very large and very far away had let out a breath and not yet drawn the next one.

Saskia was holding her watch in both hands like something that might break. She looked at it, and at Hester, and put it back in her pocket, carefully, and sat down on the housing with her face in her hands.

For a while none of the three of them could manage a word.

* * *

When Hester could stand, she stood. Sorle had to help her and she had to help him, so it took some time. The water was below her knees now and going down, and she did not look at what the floor showed her under it.

At the top of the three steps, by the brass trunk of the stay-lines, the two Fathomers were sitting against the wall. The young man was awake and shaking, his teeth chattering, his arms wrapped round his knees. The older woman was lagging still. Her eyes were open on nothing.

Orsolya was kneeling between them, where she had knelt. Her hands were still at the trunk.

No. They had come out of the slots. They lay in her lap, palms up, open, the white fingers a little curled, as a sleeper's hands are curled. She was sitting back on her heels with her head bent a little forward, as though looking down into her own palms for something written there. She did not blink when Hester's lantern came up the steps.

"Warden," said the young Fathomer, Brannoc, through his chattering teeth. "She let go when it slowed. She said, *that's it, that's done.* And then she just—sat."

Hester knelt down in front of her. She knew the look of it from the gallery floor of the Fourth Fathom on the night of the Silent Supper, when Ama Tessaly sat down in the middle of a stay and did not get up again. But Ama's lips had gone grey, and Orsolya's had not. Orsolya's chest was moving, slower than sleep, a breath to every ten of Hester's.

Settled. Not to death. For hours, perhaps. Perhaps a day. Thirty years in the Choir and one more hold than her heart had wanted to give.

Hester sat back on her heels opposite her, so that they were two women kneeling face to face on a step in the dark with the water going down below them. She found that she was crying, and that her tears were leaving salt on her cheeks, and that she did not care.

"It went up," she told Orsolya. "It went up the shaft. All of it. The Fifth held. You held it. I told them you would."

Orsolya's open hands lay in her lap.

Below them in the Hush the last of the black water slid back through the seam into the emptied dark behind the wall, and was gone, and left the floor shining, pitted and scored with white fractures, drying already at the edges into a thin new skin of salt.

CHAPTER 25

# *The Gull*



*And the grey birds cried over Ostrine water where no grey bird has cried since.*

— "The Last Fleet," Rim ballad, traditional

They carried her up the Stair in a blanket slung between two porters, because her legs would not do it. She remembered pieces. The chalk-names going past at the height of her eyes, Ama Tessaly's new and white among the old. Saskia's voice somewhere below saying *mind her head, mind her head, for pity's sake.* A Proctor's lantern. The cold. The cold most of all: her clothes were soaked to the chest with seawater, and the seawater had begun, in the long climb, to dry on her into a crust, and the crust was not grain. It kept nothing. It only itched.

At the First Fathom someone tried to take her to the Physic wards and she said no, so clearly that the porters stopped.

"The Well-Cap," she said. "I want to see."

"Miss, you're not fit—"

"Take her," said Sorle's voice, from somewhere behind. He was walking, with a stick he had got from somewhere, and a Proctor holding his other arm. "Take her up, man. She has earned the view. So, God help me, have I."

They came out of the Gatehouse into the dark before dawn.

It was the hard dark of midwinter on the White, the frost so deep that the air seemed to ring with it. The Lantern stood up black against a sky going grey at its eastern edge. The salt of the Shelf was stiff with rime and squealed under the porters' boots. And it was full of people: Proctors with lanterns, Readers with blankets

over their gowns, aspirants still in their Assay Night finery, half-drunk and white-faced, porters and cooks, all standing in the frost on the eastern flank of the dome, in a long uneven line, looking east.

There was steam in the east.

The porters carried her round the foot of the Lantern and set her down on the salt at the edge of the crowd, and Saskia came and knelt and put a second blanket round her and held it closed at her throat. Hester looked.

A quarter of a mile out on the White, where the Well-Cap had sat for nine centuries on its square of founders' brick, there was no Well-Cap. There was a lake.

It lay on the white plain like ink spilled on paper, roughly round, four or five hundred yards across, perhaps more. It was steaming. The water was warmer than the midwinter air, and the steam hung a man's height above it and drifted south on the faint wind. Near the middle the water was still welling, slowly, from the mouth of the Founders' Shaft, in a low dome a few yards wide, like a spring in a field. At the edges it had frozen. All round the lake, where the black water met the white salt, a rim of ice was forming, grey and thin and creaking, a yard wide, two yards, and the frost was growing out across the water on it in long feathered spears.

The iron Well-Cap lay on the salt a hundred yards from the shore, upside down, where the sea had thrown it.

"Oh," said Saskia, beside her, on a long breath. That was all.

The whole long line of them stood on the frozen dome and watched the steam go up. Somewhere behind Hester a woman was crying, quietly, the way you cry at a wedding. The sound of the water came to them across the quarter-mile of salt. It was a soft lapping, a small slap and suck where the ice met it, and it was a sound that not one person standing on the Shelf had ever heard in their lives, except in a bathtub.

* * *

The light came up slowly. That was midwinter: the sun took its time. The sky went from grey to pearl to a thin cold rose, and the White went rose with it, and the steam on the lake went gold at its upper edge where the first light caught it. And as the light came, people began to walk out.

A few aspirants first, daring each other. Then Bassano, unmistakable in a fur hat. Then more, and Proctors half-heartedly trying to stop them, and then not trying. Hester got up. Saskia said "Vail—" and then saw her face, and got up too, and put an arm under her shoulder, and they walked out across the frozen salt together, very slowly. Sorle came behind them on his stick, saying nothing at all.

The shore of the lake, when they reached it, was a ridge of new ice standing up from the salt like the lip of a cup. Beyond it the grey rim of frozen sea ran out a few yards and thinned and went black. Hester stood at the ridge and looked down.

The water was clear. She had thought it was black; it was not. It was black the way deep water is black, and at the shallow edge, where the ice was thin, she could see down through it to the salt floor of the lake a yard below. On the salt floor, lying in the slow current, there was weed.

It was green: not the copper-green of the pans, but green as new grass is green, as Harl cabbages are green in a market in spring. Long ribbons of it, a dozen, more, lifting and lying down again in the welling current, and the light coming through the water lit them from inside. As she watched, one ribbon lifted and turned over and showed the paler underside of itself, and on it, clinging, there was something small and dark and many-legged that moved.

"Crab," said Saskia, in a strange voice. "That's a crab. Isn't it? Pip has a picture book. That's a crab."

It was a crab. It was the size of a sol, dark green and mottled, and it went sideways off the weed and down onto the salt floor and stopped there, waving one small claw at nothing.

And past it, in the deeper water beyond the ice, something flicked. A glint, silver, there and gone. Then another. Then, quite clearly, five or six of them together, small and quick and silver as new flecks, turning all at once in the current as if they were one thing: fish. Living fish, under the ice, in a lake on the White, going about the business of being fish as though nothing had happened to them at all. As though the afternoon on which the sea had last been a sea had simply gone on.

Hester knelt down on the ice. She put her bare hand flat on it, over the place where the crab was. She did not need the hold. The ice was cold and wet and tasted, when she put her fingers to her mouth, of salt and of nothing else. It was not sweet. There were no coins on her eyelids. It was only salt: the plain bright

startled taste of something that was alive and moving and had no intention of being anything else.

Quick, she thought. All of it quick.

* * *

The gull came out of the steam a little after sunrise.

She knew it before she heard it properly. She had heard it once, in a single grain of warm white salt on a customs bench, on the first morning of autumn: a high falling cry, two notes and a third that broke. Teo had found it for her in a hymnal woodcut in the Brinestacks. *And the gulls, the birds of the sea, crying.* There were no gulls. There had been no gulls on the Rim for nine hundred years.

It came out of the steam near the middle of the lake, in the water, struggling: a lump of wet grey and white, low in the water, beating at the surface with something that might have been wings, and going under, and coming up. The crowd on the shore had seen it. A sound went along them, a long indrawn *oh*. The thing in the water beat at the surface again, and got its head up, and Hester saw a yellow beak and a round furious eye. It was swimming. It was swimming toward the ice on the northern side, where the frozen rim was widest, and it reached the ice and got its breast up onto it and hung there, its feet going, and then hauled itself out, all at once, and stood.

It was the size of a hen, perhaps, or a little bigger, grey on the back and white below, with black at the tips of its long wings. It stood on the ice with the black water behind it and the steam going up, and it shook itself. It shook itself from the head down, all over, the way a dog shakes, and the water flew off it in a spray that caught the low sun and went gold. It opened its wings and shook them too, and folded them, and opened them again.

Then it put its head back and cried.

Two notes and a third that cracked. A sound like a gate hinge. Like a child calling from a long way off. The sound went out across the White, over the frozen salt and the silent crowd and the black lake steaming, and came back off the dome of the Halcyon as an echo. It was the loudest thing in the world.

Beside her, Saskia had both hands over her mouth.

The gull cried again. Then it ran three steps along the ice and opened its wings and was in the air. It went up into the light, over the steam, beating hard. It circled once over the lake, low, as if to see what it had come out of. Then it turned

west, toward the city, toward the rose-lit roofs of Ambry two miles off on the old shore, and flew. It was a grey speck and then nothing.

It was a long time before anyone on the shore moved.

* * *

When Hester turned round at last, looking for Sorle, she saw the Chancellor.

Perpetua Holm had been carried out of the Readers' Close in a chair. It stood on the salt at the foot of the Lantern, a carved chair with poles for bearers, and four porters stood beside it, stamping in the cold. The Chancellor sat in it as she had sat in the Hall of Assay the day before: upright, wrapped to the chin in black fur, her hands folded on her knees, her white face turned east. She had not moved, as far as Hester could tell, since the porters set her down. She was looking at the place in the sky where the gull had gone.

Hester did not decide to go to her. She found she was walking, with Saskia's arm under hers, to the foot of the Lantern. Up close, the Chancellor's face was very old and very still and quite composed. It was wet. There were lines of salt drying on it, from the corners of her eyes down past her mouth, as the tears of the Settled always dried. Hester had expected many things of that face. She had expected anger, or calculation, or the sharp blank fear that had been on Deputy Vey's face on the dais the day before. She had not expected grief.

There was grief in it, a great deal of grief, like a weight at the bottom of a scale, and no surprise at all.

"Chancellor," Hester said.

The old eyes moved and found her. It took some time. Holm's voice, when it came, was the voice of the Settled, a long slow whisper with pauses in it, as if each word had to be carried up from a long way down.

"Miss Vail," she said. "Aske's aspirant. Sorle's, now, I hear."

"Yes, Chancellor."

"Assayed with distinction." A pause. "Yesterday."

"Yes."

The Chancellor looked past her, east, at the lake. The steam was lifting off it now in the sun, thinning, so that you could see the whole black width of it. There was a line of ice all round its rim, like a ring of salt round the edge of a glass.

"It was always going to come back, Miss Vail," said Perpetua Holm. "We only hoped to be dead first."

Then she closed her eyes. One of the porters looked at another, and they bent and took up the poles, and the chair rose and turned and went away toward the Readers' Close, swaying, with the old woman in it upright and motionless and wet-faced. Hester stood in the frost and watched it go, and did not know what she had just been told, and knew that it was something.

* * *

The rest came fast, as the rest always does. The Halcyon was an institution, and an institution has a way of turning even a sea on the White into paper.

Orsolya Thane woke on the evening of the twenty-second, on a cot in the Physic wards, twenty hours after she had sat down at the top of the three steps. She asked for water, and for Chief Proctor Gage, and for Hester Vail.

Hester was four cots down under two blankets, with Rule's orders not to stand. She stood. A Physic's assistant opened his mouth and shut it again.

Gage came with a clerk and a lamp. He set a stool square to the cot and sat on it with his cap on his knee, and the clerk opened a ledger on the next bed. Orsolya was sitting up against the salt wall with a cup in her two hands. She could not quite close them round it. She looked at Hester a long moment, and then at Gage.

"I'd like her to hear it," she said. "Write down that she's here."

"Aspirant Vail, present." The clerk wrote. "Warden, before you say anything, you should know that—"

"It goes in that book. I know. That's why I asked for the book." Orsolya set the cup on the blanket. "Caution me, Chief Proctor. Then we'll start."

He cautioned her, in the old form, clipped and complete. She heard him out. Then she began, not at the Old Tap, but at the beginning.

"Seedmonth of 901," she said. "The Chancellor's rooms in the Readers' Close, at the Lantern Hour. I took up the returns ledger and the Choir's sick-roll and put them on her table. Perpetua Holm was in the chair. Deputy Chancellor Vey was standing at her shoulder. I asked for an inquiry. I asked for money for twice the Choir. I asked for the Delvers to be stopped on the Shelf." Her voice did not change. "The Deputy did the talking. The Chancellor sat and let him. His words

were, *Manage it quietly, Warden. You've always managed.* Write that down, lad. Those words."

The clerk's pen had stopped. Gage looked at it, and it went on.

She gave the rest in order, with dates, the way a Choir roster is called. The sleeves under Coldwater Street and the brinewright who had fitted them, by name. The contract with Ferrers and Lisk, and the three letters Edwin signed it with, on her word, and where every sol of it had gone: stipends, widows' pensions, never a fleck to her. Bett Linnow, Jem Corrie on the nineteenth, and the three others, by name and plinth. Ama Tessaly, and every shift she had let her sing. Then the sixteenth of Russet.

"Corvin went down to the Old Tap at the ninth bell to shut it," she said. "He meant to be back up for this lass at the tenth. I kept him there, with his hand on the wheel, in Hush grain. Edwin Dunmore and I brought him up the Stair on a cask-trolley, because the porters have the lifts after the eighth. We waited on the turn below his Cell while she stood at the door. We waited again while Benedek Sorle came and went. We had him in a little after the half, and I put a dish in his basin for you to write down."

Hester did not move. She watched the clerk's pen, and the lamp on the ledger, and Orsolya's open hands on the blanket.

It took an hour and a half. At the end of it Gage stood, and put his cap under his arm, and said the words of arrest, and Orsolya bowed her head to them as if to a hymn.

Only then did she look at Hester again.

"Did it all go up?"

"All of it."

Orsolya shut her eyes. "Good," she said. "Then that's done."

Jerome Pell was taken at his sister's house in the Middle Ward on the twenty-third, with the Cold House's Halcyon maintenance receipts in a tin box under her spare bed. Edwin Dunmore had bought passage on an eastbound skiff at the second bell of the twenty-second, paying in silver and not haggling. The skiff was overdue at Quell.

Lucan Ferrers walked into the Assize Chamber on the morning of the twenty-third, without an appointment, in the coat he had worn into the Cistern, which still had brick-dust on the cuffs. He laid on the clerk's table a fair copy, in his own hand, of the residual grain contract between the Office of the Warden of

the Lower Fathoms and Messrs. Ferrers and Lisk, Exchequer Yard, with a sworn statement that he had found the original in his father's study. By noon it was in the *Courant*.

Teo told her about the Cistern that night, sitting on the end of her cot with a twist of saltcake he was not supposed to have brought in.

"You'd think the dark would be the thing," he said. "It wasn't. It was the noise. You know I hear it as voices. All the way down from the grate, the line was full of them. Three hundred, near enough, in the brass. Not words. Like a congregation told to hum that's forgotten the hymn. And the rods were cold enough to take your skin off. Lucan had his watch open on a brick and counted the minutes from the half out loud. I don't think he knew he was doing it.

"We couldn't hear the bell, of course. At twelve he just said 'Now,' very quietly, as if he were asking for the salt, and we put the saws in. Brass is stubborn. It took longer than you'd credit. He slipped and laid the back of his hand open and never said a word. He kept sawing with the blood running into the cut."

He turned the saltcake over and did not eat it.

"And when the rods parted, the voices stopped. Not all at once. They went *back*. Like people coming out of chapel and going home down different streets, one and then the next and the next. I knelt there with my hand on the pipe and listened to every one of them go home. One of them was Tib, I think. Don't ask me how I knew." He smiled, crookedly. "Then Agathe came down the cellar steps with a lamp and a bowl of water for Lucan's hand, and said, 'Well, they're dry, the lot of them,' and boxed both our ears for frightening her. I've never been so glad to be hit."

Hester said nothing. She took the saltcake out of his hand and broke it in two, and gave him half.

The Deputy Chancellor issued a statement on the twenty-fourth, read aloud at the Long Table at the Lantern Hour. It described the events of the night of the twenty-first of Rime as a natural quickening event of unusual magnitude, vented through a disused shaft by the timely action of members of the Halcyon, whom it did not name. It promised a Board of Inquiry. It did not mention a gull, or Seedmonth of 901. Somebody among the third-years laughed out loud at *natural*, and the clerk read on over him.

One pulse of the vent had backed up an old founders' adit into the east gallery of the Fourth, before Sorle lengthened the count, and the overflow stacks there

had been under brine for an hour. Wynn Callow had himself carried down to look at them, and sat in the doorway most of an afternoon, and said nothing to anyone about what he had seen.

Agathe's letter came up on the twenty-fourth. *My dear. They are dry, every one. Your Tib is clear. Nell Corrie is crazed all over like a dropped plate but clear under it, and holding. They have sent us a Mrs. Arden from the Board who seems sensible. Come when you are able. Tide willing. A.L.*

And on the shore of the lake, through all of it, people came: across the Causeway by the hundred and then by the thousand, in carts and on foot and in landships that tacked up and down the black water as near as they dared. They brought children. They filled jars and carried them home. Lowside had already named it the Tear. On the second day the gull came back. It sat on the upturned Well-Cap for an hour in the afternoon sun with the crowd watching it in perfect silence, and then flew off again toward the city, crying.

* * *

Annis Rule had listened to Hester's chest on the morning of the twenty-second with a horn trumpet and her eyes shut, for a long time.

"Your heart keeps its own time now, Miss Vail," she said at last. She let Hester listen to it through the horn: small and quick and not quite even, a tick with a catch in it, like a pan with muck in the bottom. "That will not mend. You may release small things, slowly, with someone counting. But another rush like that will stop it."

Hester buttoned her shirt. "Ta," she said.

They vented Corvin Aske over six days, and they did it small. Rule had said small things, slowly, with someone counting, and Sorle took her at her word: a sixth of the arrears a day, a finger's width of salt at a time, his count, and Rule's fingers on Hester's pulse throughout.

Sorle would not let them do it faster. He had done the arithmetic on four slates, sitting up in a Physic bed, and done it again with Hester checking every line. A man kept in Hush grain for three months, he said, carried arrears enough to boil the blood in his veins if they came out at once. Spread over six days, in a warm bath, in stages, they might come out as a fever.

"Annealed," Saskia said.

"Annealed," said Sorle, with no trace of irony. "Thank you, Mrs. Orme. Yes."

They did it in the Physic wards on the Third Fathom, in the long tiled bath-room at the end, where the Physicians returned the Halcyon's own kept staff when a cure was found. Rule oversaw it. She had returned two hundred people in her life, and said on the first morning that she had never returned one who had been kept against his will and was glad to begin. When the sheet came off the casing, Hester stood and looked at it in the bath-room lamplight: the thin man standing in clear salt with one arm reaching and his mouth open on a word, and the faint widdershins spiral in the grain of it, turning round him like a shell.

Clear. Three months in Hush grain and still clear, without a breath of bloom. *The living keep clear.*

They lowered him into the warm brine. And every morning and every evening for six days, Hester went into the release with her hands on the casing under the water, and opened them, a little. Sorle sat on a stool at the bath's edge with his slate and his watch and told her when, his left hand in his lap in a wool mitten. It had not closed since the Hush, and Rule did not think it would. Saskia came between her lamp-work shifts and counted. Teo came and sat on the tiled floor with his back against the wall and his shawl round him and did not count anything, but stayed. The salt went down around Aske a finger's width a day, and the water grew hotter, and Rule's assistants drew it off and ran in more. On the third day the casing was thin enough that Hester could see his eyes clearly through it, open and short-sighted and fixed on something on the far side of the room that had not been there for three months. On the fourth day his skin above the waterline began to steam. On the fifth day the bath-room was hot as the Pans, and Hester came out of every release with her heart ticking and catching and her shirt soaked through, and Sorle made her sit with her hands in a basin of cold brine, his own good hand laid over them, until he could count her pulse without losing his place.

On the morning of the sixth day, the twenty-eighth of Rime, the last of the salt went.

It went as the last of the ice goes off a pond, all at once, the final thin sheet cracking and sliding off him into the water. And Corvin Aske's reaching arm finished its movement. His hand closed on the air where the Old Tap had been on the night of the sixteenth of Russet, and his mouth finished its word.

"—*you can't* hold it, Orsolya, it'll only grow—"

He stopped. He was standing waist-deep in a hot bath with steam rising off his shoulders, his spectacles crooked on his nose where they had sat for three months, and an assistant on either side holding his elbows. He blinked. He looked at the tiled walls, and at the steam, and at Reader Rule, and at Sorle on his stool, and then at Hester, standing in the water in front of him with her hands still open on nothing.

"Oh," he said. "You tasted it."

"I tasted it."

He took that in. Hester watched him take it in: the bath, the Physicians, Sorle, the heat. He had always been quick.

"How long?" he said.

"Three months."

"Three—" His eyebrows went up over the crooked spectacles. "Have I missed the Assay?"

"You have."

"Did you pass?"

"With distinction."

"Well, of course you did," said Corvin Aske, and began, absurdly, to laugh, and then to shake, and the assistants caught him as his knees went. They got him out of the bath and into a blanket and onto a bench. He sat there with the blanket round him and his teeth chattering and the steam coming off his hair, and held out his right hand to look at it.

It did not open properly. The fingers stayed curled, stiffly, as a man's fingers stay when he has held a pen too long in the cold. He tried to straighten them with his left hand and they went straight and then curled again, slowly, of their own accord. Reader Rule bent and looked at them and said nothing, and then said, in her grey voice, "That will be the arrears. Six days of heat through one hand. Some of it may come back. Some of it will not."

Aske looked at his hand for a long time. Then he looked up at Hester.

"Orsolya," he said.

"In the Proctory cells."

"Is she—"

"She held the Fifth," Hester said. "While I vented. She sent her people to the trunk and held it herself. She's Settled some. She's all right. She told Gage everything. I was there."

Aske closed his eyes behind the crooked spectacles. When he opened them they were wet.

"Of course she did," he said. "Of course she did, the daft woman." Then, more quietly: "I was going to ask her first. Before Gage. I owed her that. I thought—" He stopped. "Never mind what I thought. It's three months ago." He turned the stiff hand over in his lap and looked at its palm. "Is there tea? I'm told there's always tea."

Sorle was already pouring it, one-handed. He put the cup into Aske's left hand, since the right would not hold it, and put a pinch of salt in it without asking. Aske drank, and made a face, and drank again.

"Disgusting," he said. "Tell me everything. Start with what you tasted."

CHAPTER 26

# *What the Salt Keeps*



*What is kept is not lost.*

— Motto of the Halcyon

The Proctory cells were on the First Fathom, behind the Chief Proctor's office: three small rooms cut square into the salt, each with a cot and a stool and a door of iron bars. Somebody, a long time ago, had scratched a halcyon into the wall of the middle cell, a crude one, with a crooked wave under it.

Orsolya was in the middle cell, on the stool, wrapped in an iron-grey Choir blanket, looking at the halcyon.

"Hester," she said, when the Proctor had unlocked the door and gone back to the end of the passage. She said it without turning her head, and she did not say *chick*. "Sit down. Before you fall down."

Hester sat on the edge of the cot. She could see Orsolya's hands in her lap under the edge of the grey wool. They were still white. They lay open, palms up, as they had lain on the founders' step in the Hush, as if the Warden had forgotten how to close them and had stopped trying.

"Corvin's up," Hester said.

"I know. Gage told me. His hand?"

"Stiff. Rule says some of it will come back."

"Some of it won't." Orsolya nodded slowly. "No. It wouldn't."

"He asked after you. First thing, nearly."

Orsolya closed her eyes, briefly. Then she looked at Hester for the first time, a long look, Lowside to Lowside, the look of one woman checking another for a short weight.

"I'll not say sorry to you," she said. "I'll say it to Corvin. I'll say it to Ruth Linnow, if she'll have it, and to Nell Corrie, and to the families of the other four, God help me, and to the Choir. Ama was sixty-six." She was quiet a moment. "But I'll not say it to you, Hester. You'd not believe it. And you'd be right not to, because I'd do half of it again. Not Corvin. Not the Cold House. But I'd go down to the Fifth again tomorrow and hold that line, and I'd hold it with whatever I had. You know that."

"I know."

"Good."

"Why the seventh dish?" Hester said.

Orsolya was a while answering. "I'd said it to Perpetua Holm in her own rooms, and she sat there like a stone and let Vey answer for her. I wanted her to hear it said out loud. In the Hall, before the whole city, by somebody she couldn't send down to the Fifth or pension off. A lass off a customs bench with a tongue like Corvin's." She looked at her open hands. "She heard it."

"And your hand? At the stove. You showed me the turn."

"I did." She did not go on at once. "I've asked myself that. You'd stood at Corvin's door the morning we found him. I knew you'd seen the grain. And I showed you anyway, the left wrist and all." She turned one hand over in her lap. "Part of me wanted somebody to see it. You can carry a thing like that a long while on your own. Not for ever."

She looked at the halcyon on the wall. "Brannoc came by. He says the Choir's to be stood down a month while the Board looks at the stays. Says the Hush has gone quiet as a church. First time since I came into the Choir." She breathed out. "Your road."

"Corvin's road."

"Your hands, though."

Hester said nothing. When Orsolya spoke again her voice had gone lower and plainer, the voice she had used on the White with Lucan's casing dragging at the lip of the sink.

"Did it hurt?" she said. "Letting go?"

Hester thought about the wheel spinning free in her chest, and Saskia's voice going fast as a wound clock, and Sorle's old hands over hers in the black water. She thought about a boy's voice in a hot room above Tanner's Row, and her own hand turning over.

"Yes," she said.

Orsolya nodded. For the first time since Hester had come in, something in her face eased.

"Good," she said. "Means you did it right."

* * *

On the afternoon of the twenty-ninth of Rime, Hester went to the Cold House, and her father came with her.

She had not asked him. She had gone to the Pans because she had told him she would, and he had looked up at her through the steam from pan nineteen as he always did. Then, for the first time in her memory, he had set down his rake in the middle of a boil, told the boiler on pan eighteen to mind it, washed at the pump, put on the clean coat from the Assay, and walked out beside her into the cold without a word.

They did not talk as they went. At the top of the rise on Chandler's Lane, where you could see the roofs and the sea-wall and the White, they both stopped. There was a black mark on the White now, two miles out, east of the Halcyon's dome: a long black oval with the low sun on it, like a coin dropped on a tablecloth. Aldous said, "Well," and started walking again.

The board over the door said THE LIVING KEEP CLEAR in its two hands, the old and the careful. Her father stood on the step and looked up at it, and Hester saw his jaw work.

"Da," she said. "You needn't."

"I know I needn't."

He went in.

There was a new card beside the ledger: *Mrs. H. Arden, Director (acting)*. Hester signed the visitors' book and held out the pen, and her father looked at it before he took it. He had sat at this desk once already this winter with a release form in front of him and the pen in his fist, and put the pen down, and gone out. He took the pen now and signed under her, slowly, in big careful capitals: A. VAIL. FATHER.

Hester asked for Mrs. Arden. She came out of the back office, a square grey woman with ink on her second finger, and when Hester asked for the keeping form for two hundred and eleven she looked at her a moment and went and found it without asking why.

It was the same form. Hester had not seen it in eleven years and knew it by heart: the printed heads, *Sleeper*, *Condition*, *Signatory*, *Relation*, and her own name under them in a younger, tighter hand. *Hester Vail, sister*. There was no line for what the sleeper himself might have said. There was a margin.

She took the clerk's pen and wrote in it, small and square:

*He said to me: Let me sleep. The night before Lantern Night, 892. H. Vail, 29 Rime 903.*

She blotted it. Her father read it upside down across the desk, his lips moving. Mrs. Arden read it too, and put the form back in its file, and the file in its drawer, and locked the drawer. It was on the record.

Then they went through the double doors, which he had not been through in nine years, and down the six worn steps into the cold sweet air.

The light came in long bars through the high windows and lay across the eight rows. The sleepers lay as they had been laid: the old man with his mouth open on a word, the girl with the red ribbon, the woman with the baby. Mother Agathe was at the far end of the second row with her brush and her oil can. She saw them and straightened, slowly, and did not come. She lifted one hand a little and let it fall, and went back to her brushing.

By the eastern wall there was an empty plinth where Bett Linnow had lain. Someone had put a sprig of Hask juniper on it.

There was another in the seventh row. Hester went to it first, while her father stood at the foot of the steps. The card was still in its brass holder: *J. Corrie*. The stone had been swept and oiled, and there was nothing on it. On the next plinth Nell Corrie lay in a casing crazed from end to end with fine white lines, like a dropped plate held together by its glaze, and she was clear under it, and dry. Agathe had oiled her till she shone.

Hester stood between them. She had nothing to put on the stone. She had chosen the night, and the night had cost this, and it would go on costing it. She put two fingers on the empty plinth, where his feet would have been, and then went back up the row.

Aldous had not moved. Hester stopped beside him and looked down the fourth row to the third window, and waited. It took him a long time. Then he went along the row, and she went with him, and they came to two hundred and eleven.

Tib lay on his back with his head turned a little toward the window. His eyes were half open. His hand was curled on his chest round a pencil that was not there. His casing was clear from end to end and perfectly dry. The light came through it and lay on him, and you could tell where the salt ended and the air began only by a faint brightness along its edges.

Aldous looked at his son.

He stood beside the plinth with his big burned hands hanging at his sides. Then he put out his right hand, the good one, and laid it flat on the casing over Tib's chest, over the curled hand. Do not touch the casings. He left his hand there. His shoulders moved once, and then were still.

Hester stood on the other side of the plinth. She had thought since the Hush about what she would say, and had not got further than the first line. She did not need to. You did not push it out. You opened your hand.

"Tib," she said. "It's Hester. Da's here. He's come to see you."

The light lay across the rows.

"I've to tell you something," she said, "and I should have told you eleven years ago, and I'm telling you now with Da here so I'll not be able to pretend afterward that I didn't. You said something to me. The night before Lantern Night, in the room in Tanner's Row. You were burning up. You opened your eyes and you said, *Let me sleep, Hes. Just let me sleep.*" Her voice was steady. That surprised her. "And I knew what you meant. You didn't mean keep me. You meant let me go. You were fourteen and you'd had the bloom three weeks and you knew what it was. And I came down here and I signed the paper anyway. I told myself you'd asked for sleep, and keeping's a kind of sleep, so I'd done what you asked. I told myself that every month for eleven years. It isn't true. I kept you because I couldn't stand to let you go. Not for you. For me."

Her father's hand on the casing had not moved. She did not look at his face.

"I'm sorry," she said. "That's the first thing. It was your sleep, and I took it off you, and I've been paying six sols a month so I'd not have to think about it.

"And the second thing is this. I'll not let you go today. I want you to know why, because you've a right to know. It's not because I can't. I think I could now.

I've learned how." She looked at the clear salt over his face. "It's because I don't know enough yet. There's a lake out on the White, Tib, a real one, with fish in it. There's a gull. There's things that have been kept nine hundred years and come back alive and whole. And I don't know yet what that means for you. Nobody does. So I'm going to find out.

"And I promise you this." She put her own hand flat on the casing, beside her father's, over the curled fingers. The salt was cold and dry. "When I know how to bring you back properly, or when I know how to let you go, I'll do it. Whichever's right. For you, not for me. And before I do it, whichever it is, I'll tell you first. Here. Out loud. The way I should have done."

She stopped. The ward was quiet. Down at the end of the second row Agathe's brush had stopped.

Aldous took his hand off the casing. He looked at the print of it, a faint mist on the salt that was already fading, and then at his daughter across the plinth. His eyes were red and wet and small.

"Well," he said. His voice was thick. Then, after a long while: "He'd have told you that was a daft promise."

"He would."

"Made it anyway."

"Yes."

Her father nodded. He looked down at Tib a while longer. Then he did a thing she had not seen him do in eleven years, or in thirty-three. He bent over the plinth and put his lips to the salt over his son's forehead and kept them there. Then he straightened, and wiped his mouth with the back of his wrist, and turned and walked away up the row without looking back.

Hester stayed. Mother Agathe came up the row with her can and her brush and stopped beside her and looked down at two hundred and eleven.

"He's clear, my dear," she said. "Look at him. Clear as the day they did it."

"I know."

"The living keep clear," said Agathe, and patted Hester's arm once with her small dry hand, and went on down the row.

* * *

On the morning of the thirtieth Sorle sent for her.

His study was as it had been in Fallow, after the sink: books on every flat surface, slates propped against the books, the kept moth on the desk in its globe of salt. One slate, propped against a pile of Horology quarterlies, bore in large chalk capitals the words *NATURAL QUICKENING EVENT*, underlined twice, with a row of exclamation marks after it that went off the edge.

"Sit," said Sorle.

She sat. He did not. He took down a long narrow ledger bound in black cloth gone brown at the corners, and laid it open on the desk in front of her, so that the kept moth had to be moved. It was the register of the Black Bench of Horology. The names went back up the page, a few to a year, and then whole years with no name at all, and then, three years ago, his two third-years, who were terrified of him.

Under them, in fresh ink, still a little shiny, he had written:

*Hester Vail. Turning Intake, 903. Assayed with distinction, 21 Rime 903. Admitted to this Bench, 30 Rime 903, by B. Sorle, Reader.*

"You've been on my Bench since Fallow," he said. "Informally. Under protest from the Registrar. This makes it law." He held out the pen. "You sign under it. There."

She signed. Her hand was steady. She blotted it.

"There," said Sorle. He closed the ledger one-handed and sat down at last on the other side of the desk, his white left hand lying open on the blotter where he had put it, and looked at her.

"I should tell you," he said, "that you will be a very great trial to me. You have no theory. You have no manners. You hold like a miser and release like a drunkard. You think with your tongue. You took a matter of the gravest institutional importance into your own hands without the slightest reference to proper authority, and you took me with you, and I have not been so cold or so wet or so frightened since I was a child."

"Yes, Reader."

"And you were right," said Sorle. "Which I find, after thirty-two years, I had entirely forgotten the taste of." He looked at the slate with *NATURAL QUICKENING EVENT* on it. "It is not, I discover, a sweet taste. It is very like salt."

* * *

She found Lucan on the Choir Steps in the afternoon, which was not a place she had expected to find him.

Snow had drifted into the corners of the tiers in thin grey crusts. He was sitting near the top, alone, with his arms round his knees, looking east at the Tear: the black oval on the white, the crowd along the near edge like a line of ants, the little sails of the landships tacking up and down the water.

She climbed up and sat on the tier below him. He did not seem surprised.

"My father has resigned the Exchequer," he said, without preamble. "This morning. *For reasons of health.* The Assize will hold a hearing in Thaw. Mr. Lisk is in Hask, it seems. Visiting relations." He looked at his gloved hands. "He has not spoken to me since the twenty-third. My sister writes that he has had my rooms in the Upper Ward cleared and my books sent to the Halcyon in crates, addressed in his own hand. She thinks that's a hopeful sign."

"Is it?"

"I've no idea. I've never had a hopeful sign from my father before. I don't know what one looks like." He was quiet. "Sorle has written me into his register. Properly, this morning, under you. He said that if he must suffer one insufferable aspirant he may as well suffer two, since the insufferability appears to be cumulative rather than multiplicative, and he would like to test the hypothesis."

"God help us both."

"Yes." He turned his head and looked down at her. His face was thin in the cold light. There was a scab across the back of his right hand where the saw had slipped in the Cistern, healing badly. "Vail. On the White, in Fallow. When you kept me. I said I'd repay it."

"You've repaid it. You cut the line."

"That wasn't repayment. That was—" He looked out at the Tear. "That was what wanted doing. You taught me that. It's a Lowside phrase. I've caught it like a cold." He was quiet for a while. Then, in a different voice, shorter: "I've never owed anyone anything before. I didn't like it. I thought it would be like a bill. Something one paid, and was done with."

"And?"

"And I find I don't mind owing you," said Lucan Ferrers.

She looked up at him. He looked back, and did not look away, which was new.

"That's a start," Hester said.

They sat in the cold a long time after that, watching the landships on the black water. When the light went, he stood and offered her his hand to get up. She took it, though she did not need to.

* * *

The Ebbtide Vigil fell on the last night of the year.

Every year of her life Hester had watched the Tiders come out of the Lowside chapels at dusk in their grey shawls, with their candles, and walk out past the end of the Causeway onto the bare salt, singing, to meet the tide. They stood in the cold and waited for the sea, and the sea did not come, and at the twelfth bell they walked home. Lowside called it the Wet-Foot Walk and made gentle jokes about it, and gave the walkers hot cider at Eastgate coming home, because it was a cold thing to do every year for nine hundred years and be wrong.

This year the whole city came.

They came out of Eastgate at dusk like a river, and the river was lit: Tiders and not, Lowside and Upper Ward, delvers and glaziers and clerks and children, down off the Causeway and out across the White in the dark, not a procession any more but a great slow field of small lights a quarter-mile wide, going east, toward the black water. From the dome of the Halcyon, as Hester came down off it with the others, it looked as if the sky had been laid on the salt.

Teo had taken his grey Tider shawl out of his chest that afternoon and looked at it a long while and put it on. Hester, in the same hour, had taken down the two dishes that had sat on her shelf since Russet, with their two kept drops of brine, and put a finger to each, and opened her hand. They had gone to water at the first touch.

They walked together. Saskia was beside Teo with Pip on her hip and Hennie Orme on her other arm. Pip held a candle in both fists and asked every few yards whether there would be fish. Lucan walked a little apart, and then not quite so far apart. Corvin Aske came as far as the Gatehouse on Sorle's arm, both of them wrapped to the eyes, and stood there to watch them go, and lifted his good hand. And at the foot of the Causeway, where it came down onto the salt, a short wide man in a clean coat was standing out of the stream of people with a candle that had gone out. He fell in beside Hester without a word, and walked with her a quarter of a mile, perhaps more. Then he stopped, and said, "That'll do me," and touched her arm, and turned back toward the city.

The shore of the Tear was a ridge of grey ice, and the candles came down to it and spread out along it, left and right, until the black water had a rim of light all round it. The Tiders began the hymn they always sang, the old one about the tide coming home over the sand. Hester had heard it all her life and never listened to the words. She listened now. People who did not know the words took it up, humming, until the whole shore was singing. The sound went out over the water and did not come back, because there was nothing out there for it to come back off. There was only the dark, and the water, and the faint smell of weed.

Teo touched her arm.

"Come and read it with me," he said.

They went down off the ridge onto the ice-rim, where the frozen sea ran out a yard or two from the shore before it thinned. Teo knelt, and Hester beside him. Under their knees the ice was grey and rough and new, and in it, where it met the shore, there was a thin white crust: salt, coming out of the seawater as it froze, as salt comes out of any sea at its edges in the cold. Salt that had been sea on the twenty-first of Rime and had only begun, these last nine days, to be anything else.

Teo took off his gloves and laid both bare hands flat on it and shut his eyes, and went into his poor restless hold. It was steady tonight. His breath slowed. His lips went pale. She took off her own right glove and touched one finger to the crust and put the finger to her tongue.

It tasted of the sea. Not sweet, not heavy; no coins on her eyelids. Salt and cold and something under the salt, bright and wet and startled, as when you bite your tongue. It tasted like tears, which she supposed it was. It tasted of something living.

Beside her, Teo had gone still. Not the hold's stillness. Something else. His eyes were open, but he was not looking at anything on the ice.

"Teo."

"Wait." His voice was low. "Wait. There's—"

She waited. Up on the shore the singing went on, the tide coming home over the sand. The candles moved along the ice-rim like a slow river.

"There's someone," Teo said.

He did not move his hands. He was listening, as she had seen him listen in the Brinestacks, for a sound inside the Roar, and it was there.

"It's a voice," he said. "Hester. A person. Not the gull. Not the sea. A *person*." His breath was coming fast. "One word. Over and over." He swallowed, and

shaped it slowly, carefully, as you shape a word in a language you do not know. "*Aelith?* Like that. Up at the end. Like they're asking."

"What does it mean?"

"I don't know." He opened his eyes and looked at her. In the candlelight his face was wet. "I don't know what language it is. I've never heard it." He laughed, once, a sound with no breath in it. "I left the Order because I wanted to know. And there's someone in the salt asking a question, and I don't know what it is."

Hester looked past him, out over the black water, east, toward the Deep: three hundred miles of nothing, the White going on under the stars to the end of the world.

The wind was coming off the water. She had not noticed it start. It came across the Tear out of the east in a long, slow, steady breath, and it was not the Sere, which was dry and smelled of nothing. This was wet. It smelled of weed and salt and something under the salt she had no word for. It moved the candle-flames along the shore all together, every one of them bowing west, and lifted the edge of Teo's grey shawl, and went on past them over the ice toward the city.

She knelt on the new ice with the wind in her face. Her bare hand was on the crust, flat, the fingers open. She left it there.

Behind them on the shore, the whole city was singing a hymn about the tide. Out on the black water, very faint, very far off, something answered it. It might have been a gull.

*What the Salt Keeps* is the first novel of
THE HALCYON CYCLE



Book Two: *The Lantern Tithe*